Gold Light, Green Light

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37516711.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Green Lantern (Comics)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Ghost!Mara, Horde Prime (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), and the rest! - Character, He-Man characters, Jessica Cruz, Soranik Natu, Various Green Lanterns

Additional Tags:
GL!Adora, Crack Treated Seriously, Very seriously, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, (screw her), Warning: Horde Prime (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), they get therapy, Friendship, Enemies to Friends to Lovers, Catradora for Life!, Action/Adventure, Therapy Cat Melog (She-Ra), Soft Adora/Catra (She-Ra), AKA the best kind, Space Adventures!, Mind Control, breaking mind control - Freeform, found family fluff, Anxiety, Depression, Sheer Unbridled Joy, BAMF Adora, BAMF Catra, OP Adora, Shadow Weaver getting a verbal smackdown, Horde Prime getting a giant green fist to the face, DC Comics References, She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018) Season 5 Spoilers, after the war, Creative Power Use, (par for the course for Lanterns), quiet moments, Crazy moments, Epic Battles, Epic Love, And one nerd's insane idea brought to life, Trying to rig He-Man stuff into the show's mythology

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by Kungfu_Blaziken

Summary

A new force enters the battle for Etheria, changing the paths of Adora and Catra forever. She has the power of Green Lantern's Light!

Notes

Originally published on FF.net from 9/11/2020 to 1/28/2022
Some editing has been done. Most author's notes maintained for archival purposes.

Well…this is an interesting turn of events.
I'm a late convert to the She-Ra fandom. As in 'Season 5 had aired before I started' late. I suppose I only have myself to blame. I didn't have much experience with the overall franchise (only having sporadically watched the 2003 He-Man series), I didn't appear to be in the presumed target audience, and unlike similar female led shows like Supergirl or Batwoman, this didn't have any connection to stuff I was familiar with and liked.
I was vaguely aware of this show because my brother had watched the first season out of curiosity and fell in love with it, but aside from general jokes about the sexual tension between the hero and her villainous rival and an ongoing headcanon that either version of She-Ra could have said 'I have the power!' like He-Man but just chose not to, I didn't know what was going on.
Then the Internet blew up over this final season, and I finally broke down and loaded the show up. I expected to be entertained, but it would be something I'd sit down to watch between other things.
I spent the next week binging the entire series, and the week after diving into fanfic territory. Then I started jotting down

ideas of my own.
And now here we are.
But why Green Lantern, I hear you ask? Well, that's a much shorter story.
See, after Season 3 came and went, my brother was idly talking about it while I played on our Playstation, and the subject of 'Etheria's in a pocket dimension' and the then-shadowy specter of Horde Prime came up. He was summarizing the situation as "So if Etheria ever popped back into normal space, they'd pop back smack in the middle of an evil galactic empire."
Then I made the following crack: "So what you're saying is, if that happened, their only hope would be if She-Ra suddenly got chosen by a Green Lantern ring."
…
My God I'm a nerd.
Although it makes me wonder, how has no one else thought of this crossover before?
Anyway, the idea stuck with me, and eventually evolved to what we have here today.
So, with all that set-up out of the way, let us dive into a story based upon a landmark in LGBT representation…
A fanfic written by a cisgendered, heterosexual dude…
…
Have I made a terrible mistake?

(Notation from the future)
Strangely, no, it was not a terrible mistake. I'm quite proud of where this ended up, even if the third arc took forever to do and made me want to pull my hair out at points.
Life's funny like that.

See the end of the work for more notes

The Voice

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 1

The Voice

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The voice was back.

It was getting really hard for Catra to ignore it.

She certainly tried, of course. The new tactic was climbing up to rest in one of the viewports of the massive spaceship and looking out at the stars. It actually amazed her, sometimes. She'd gone her whole life with a void over her head, and now that void was filled with points of light. Sometimes, she'd spend hours just looking out at space, marveling at the sights and imagining herself a great explorer.

But Catra wasn't an explorer, not now. The only difference between her and Glimmer was that one was in an actual cell. She

wasn't fooling herself. She was just as much a prisoner of Horde Prime as the other girl. The alien warlord had made that very clear when he forced her to watch the so-called 'cleansing ritual'.

She could still hear Hordak's screams. It was an odd feeling, when someone you hated was in such torment that you couldn't help but pity them.

Her view changed as the ship drifted about. Now she was facing a large planet. She couldn't help but compare it to Etheria.

Then a massive fireball erupted from the surface.

Catra started, then took another look. So dazzled by the blues and greens of the planet below, she completely missed the black shapes of Prime's armada hovering over the planet. And in an instant, she realized what she was seeing.

She watched in slowly mounting horror at the saturation bombing of a defenseless planet. Finally, she tore her eyes away.

A traitorous part of her mind wondered if the same thing was happening to Etheria. The voice spoke again.

She jumped down to the floor, unwilling to keep watching a world burn. Then she made her way through the sterile halls of the ship, the only sign of her agitation the flicking of her tail.

She didn’t mind the quiet, really. It was the cold that got to her. Clearly, Horde Prime and his clones preferred much cooler temperatures, and either weren’t aware of how uncomfortable it was making their guests or didn’t care. Catra had her money on the latter. It seemed like just the type of psychological warfare Prime clearly enjoyed, a less dramatic version of forcing them to watch footage of their home planet under attack.

Catra shook her head, banishing her train of thought and the voice once more. With nothing much to do, she’d found herself getting a lot more introspective lately, and it was getting exhausting. She needed something to take her mind off things.

Perhaps she’d visit Glimmer. She technically wasn’t allowed to, and she was certain that Prime knew of the stealthy trips to see the other prisoner, but nothing had stopped her yet, so she figured that Prime didn’t actually care that the two girls talked.

And talked they did. Catra had been to see her a few times, and the two had slipped into a strange sort of camaraderie. Perhaps it was because no one else on this ship was much of a conversationalist. Granted, Catra wasn’t either. She was content to let Glimmer fill the air, making this or that comment as needed. Glimmer never seemed to mind taking control of the conversation, probably figuring that Catra was just the quieter of the two.

Which was true, but that didn’t mean Catra didn’t, on some level, appreciate that Glimmer took the lead more often. Sometimes

she just wasn't sure what to say, especially to someone like Glimmer who, until recently, was on the opposite side of a war.

Catra kept low and quick as she neared the brig. She wasn't sure why, it was just habit at this point. She finally reached the designated cell and flicked against the forcefield, turning it transparent.

Glimmer looked up from her little project in surprise.

"Where did you get that?" Catra asked, pointing at the needles and basket of yarn.

"I managed to get one of the clones to listen long enough to put in a request" Glimmer said, "Prime took control of the delivery boy and made some comment about me getting bored. Guy likes to hear himself talk, doesn't he?"

"Let's just be thankful he doesn't bother us much," Catra grumbled before taking a seat against the forcefield.

This was their thing, sitting more or less back to back. It was a bit more comfortable, honestly. Despite the circumstances, neither entertained the idea they were really friends. Not being face to face seemed to help keep conversations going, for the most part.

Catra heard Glimmer drag her basket over before sitting down.

"Whatcha knitting, anyway?"

"Figured I'd make you a scarf or something," Glimmer said, "I managed to figure out how to change the heat in here, but I imagine you're not as lucky."

"That cell has environmental controls?"

"They're fairly shoddy, but yeah. I guess I'm not Prime's first prisoner. Back on subject, how are you doing with the cold?"

"Somehow, I never get used to it," Catra groused, "You'd think being covered in fur would help, but no. I've just always been sensitive to cold. That mission in the Northern Reach was a nightmare, honestly, and not just because I accidently drove She-Ra berserk. Seriously though, I had no idea that would happen, I just thought it was an off-switch."

"Wild guess, Entrapta didn't mention that part," Glimmer replied, pausing a second to take in Catra's affirmative snort, "But maybe the cold thing's your upbringing. From the few times I've been to the Fright Zone, the thing that struck me as the oddest was how warm it was. I figured with all the smog blocking most of the sun, it'd be colder."

"You'd think that, but no. I blame all the machinery giving off excess heat."

"Makes sense. Dark red a good color for you? Sorry I assumed, but that seemed right."

"No, that's fine."

They lapsed into companionable silence for a moment. Catra listened to the clacking of the knitting needles and the soft breaths of Glimmer counting off stitches before speaking up again.

"Why knitting?"

"My mom taught me when I was younger. It was a hobby we could do together."

Catra grimaced, glad Glimmer couldn't see her react to the somber tone. She was well aware that Queen Angella had been a casualty of the portal debacle. She was certain that it was a sensitive topic, given that this was the first time she'd heard Glimmer bring up her mother.

"So if you were back on Etheria right now, this is what you'd be doing?" Catra asked, attempting to change the subject.

"Probably not. I use knitting to destress nowadays. I guess what I'd be doing was teleporting around, visiting all my friends. And if it were a really good day, I'd be having a sleepover with Bow and Adora."

Catra felt a pain in her chest at the mention of Adora. She slumped a little as Glimmer continued wistfully.

"We'd chat about nothing in particular, maybe play that tabletop game Bow made up. One time, we snuck into the kitchens, stole some cake, and then ate it with our hands, right off the platter."

Glimmer trailed off with a chuckle, and Catra found her voice.

"We used to do that…"

"Do what?"

"Sleepovers. Me and Adora would play pranks on Kyle and stay up all night talking about…you know, whatever. Sometimes, if I was having a rough night, I'd slip out of my bunk and curl up at the foot of Adora's bed. Listening to her little snores was strangely soothing."

She wasn't sure why she added that last part. Her midnight changes of beds were an open secret among the cadet quarters, but had always seemed kind of private.

As if sensing Catra's discomfort, Glimmer tried to lighten the subject.

"Did Adora still thrash around all night and…like, sleep-fight? What was that about?" Glimmer asked, laughing

"She always did that!" Catra laughed, "Adora can't even relax when she's asleep! It's a good thing the beds were long, because she probably would have kicked me all night."

The two of them laughed for a bit. Then Glimmer sighed.

"I was such a jerk to them," she said sadly, "They tried to warn me about the Heart over and over, but I just kept blowing them off. I kept having trouble with everything going on, but instead of asking for help, I took it out on them. I was a bad friend."

Catra scoffed.

"Yeah, well, join the club, Sparkles. Even Miss Positivity Scorpia decided I wasn't worth being around. Don't know why I try. Everyone leaves eventually."

There was silence for a moment.

"You could have joined us, you know," Glimmer said softly, "I mean, after you attacked Bright Moon, I wouldn't have liked it, but I'd have grinned and bore it for Adora's sake. I don't think she ever stopped missing you. You'd come up in conversation and later I'd catch her staring into the middle distance. I think deep down, even after everything, she always hoped you two would reconcile."

"Even after the portal?"

And Catra still kicked herself over that one. All she could figure out, with the benefit of hindsight, was that it had come at the end of a long line of traumatic hits. Adora leaving, having to fight her best friend multiple times, Shadow Weaver in general, the pressure of being the Horde's second in command, losing everything and getting all but exiled to the Crimson Wastes, the general chaos of the hours counting down to the portal's activation…

She snapped, spiraled down into an insanity that she genuinely regretted now. And while leading the Horde to greater conquests in preparation for Prime's arrival had helped her piece herself back together, it had still led to where she was now: completely alone and complicit in planetary destruction.

So honestly? Not much of a step up, all things considered.

Glimmer's dry laugh pulled her out of her musings.

"I was still dealing with my mother being…gone…but I did overhear a conversation between her and Bow. You came up. I wanted to get angry at what she said, but she sounded so broken that I couldn't muster it."

"What did she say?"

"That you were a madwoman, that you had thrown away any good in favor of winning at any cost, that you were so desperate for approval that you'd watch the world burn…but, and I'm quoting directly here, 'Damn it if I don't still want her back. I miss my friend and I hate what she's become.'"

Catra was silent for a long time. When she finally spoke, it reminded Glimmer of the tone of voice Adora had had in that aforementioned memory.

"I keep hearing this voice. I've heard it off and on throughout my life, usually when Shadow Weaver blamed something on me or whatever. But I started hearing it more and more after Adora left. I heard as I ran away from Thaymor. I heard it after I left her in that crystal crypt. I heard it every time we fought. I heard it when we'd hacked the Black Garnet. I heard it when I infected Adora with that weird virus. I heard it when I pulled that damn lever and when we were in that altered reality. I heard it as I was

practically running the Horde. And I hear it now. Before, I've been able to ignore it, but it keeps pounding in my head."

"What does the voice say?" Glimmer asked.

Catra sighed through her nose and her ear twitched.

"'This is wrong.' That's all it ever says, over and over."

She gave a bitter laugh.

"It sounds like Adora."

"You miss her, don't you?"

Catra said nothing. She just got up and walked away, flicking the forcefield back to opacity as she went.

oOo

After some time wandering the halls, Catra was found by one of the clones.

"Horde Prime requests your presence, little sister."

Catra didn't bother with even a token protest. It wouldn't have mattered much. Instead, she followed the clone to what she'd taken to calling the throne room. She wasn't sure what Prime called it, probably something grandiose.

He was more of a drama queen than Hordak was. Which made it strange that the room was so sparse otherwise. The most notable feature, aside from the fan of screens from which he studied various parts of his empire, was that it was exceedingly cold in the room. The only place colder was the alter that housed the green pool and the clone pods.

Only Prime and one other clone were in the room, both studying the screens in front. Catra coughed awkwardly, and Prime's chair spun about, the intergalactic monster himself looking quite relaxed. As she always did, she fought down the wave of revulsion that welled up every time she saw him.

"Ah, there you are, little sister. I have a task for you."

Catra didn't answer beyond a confused look, so Prime continued. He snapped his fingers, drawing attention to one screen that changed to an image she knew.

"On your home world, there is a stronghold. I believe the locals call it Bright Moon? My spies have noted that the planet's paltry defenders have abandoned it, no doubt unsure they could hold such a location considering my fleet. However, it still stands as a symbol. I would like that symbol crushed. Consider it a test, little sister. I give you command of a small collection of troops. Go forth in my name and conquer."

Catra tore her eyes away from the screen.

"Is that all?"

"That is all. Crush any rebellion in any manner you see fit."

"No offense, but I'm not exactly familiar with your troops and capabilities."

"I am aware. That's part of the test. But that is what my wayward brother is for."

Prime waved his hand at the attendant clone, and Catra realized with a shock that this was Hordak, or had been at least. The clone gazed at her with a blank expression.

"I have studied this one's memories of your world. He did quite well, for a time, that much I will admit. If it weren't for his presumption, I would find more pride in it."

Prime's hand squeezed the arm of his throne as he said this, but he soon relaxed again.

"Regardless, he will be able to assist you. Consider it a field test of his finished re-education."

Prime then gave her a sickening smile, his eyes blinking asymmetrically.

"I imagine Etheria's symbol of hope will show her face should you attack. It won't be a problem if you have to face…Adora, was it?"

Catra hid her stress-induced fist clench behind her back.

"No sir," she answered, "I'll get it done."

Prime still noticed the small frown in her face.

"See that you do. Rejoice, little sister. You are about to help your planet ascend into the pure light of my grace. Everything you wished for will be provided for in my glorious order."

It was funny that he put it like that, Catra thought as she walked away. As if winning and glory and power were things she wanted. She had them, helping the Horde's final push. She was finally in a place where she mattered, where none could ever doubt that she was useful. She was winning, she had power, she was bringing ultimate glory to herself and the Horde.

But she had never been more alone.

The loneliness had gnawed at her soul, exploited cracks in the walls that she'd been trying to build and strengthen ever since Thaymor, ever since the blow of Adora leaving had rattled her down to her core. If Scorpia leaving had sent a wrecking ball into those walls, then Double Trouble's deconstructing monologue had shattered what was left of them.

As much as she wanted to blame others for all her pain, there was a point where she couldn't do that, where she had to consider that she was her own worst enemy. It was a strange feeling, thinking you were rising up only to find yourself at rock bottom with no one to blame but yourself.

She had only followed Glimmer and Hordak into the teleport beam out of instinct, only spoken up out of the most basic need to survive, even if only for a little longer. She was good at surviving, always had been. Thriving, that was another story, but survival she could do.

But as it stood, she wasn't sure what she wanted. All she knew for certain was that she was tired. Tired of anger, tired of

loneliness, tired of everything.

As Catra left to prepare for battle, she heard the voice again.

This is wrong.

Chapter End Notes

I do not own She-Ra and the Princesses of Power. It is owned by DreamWorks Animation, show creator Noelle Stevenson, and based upon characters made by Larry DiTillio, J. Michael Straczynski, Filmation, and Mattel
Exercise civility in the comments. Constructive criticism is okay, insults are not. Flames will be fed to Tempest the Gyarados.

The Ring

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 2

The Ring

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Adora looked over the shattered remains of her sword and sighed.

"It was right. I had to. But I sure wish we still had She-Ra."

She had a strange relationship with She-Ra. On the one hand, she loved the power to help people, to protect them from the monsters. She-Ra was strong enough to bear any weight, take on any challenge.

On the other hand, the powers came with more questions than answers, as well as a burden heavier than even She-Ra's strength. The burden of *destiny*. And it was such a *heavy* weight. The knowledge that she had to be the one to defeat the Horde, that only she was strong enough, that one wrong move

could mean that she loses and she can't ever lose because if she did people would die…

It kept her up at night, made her second-guess herself far too often. And she'd had enough soldier training to know this for certain: on the battlefield, indecision meant death.

And then of course, she finally got answers. Where She-Ra might have once been a protector, now she was a weapon. She was made by an uncaring race to unleash untold destruction in the name of…what, peace? They stripped a planet of so much of its magic, turned it into a superweapon, subverted a guardian to make her an unwilling pawn in a cosmic game, hurt who knows how many people to fulfill their agendas, and then had the gall to claim it was for *peace*.

If Adora was a First One, a descendant at the very least, then she rejected it. She wanted no part in a race of people that would be complicit in so much destruction. She left the Horde for a reason.

Still…being able to turn into an eight-foot-tall juggernaut of strength and magic would have been *really* useful right about now…

"Just my luck," she muttered, "I break the key to something horrible to protect everyone, but then something just as bad shows up."

She heard the rustle of the flap of her tent and turned to see Bow. Her friend looked concerned.

"What happened?

"Bright Moon. Swift Wind spotted several ships heading toward it. It's an assault."

"What?!" Adora shouted, jerking into readiness, "But why? It's not a Rebellion stronghold anymore, we knew we couldn't hold it so we ran!"

"I don't think this new Horde much cares," Bow replied, "King Micah's mustering the troops, we leave in five."

Adora nodded, then rushed over to a chest. From within it, she extracted a set of light torso armor that she'd scavenged from an old Horde outpost, abandoned in the wake of the Rebellion's final push before Horde Prime had come. Without She-Ra's durability, Adora needed an extra edge. She also grabbed an expanding staff, her new weapon for the foreseeable future.

As she armored up, her eyes caught the former Sword of Protection. She's scavenged much of the scraps, a part of her hoping that it might be repairable. She hadn't gotten around to trying yet, and something told her that without special care, the magic wouldn't flow properly. As it was, the largest piece was the

hilt, a few inches of blade sticking out before terminating in a jagged edge.

She grabbed it and slid it into her belt. The sword had no function, but keeping it close felt right. She wasn't sure if it was a side effect of bathing in so much of its power or a more mundane sense of familiarity.

oOo

It was chaos. There were Horde robots on every corner, surveillance drones in the skies, and death just a few steps behind.

It was clear that Horde Prime's goal here wasn't anything specific. It was pure destruction, a breaking of hope.

Adora and the rest of the Rebellion fighters had quickly given up on taking Bright Moon. Now their objective was getting the civilians out of harm's way.

Adora slid out of the way of a laser blast, ducking to some cover. She heard the crackle of electricity and a brief explosion.

"Thanks Scorpia!"

The former Force Captain didn't respond, just dashed off to renew the fight. Between her sheer strength, great durability, and potent electrical powers, she was easily the most valuable soldier in this fight, followed closely behind by Micah and Frosta with their respective powerful magic.

There was a time Adora would have filled that role. But she tried not to think about it. She still had raw skill to fall back on.

She vaulted over her cover, nailing a robot with a flying kick and knocking it down. She speared the head with her staff before moving on. Another fired its weapon at her, but she ducked beneath, rolling to pop back up inside its guard. She grabbed the still firing weapon, having moved too fast for the robot's simple program to react, and twisted it around to fire on its fellows. She took out three of them before her improvised weapon wrestled back control. Before it could do anything, however, a golden arrow erupted from its eye.

As it fell, Adora heard Bow's voice.

"Their patterns are changing! It looks like they're all joining up for a final push!"

"How many people are left?" Adora called back.

"Netossa and Spinnerella are getting the last out now, but we need to get the Horde's attention off them!" Bow shouted down as

he shot a drone out of the air, barely looking at it.

"I'll get their attention," Adora muttered before racing off.

She heard Bow's exclamation of panic, but ignored it, drawing her shattered sword as she ran. It wasn't a complete weapon, but it would serve as a dagger. She tackled a robot, stabbing it with her broken weapon and managing to rip its head off. She didn't stop, rolling off the broken machine and continuing her run.

oOo

Catra looked upon the destruction from a command tank. Beside her, the clone rattled off statistics from their side of the battle.

"You can stop the report, Hordak. I've got eyes, and they're probably better than yours."

The clone started.

"I…I have no name. Such a thing is sacrilege to our Lord."

Catra fought down a shudder. She didn't like Hordak, but to have everything taken from him, even his name? It was monstrous, but she dared not say it out loud.

"Yeah, well, us lowly Etherians prefer using names. So I'm still gonna call you Hordak, if only for ease. Having to go 'Hey you!' every time I want to talk will get old real fast."

Hordak didn't respond, and Catra considered that a small victory.

Then she saw her. The streak of red and blond running across the battlefield, drawing fire from the Horde forces.

"Adora…"

Catra looked on as Adora ducked and weaved around attacks, taking out robots and drones with startling efficiency. It was like poetry in motion, and a small part of Catra wondered if being a large juggernaut had been holding her back in some way. She-Ra wasn't really built for speed and quick dodging, that was partially how Catra had gotten so many hits in back in the day.

The other part had been, as friends who had grown up with each other, they could hurt each other in ways others couldn't. They knew all the right buttons to press.

Catra shook that thought out of her mind. The real question was what Adora thought she was doing, especially fighting when not as She-Ra.

Part of that question was answered when she saw the broken sword in Adora's hand.

"Oh," she whispered.

A measure of respect welled up in Catra. Even stripped of her greatest ability, Adora fought on.

Unfortunately, it wasn't enough. Adora was soon surrounded by Horde forces.

"Well, it seems Lord Prime will be getting She-Ra sooner rather than later," Hordak said, a flicker of his old personality appearing in the tone of his voice, "Although perhaps not in the best condition."

"Wait."

It took Catra a moment to realize that she had spoken, but to her credit, she recovered fast.

"Horde Prime probably won't like that she's so beat up when she's brought to him. He needs her for the Heart, you know that. I think I can get her to surrender. Give me five minutes."

Hordak looked at her with an unreadable expression before nodding.

"Very well, you may have your attempt."

Catra didn't give him any time to second-guess himself, jumping from the tank and rushing toward Adora.

When she got there, she saw Adora. The clearly-scavenged Horde armor was hanging on by spit and prayer, most of the straps having broken at some point. Her hair was torn from its usual ponytail and Catra pushed away the thought that it looked good down, now really wasn't the time. She was covered in scratches, a particularly large one on her cheek oozing blood. There was a burn on her leg, but it didn't seem to bother her, adrenaline likely keeping her from fully noticing it. She'd lost her staff, likely between when Catra spotted her and when she got surrounded, but held her broken sword firmly.

Simply put, she was a mess, but Catra knew that she wouldn't be stopped by something so simple.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora had a spiteful remark on her tongue, almost instinctive at this point in their rivalry, but stopped. The usual greeting was hollow, and Catra looked haggard.

“No offense, Catra, but you look terrible,” she found herself saying.

“I’ve had a rough time of it. Since Salineas, if I’m being honest. But you look pretty rough yourself.”

“So you’ve thrown in your lot with them, huh?” Adora asked, jerking her head toward the robots.

“Not completely willingly, but we do what we must to survive,” Catra shrugged, “You should be grateful. When your friend Shimmer—”

“Glimmer?”

“—when she got abducted, I hitched a ride. I’m the reason Prime didn’t kill her outright.”

“Do you want a thank you?”

“It was mostly instinct, honestly. My silver tongue working so we could live another day.”

"So why are you here now?"

Catra looked conflicted for a moment.

"You're not going to win. Try to imagine this: I thought I was the big, bad villain. I came *this close* to bringing Etheria to its knees. Then Horde Prime just strolls up and says 'Ha! Cute, kid! *Hold my drink.*' And then he delivered. I've seen him, up close. He's so much worse than Hordak ever was. Hell, he smacked Hordak down without even blinking and then brainwashed him back into the old fold. I've seen his armada, the only reason he hasn't blown Etheria into dust already is because he's after the Heart. What do you expect to do against that?"

"I have to try," Adora replied, "There are too many people counting on the Rebellion to keep them safe. So I'm not backing down. Not now, not ever."

Catra scoffed.

"Where was this when our friendship mattered?"

"That's not fair. You know why I couldn't stay. I didn't agree with the Horde anymore. If I stayed, I'd be living a lie. Besides, I'm not the only one who gave up on us."

Catra's face falls.

"You think I don't know that?" she whispered, "You think I don't know that I was the one who escalated? That there are things I don't regret, too? But I can't go back. Not after everything I've done."

Adora took Catra in, and realized something with a start.

In all the time they'd fought, Catra had always seemed so large, so slick as to be untouchable. But now, she was just so…small. Adora hadn't seen her this small and hurt since they were children.

"You look out for me, and I look out for you."

It came to her mind unbidden, and she knew in her heart that she had to say something.

"Yeah…you've done a lot of bad things, Catra."

Catra flinched, but Adora continued.

"Maybe what you need now is to do a good thing. At least one. Because that's how it starts. With just one good thing."

Catra turned away.

"Not everything is that simple."

"Isn't it?"

Catra didn't answer, didn't dare look back because she knew what she'd see, so she just kept walking.

She made her way back to the tank, finding Hordak on the ground waiting for her.

"I tried," she told him.

"Then we capture her the old-fashioned way," came the monotone reply.

Catra turned away, not willing to see what happened next. There was a time she might have gleefully watched her rival fall under a mass of dark forces, but now…it felt wrong.

The voice was back again, louder than ever.

And so it happened. Hordak gave the order, and the forces charged. Adora stood firm and unafraid, bloody but unbowed, holding her broken sword up to help her fend off the darkness.

In the end, that saved her.

oOo

Horde Prime stared at his screens, observing both Etheria and the space around it.

Suddenly, a streak of green light arced toward the planet.

But it was not the sickly, toxic green of Prime's essence. It was a brilliant, verdant green.

It was a green that Prime recognized.

"No…"

oOo

Emerald light bathed the fractured kingdom of Bright Moon. A light brighter than the sun descended upon them. And a voice echoed.

Adora of—KRTZKT ERROR KAAK—You have powerful will and the ability to overcome great fear. You have been chosen. Welcome to the Green Lantern Corps.

The light engulfed Adora. Catra heard her start screaming.

And then there was chaos.

Bolts of light struck out from the center of the emerald mass. It gouged the ground like lightning and devastated their forces. The command tank was split in twain from one of the lights. Bolts punched through robots and drones alike. Hordak himself went down with a wound to his arm.

But when Catra faced the light, when she froze in fear at an oncoming bolt, she was shocked to see it suddenly change direction, weaving around her like a river past stone and continuing on.

Taking a chance, she raced for the light. It refused to strike her.

"Adora!"

For the moment at least, gone was her fears of Horde Prime's power. Gone was her anger over the world. Gone was the ball of hate that had been rotting inside her chest ever since that day in Thaymor. All that was left was worry for her oldest friend in the face of an unknown force.

She finally reached the inside of the light, finding Adora screaming in pain and fear. Emerald light clashed with golden light, both standing out in twisted veins on her body. In the back of her mind, Catra realized that whatever it was, it wasn't reacting well to what was left of She-Ra, but at the moment, she reached out without thinking.

"Adora! I'm here! I've got you!"

Adora calmed a bit at her touch. She'd stopped screaming at least. She looked up with hazy eyes and the ghost of a smile graced her face.

"Catra—"

And then her eyes rolled up and she passed out.

The emerald light began to fade. Catra reacted on pure instinct, gathering Adora up and dashing for the forest.

She ran through the undergrowth of the Whispering Woods, desperation flowing through her body. The veins of gold and green still twisted across Adora's body, and it worried her.

"Hey, you with the tail!"

Catra skidded to a halt.

"Wha--"

"Over here!"

Catra turned her head to see an ancient woman waving at her from behind a bush.

"Quickly, they may try to follow. But Madame Razz knows all the safe places in the forest. Come, come!"

Lacking any other options, Catra followed the strange woman.

The woman, apparently named Madame Razz, soon led her to a hovel resting in the roots of a massive tree. Nudging her way past the curtain of a front door, Catra laid Adora down on the bed that Razz indicated.

“I’ve got some burn cream and some wrappings for her wounds,” Razz said, bustling about the hut, “Try to get an accounting of what ails her.”

Adora twitched unconsciously, her face screwed up in pain. Catra felt a sting in her chest as she and Razz tended to Adora.

“This is strange,” Razz muttered, tracing one of the glowing veins with one finger, “What exactly happened to her?”

Catra told an abbreviated version of prior events, and Razz nodded along as she applied her medicines.

“You two are lucky you caught me on one of my better days. Sometimes, the past, the present, and the future…they get all muddled around in my head.”

Razz laughed self-deprecatingly.

“When over a thousand you reach, we’ll see how well your mind is.”

“I’m sorry, what?” Catra asked, but Razz just continued.

"But I think whatever energies she's absorbed, it's clashing with the power of She-Ra that also lives in her."

"But the sword's broken," Catra said, indicating Adora's left hand, which still had a death grip on the broken blade.

"Pah! She-Ra is not a sword," Razz replied dismissively, "She-Ra is a force, one far older than you can imagine. She-Ra is Etheria's protector, no matter what form she may take. Besides, one does not regularly bathe in such powerful magic without it leaving a mark. The power surrounds her even now, diminished as it may be for the moment. But the real conflict seems to center on this ring."

Razz held up Adora's right hand. On her finger sat a ring that Catra had never seen before. It was a simple thing, made of dark green metal with an odd sigil upon it. The lines of the sigil glowed a strange green light. Veins of green seemed to pulse on the hand that bore the ring, reaching up her arm before disseminating throughout her body, popping up in various places and clashing with similar veins of gold.

Catra reacted quickly, trying to tug the ring off. But no matter how hard she pulled, the ring didn't so much as twitch. Razz finally stopped her.

"Any more and you'll tear her finger off, and I think you should ask her permission before going that far."

"We have to do something!" Catra growled.

"We've done what we can," Razz replied, placing a damp cloth on Adora's forehead, "The rest is up to her."

Catra took a deep breath, trying to calm herself down. Adora was away from the Horde at least—

A Horde that Catra had had a precarious position in. A Horde headed by a madman worse than Hordak and Shadow Weaver combined. A Horde that was swiftly taking over the whole planet.

A Horde that wanted She-Ra's power. A Horde that now would be looking for Catra was well, eager to repay her betrayal.

"Oh, we're boned," Catra moaned.

"Pardon, dearie? I didn't catch that," Razz said.

"Oh, nothing, just that I've yet again found myself up the creek without a paddle, that's all! Now a bunch of monsters will be gunning for me, and for what? For saving someone who probably hates me anyway? Why did I go for Adora? That ship's sailed, no matter how much I wish otherwise sometimes!"

Catra let out a yowl of frustration and kicked over a bucket. Unfortunately for her frustrations and fortunately for Razz's house, it was empty. Catra growled and slumped down to the ground beside Adora's bed.

"Just another rotten day in my rotten life! What the hell does the universe even want with me? I didn't ask for any of this!"

Suddenly, there was a gentle touch on her cheek. Razz was looking at her very intently.

"What?"

"You know, you live long enough, you see the same eyes in different people. Eyes are windows to the soul, you know."

"And?" Catra asked, feeling a little creeped out.

"You have been through so much. I can see it in your eyes. A life with so little love that you cling tight to what you get, even if it's from a poisonous source. And this has made you angry, made you lash out even at those trying to extend a hand in kindness. Yes, many have wronged you in the past, made you bitter, left you unable to see the darkness within and without until it was too late…"

Catra stared at her. Was this woman a mind reader or something?

"But that can be fixed."

Razz dropped her hand from Catra's face, instead taking her hand and patting it in a maternal fashion.

"You are still young, child. You have an entire life before you with which to find your place. And there are people out there who can help you, if you let them. You simply have to swallow your pride and simply *try*."

Catra was struck still by the old woman's gaze, brimming with kindness and wisdom that she didn't expect.

"Remember this above all else: The dark is generous and it is patient and it always wins—but in the heart of its strength lies its weakness…"

Razz gently grasped Catra's chin and guided her gaze to Adora.

"One lone candle is enough to hold it back. Love is more than a candle. Love can ignite the stars."

Chapter End Notes

You know what strikes me about She-Ra and the Princesses of Power? It's not like the original She-Ra, where it's a mighty hero having adventures. This story isn't really about She-Ra. It's about Adora. It's about the girl, not the hero. It's about an honorable soul who, finding out that her life is a lie, decides to take the chance given and run away from it, however scary it was to leave behind everything she's ever known. It's about her being chosen to carry on a heroic legacy, and her struggle to live up to it. It's about one young woman's choice to stand against a tide of darkness, while trying to keep in mind that she doesn't have to stand alone, and if that lesson doesn't always stick, well that's okay, she's human.

But it's also Catra's story. It's about another young woman who's been through a life of abuse and it's made her bitter. It's about this broken girl and her continuing poor decisions, and how she moves past them. It's about, seeing what she worked for and the one person she truly cared about being ripped away from her, she was consumed by anger and hate, spiraling into villainy. It's about how love helped her claw her way back out.

ND Stevenson has stated that they love the nemesis relationship, how these two people hate each other but also love each other and how it all gets wrapped up together. The fact that the creator does such a good job portraying this, that their fight at the end of Season 1 feels just as inevitable as the Big Damn Kiss at the end of the series, is a testament to one of the show's core strengths: that the stories of two people can be so intertwined, even if they're taking different paths.

Adora and Catra's roads were always going to lead back to each other. And no power in the universe would ever change that.

The Lantern

Chapter Notes

> Have any of you seen Justice League: The New Frontier? You should, it's great. I pulled from Hal Jordan's first experience activating the ring's full power for Adora's dream sequence here.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 3

The Lantern

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The blackness swirled with green streams and sparks. Strange faces loomed in the ever-changing pattern. She could hear whispers, strange voices interspersed with pieces of memory.

Adora…

"Hey, Adora!"

"Ever since the Horde got here, they've been poisoning our land, burning our cities, destroying EVERYTHING in their path! And you're a part of it!"

"FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"

"I'm saying this is wrong. They've been lying to us, manipulating us…I'm not going home, Catra. I can't, not after everything I've seen. Come with me. You don't have to go back there, we can fix this."

But Catra's confusion swiftly turned to anger.

"Are you kidding? You've known these people for, what, a couple hours? And now you're gonna throw everything away for them*? Ugh. What happened to you?"*

"The Rebellion accepts your allegiance, She-Ra, Princess of Power!"

Listen well, Adora…you hold powerful will and unstoppable courage…courage enough to stand for your beliefs, despite the personal cost…

"You were nothing before I took you in, Adora! And you will be nothing without me!"

"Maybe my plan won't work…but then again…maybe it already has."

"YOu tOok EVerYthiNG FRom mE!"

"I won't be controlled. I am not a piece of their machine. I am not a weapon*. And I am going to end. This. NOW!"*

And with a nigh-impossible burst of effort, a sword shatters.

The ring has great power, but it has chosen you…you are the key…

"Why are you looking at me like that? Wait, no. I know what this is about! Ugh, I knew you'd be weird about me letting you escape. I told you, it's not because I like you!"

"I mean, I didn't—I didn't say anything."

"Hey…I miss you too."

"What? Psh, I don't miss you! Get over yourself!"

"Not until you admit you like me!"

And for a moment, they laughed and played like they were children again.

"What is this?"

"Since you've never slept in a room by yourself before, Bow and I thought we'd throw you a sleepover, then you wouldn't feel so

alone."

"We even got you a new bed."

She walks over and lays down on the hard mattress.

"It's wonderful."

"We can do this tomorrow, too. Since Glimmer's grounded for ignoring orders."

"For one week! That's three weeks less than normal! AND, Mom said she'd consider my plan to recruit new princesses into the Rebellion!"

"Thanks, guys. I might not ever be the perfect hero everybody wants me to be, but that's okay."

Hit by a pillow, courtesy of Glimmer.

"Of course it's okay. Do you have any idea how annoying you'd be if you were perfect?"

"Aw, Best Friend Squad is having a pillow fight!"

"Yeah, we're not calling ourselves that."

"I prefer the Glimmer Group."

"Nah. We're the Best Friend Squad."

Your will drives the ring…clear your mind and focus on what matters…

"You inspired us. You inspired me. Not because it was your destiny, but because you never let fear stop you…Take care of each other…"

"Best Friend Squad, together again!" "Woo!"

"So it's up to you now. I couldn't stop it. In the end, I wasn't strong enough. But you, Adora, you will be more powerful than they ever planned…Adora, I believe in you. You can save the world we love."

"I'm not Mara. I'm not the She-Ras of the past. I didn't do this to fulfill some destiny. I became She-Ra to help others. My attachments…my friends…are a part of who I am."

"It doesn't matter what they do to us, you know? You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really *bad can happen as long as we have each other."*

"You promise?"

"I promise."

The light can be shaped by your imagination, your will made manifest…

"The sword has many forms, and you can alter it through your own will."

Shed that light over dark evil. For dark things cannot stand the light…

There was Hordak reclining on his throne. There was Catra, corrupted by rage and the energies of the portal. There were the marching armies of the Horde. There was Shadow Weaver, tendrils of darkness twisting around her and speaking in that poisonous tone of voice.

You are more than you were. You are now a Green Lantern.

And throughout all that she saw and heard, there was one whisper repeating something, like a mantra. The whisper flowed underneath everything, settling into her brain…

In brightest day…

Adora bolted upright.

"Ah-blackest-night!"

"Adora?"

Adora turned, seeing someone she didn't expect sitting on a stool by her bedside.

"Catra?"

Catra breathed a sigh of relief.

"Hey, Adora…had me worried there for a bit."

Adora shook her head, rubbing at her temples.

"What happened?"

"Crazy magic ring showed up and latched onto you. What was left of She-Ra didn't like it, and the weird energy clash knocked you out. You're welcome for getting your fat out of the fire."

Adora lowered her hands, noticing the strange green ring now adorning her finger. She immediately started fiddling with it.

"Yeah, don't bother," Catra said, "That sucker wouldn't budge."

She looked over at the smirking Catra.

"You're enjoying my confusion, aren't you?"

"Maybe a little. Hey, with my life, I take my comedy where I can get it."

"Why are you here? Why did you save me?"

Catra's grin vanished.

"So shocked?"

Adora was struck by the bitterness in Catra's voice. Catra gave a mocking laugh.

"Why did I bother, I wonder? I should have known you'd act like this. You never did have much faith in me. Always having to be the hero, never grateful when someone else tries to protect you, isn't that right?"

It was an old argument, one that Adora hadn't been able to defuse. At the moment, she realized she didn't want to, not if every other time had been a failure.

"How many times do I have to tell you? It was *never* like that! You weren't a sidekick or a pet, you were my *friend*! Is it so hard to believe that I'd want to help you, to protect you?"

Tears of frustration pooled in Adora's eyes. Catra snarled right back, rising to her feet.

"That didn't stop you from leaving! Leaving me alone in the Horde, leaving me to Shadow Weaver! I had to crawl my way up from the bottom, and where were you? Off playing princess with your shiny new friends!"

"I tried to get you to leave with me, but you wouldn't listen!" Adora shouted back, standing up herself, "Too proud to admit how hurt and afraid they made you, too proud to take an out when I offered it!"

"What happened to all those plans we made? You threw them away, just like you did me!"

"You walked away!"

"You left first!"

"Why are you like this?!" Adora cried out, throwing her hands in the air.

"What do you care?" Catra spat, "What does Adora care about anything that doesn't fit in her new perfect life?"

"*Perfect*? Do you have the slightest idea what me and my friends have been through?! What we had to sacrifice to stop the Horde? To stop you at your worst? I get that you've been through hell, but so have we!"

"Oh, don't pretend you 'get it'! I know you all hate me!"

"*I never hated you!"*

Everything stopped. Adora breathed heavily, hot tears dripping down her face. Catra stumbled back against the wall, stunned and staring at Adora with wide eyes. Her flare of anger was extinguished, replaced by a swirl of emotions.

"I never hated you," Adora repeated, her voice soft, "There were times I wanted to. It would have been so *easy* to hate you for everything…but I never did. Just the thought of it made me sick."

"You gave me a death glare after the portal thing," Catra countered weakly.

"I was angry over everything that had just happened. I worked it out in the training yard afterward," Adora said, sitting down on the bed with a faraway look in her eyes, "I just hit the dummies until I started screaming, then screamed until I started crying. I had

nightmares of you becoming that…thing. Watching my oldest friend be consumed by madness…it was…"

She trailed off, but Catra could guess.

"Wasn't fun on my end," Catra said, "It took a while to piece myself back together. My own nightmares didn't help. I…regret it, now. I was just so angry in the moment that I couldn't think straight, I just wanted the win."

"Wasn't worth it, was it?"

Catra's silence and broken gaze answered for her. Adora sighed and shifted in the bed, staring at the wall.

Neither of them spoke for some time, their minds awhirl and their hearts aching over what had been lost.

"So," Catra spoke up, taking a forced-casual tone, "How about that ring?"

"I had this weird dream," Adora said, recognizing that Catra wished a subject change and rolling with it, "Everything was green, and there were these voices. They were talking about how I'd been chosen. I think…I think the ring was talking to me."

"About what?"

"About what it does…hang on, I think I…"

She put her ringed hand against the wall and closed her eyes, face screwing up in concentration. The ring began to glow brightly. Energy pooled beneath her hand, a shimmering field of dark green appearing like ripples in a pond.

Adora's hand sank into the field, and Catra's breath caught.

"Did…did you just make a portal?" she whispered.

Adora didn't hear her. A feeling engulfed her hand, hot and cold at the same time. Something hit her palm, and she grasped it instinctually. She pulled back, bringing the object out from the green into reality.

She opened her eyes and stared. Hanging from her hand was a new object, all curved lines and green metal. One face of it shimmered a bright green.

"That…looks like a lantern," Catra said.

"It is," Adora said, her voice sounding far away.

Catra started, nothing how empty Adora's eyes looked.

"Adora?"

But Adora ignored her, setting the lantern down and touching her ring to the glimmering face. The light shined brighter, and Adora began to speak:

"*In brightest day, in blackest night,*

No evil shall escape my sight.

Let those who worship evil's might

Beware my power, Green Lantern's light."

The air seemed to shudder under the weight of the words, as if speaking them meant something more than the words themselves could contain. There was a bright flash of light, and another voice sounded.

Power at one hundred percent.

There was a moment of silence as the green light faded. Adora blinked back into focus, looking from the ring to the lantern. A thousand questions burned between them, but Catra only managed one.

"That thing has a battery life?"

"I guess? I'll be honest, I'm not really sure what I did, but it felt really important."

Adora huffed.

"Great. Another mysterious weapon that I have no idea how to use. Because the last one wasn't enough."

"Won't lose this one, though," Catra said, "Again, that sucker's got a death grip on your finger. The more I looked at it while I waited for you to wake up, the more it seemed like it was almost…fused to you or something."

Adora just hummed, inspecting the ring.

Then Madame Razz poked her head in, completely wrecking the strange solemnity of the moment.

"Are you two done with emotional outbursts and experimenting with odd powers, or are you just taking a break?"

“How long were you standing out there?” Catra asked.

“You two probably woke half the forest with your shouting, and you ask Madame Razz how long she was listening?” Razz replied, stepping in with a deadpan look on her face.

“That’s…a fair point, actually,” Adora said.

“I trust you’re feeling better, dearie?”

“More confused than hurt at the moment.”

“So, nothing new then,” Razz laughed.

Adora glared at her, then at Catra when she heard a snicker.

“You two, the Horde, the ring…what is this, pick on Adora day?”

“I dunno, let me check my calendar,” Catra said with a snort.

“Okay, but in all seriousness,” Razz said, “You’ve got a ways to go, Adora. I know it is not fair for Etheria to ask so much of you, but these things rarely happen when we’re completely ready. You’ve

been chosen again, chosen for something great. What that will entail, I do not know. But with Etheria under threat, this new thing could not have come at a better time. My hope is that it will tip the balance. And perhaps, with this new power, She-Ra might return."

"But I broke the sword--"

Madame Razz made a dismissive noise.

"It is as I told Mara. She-Ra is far older than the First Ones, the mantle stretching back beyond recorded history. The sword was made by the First Ones to control the power, but it was never your source of strength."

Razz leaned heavily on her broom, giving Adora a piercing stare.

"The sword did not choose you. *She-Ra did*, her power working through the sword. She has always been there, a powerful ally in your fight against the darkness."

Razz picked the broken hilt off the floor where it had been all night and pressed it into Adora's hand.

"This is but a tool. She-Ra is far more than that. What you need, you already have. What happens next, that is up to you. Your

fate might be to protect Etheria, but how it happens is your choice."

Razz turned to Catra, giving her a smile.

"And of course, we all get by with a little help from friends."

Catra bristled slightly.

"I'm not her friend…not anymore."

Razz gave her a gimlet stare.

"No one drags another person away from a warzone and through a dangerous forest, then sits at their bedside all night, wringing their hands with worry, if they aren't friends."

Razz looked over at Adora.

"Protests too much, this one," she said, gesturing toward the sputtering Catra.

"It's a common theme," Adora replied.

Then she looked at the objects in her lap. The shimmering lantern and the broken sword stared up at her.

A spark of an idea burst to life.

"I know that smile," Catra said, looking at Adora, "You've got an idea."

"The start of one, at least," Adora said, projecting the portal again and putting the lantern back, "You sticking around? I could use the help."

Catra sighed.

"I don't have much better to do. Might as well."

She tried to play it cool, but deep inside, a part of her was happy to be around Adora again.

"Then come on. I need a few things before we get started."

Adora stepped outside the hut, breathing in the air. It felt like a new start.

“Thanks for your help, Razz.”

“No problem, dearie. I enjoy our visits. Just one more piece of advice before you both go…”

“And here we go,” Catra muttered, but Adora hissed at her to be nice.

Razz took on a very solemn air.

“You have both been through hardships. You have both made mistakes, some bigger than others. But you cannot let recent history poison your future.”

Razz trailed off, gazing up at the sky.

“Yes, the winds are changing, whether anyone wants them to or not.”

“I don’t think it’s that simple, lady,” Catra groused.

“Yeah, change isn’t exactly easy,” Adora said, her voice carrying the weight of experience.

Madame Razz lashed out twice, hitting both of them on the head with her broom.

"Ow! What the hell was that for?" Catra hissed, clutching her head.

"What does it matter? It's in the past!" Razz laughed.

"Still hurts, though," Adora moaned.

"Ah, yes, the past can hurt," Razz replied in a wizened tone, "But the way this old woman sees it, you can either *run* from it…or, *learn* from it."

She swung her broom again. This time, Adora ducked, and Catra leapt out of the way.

"There, you see! But don't let me keep you, I'm sure you'll both be very busy. Maybe after all this, we can bake a pie!"

Then Madame Razz walked back into her hut, humming an old song.

"That woman is *weird*," Catra finally said.

"I'm like seventy percent certain she's a witch," Adora replied, "So…yeah."

"Maybe crank that number up. She made this crack about being over a thousand years old, and I'm not sure she was entirely joking."

Adora paused, her eyes wide.

"That…would explain way too much."

"What do you mean?"

"I'm not the first She-Ra. There have been others. The last one was named Mara, and Razz claimed to have known her. Thing is, Mara died a thousand years ago."

Catra stared at her, her eyes wide and her tail bristling. Her gaze shifted from Razz's hut, then back to Adora.

"Nope," she finally said, spinning on her heel and starting to walk away, "Screw this, we're out. We're moving on, where to first?"

oOo

"Well, this place is a ghost town," Catra said, looking around the abandoned tents.

"Micah and Shadow Weaver were talking about pulling up sticks and relocating," Adora said, "They must have pulled a rush job of it after Bright Moon."

"What do you expect to find here?"

"Hopefully, something they didn't think to pack up when they left."

Adora walked forward, counting the tents before making a satisfied noise.

"This one. This one was mine."

She entered the tent, Catra following.

"So we're looking for something specif--"

Then Catra noticed the jagged pieces of metal on the table next to the cot.

"Oh."

"You catch on quick," Adora said, going through a trunk, "Okay, this'll work."

She withdrew a shirt, tying the collar closed and the sleeves together. Then she started shoveling the metal shards into the makeshift sack.

"Glad I still have the hilt, or we'd have to sneak back into Bright Moon. And with it crawling with Horde, I don't expect that to have been easy."

"Yeah, you had a death grip on it, even unconscious," Catra said, "It took ten minutes to pry that thing out of your hand. You're going to try and reforge the sword, aren't you?"

"That's the plan," Adora said, tying her sack closed, "I'm sure we'll find blacksmithing tools somewhere."

"Okay, but how? Do you even know?"

"Actually, yes. See, sometime after a joined the Rebellion, Bow and Glimmer were worried about me, thinking I was working myself too hard."

"Yeah, I can see that," Catra deadpanned, "That's kind of always been a thing with you, Miss Perfectionist."

"They ended up taking me to Mystacor for a relaxing vacation. Didn't work, Shadow Weaver was sending her little spies to torment me at the same time, so I didn't get to really destress until later in the trip."

Adora paused, getting an angry look on her face.

"Woman just can't help but ruin everything for people."

"In other news, water is wet," Catra snarked.

"Still, I recognized that I needed something to relax myself with when I wasn't in the field or improving my She-Ra stuff. I needed a hobby. After getting back to Bright Moon, I ended up asking Queen Angella for ideas. Took a while, though. I didn't have the patience for puzzles or chess, I got tangled up in yarn and nearly stabbed myself with the needles when I tried knitting, and the less said about my sad attempts at baking, the better."

"So you ended up with blacksmithing?"

"Yup. By complete accident, really. But I found I had a small talent for it, and working with the royal smith helped me mold that talent into something finer."

Adora got a smile on her face.

"It felt…good. Working with my hands, creating something. Never got the chance to learn small-detail work like chainmail, but weapons? That I can make."

"So you're going to take a piece of advanced First Ones weaponry and just…fix it?"

"Hopefully. My idea was that I would bathe it in the green light as I make it. That might jumpstart the sword's magic."

"How do you know that'll work?"

"I don't. But I have to try. We *need* She-Ra. And I can't stand by while the whole world is in danger."

"Honestly? I didn't think you would," Catra sighed, "That's just who you are."

oOo

They ended up finding a bombed-out village at the edge of the Whispering Woods and settling there. They cleaned up a house to live out of, and Adora got the smithy next door working again.

It had been over a week since then, and Catra strode back into their little homestead from hunting in the woods. She'd managed to bring in some birds, so it would be good eating tonight.

After putting the fresh meat away, Catra made her way to Adora's workshop. As she entered, she shucked her black jacket. She'd scavenged it and a new shirt from the village wreckage, ditching her Horde-aligned top. Adora had claimed the jacket looked nice on her, but it was too hot to wear in the forge.

Adora was just finishing up another attempt, inspecting the now-cooled blade.

"That looks good," Catra said.

"It *looks* good, but…"

Adora swung at the anvil. The sword broke.

"Another failure," she moaned, setting the pieces aside, "It's a good thing the First Ones metal has special properties, so I can recover it, but that's the fifth try."

Adora sighed, stretching out her tired arms. Catra tried not to stare. It had been a long time since she'd seen Adora's muscles in all their glory. She'd almost forgotten how impressive they were, even without She-Ra enhancing them.

"You'll get it eventually. How's the green light working?"

"Actually, not as well as I'd hoped," Adora replied, gesturing toward the lantern sitting in the corner, "It's like nothing on Etheria, and the She-Ra energies are still clashing. It's calmed down a lot since that first day, but…I don't know, I feel like I'm missing something."

"Maybe you are? I mean, where did the ring even come from?"

"From beyond. And that's all I know. I know it's part of something greater, something called the Green Lantern Corps, but I don't know how to reach out to it."

Adora tapped at the ring.

"I'm sure I could contact them, but that mechanism is…I don't know, damaged or something. Maybe it's Etheria's magic, maybe

it’s that weird initial reaction to the She-Ra energy in my system, or maybe something happened to it on the way here. Either way, we shouldn’t expect anything from that anytime soon.”

“The light itself still works, right?”

“Sometimes, yes. I’ve been practicing shaping the light like my dream said, but sometimes I have to stop because it’s making She-Ra…well…”

“Cranky?” Catra snarked.

“Something like that, yeah.”

“Well, I doubt you’re getting more today.”

“Yeah, you’re right,” Adora said, moving to douse the fires, “It’s just bugging me. I feel like I’m stuck in a rut.”

“I felt the same way after you left,” Catra replied, nodding.

“How’d you get out of it?”

"I went insane. Don't recommend it."

Adora grimaced.

"How are your nightmares?" she asked softly.

"Not as bad as before," Catra replied.

What she didn't say was that knowing Adora was nearby helped. They'd taken to sleeping in the same room. It was touch-and-go at first, but things had softened between them. It was a strange sort of domesticity, living out of the village at the edge of the woods. They worked out how to cook together, slept near each other to ward off inevitable nightmares, and had actual conversations that were surprisingly civil. They didn't touch very much on the recent past, both recognizing that minefield for what it was and knowing they were nowhere near ready to talk about parts of it without devolving into anger, but still…

Part of Catra didn't know what to think, having Adora so close after so long at each other's throats. Another, more logical part of her reminded her of the conversation in Razz's hut, how even at her angriest, Adora had never hated Catra. Still another, sounding very much like the scared little girl she'd been so long ago, was happy that things seemed to be less tense between them, and growing less as time went on.

Catra wondered what would happen to ruin this.

She shook the thought away.

Later, however, her entire train of thought came back.

"I missed this."

Catra looked up in confusion, but had the sense to swallow the chunk of meat in her mouth before speaking.

"Missed what?"

"This," Adora said, gesturing, "The two of us, just…doing things. Together. I missed it."

There are a dozen comments on Catra's tongue. Many of them were negative, some variation of 'well, you shouldn't have left then' or a similar snide remark of the break in their friendship.

Instead, she was surprised to find herself say, "Yeah, I did too."

A little seed of hope that a long life of trauma had conditioned her to ignore suddenly bloomed in her chest, something that said maybe this time she'd get to keep this undeniable good.

She couldn’t ignore it.

Chapter End Notes

You know what I always found odd? There are multiple stories where a Lantern is separated from their ring for one reason or another, and especially in the Silver Age where that was good for quick drama, such a thing seems very easy to accomplish. I feel like that’s an oversight on the construction/programming of Lantern rings. You’d think there’d be a security feature to prevent anyone but the user from removing a ring, or heck, just making it near impossible to remove period (the Guardians notwithstanding since they made the damn things). We’re talking about one of the most powerful and versatile weapons in all of fiction, it should not be as easy to lose as your car keys!
And on a different subject, there were two people I had in mind when writing Madame Razz. The first was the obvious Yoda parallels that the creators no doubt intended. The other connection was made as I was planning out her scenes, that being Rafiki from The Lion King.
As should be obvious.

Forged

Chapter Notes

I am really proud of the final scenes, e.g. the forging. But we have a lot of other things to get through first, so here we go!

Gold Light, Green Light

-

Chapter 4

Forged

-

-

"Why did you leave?" the small furry child asked, her eyes wide and dewy, her ears folded back, her tail hanging low.

"I didn't want to!" Adora shouted back over the yawning chasm between them, "I wanted you to come with me!"

"But you still abandoned me!" the child shouted back, aging before Adora's eyes, "You left me in the Fright Zone, to Shadow Weaver's tender mercies! Is it any wonder I spiraled into the dark!"

The young woman suddenly gained a fractured appearance, her face and arm eclipsed by jagged blackness.

"YoU miGHT aS WelL hAve PUsheD ME yoURselF!"

The blackness vanished, revealing the woman whole, but her face showing nothing but cold anger.

"Shadow Weaver got one thing right: you are responsible for me. Your influence helped me survive, your absence made me fall. Your actions against me drove me even further. Even you can't reach me now."

"No, it's not too late!" Adora shouted, "We can still fix this. Please, help me fix it! I can't lose you again!"

But the woman just shook her head.

"It's too late…"

And then Shadow Weaver was behind her.

"Far too late," the sorceress said, raising a blade formed of shadow.

SHLUNK!

“CATRA!”

Adora came awake screaming. Cold sweat dripped off her, and the room was filled with the sound of her heavy breath.

She looked across the room. Catra was looking at her from the other bed, eyes wide.

“You too, huh?” she asked.

“Wha…what?”

“Guess we’re both having nightmares tonight,” Catra said sadly.

Adora got up and hurried over, grasping Catra’s shoulders as if to confirm what she was seeing.

“You’re here…you’re okay…”

“Woah, that must have been some nightmare.”

Adora shook her head.

"Please…don't ask."

"Wasn't going to," Catra replied.

Then Adora took a hard look at Catra. The whipping of her bristled tail, the fold in her ears, the way she wouldn't look Adora in the eye.

She made a decision.

"Scoot over. I don't think either of us is getting back to sleep unless we're sure the other is okay."

Catra didn't argue, although for a moment, she looked like she wanted too. Her nightmare must have shaken her up just as much.

For a moment, they didn't speak. They just lay back-to-back. There was a stiffness to it, the two uncomfortable with this level of closeness after so long apart.

"Horde Prime killed you," Catra said suddenly, "He made me watch. I couldn't do anything."

Adora inhaled sharply, then turned over and drew Catra into a hug. Catra stiffened at the contact, but slowly relaxed.

"It was Shadow Weaver for me. She stabbed you from behind."

"She really is the worst, isn't she?"

"I'm really sorry for leaving you alone with her."

She heard Catra inhale sharply. Then she felt Catra gently grab her hand.

"I'd risen up, but she still claimed I was nothing. I beat her, and she still didn't respect me. She showed me some affection once, but it was just a ploy to get her what she needed to escape."

"All she does is take. All she does it ruin people. That's all she'll ever do. But we don't need to let that be her legacy for us. We can overcome."

Catra didn't answer, but she did hold Adora's hand tighter and curl slightly around her arm.

oOo

Sunlight crept in from the gaps in the window shutters. Adora's eyelids flickered and scrunched at the offending light.

Eventually, she opened her eyes, and started slightly. Catra's sleeping face was inches from hers. The other girl must have turned over in the night. She was curled up close, her tail laying across Adora's waist. Adora could feel the soft tickle of Catra's fur. It felt…nice, having her this close.

Adora smiled. Catra looked so peaceful, a far cry from the subtle anger and nervous energy that characterized her waking hours. Her face was relaxed, the tiniest of snores issued from her mouth, and her ear twitched occasionally in her sleep.

As Adora lay there, listening to Catra's soft breathing and unconscious purrs, she was struck by a feeling of tenderness towards Catra. It was nothing new, she'd always felt protective towards the catgirl, but this seemed…different. This peacefulness she was seeing, she wanted Catra to feel like that all the time, and if she could be a little selfish, she wanted to be the cause of it. She'd missed Catra so hard it had ached. Having her near after so long, it was like being able to breathe again.

She'd never say it aloud, though. Catra was too proud, too wild, for any kind of talk like that to go over well, especially suddenly. And there was too much bad blood between the two. Things were improving, now, but Adora didn't feel comfortable discussing any kind of deeper feelings with Catra, and she was certain Catra

was the same. If she did bring it up, it would only push Catra away, and she couldn't bear to go through that again.

Unless something dramatic happened, things were just going to have to progress slowly.

But Adora couldn't lie to herself: she wanted desperately to have Catra in her life again, to be close to her like they once were.

It would have surprised Adora to know that Catra had been having the same thoughts…

oOo

Catra's ears flicked. She growled a bit.

Adora paused in hanging up some wet clothes on the line.

"What is it?"

"I don't know. Something's off."

A sudden wind blew. A rumble echoed from the direction of the open field.

"Hide," Catra suddenly said.

"Wha--"

"I said hide!"

Catra grabbed Adora's hand and practically dragged her into the smithy, shutting the door behind them.

"Catra, what's going on?"

"Something's out there. I don't know what, but it can't be good."

"I didn't see anything!"

"Exactly."

Adora blinked, then walked over and grabbed the hammer off the anvil.

“What do you figure?” she asked, her low voice all business.

“Don’t know, but it’s making my fur stand up.”

Adora glanced at Catra’s tail, which was bristling.

They waited in silence for a moment. Then, muffled voices could be heard outside. Catra put one hand on the door and raised the other. Her fingers slowly counted down, and Adora raised her hammer.

The leap into action was done quickly and professionally. Catra went first, bursting from the smithy and tackling one figure to the ground, only for her vision to briefly fill with purple and something hairy brush at her mouth. At the same time, Adora rushed toward the other one, only to find an arrow pointed at her nose.

“Adora?”

“Bow?”

“Entrapta?”

“Catra?”

Bow immediately dropped his weapons and yanked Adora into a hug.

“I was so worried!”

“Ha-ha! You’re both alive!” Entrapta squealed, wrapping Catra in a hair-hug, “Excellent!”

“Personal space,” Catra hissed.

Entrapta immediately released her.

“Apologies, it’s been a while.”

Catra flinched, her brain catching up with the rest of her in regards to Entrapta. She stepped back quickly, then gave the newcomers an odd look.

“What are you two doing here?”

"Looking for Adora. Didn't expect you," Bow replied, giving her a flat look.

"Bow, don't start. Catra was the one who got me away from Bright Moon. If it weren't for her, I'd either be captured or dead," Adora said, her tone brooking no argument, "She's with us, deal with it."

Bow sighed.

"Okay, fine. Let's get out of the open and we'll talk."

They filed into the smithy, Entrapta immediately making a beeline for the sword fragments.

"Oh, are you trying to repair your sword?"

"Trying, mostly failing," Adora said, "Things have been…weird. But, you guys first. What's been going on? We went back to camp, but it was deserted."

"After getting back from Bright Moon, we noticed a few surveillance drones sniffing around," Bow explained, "Me and Scorpia took them out, but it was clear we had to move. Everyone scattered for safety, but we met back up in the Kingdom of Snows. Not the castle proper, too obvious, but the mountains had plenty of hidey-holes."

"I remember hearing about those in the Horde. It's partly why the kingdom was never conquered," Adora nodded, "The other half is the royal family having control over ice and snow, and in the right environment, they're practically unstoppable."

"Home-field advantage cranked to eleven," Entrapta agreed, "I did calculations for Hordak once. They did not end well for the Horde."

"I saw that report," Catra interjected, "It's why I ordered all troops pulled back from that border. Didn't want to give Little Snowbird an excuse."

"Sound strategy," Bow said, "Frosta buried one squad of Prime's robots in an avalanche last week. Also, that's an adorable nickname and I'm stealing it. Anyway, everyone trickled back in over the next few days, but when you didn't show up, I got worried. Thankfully, we still had Mara's ship, and Entrapta was able to work it."

"It is a fascinating machine!" Entrapta squealed, "I've dedicated as much time to it as I can, it's almost spaceworthy if we need that! We've held off on trying to rescue Glimmer since we don't know exactly where in space she is, and that's kind of important to know when we're dealing with the vast emptiness!"

"Makes sense," Adora said over Entrapta's mad laughter.

“So we decided to use it to cover more ground,” Bow continued, “Shadow Weaver managed to apply a spell of invisibility to it, all the better for ducking patrols. Problem is, it doesn’t last long—"

“A mix between the power needs of cloaking a ship that big and the nature of the exterior, it’s a unique metal,” Entrapta interjected.

“—so we’ve had to duck back almost daily to recharge the crystal she tied the spell to. It’s why it took so long.”

“Well, I’m glad you’re here, I could use another set of eyes,” Adora said, “So something weird happened at Bright Moon…”

As Adora launched into her story, Catra settled against the wall, watching everything. She didn’t feel like socializing, and it wasn’t all down to her own solitary nature. She felt guilty over what happened to Entrapta, effectively sentencing the princess to die. Being around her again was like a constant reminder of her madness.

And then there was Adora. How easy it was for her to slip back into camaraderie with Bow, as if this recent time with Catra, slowly trying to rebuild a fractured relationship, hadn’t happened. Catra knew she wasn’t being entirely fair, but she couldn’t help but feel alienated.

So she kept silent, even as Adora moved into explaining her sword problem

"I gotta be honest, Adora, as much as I know about metalcraft, this isn't really my specialty. I don't really work with swords, especially super-magical ones," Bow said, rolling the detached hilt in his hands.

"The Sword of Protection isn't just magic, though," Entrapta said, looking through the metal shards with her mask and a hand-held device, "It's also advanced science. That means it has rules, however esoteric. We learn the rules, we have a chance. Adora, have you made any notes on what you've done so far?"

"Catra, that desk beside you?" Adora called out.

Catra shifted around, rifling through a drawer.

"Notebook!" she called, tossing it over.

Entrapta caught it with one hair tendril, then opened it up, her eyes scanning over it rapidly.

"Lucky for you, I'm a speed-reader," she said, "Okay, so in my opinion, you're on the right track. And I can't fault your technique. One of the problems might be your facilities. We could go to Dryl and use mine, I custom-mix most of the alloys I

work with, so my melter might work better for the First Ones metal than this old forge. And clearly, just letting the green light play off the metal isn't working. Perhaps something more potent, something to more strongly kickstart the sword's inherent magic? I need to think more on it."

"I think one of the main problems is the metal you're using," Bow said, looking over Entrapta's shoulder at a rough list, "You weren't able to recover all the sword pieces, so you've been trying to alloy it with regular Etherian metals. I don't think that'll work. We need something better."

"A metal quality closer to the sword's original alloy might work," Entrapta nodded, "I got an idea, grab one of the pieces. We can see if we can find a match in the ship's database."

They quickly filed out of the smithy and into the field. Bow clicked a small device, and a hatch opened in midair, releasing what amounted to a gangplank.

"Well, this is a sight," Catra snarked, staring into a metallic hole in the sky, "But at least only the exterior is invisible."

"If the whole thing were invisible, that would be really hard to drive," Entrapta said, "And it would probably look ridiculous. I keep imagining someone zooming away in a seated position."

"That's an image," Bow chuckled.

"That's a weird representation of a stealth ship," Catra countered.

It took a minute to get the database working, Entrapta explaining that there were still a few bugs in the system.

"Well, the ship is over a thousand years old," Adora had said.

But they managed to get a scan of one of the sword shards and cross-reference it. Luckily, a record of a suitable ore was in the database. Unluckily, they would have to mine it from one of Etheria's moons.

Resigned to taking a trip, Adora and Catra packed up the blacksmithing tools and anything else they needed and loaded it on the ship. On the last trip, they saw Bow releasing a bird into the air.

"Sending a message back to the others via carrier pigeon," he explained, "Best way to prevent the new Horde from intercepting. No one suspects a bird."

"I mean, I might, but that's just my feline instincts," Catra muttered.

oOo

“I can tell this thing is old,” Catra growled over the rumbles shaking everything.

“Sorry, it’s never done this before!” Entrapta said, rapidly working the main console.

The ship leveled out, the rumbles ceasing.

“That’s strange,” Entrapta said, “She’s always been a little wobbly, but nothing like that. I should check the engines again.”

“Probably a good idea, since we’re breaching the atmosphere,” Bow said, moving to take Entrapta’s place.

As Entrapta scurried out of the cockpit, Catra grumbled.

“Why did I agree to come along, again?”

“Well…in for a bronze chip?” Adora said weakly.

“That phrase never made sense to me.”

"Or maybe Adora gave you puppy eyes until you caved," Bow muttered quietly, but not quiet enough to miss Catra's ears. She turned and grunted, ostensibly to end the conversation, but mostly to hide her sudden blush.

The conversation was truly ended when a nearby panel popped open, disgorging a mass of wires.

"I got it!" Adora cried, "Where's the tape?"

Bow loosened a box that had been wedged under his console and kicked it toward Adora. Catra helped Adora wrestle the mass into a manageable shape before shoving it back into is former place.

"I now get why you were so wary," Adora said to Catra.

"Right?" Catra nodded, "We're lucky this is only a shor--"

"Please don't jinx it!" Bow yelped.

The rest of the trip went relatively smoothly. Entrapta soon returned to the helm, muttering about a list of things to look at later. The ship continued to jolt unexpectedly, but Entrapta quickly compensated. They skirted the few Horde ships in orbit before settling on the furthest moon of Etheria.

"Okay, if no one else will, I'll say it," Catra said, "This is insane. We just took thousand-plus-year-old spaceship to one of the moons."

"Bet you didn't get this kind of excitement in the Horde, right?" Adora said, nudging her playfully.

"Adora, she was practically running it near the end," Bow scoffed, "That had to have been kind of exciting, in a twisted way, right?"

"Actually, if I'm being honest, I was pretty miserable," Catra deadpanned.

And there was an awkward silence.

"Okay, good news, bad news time!" Entrapta grinned, completely oblivious to the conversation of her fellows, "Good news, we made it safely, and there's equipment on the ship that's in good condition, so we should have no trouble extracting the ore we need."

"And the bad news?" Bow asked, secretly glad for a change in subject.

"I only had enough time to make sure two spacesuits are ready for action. Modifying my helmet so I could use my hair safely was the big challenge, and it ate up time."

"Then you and me will get what we need," Adora said, "Bow and Catra can keep lookout in case any Horde drones get suspicious."

"Can do," Bow said, saluting.

Catra ended up splitting her gaze between the scanner she'd set up near and the window, looking in the direction that the suited Adora and Entrapta had disappeared in. She bit her lip and reached over to another console.

"Everything okay out there, Adora?" she spoke into a device.

"*We're good,*" Adora's voice answered from a speaker, "*Entrapta and I found the ore pretty quick. We need to sort through some samples, but we should be ready to return to Etheria within…I wanna say an hour? All quiet in the skies?*"

"All clear, but pick up the pace. Even if this ship is invisible, being out in the open is making me nervous."

Adora sent her affirmative, then all went silent. Catra turned back to the scanner.

"So, you and Adora, huh?" Bow suddenly said, "You two friends again, or something?"

"Or something," Catra said in a tone that made it clear she didn't want to talk.

Bow didn't pick up on that.

"I mean, you guys were fighting pretty hard before. Must be weird, being so close without trying to kill each other."

"I'm trying to focus, Arrow," Catra snapped.

"It's Bow—"

"Don't care."

"Hey, the Horde is focusing on the planet. I doubt they're even looking in this direction. Adora's just being paranoid."

"It's not paranoia if they're really out to get you," Catra replied.

Bow stared at her.

“What?” she snapped.

“You’re worried about the mission, I take it.”

“You aren’t?”

“Of course I am, I’m just better at hiding it.”

Catra just shook her head, grunting.

“Guess I’m just waiting for the other shoe to drop.”

“Considering everything, I guess that’s fair,” Bow said, “But say we do survive this. Say we win. What do you think is going to happen next? What do you want when this is all over?”

An image sprang to mind. A field of green a warm summer breeze. There is a blonde standing in front of her. She sees her hand reaching out to touch the other girl’s shoulder. Adora turns, greeting her with a warm smile.

Catra shook her head, banishing the image.

"Something quiet," she said bluntly, then gave Bow a light glare.

Bow shrugged and turned away, realizing that she didn't want to continue.

Catra grimaced, glad Bow hadn't pressed any further. Truth was, she hadn't been talking solely about the mission with the shoe-dropping thing.

Growing up in the Horde was horrible, but she didn't have anywhere else to go. The only good thing had been Adora. They'd had such plans, they were going to rise through the ranks together, rise so far that nothing and no one would be able to hurt them…

And just when that started to happen, Adora left.

But Catra kept going. Trying to ignore the pain in her chest that greeted her every morning and stabbed at her regularly throughout the day, she rose on her own. If she became powerful enough, no one could hurt her. And she did it. She surpassed Shadow Weaver, she was Hordak's second in command, she was making great strides for the Horde…

Then Shadow Weaver tricked her, escaping. Then Hordak blamed her, banishing her to the Crimson Wastes, throwing her away like she'd been nothing after all.

But Catra kept going. She took over the most powerful of the gangs in the Wastes inside a day. She beat her rival so thoroughly, ready to drag her back to the Fright Zone in chains and return in glory…

Then she found out that Shadow Weaver had made a beeline right for Adora. That her brief acceptance of Catra had been more lies, it was always Adora in her eyes. And anger and grief drove her to madness, and she pulled that damn lever.

But Catra kept going. She pulled herself together through sheer will, managing to keep her crying jags private. She started running the Horde in all but name, making massive pushes. They were two steps away from running all of Etheria…

Then her only remaining friend rejected her and left. Scorpia took with her the potential for the Rebellion to win, and barely a week later, her advance was being crushed.

Then Hordak turned against her again, this time for sentimentality, this time over what she'd done to Entrapta in her madness.

Then she beat one of the monsters that had been looming over her since she was a child, but Double Trouble was right there detailing how none of this was in any way a victory, and it never would be, because Catra was her own worst enemy.

Then Horde Prime came, and what else needed to be said on that front?

And now here Catra was. She and Adora seemed to be making up, slow as it was. They had a plan. There was a single point of hope that they'd all make it out. Catra felt that hope again, that everything would somehow work out and she and Adora could be friends again, could be together again…

So what was going to ruin this?

Because nothing ever went right for Catra. Nothing ever would.

oOo

As they stuffed the last of the required ore into a sack, Entrapta paused.

"Something wrong?" Adora asked.

"Nothing, just…in all the excitement, I'd forgotten. Do you realize that we're the first Etherians in written history to set foot on one of the moons?"

Entrapta stared up at the planet above, looking in awe.

"It's beautiful, isn't it? We're probably the first Etherians to ever see this sight, assuming the First Ones didn't take a few up themselves."

Adora hummed, looking at the world she called home. She had to admit, it was an incredible feeling. It looked so small from here, so fragile.

"You can save the world we love…"

"Pardon?"

"Just something from Mara's last message," Adora said.

She pointed up at Etheria.

"This is why we're doing it. To protect this world. To fight the monsters that would destroy it."

Beneath her glove, the ring lit up, the green light shining bright enough to be seen through the heavy fabric. Seeing this, Adora smiled.

“Let those who worship evil’s might,” she intoned, “Beware my power…”

“Fascinating,” Entrapta squealed, catching Adora’s attention, “I’d really love to examine that ring in greater detail.”

“Somehow, I think you’d figure something out,” Adora laughed, “Let’s get back to the ship…you know, we really should come up with a better name.”

“Or maybe find out the original one,” Entrapta replied, shrugging, “Trying to rename it seems…wrong, somehow. Old girl’s got a lot of history, after all.”

“True enough. What would you name it, though?”

“I keep coming back to Darla?”

Adora made a face.

“Yeah, I don’t think that fits, sorry.”

oOo

Adora and Entrapta arrived back at the ship with no issues. After stowing away the treasures they'd uncovered (as Bow had put it), Entrapta started take-off procedures.

One console suddenly started squawking.

"What is that?" Catra grimaced, tugging at her ears in response to the high-pitched noise.

"The radio, I think," Entrapta said, looking over the offending area of the controls.

"We really need to figure out these glitches," Bow said, rubbing at one ear.

"I wonder what this is supposed to mean," Adora said, tapping at the console.

"*Translation software initiated,*" came a flat voice from the console.

"Wait, did I do that?"

"—therian queen, and leave her more open to cooperation. Be on watch for any attempted rescues. Glory to Prime. Message repeats. All brothers be on lookout. The prisoner will be planetside for a day while study is undergone on the Heart of Etheria. Hopefully, seeing the state of her planet will go toward breaking the spirit of the Etherian queen, and leave her more open to cooperation. Be on watch for any attempted rescues. Glory to Prime."

There was a stunned silence as the radio's squawks ended.

"Glimmer," Adora whispered.

"Entrapta, track that transmission!" Catra barked, "Give me everything you can find!"

"Aye, Commander!" Entrapta squeaked, already getting to work.

"What are you—"

Catra whirled to Bow, cutting him off.

"Do you want to save her or not?"

Bow blinked dumbly before re-centering himself.

"Only if we have a plan. We can't afford to go off half-cocked on this."

"I'm thinking, I'm thinking!"

It took time for Entrapta to gather all the information she needed, as well as triangulate where Glimmer would be based on more transmissions. Once she had that information, Catra was a force unto herself, rapidly making a solid, if simple, plan.

Basically, the strategy was shock and awe. Catra and Bow, the fastest of them, would create a diversion and draw the guards away. Entrapta would slip in and start hacking anything she could get her hands on, sowing chaos amongst the enemy. And Adora would go for Glimmer. Once she was safe, Adora would send up a green flare, and everyone would fade into the forest. Before Prime's goons could get together a search party, they would be on an invisible ship and darting off towards Dryl, where the mountains would hide them.

Bow and Adora made a few adjustments, but the plan was quickly hashed out.

"This is really solid," Bow said.

"Why so shocked?" Catra said, "I seem to remember pulling off a lot of victories overall for the Horde. You'd win a battle or two, but we'd always bounce back. The big final pushes before Prime came, those were mostly my work."

"I was really good at tactics in our classes," Adora explained, "I could make plans for an immediate goal and adjust them on the fly. Catra, though, she could do long-term much better than I could, figuring out what was needed overall to achieve a single goal. Basically, I was good at fighting battles, Catra was good at fighting wars."

"Only reason you guys survived as long as you did was crazy princess powers screwing with my equations. I would have won the Battle of Bright Moon if the water princess, Flower Girl, and Little Snowbird hadn't shown up."

"I can't argue with that, but I feel like I should," Bow muttered.

"Well, we have a plan," Adora said, "All goes well, we should be able to pull it off without any problems."

oOo

They didn't.

Oh, they got Glimmer out just fine. It was the rest that was the problem.

Glimmer wrung a dark red scarf between her hands. She managed to take the gifted knitting supplies with her back to Etheria, but the scarf had been the only thing she'd had in her hands when Adora grabbed her.

She looked around the ship, tasting failure on the air.

Entrapta was at the controls, moving mechanically as she steered them toward Dryl. Her mask was down, hiding her face, which Glimmer took as a sign of avoidance of the topic on hand. She'd been able to hack the systems, but barely. The coding language was too complex for her to do what she wanted in a limited time frame. As a result, she wasn't able to sow nearly as much chaos as she'd wanted. Which lead to a domino effect on the rest of the plan.

Glimmer had been grabbed just as the alarms sounded. The clones and bots, realizing they'd been had, had broken off of Catra and Bow and dashed back to the tower. The two had been forced to double back and help cover an escape, which was decidedly difficult when neither of them were Scorpia- or She-Ra-level heavies.

Glimmer looked over at Adora, who was sitting stiffly in the captain's chair. The only movement in her were her eyes, flicking between the middle distance and her ring.

When things had fallen apart, Adora had tried to use the ring to help the two of them escape. With Glimmer's magic suppressed by the shackles she'd had on, and the number of bots too many to fight for simple hand-to-hand, it had been their only choice. Adora had managed three beams of energy, cutting through multiple bots at once and sending one clone flying, before the ring gave out.

Glimmer remembered Adora clutching her arm in pain, seeing veins of gold and green erupt on her skin. It was only later that she was told that the power of the ring was clashing with the energy of She-Ra. At the time, however, there was only fear that they wouldn't get out in time.

But then something happened that she had never expected.

Glimmer felt a touch at her shoulder.

"How you holding up?" Bow asked.

Glimmer sighed, staring at the scarf.

"I made this for her. On Prime's ship, he let me have some supplies to pass the time. I was making this for Catra. I…we talked some, on the ship. She wasn't…wasn't what I thought. I don't think she's bad, she was just…"

"Hurt?" Bow offered, "Yeah, I got that impression of her. Hurt and not knowing how to process it, so she just lashed out."

There was a part of Glimmer that had still seen Catra as an enemy. That part had died today.

There was a blur of orange, black, and dark red. Several robots fell in pieces, clearing the way.

"Go, now!"

"Catra!"

"Just go, Adora! Run!"

Catra's face had softened slightly as she spoke her next words.

"It's you he wants. But I won't let him. Don't come back for me."

The slamming of a fist on metal broke Glimmer's train of thought.

"We shouldn't have left her," Adora growled, "*I* shouldn't have left her."

"We didn't have a choice, Adora," Glimmer started, but Adora cut her off, standing up and pacing rapidly.

"You're a little out of the loop on this, Glimmer. I know she was our enemy, but…she was getting better. She was coming to terms it everything, making the right choices. They attacked Bright Moon. We were getting the civilians out, but the Horde had me dead to rights. The ring came, but its energies clashed with what remained of She-Ra, so much that it nearly ripped me apart. Catra calmed me down. Even if she hadn't, and I survived the ring binding itself to me, I would have been too weak to fight back, and Prime's forces would have captured me easily. Catra got me out. We heard that you were planetside, and realized that we had one chance to get you back, but we had to work fast. Catra made the plan. Catra sacrificed herself to let us escape. Catra needs our help."

Adora glared at her ring.

"And if I could have gotten this working right, we wouldn't be having this conversation. If I could have used it right, or used She-Ra, we'd all be here. But Catra stepped up, and now she's in trouble. We have to help her."

"Adora--"

"I left her behind once, I'm not doing it again!"

Glimmer finally noticed the tears brimming in Adora's eyes.

"I walked away in Thaymor. She did too, but I decided to leave the Horde first. To leave *her*. She didn't know how to handle that, so she ran. And we've been running away from each other ever since. I missed her so hard it physically hurt, and then we found each other again. We were building something again, and now this. I can't lose her again. I *won't* lose her again. I--"

Adora was cut off by Glimmer hugging her.

"I'm sorry," she said, "I really do need to listen more."

There was silence for a moment, and then Bow approached.

"You're not just talking about what just happened, are you, Glimmer?"

Glimmer sighed.

"I was horrible to you both. You tried to warn me, but I wouldn't listen. I thought I knew better than people who did actual

research about the subject. I keep trying to figure out why I acted like that, and all I keep coming up with is…"

Glimmer shook her head, tears starting to form.

"It was never supposed to be me. It shouldn't have been. I wanted to end the Horde by any means necessary…because I couldn't stand the thought that she never got to see it. Never got to see peace on Etheria, never saw the end of the war that took so much from her."

They didn't have to ask who.

Adora brought Glimmer into another hug.

"The last thing she said to me…she said 'Take care of each other.' She…Angella was more of a mom to me in a week than Shadow Weaver was for my entire life. I miss her too."

Glimmer gave a pained laugh.

"You know, she told me once that, if she didn't know you'd freak out over it, she'd have offered to adopt you."

"Smart woman."

The two gave bitter laughs. Bow wrapped his arms around the two, humming softly.

The ship shuddered a bit.

"We're right outside Dryl," Entrapta said, her mask still down, "I'll go talk to someone about setting up some rooms, then I'm going to work on the ship. I guess we can plan what comes next in the morning?"

She left before they could answer.

"I think she's having trouble processing what happened to Catra," Bow said.

"She can join the club. But I know what I have to do," Adora replied.

"Adora, you don't have a plan!" Glimmer argued.

Adora didn't answer, just walked out of the cockpit, a storm in her mind.

She gathered her tools and metal from the ship and made for the forge, breathing heavily. She found it rather easily, strangely enough, or perhaps she'd been searching for some time and she hadn't noticed in her unyielding rage. Could have been either.

As she lit the fires and melted the metal, her mind raced. Memories of Catra, both good and bad, played before her eyes.

One of her earliest memories, a fuzzy form curled up close. Feeling a great calm as she hugged it close.

"Adora," came a purr, "My Adora."

"My Catra," Adora replied.

Adora didn't think what Shadow Weaver did was fair. The accident wasn't Catra's fault.

She slipped into the room, hiding a ration bar under her shirt. She poked at the form buried in the blankets.

"Go 'way."

"Catra, it's me."

"Go 'way, Adora."

"I brought food."

A single blue eye poking out of the cocoon.

"Won't you get in trouble?" Catra asked as Adora held the bar out to her.

"Only if I get caught," Adora smiled, "Besides, you're my friend. I'd do anything for you."

Catra slowly took the bar, nibbling on it. Adora heard a muffled thanks, and climbed onto the bed to give Catra a one-armed hug.

"You and me. That's how it's always gonna be."

"Yeah," Catra said, slowly smiling, "You and me."

Catra laughed like a loon.

"You should have seen your face. You were like--"

She went into full dramatic mode, falling to the floor at the end.

"ARGH! NO! BETRAYAL!"

Adora tried not to smile at her friend's antics and failed.

"Ugh, come on, Catra. We're senior cadets now. I can't believe you're still pulling such childish, immature, IS THAT A MOUSE?"

"WHAT, WHERE?" Catra shouted, leaping up with her fur standing on end.

Adora laughed and grinned at her.

"Are you ever going to not *fall for that?"*

"I was hoping you could be, I don't know, happy for me?" Adora sighed, regarding her new Force Captain badge.

Out of the corner of her eye, she could see the sullen Catra look conflicted before the old mask of irreverence came back.

"Ugh, whatever. It's not like I even care. I just wanna get out of this dump at some point before I die of boredom*."*

Adora knew she was just playing it up, and smiled at her friend.

Laughter as they rode the skiff out of the Fright Zone, enjoying one last moment together before responsibilities loom their ugly heads.

Little did they know, it would be the last moment of unrestrained joy they'd have for a long, long time.

Catra taking part in the attack on Thaymor, not caring as much about the mission as she did finding Adora, something her tone and her joy at finding her friend gave away.

But then the rift.

"Come with me. You don't have to go back there, we can fix this."

For a moment, Catra stared at Adora's hand with something like longing. Then her face hardened.

"Are you kidding? You've known these people for, what, a couple hours? And now you're gonna throw everything away for them*? Ugh. What happened to you?"*

Falling to the ground, her transformation failing. Seeing Catra in the smoke, looking confused and lost. Then anger crossed her face, and she stepped backward into the smoke, away from Adora.

Waking up in the dead of night, feeling a cold brush where there should be warmth, and realizing with great sadness that Catra was gone.

The lights dim, music starts, and people begin to pair up. Adora turns and sees a smirking face and an outstretched hand. She scoffs a bit, her suspicion still high, but takes the hand regardless.

The dance begins, and Adora tries desperately to concentrate on the steps and not on how good *Catra looks in that suit (which, WOW).*

"I don't know about you, but I am having a blast."

Fighting on the ice castle's roof. Catra does a charging elbow, but misses, nearly falling off the edge. Adora catches her almost instinctively.

For a moment, all else fell away, and it was just the two of them.

Catra pointed the sword at them, a harsh glare on her face.

Then, unexpectedly, she reversed her grip, holding the hilt towards them.

"What are you doing?" Adora all but whispered.

"Take it," she all but spat.

Confusion, sadness, resolve, and a dash of hope warred within Adora.

"This is not because I like you," Catra grunted.

Adora took the sword, opening her mouth. So many things could have spilled out. How much she missed Catra, her pain and regret over how they had fought, explaining how toxic she now knew Shadow Weaver truly was and how sorry she was that she never saw the whole story, another chance to come with her and get away from the Horde and Shadow Weaver…

"Just…get out of there," Catra interrupted, turning away.

The adventure in the Crystal Castle, the brief joy in seeing how young and innocent they were turning sour when all Catra took away from the adventure was that being Adora's friend had only been pain, had only held her back.

So many things Adora wished she could have said as she dangled over the crevice. How Catra was the only thing that kept her sane while in the Horde, how much their friendship had meant, how her absence was a constant ache.

'You were never a sidekick,' *she wanted to say*, 'You meant everything to me.'

But it was too late.

"Bye, Adora…"

"You know, I'm actually glad you did make it out of there alive. Because now…"

And then flippancy was replaced by rage.

"I can take you out myself."

And the brawl. Fighting across the ruined landscape, Adora's heart breaking a little more with every blow. Grief briefly turning

to rage at how Catra would so casually throw away years of friendship.

And even in the aftermath, with Bright Moon saved and Adora surrounded by her new friends, there was a part of her still mourning for her lost one.

The portal.

Watching her friend slip into madness.

Watching her willing to let the world burn, just to make sure Adora lost.

Adora giving up on Catra.

She regretted it not even an hour later.

Trying to drown her grief in anger, a part of her wanting to give Catra a taste of her own medicine, even as Catra descended into full villainy.

But anger hurt. She didn't know how Catra endured it for so long.

She felt it burning, clawing at her soul. She knew she couldn't keep it up. If she did, she didn't know what she would become. She just knew she wouldn't like that person.

It was almost a relief seeing her again at Bright Moon, looking every bit as tired as Adora felt.

The homestead on the edge of the woods, trying to piece things back together.

A simple joy welling up at just being close to her.

Adora and Catra, together again.

She had to protect this. Protect this rekindled closeness, protect that little smile she saw on Catra's face when they were comfortable.

And then a recurring phrase, one that had been woven through the years.

"Hey, Adora!" squeaked a young Catra, "We're gonna be late for dinner! What's the hold-up?"

"Sorry, Shadow Weaver wanted to talk about something," Adora replied, smiling at her friend, "Race you there!"

"Hey, Adora. How's it hanging?"

"Catra. Did you really show up late and let us do all the hard parts? That is low, even for you."

"Aw, you know nothing's too low for me," Catra said, then dropped her smugness for a genuine laugh, reaching down, "Now come on, you look stupid hanging down there!"

Adora couldn't help but smile as she took the offered hand.

"Hey, Adora! Adora!" came the worried voice.

"Catra? What happened?"

"You fell out of the skiff after you drove it into a tree."

She sounded flippant at the time, but looking back, Adora could feel the relief in her voice.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said, running a claw over the sword.

For a moment, Adora felt relief. But that relief would turn to horror as Catra outlined her betrayal.

"Hey, Adora," Catra grinned from atop a tank.

A small spark of hope burned in Adora's chest, but it would be crushed when Catra attacked, fully throwing their friendship into the dirt.

"Hey, Adora!" Catra called out, quickly recovering from the sudden shock of seeing her so far in the north. Adora could also tell how tense she was, likely trying not to shiver in front of her. Catra never did like the cold.

"You two joined Tung Lashor?"

"They haven't joined him."

Adora started at the familiar voice, the speaker coming into view, standing cool and confident.

"They joined me. Hey, Adora."

She struggled to her feet, and then felt a touch at her forehead.

"HeY, AdOOOrrrrAaAaA…"

The sight of her oldest friend, her best enemy, wrapped in splintered shadow and negative energy, would haunt her nightmares for the rest of her life, she knew.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said, looking for all the world like the villain of their story, "Took you long enough to show up."

Waking up to an unexpected face…

"Hey, Adora…had me worried there for a bit."

A conversation filled with emotion, a feeling of hope blooming in her chest.

And the promise…of course the promise…

"It doesn't matter what they do to us, you know? You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really *bad can happen as long as we have each other."*

"You promise?"

"I promise."

Adora shook her head. There was no time for reminiscing. It was time to work.

And work she did. She extracted the ore, purifying it. Entrapta's machines were most helpful in that regard, cutting the time it

would have taken by a large amount.

As Adora worked on the hot metal, she wiped sweat from her brow and shucked her jacket. She lost herself to the creative process, working over the forge like a woman possessed. Soon, she had a long rod of metal, ready to be shaped.

Adora reached for her hammer…and then stopped.

She gazed at the ring on her hand, and a thought crossed her mind.

"My will powers the ring, right? That's how that works…I wonder…"

She concentrated. She felt. She *willed*.

She felt something, like energy crackling under her skin, and knew it was She-Ra. The golden power burned and she grit her teeth.

"Please. I have to protect Etheria. I have to save *her*. This will help me do it. The green light can help us, but you have to let me."

She brought all her feelings to the forefront of her mind, laying her thoughts and dreams bare in the hopes that She-Ra would understand.

Catra's smile crossed her mind, the image holding as her heart warmed.

The crackling died down.

"Thank you," Adora said, and continued to concentrate.

You are the key…your will drives the ring…clear your mind and focus on what matters…

The words from her dream flowed through her mind. Like the dawn, everything became clear. It all snapped into focus, everything she had to do and how it could be done.

And then there was a hammer in her hand. Made of the green light, formed by her own will.

"Hold it. Hold it. Keep it there. This is for Etheria. This is for my friends. This is for Catra."

And she swung.

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

oOo

Entrapta entered the kitchen, accepting the plate of food from Bow.

"Thanks."

"Any idea what those hiccups were?"

"I'm not sure. There's something in the systems, but I can barely tell what it is. And when I go to fix it…I don't know, it's like the ship is fighting me, weird as it sounds."

"It's old and powerful tech, I'd be surprised if *any* repairs went smoothly," Glimmer interjected.

KRA-KLANG!

"And then of course, there's that," she finished, wincing at the noise echoing through the castle.

KRA-KLANG!

"How long has she been at it?" Entrapta asked.

"Hours. I don't think I've ever seen her that focused."

KRA-KLANG!

"This Catra stuff has got her really worked up," Bow said.

"Well, yeah," Entrapta replied, as if it were obvious, "They're friends."

oOo

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

"Brightest day…blackest night…no, not quite me…power, yes, and definitely the last bit."

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

"I am the key. I choose this. I pick the shape of the future, and I will it into being. I don't follow some centuries-old plan, *I make the plan*."

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

Sweat dripped down her face and arms, but she kept at it. It was nearly done. She'd already attached the bottom of the blade to the hilt, the two pieces fusing together from the heat and her new power. She was just finishing the rest of the sword. The shape was nearly perfect, the green lightning coming off the hammer with every strike helping sharpen the edge. And the strength of the metal was just right. She could feel it.

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

"You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really *bad can happen as long as we have each other."*

"You promise?"

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

"I promise."

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KLANG!

KRA-KOOM!

Adora let the hammer dissolve into sparks and dunked the hot metal in the water barrel. Steam erupted upward, but she didn't even flinch.

As she extracted the sword, she smiled. The blade started just as wide as the old, but tapered into a thinner blade as it went. Despite the lesser weight, the sword's balance was perfect. The blade gleamed a silver color, just like before. But there was now a web of green all throughout, like cracks. It reminded Adora of a bit of pottery she's seen in Queen Angella's possession, a teapot patched with gold lacquer. She'd asked once why such an obvious patch job, and Angella had explained it was an artistic thing, that the gold lines emphasized a part of the pot's life, showed off a scar rather than hide it.

"Nothing is ever really broken," she muttered, remembering the late queen's words, "Things can still be fixed."

There was still one last test.

She swung at the anvil. The sword went through it like a knife through butter. An afterimage of green followed the blade, emphasizing its journey.

Adora smiled at the two pieces of anvil. She could feel it. Once clashing energies were now in balance, forged together by the strength of her will into something new, just as she'd forged the sword anew. The might of She-Ra and the power of the Green Lantern were now in harmony.

It was no longer the Sword of Protection, no longer the leash that the First Ones had put on a legacy. This was her weapon, an old power fused to something new. In an instant, she had a new name.

"The Sword of Courage"

She did a few practice swings with it. It felt right, like an extension of her arm. She gathered her jacket and belts, sliding her sword into place against her back. She felt a subtle heat flare against her back, and knew that the sword had formed a sheath for itself, ready and waiting to be used.

"Hang on, Catra. I'm coming."

Green Lantern's Light

Chapter Notes

And now, the moment you've all been waiting for!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 5

Green Lantern's Light

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It burned. Everything burned.

But not from heat. No, she could have taken that, Shadow Weaver's favorite tortures made sure of that.

It was cold. Colder than ice, colder than she ever thought possible.

Her head broke the surface, she tried to gulp down air, but the cold leeched all her strength. She barely had enough time to hear the twisted chanting.

Prime casts out all shadows. Prime casts out all shadows.

The liquid entered her mouth, the slime tasting like nothing and the worst possible thing simultaneously. She felt like she was choking, drowning, but she wouldn't die. This feeling would never stop, she'd never escape.

The familiar tingle of electricity surged through her. She screamed out of instinct, letting a fresh wave of slime enter her.

Everything was pain and burning and cold and omnipresent doom.

She felt a wall, realized that in her thrashing, she'd hit the edge of the pool. She desperately clung to it, trying to climb out.

As her head broke the surface, a hand touched it.

"Not so fast, little sister. We're not done. All beings must suffer to become pure."

And he shoved her back under, holding her down as the slime filled her. She could vaguely hear the chanting through the liquid and the pain.

All beings must suffer to become pure! All beings must suffer to become pure!

There was only one bright point in all this pain, only one thing that kept her clinging to any shred of hope.

Adora was safe. Adora would remain safe. She did something good with her worthless life, protected her in the end, made up a little for all the hurt she'd inflicted in her rage.

She broke the world in her anger over Adora. She'd give everything she had left to save Adora.

The last thing she felt was the feeling of air on her fur, Prime's hand on her face, and a terrible stinging on the back of her neck.

And then everything was gone…

oOo

The walled town had become a stronghold for Horde Prime. Its citizens lived in fear. Drones arced through the skies, and clones dotted the streets.

Two such clones were guarding the front gate when a young woman strolled up. She had a sword sheathed on her back, but was spinning a staff in one hand like it was more important at the moment.

The blonde strolled right up to the clones, calm as you please, and spoke five simple words.

"Take me to your leader."

The clones regarded each other out of the corner of their eyes, confusion arcing between them via the hive mind.

"You are not authorized to be--"

She brought her staff down over the speaker's head, sending it to the ground. She gave the other an unamused look.

"I don't have time for this. Call your boss and set up a meeting. He's got a friend of mine, and I want her back."

oOo

Entrapta and Bow furiously poked at the console, scowls on their faces.

"I don't understand! My diagnostics came back clear!" Entrapta whined.

"Well, we need to figure out something," Bow snapped, "We can't just let Adora go off alone."

Off to the side, Glimmer fretted. She was wearing the dark red scarf, and she twisted one end in her hand.

"We have to help them, help them both," Glimmer said softly, "Why did Adora have to go off alone? She shouldn't have had to."

"She seemed confident she could work the ring this time," Entrapta replied, but it seemed hollow.

"Oh, right, the thing that's been giving her trouble for weeks now, yeah, that's useful," Glimmer said sarcastically, "It just had to be her way, didn't it? We couldn't have backed her up, given her an escape route. No, we have to stay safe, keep Mara's ship out of enemy hands!"

The lights went out. Glimmer screamed in frustration.

"And why is this thing deciding to utterly break down now*? We're trying to do a rescue mission, for fu--"*

“Oh, you were trying for a rescue mission? Why didn’t you say so? How can I help?”

The three stood shock-still.

“Entrapta, was that you?” Bow asked slowly.

“No, it was not,” she replied in an even tone.

“Glimmer?”

“Don’t look at me.”

“Well, it wasn’t me…”

The three slowly turned to the glowing figure sitting in the captain’s chair.

“Um…hi?”

And cue the screaming.

oOo

Adora was on a ship.

Not Prime's ship, not yet. Rather than just beam her aboard from a distance like she'd heard they could do, she was on a simpler vessel leaving Etheria.

She knew what it was: intimidation. She mattered so little that Prime was in no hurry to speak with her.

Joke was on him. The extra time only served to help her focus her rage, sharpen her will. When the clones weren't looking, she made small and simple shapes with the ring. It was *so easy* now, the wall she'd been ramming against now gone.

She dismissed the green dagger and sat back, closing her eyes. She could feel it, the power brimming below the surface, the new harmony crackling beneath her skin. It was like fire and ice and lightning. It was strength made manifest. It was a power that truly felt like it was *hers*, not some borrowed and ancient energy.

Clear your mind and focus on what matters…

She knew what she wanted. She was going to get it, one way or another.

She was getting her best friend back.

oOo

"We have arrived."

Adora opened her eyes and regarded the clone lazily.

"Oh, we're finally here, are we? Took long enough."

She stood up and stretched.

"Well, let's get moving. I'd rather not waste the rest of the day on stupid intimidation tactics."

If the clone was surprised that she had figured out the tactic, it didn't show it. Rather, it held out its hand.

"Please surrender your weaponry before exiting the vessel."

“Didn’t you try this on Etheria? Didn’t work then, did it?”

“Please surrender your weaponry before exiting the vessel.”

Adora rolled her eyes. Then she punched the clone in the stomach.

“I really don’t feel like playing around,” she told the clone as it crumpled onto the floor.

She casually stepped over it and strode off the ship, being greeted by two more clones.

“Please surrender your weapon—”

“Didn’t we just go through this?” Adora asked, cutting them off, “It’s not happening. Get over it. Now where’s Prime?”

The two clones tilted their heads, as if listening to something. Then they motioned Adora to follow.

Down endless hallways they walked. Any other time, Adora probably would have looked at the alien surroundings in a strange

fascination. Everything was whites and greys and curves. The lighting was bright, giving everything a sterile look. The air was filled with a sense of impending doom, but Adora was too deep in her rage and focus to feel it beyond a general sense.

As it was, with her so focused on her goal, she only noticed the cold.

"Glad I packed a jacket," she muttered, then thought no more of it.

They finally arrived in what seemed to be a throne room. A large chair sat before a fan of screens. The darkness around them was dotted with countless points of light. A deep chasm surrounded the platform.

But instead of the monster that Glimmer had described, there was only another clone, standing casually in front of the empty throne. Its eyes glowed an eerie light, and a cruel smirk sat upon its face.

"Forgive me for not attending to you personally, She-Ra," it spoke in a deeper voice than the others, "But I had numerous other appointments today."

"Or you're just a coward who doesn't want to face me himself," Adora spat.

The clone's smile dipped for a moment. Adora plowed on.

"This is all just an attempt at intimidation. Making me wait on a long space trip instead of zapping me right here, as if I weren't as important. Claiming you have other appointments, same thing. A little walking tour of the ship to show off what you consider to be the center of your power…"

She gestured toward the arm cannons on her escorts.

"Making sure all the clones I interact with are visibly armed, while attempting three times to disarm me, trying to make me feel weak in this situation."

She gave a mocking laugh.

"If this is evil's might, I'm not impressed. You're just another bully, like all the rest. The only difference is your fancy toys, which I couldn't care less about."

"And yet, you willingly march right into my arms," Prime replied, "Weapons, yes, but no perceivable back-up and clearly no plan. You, my dear, have made a grave miscalculation."

"We'll see."

"I'm sure…now, I allowed you to keep your weapons until now, but there is no need for them. Surrender them. And your ring, if you please."

"Even if I could take it off, which I can't, it's been getting even more possessive since I used it to reforge my sword," Adora replied casually, "They really like each other now, I doubt you could separate them for long. So, counter-offer, you give Catra back and I won't blow you off the face of the universe."

"With the Heart of Etheria, I presume?" Prime asked with a mocking smile, "If you could use it, you would have by now. Or perhaps with your new ring? If you knew how to access its full power, you wouldn't have needed to call for a parley. No, I don't believe you have any power in this situation."

"Oh, I think you'll be surprised," Adora said calmly, "Your arrogance is your weakness."

"I am Prime. I am older than you can imagine. I give my brothers life and in return, they grant me their life force when I require it. When one vessel fails me, I simply elect another. Thus, Prime has reigned eternal through the centuries. And I always shall. I have conquered countless planets. My empire stretches across the stars. I am more than you can comprehend, little mortal. I have no weaknesses."

"Keep telling yourself that, pasty. Look, I really don't have the patience for this. Last time, where's Catra?"

But Prime just kept smiling.

"You know, I know of your ancestors. You called them the…First Ones, was it? They had a mighty empire themselves, but I crushed it beneath my heel. My greatest strength is experience. I know all the tricks, and I have all the time in the universe to exercise them. I anticipated this eventuality. You were wrong about one thing: having you take a slower trip wasn't just for intimidation. It also gave me some extra time."

Prime pointed behind her. Adora turned to see a small figure entering the room.

"You'd be surprised how quickly she saw things my way. So much pain in her, so desperate for it all to stop. It was rather easier than expected."

The figure walked up to the platform and lowered a hood.

"Hello, Adora."

Adora finally felt the cold. She felt it shoot down her spine and stab into her heart.

Wrong, *wrong,* ***wrong***. *This was wrong!* It looked like Catra. It had her voice. But the words were empty, the tone off. Her gaze was unfocused, her eyes a toxic green.

This was *not* Catra.

"What did they do to you?"

The white-clad shell of Catra moved past Adora, standing before Horde Prime's envoy and kneeling.

"She was a mess, truly," Prime said, "Most of her seemed to consider her capture a sacrifice, a chance for you to flee. But a small part of her hoped you would come for her, even after all the pain you'd caused each other."

He bade Catra to rise and caressed her face. Adora thought she saw a shiver of fear at Prime's touch, but it was gone as quickly as it came.

"So ensnared she was in rage, grief, and pain. Her opinion of herself and her worth, quite low. I took her pain away, made her anew. Gave her a place in the glory of Prime's light."

"Prime casts out all shadows," the-thing-that-wasn't-Catra intoned.

Prime chuckled and left with the clones.

"I'll leave you two to get reacquainted. Let me know when you're ready to make a proper deal."

And then Adora was alone with the mindless thing wearing her friend's face.

"Catra, please tell me you're in there," Adora said, feeling a shock of fear for the first time since forging her sword anew.

"Of course I am, Adora," Catra said, her voice hollow as an empty tomb, "But not as you knew. I have no anger, no hate, no grief. Prime has given me peace, something you failed to do."

"So the homestead meant nothing?" Adora countered.

"You mean that shadow of our old friendship?" the shell replied with a hint of derision, "Be serious. You broke my heart, Adora. But Prime has made me whole again. I am happy here."

The green-eyed form slid close to Adora, trailing a hand up her arm in a mockery of familiarity.

“You could be happy, too.”

And Adora looked at this face. The smile on it was false. The eyes were unfocused. The hair was short and slicked back, making her seem so much smaller.

“Do you remember when we’d climb up to the tower in the Fright Zone?” Adora asked, “We’d look out over at the horizon, talking about what we’d do when we finally saw the world outside. Remember how you once said you never felt so calm as when you were up there?”

“Old, foolish, childish me. I have grown beyond that.”

“Wrong answer.”

Adora shoved her away.

“The real Catra said the same thing to me not a few days ago. She wished she could feel that peaceful again, that she just wanted to feel like she wasn’t such a monster. I told her not to give up, that things well get better.”

The thing wearing Catra’s face looked shocked for a moment, then the claws came out.

Adora dodged the first few blows, but a swipe got her front, cutting into her jacket. Adora pulled out her compacted staff, but before she could extend it, Catra had knocked it out of her hand.

The blows came fast and furious. But this thing was working entirely on Catra's instincts and old memories. There was no creativity, just forms Adora had seen a million times before.

In a hand-to-hand fight, predictability meant losing.

She got Catra into an arm lock, the shell of her friend struggling.

"I'm not leaving without you, Catra. I'm not giving up on you. Come back to me!"

Catra practically dislocated her arm getting out of the hold, but it didn't seem to bother her. She managed to reverse their positions, wrapping Adora in a strange parody of a hug.

"You do not have to leave, period," came the dead-sounding voice, "We are with Prime now. There is no suffering in his light. Not like before. You were all I had, and you left. Do you have any idea how that felt?"

"Yes, actually," Adora replied sadly, "Because you were all I had too."

Then she flipped Catra over her head. The shell tumbled across the floor, hitting the stairs leading up to the throne with a sharp crack.

Adora's heart leapt into her throat. Catra's neck had been the first point of contact.

But the shell just smiled and laughed, slowly standing and jamming her arm back into place with nary a grimace.

"That did not stop you from hurting me. But I am free of that, now. We can all be free. A world of peace, forever. Do you not want that?"

"Not from him," Adora shot back, waving at Catra, "This isn't peace! He reached into your head and scooped out everything that made you *you*!"

"But do you not want your pain taken away?"

"No, I don't! I need my pain! It tells me that I'm alive! That I went through what the world threw at me and came out the other side! You shouldn't get rid of pain, you just need to learn to deal with it! I was helping you do that, but Prime took that away!"

Catra leapt at Adora, who dodged. Despite it all, Adora couldn't find it in her to actually fight back. She couldn't, not to Catra, not again. She settled for redirections and open-palm strikes. She hit Catra with a fist once, and felt horror at doing so.

She fought down the tears in her eyes as she and the hollow Catra continued to fight. Adora didn't want this, she'd never wanted this. Even all those times they'd fought, she'd never really wanted to do it. She just felt she didn't have a choice.

She'd always hoped that Catra would see that the Horde wasn't for her, that her place wasn't there. At some point, Adora didn't even care if that place wasn't by her side. She just wanted Catra to be in a place she was happy, where she didn't have to be afraid or feel she had to cause others pain to survive.

For a brief moment, she thought they'd gotten that. Then Prime took it away.

But this wasn't the end. Adora wouldn't let it be the end. She'd save Catra, no matter what.

At one point, the shell of Catra was on the lip of the platform. The chasm yawned behind her, certain death if she fell. Adora cried out in fear.

The shell of Catra laughed. Even that laugh was wrong, dissonant from her usual high-pitched giggles. She let herself fall

backwards.

Adora reached out and pulled her back, her heart beating painfully fast. She held Catra tight against her on sheer instinct. Catra returned this act with deep gouges to her back.

Adora shoved her away out reflexively, throwing her to the side. Catra tripped into the stairs again. A sound like metal hitting metal echoed. The green briefly retreated from Catra's eyes.

"Adora?"

Her heart nearly stopped.

"Catra?" she whispered, a shred of hope in her voice.

"Why did you have come here?" Catra asked, sounding more lucid than she had, "We both know I don't matter."

"You matter to me! The thing I regret the most was making you ever doubt that."

Catra looked at her with a mix of shock and hope. And then she screamed and the toxic green returned to her eyes.

“Oh dear,” she said, her voice now a mix of her own and Prime’s, “You’ve damaged the chip. Now I’ll have to cut this short.”

Clones filed into the room. All were armed, and pointed their weapons at Adora.

“You were right, Adora. There is no time for this,” Prime-Catra intoned.

“Let her go,” Adora growled, “I’m warning you--”

“You have no power here, Adora.”

Prime examined Catra’s claws with a casual air.

“She was afraid in the end, you know. But she was such an interesting specimen, I had to add her to my collection. Perhaps I will make her my new vessel, at some point. Although I’m afraid she wouldn’t last long containing my essence.”

And something snapped inside Adora. Her rage shot right past burning hot and into the realm of impossible cold. Her hand clenched hard enough to turn her knuckles white. Her eyes went steely. She took a single, deep breath.

"Horde Prime," she said very, *very* calmly, "I want to tell you something before this next part."

"And what is that?" asked twisted voice.

"That I am going to rip out one of your eyes, just one, so you can still see when I force you to eat it. That I am going to hang you by your own entrails. That I am going to paint your ship with your blood and do it with an honest-to-All-Mother smile on my face. That I am going break you so utterly that whenever anyone mentions your name in the future, it will be in tones of utter fear at what was done to you. But most of all, *that you have made a grave miscalculation, and it will cost you everything.*"

Adora finally unsheathed the Sword of Courage, the blade gleaming brightly. And then she began to speak:

"Grayskull calls upon me to fight

To defend innocents from their plight

I stand firm against evil's might

I have the power of GREEN LANTERN'S LIGHT!"

There was a blinding flash of light. And a new figure stood there.

She was tall, almost eight feet in height. Her hair looked like spun gold, and was styled in a long ponytail. Her clothing was predominately white, pants and boots and sleeveless shirt. A half-skirt extended down her back, its inner lining a deep black. The boots were trimmed in a verdant green. Armor made of green metal covered her forearms. She bore a gold tiara that was more like part of a helm, guarding forehead and cheeks and sweeping outward like wings. In the middle of the tiara sat a large emerald, emblazoned with a symbol resembling a lantern. There were shoulder-guards attached to her shirt, the metal linking with an intricate sigil on her chest. Both shoulder-guards and sigil shifted in color. Gold became green became gold became green-and-gold, the colors swirling like liquid, never the same way twice. Her eyes bore a corona of energy, the same green-and-gold burning intensely.

"I am She-Ra," she said, "And I came to rescue my friend."

Several of the clones fired, bolts of toxic green shooting towards her.

She didn't even move. She didn't have to.

A bubble of shimmering energy sprang into being around her. Toxic green met verdant green and lost. The fire quickly ceased when the clones realized they were doing nothing.

She-Ra smiled darkly, the corona around her eyes and the ring on her finger flaring.

“My turn.”

The bubble shattered like glass, sending dangerous looking shards in all directions. The clones ducked, only for a few to realize that the shards weren’t solid enough to do harm. But by then, it was too late, and She-Ra was upon them.

She knocked two clones away with a swing of her sword, hitting them with the flat side and sending them flying. She punched a third in the stomach, sending it wheezing to the floor. A beam of energy erupted from her sword, taking down a fourth.

Other clones returned fire, but the energy shield returned, blocking their fire. She-Ra charged at them, and they kept firing out of fear. When she was close enough, she raised her sword. Green energy encased it, expanding and solidifying into a massive war hammer, which she brought down on the one in the middle. She used her new leverage to flip up and lash out with a pair of kicks to two on the side. The other clones dodged out of the way, but when She-Ra regained her footing, multiple swords appeared around her, circling around her like a wheel of doom.

Adora was in the zone. Before, becoming She-Ra was jarring, and she’d never felt fully comfortable when transformed, like she was wearing an ill-fitting suit. She’d just gotten used to the feeling over time.

This new form, this Lantern-enhanced She-Ra, fit better. Everything was fluid, the power settling into her smoothly and reacting to her wishes as easily as moving her arm. She felt like *her,* not some name she'd been forced to bear.

This? This felt *right.*

She heard Prime shouting orders, still using Catra's mouth. She saw a squad of robots enter the room hurriedly, trying to back up the clones.

It didn't matter. The reborn She-Ra demolished either with brutal efficiency. Her energy constructs are on point, her practice transforming her old Sword of Protection coming into play. Her shields easily countered their energy weapons, and all fell before her brute strength.

Horde Prime had numbers and advanced weaponry on his side. But there was only so much one could do when faced with an eight-foot-tall warrior woman with super-strength, incredible stamina and durability, an absurdly sharp magic sword, a magic ring that could create energy constructs of just about anything she set her mind to, and a mass of pure rage the size of a small moon.

Adora heard a familiar yowl from behind her and spun. A giant green hand grabbed the controlled Catra out of the air. Adora pulled her close and projected a bubble around them to get some breathing room.

Catra thrashed in the grip of the hand, Prime's voice shouting at her, but she tuned it all out. Instead, she stuck her sword into the ground to give herself free hands, walked to Catra's back, and grabbed at her head to keep her still.

Sure enough, there was a metallic device attached to the back of Catra's neck. It was already cracked slightly from previous blows, but the green in the center still shined.

"I'm sorry if this hurts, Catra. But I have no choice."

She brought her ring up to the device and *willed*. A thin beam of power shot out and rammed into the metal. Sparks flew and Catra gave a pained scream.

The light went out and Catra slumped, breathing heavily. Adora turned her around and looked at her worriedly.

"It's okay, Catra. I'm here. I'm taking you home. We're going home, Catra."

Catra picked her head up. Her eyes were once against that familiar mix of blue and gold.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said tiredly, gazing at her with relief.

“Hey, Catra,” Adora replied tenderly.

Adora dismissed the hand and brought Catra into a tight hug, finally letting the tears she’d been holding back for so long fall. Catra stiffened for a moment, then returned it just as tightly.

Given what had just happened to her, it wouldn’t have been surprising that Catra would have been freaking out over being surrounded by green.

But this green shimmered and shined in a way that Prime’s green did not. Where Prime’s green was a frigid cold, this carried a warmth like a summer day. Where there was an existential feeling of doom, now there was only comfort.

She breathed in Adora’s scent as the other girl held her in her arms, and felt at peace.

“Adora?”

There were so many things Catra could have said, that she wanted to say. Instead, mostly thanks to the wave of incredible exhaustion coming over her, she settled on “Can we get out of here?”

As if in answer, a voice spoke out.

Software patch still in progress. Computation systems sixty-percent operational. Local star charts available. Adora, would you like to plot a course to Etheria?

The ring's voice was different from the mechanical tone that had issued from it before. It sounded more like Adora's own voice, albeit more clinical.

Adora and Catra blinked at it in confusion.

"Can you get us both there safely?"

Affirmative.

Travel through space had been something Adora had heavily suspected the ring could do, given her green dream, but it was nice to have confirmation. She grabbed her sword, pulled Catra close, and nodded.

"Then let's get out of here."

The bubble solidified and moved. It blitzed past the enemy forces that were still trying to breach the bubble and punched through

the walls of Prime's ship with little effort. Soon, they were out in space, speeding away at incredible speeds.

The two women settled in for a voyage. Adora let She-Ra go, returning to her normal form, and immediately staggered a bit.

"Woah, head rush!"

"You okay?" Catra asked.

"Yeah. It's like I'm coming down off an adrenaline high. That'll take some getting used to."

Adora regarded her ring.

"Although considering I passed out the first time, it's a massive improvement."

She leaned against the wall of the bubble, Catra in her arms, and watched the stars pass by.

"It's beautiful, isn't it?"

"Yeah," Catra said, her voice low and tired, "Why'd you come for me?"

"I told you, you matter to me. Of course I was going to come."

Catra looked like she wanted to argue a bit more, but gave up. She settled against Adora, but was still stiff.

"Is this real?" she was, scared.

"I'm here, it's okay," Adora said, stroking one of Catra's ears, "Rest. I'll still be here when you wake up."

Catra finally allowed herself to relax, purring at Adora's touch. She was asleep in minutes, the entirety of her ordeal finally catching up with her.

oOo

Prime surveyed the mess of his throne room in person. He looked at the hole in the bulkhead with a heavy scowl. Emergency systems had already sealed off the exterior hole, but the damage to the interior walls were still there, taunting him with the scars upon his perfect ship.

"No!" he spat, "Not here, not now! I will *not* lose to a Lantern again!"

He dove into the hive mind and had the order sent.

Etheria was now under 'Prime's Mind' protocols.

They would all join in his light, or be destroyed.

oOo

Glimmer and Bow kept their eyes on the stars while Entrapta and their new friend drove the ship. They knew that if they encountered something, the ship's sensors would pick it up long before they did, but they felt better doing it.

A console beeped.

"Energy signature, straight ahead and closing fast!"

"Is it the Horde?" Bow asked.

"No, it's…I don't know what it is…wait, there's something familiar running underneath it…"

"There!" Glimmer shouted, pointing in front of them.

A bright green star had appeared, growing bigger as they watched. The light grew blinding and then stopped right in front of them. As the light faded slightly, they saw what it was.

"Bow, the airlock!"

"Way ahead of you, Glim!" Bow shouted back, already halfway out the door. Glimmer followed as soon as Entrapta told her that she was opening the airlock for their friend.

The two skidded to a half outside the airlock. After a minute, the door opened, revealing Adora carrying an unconscious Catra.

"I can't believe you pulled it off," Glimmer gasped.

"Honestly, I barely can either, and I lived through it," Adora said, "Where can we put her?"

"This way, there's a spare room. Bow, get the first aid kit."

Glimmer led Adora to what appeared to be a bedroom. It wasn't very big, just a bed tucked against the wall, a few cabinets, and an attached bathroom, but it would suffice.

Bow arrived with the first aid kit, helping with a few of Catra's wounds before excusing himself when Glimmer went for the zipper of the jumpsuit to check for more injuries.

"Oh, wow," Glimmer breathed, taking in the network of crisscrossing scars across Catra's back.

"Wait, when did…"

Adora trailed off, shock writ large across her face.

"You don't have that many scars," Glimmer said, speaking aloud Adora's thought, "Why does she?"

Adora shook her head, reorienting herself.

"Question for later. Question for now, how did you find us?"

"The ship zeroed in on She-Ra's energy signature. Even altered by the green light, it was recognizable enough for the First One's tech to pick up on. We went from there. Compensating was easy enough."

"Really? I didn't think this ship could do that."

"Well, it had a little help," Glimmer said.

"Turns out, dying on an advanced magitech ship, having just had enormous amounts of magic flowing through you, on the night of an unprecedented magical storm, it all has some side effects."

Adora blinked.

"Who said that?"

Blue light winked into being. For a faction of a second, Adora thought it was Light Hope back from the dead, but this new light was smaller.

Adora's eyes went wide with shock as she took in the holographic visage before her.

"Hello, Adora. It's nice to finally meet you. I'm Mara."

Chapter End Notes

If anyone wants to draw fanart of Green Lantern She-Ra, we're looking at basically the S5 outfit, with some changes. The biggest is that the formerly-uniform gold of the shoulder-guards/chest sigil are now an ever-shifting Kirby Krackle of gold and green.

Ignite the Stars

Chapter Notes

The aftermath and the OTHER moment you've all been waiting for!
Yeah, we're pulling that trigger early!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 6

Ignite the Stars

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"So it really all started with the night I died," the blue ghost of Mara said, "Like I said, lot of weird and powerful magical energies flowing this way and that. A lot of it had just run through my body like water through a sieve. And as any magic-user worth their salt could tell you, that kind of thing leaves a mark."

Adora just kept staring, not sure quite how to process this.

This was Mara. This was the woman who'd been a shadow over her since she first heard the name. This was the last person to wield the power of She-Ra. Mara was the one who trapped Etheria in Despondos, but had saved both it and the wider

universe in the process. Mara was who Adora had measured herself against, for better and for worse.

And now she was floating cross-legged in front of her, causally talking about her own death.

"Honestly, if I tried to study the phenomenon for the next year, I'd probably still never understand it," Mara continued, "Bottom line, my consciousness ended up being imprinted in my ship. I became a literal ghost in the machine."

"Wait, then how are you just talking now?" Adora asked, "We've had the ship for a while now."

"None of this is exactly standard, Adora," Mara shrugged, "Near as I can tell, I passed into a sort of fugue state, or a deep slumber, or whatever. I wasn't fully cognizant of everything that happened. Considering the *Starshine* was buried in a desert for the past thousand years, probably for the best. Don't really feel like going mad from isolation, you know?"

"Who would feel like that?" Glimmer asked sardonically.

"Fast forward to the present day, and the ship gets found. It starts to get tinkered with. Lot of stuff being repaired, lot of systems shaking off the metaphorical rust. I'm not one to name names…"

She gave a cough that sounded a lot like ‘Entrapta’.

“But bottom line, it all woke me up.”

Something occurred to Adora suddenly.

“The glitches in the system…”

“Were me waking up and better integrating myself in the ship’s systems,” Mara finished, nodding, “Very trial and error, that. The holographic systems were some of the last parts of the *Starshine* I had to take care of. I ended up modifying the data from some old recordings of me, and presto!”

Mara spread her arms wide, waving her hands excitedly.

“Techno-ghost!”

There was suddenly a low moan.

“And I think we should put a pin in the rest of this discussion,” Mara grimaced.

"A…Adora?" came Catra's groggy call.

"Could you guys give us the room?" Adora asked Glimmer and Mara softly.

"I'll just go ahead and turn off the internal sensors in this room, give you both some privacy. Shout if you need me!" Mara chirped before vanishing in a haze of blue.

Glimmer shot Adora a concerned look, but Adora just waved her off. Glimmer finally sighed and left.

Adora turned to the bed. Catra was fully awake now, and shaking like a leaf. Adora immediately sat on the bed and pulled Catra into a tight hug.

"I thought I lost you," she said, burying her face in Catra's shoulder and weeping, finally letting herself fully feel the fear she'd felt since she saw Catra in Prime's clutches, eyes hollow and voice mocking.

Catra returned the hug, holding on tightly and taking rapid, nervous breaths. Tears began to stream down her face, and she let out a long, keening cry. She shuddered in Adora's arms, and Adora pulled tighter, trying to pour as much comfort into the shattered girl as she could.

What Prime had put her through, Adora knew it would haunt her for the rest of her life. When she expressed this thought later, Catra would shudder and agree instantly.

"*I was hollowed out*," she would say, "*He unraveled me, pulled me out and stuffed something else inside.*"

And Adora would say nothing, what could she say to that? She would just bring Catra into a hug, whispering soft words of comfort and safety.

But for now, they sat in their own little world. They held each other, trying to wake from the nightmare that had just happened to them. They stayed like that for some time, clinging to each other like they were scared the other would disappear if they let up for even a second. Fear slowly bleed out as they drank in each other's presence, drawing comfort from the closeness.

After a while, Catra spoke up.

"I saw things…when he was pickling my brain with his essence, I saw my life flashing before me, everything in stark detail…I'm sorry. I'm sorry for everything. I should have gone with you, I should have tried to fix things like you were trying, I should have…I was horrible to you, and you didn't deserve it. I'm sorry. I'm so sorry…"

"It's okay, I've got you. We're not going through that again. Never again. You and me, until the end of the line."

Catra gave a watery laugh, bumping her forehead against Adora's.

"You're such a sap."

"Don't act like you don't like it," Adora replied in kind.

Catra smiled a little, then shivered hard.

"I still feel cold…"

"I'm here. You're safe. Deep breaths, I've got you."

Things were silent for a moment. Then Adora felt Catra's breath hitch.

"Why did you come back for me?"

"Not this again," Adora grimaced, "I couldn't leave you. Get it through your thick skull, *you matter to me.*"

"Even after everything I've done?"

"Do you still feel like you're that person?"

Catra's eyes squeezed shut and she took a harsh breath.

"*No…*"

"Then that's good enough. You can be better, if you try. I always believed that."

Catra broke the hug, staring at Adora in shock.

"How are you this okay with it? How are you this *nice*?"

Adora sighed. They were finally having *this* conversation. They'd carefully avoided it at the homestead, but it looked like there was no avoiding it now.

"I tried being angry at you, for everything. It *hurt*. It hurt carrying that much anger around. I don't know how you did it. I didn't like the person I was becoming, filled with anger like I was."

Adora sighed.

"Trying to stay angry at you, it was like I was being stabbed in the heart every day. So what good does it do either of us to hold onto old anger?"

Catra looked so confused. Her ears were pinned back, her tail lashed, and her hands tightly gripped the sheets below her.

"So you let go? Just like that?"

"I never said it was easy," Adora replied, "I spent a lot of time in the training yard or the forge, trying to purge it out of me. I like to think I did well, but it took work."

Adora gave Catra a soft look.

"It was worth it, though. I missed so you so much. Trying to be angry at you was nothing but pain. I cared about you, despite everything. I still do. I think I always will."

Catra growled.

"You're mocking me. Just hold up a mirror, why don't you?"

"What?" Adora asked, blinking in shock.

"I spent ages holding onto my anger! It burned so much, but it was all I had! *You left!* You were the only good thing in my life, and you left! I had nothing! There were times I felt like Shadow Weaver was right, that I was nobody and that you leaving was just proof! Everywhere I turned, I was the freak, the monster, the *villain*!"

Catra lashed out, angrily gouging the metal wall with her claws. Then she calmed a bit.

"But you never thought that, did you? I spent so much time trying to make you suffer like I suffered, trying to make you hate me, just so I could convince myself that I hated you."

"I never hated you," Adora said softly.

"And that's the real joke of it," Catra replied with a bitter laugh, "Adora doesn't hate. Adora doesn't think holding onto anger is good. Adora is kind, even when everything around her, everything she's been taught, is telling her that kindness is useless. Adora is strong, but she doesn't use that strength to dominate, she uses it to protect."

Memories flashed before Catra's eyes, of a young Adora throwing herself between Catra and bullies, even if the bully was Shadow Weaver. Of Adora smiling at Catra, actually caring about her. Of Adora and Catra, together against all odds.

"Adora is good, too good to really be in the Horde. Everyone said this weird cat-thing was worthless, but not Adora. Adora sees worth in everything."

Catra got a faraway look in her eyes, no longer fully in the present.

"Adora cares. Adora cared about me. Adora is the only good thing in my life. Is it any wonder, despite everything, that I love her so much?"

"What was that?"

Catra stiffened, jolting back to the present. She turned mechanically, seeing Adora looking at her in complete shock.

"I said that last part out loud, didn't I?"

Adora nodded slowly. Catra tried to curl in on herself, but Adora just put her hand on her shoulder, stopping her.

“Say that again.”

“You weren’t supposed to…it’s nothing! I’m just…it’s stup—”

“Don’t,” Adora interrupted, “Don’t shut me out. Don’t shut that down. That…that feels right…”

“Don’t give me false hope,” Catra growled, squeezing her eyes shut, “I can’t do this, I know you don’t want me like I want—”

Catra’s eyes flew open in shock…

Because Adora was kissing her.

It was like a blazing fire in their chests. Sparks flew in their brains. A warmth shot through Catra, finally banishing the cold and bringing a feeling of unmatched peace. Adora felt something click into place, like a missing puzzle piece had finally been found.

They pulled each other closer, their bodies fitting together as if they were made to.

And in their minds, the same voice rang out.

This is warmth. This is love. This is right*.*

After a minute, their lungs screamed for air, and they reluctantly broke for a breath. They sat there, panting lightly and gazing into each other's eyes. Adora saw sparks of happiness dancing in Catra's eyes, and Catra saw the same.

Adora suddenly laughed.

"What's so funny?"

"Just…we're idiots. We should have been doing this *ages* ago."

And Catra began to laugh too. It was actually funny, in a sad sort of way. The laughter soon petered out, and she sighed.

"I don't deserve this."

Adora pulled her close, giving her a brief kiss and holding her tenderly. Catra began to purr unconsciously, drinking in Adora's warmth.

"It's not about deserve, Catra. You have my love, and it's freely given."

Catra nuzzled her head against Adora.

"You're gonna make me start crying again, idiot," she moaned, her voice thick with emotion.

They stayed like that for a little while, and then Adora pulled Catra off the bed.

"Let's get you washed up. You'll feel better once you're clean."

Catra looked like she wanted to argue, didn't want this closeness to end just yet, but let herself be dragged into the modest water closet.

"How does that work on a spaceship?" Catra asked, looking at the small shower stall.

"I don't really want to question it," Adora replied.

Catra hummed, then turned back to Adora.

"Can you help me with my hair first?"

She tapped at her slicked-back locks, grimacing. Adora nodded, pulling a fresh washcloth and a pair of scissors out of the cabinet, gesturing with the latter and saying "just in case."

As Catra leaned over the sink and Adora wet the hair and worked her fingers through it, trying to wash out the gunk Prime had put in it, she mused at the situation. Helping like this wasn't new. They had often helped each other with their hair. Adora used to help Catra trim her wild mane when it got too unruly even for her, and Catra had helped Adora keep track of when she needed a haircut.

'*Hell, we've seen each other naked*,' Adora thought. They'd grown up in communal bathrooms, and despite separate stalls, completely innocent and accidental glimpses had been caught. At least until they'd gotten older and Catra had started showering at different times than the others, ostensibly out of body consciousness and her fur requiring special care, but was actually, Adora now realized, out of embarrassment over scars.

Now, there was something different. The new knowledge of each other's true feelings hung in the air, making this simple act feel more intimate.

Catra seemed to sense it too, and shuddered a bit under Adora's ministrations.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked, "I can let you do this yourself, if you want."

Catra fought down memories of identical men holding her down to shear off her pride. She twisted her head around and gazed into Adora's eyes, finding comfort and care in them.

"Nah, I'm good. Keep going. This feels…nice…"

Adora nodded and continued.

When she paused, Catra spoke up again.

"Where'd this stuff come from, anyway? The linens look fresh."

"They are," Adora said, "Bow stocked the ship a while back. Thought we might need it."

"Two points for foresight, I guess."

Adora grimaced as her finger got briefly stuck.

"I might have to use those scissors. There's spots that are really matted."

"Too much gunk?"

"And some debris from the fight. For such a clean-looking ship, Prime clearly needs to sweep more."

Catra gave a small snort of laughter.

Adora ended up having to clip off pieces, but not as much as she'd feared. But the end result was a short and messy style that Catra inspected in the mirror with a careful eye.

"This…actually isn't horrible. I mean, I'd rather have it longer, but still…"

"So that's what short hair looks like on you," Adora said, "I'd always wondered."

Catra then turned to the shower stall, frowning a bit.

"You know, I think I want to take care of the rest myself," she said.

“I can find you some new clothes, then I’ll be sitting in the room if you need me?” Adora offered.

“Sounds good.”

She softly kicked Adora out, then unzipped the jumpsuit. She was glad to be rid of it, opening the door slightly and tossing it out for Adora. She inspected herself, noting no new scars, although the small metal thing attached to the back of her neck was concerning. She resolved to be careful with it.

It took several false starts with the shower. Between her own dislike of water and the memories of Prime’s pool, cleaning all the grime from her body took time. She soon discovered how to increase the temperature of the water, and that helped. Making her shower screaming hot proved to disassociate it from the chilling cold of the pool.

By the time she was finished, the skin beneath her fur tingled. She relished the fading pain for a moment, then went for the towels.

As she looked at herself in the mirror, running her fingers through her fur and hair, she took a deep breath and let it out slowly.

"Clean start, Catra," she said to herself, "Let's make it a good one, yeah?"

Old fears started to rear up, whispers in Shadow Weaver's voice of how she wasn't worth it making themselves known.

She shook them off.

"No. She wants me. We're going to make this work. It has to work this time."

She closed her eyes, concentrating on the memory of the kiss.

"It'll work…"

oOo

Adora swallowed her worry as she gathered up the jumpsuit. She waited until she heard the water running, then left the room, resolving to work quickly.

Just as she was wondering if she had anything of hers that would fit Catra, Entrapta strolled up, a bundle of cloth in her arms. She held it out to Adora.

"It's for Catra. I tried to replicate what I last saw her in, but I didn't have enough for a jacket. I hope that's okay."

Adora blinked in confusion.

"Where did…how did…"

"What? I can sew."

Adora shook herself back to the present, then held up the Horde Prime-issued jumpsuit.

"This ship have an incinerator, or should I just throw this out the airlock?"

"The first one," Mara said, popping into view, "It's next to the cargo hold. But I'd wait until Catra got out of the shower and do it with her. Catharsis, it's good for the soul. Oh, Entrapta, I got the metal fabricator working, so we should be able to modify those remaining spacesuits."

"Great!" Entrapta cried, racing off, "I need to give Catra's helmet some ears!"

The two She-Ras watched her go, and then Mara smiled.

"She's fun, I like her."

"Mara, did anything like this ever happened to your friends? They went through something so terrible, and you want to help them, but you barely know where to start?"

Mara looked at Adora sadly.

"Just be there for her. Just listen. She'll reach out in her own time."

Adora regarded the technological ghost before her.

"I have so many questions…"

"We've got time," Mara replied, her hand hovering over Adora's shoulder in a gesture of support, "For now, let's make sure your friend is okay. One windmill at a time, Adora."

Mara blinked away, leaving Adora alone.

“Windmill?” she muttered in confusion before reentering the room.

oOo

It took a bit of time. Catra got caught up on a few recent developments, then had to psyche herself up for being around people who weren’t Adora, her recent trauma and her loner nature working against her. It was mostly the promise that Adora would be right beside her the whole time that gave Catra the strength to enter the cockpit.

“Huh,” Bow said as they entered, “The short hair looks good.”

“Don’t get used to it, Arrow Boy,” Catra said, self-consciously tugging at a lock, “I’m growing it out a bit as soon as I can. Having it this short is…disconcerting.”

“Preach,” Entrapta said, her living locks helping her manipulate several controls at once, “Oh, does my work fit right? I had to guess a few measurements.”

“Wait, you made this?”

“I was shocked too,” Adora giggled.

Catra looked down at herself. Maroon pants fit snugly, a black belt hanging on her hips. A pale red shirt, sleeveless of course, wrapped around her torso. There were no shoes, but Catra preferred it that way.

"I put it through some stretches, it'll do. We'll have to adjust the tail hole, though. It's a little low."

Catra's tail twitched, some of the length trapped beneath her pants.

"That was the part I was most worried about," Entrapta nodded, "Quick fix, quick fix. You take care of that Horde suit yet?"

"Yeah, it was fun setting it on fire."

"Good riddance," Bow said, "White is not your color, girl. And you know, I don't think I've ever seen you without that crown thing…"

"Prime yanked it off my head and snapped it in half," Catra deadpanned, "Because he's a petty jerk."

The door opened again, revealing Glimmer with a tray in her hands.

“Oh, Catra!” she gasped in surprise, “I didn’t think you’d be up and about so soon.”

“This one practically dragged me,” Catra replied, lightly elbowing Adora.

“Staying cooped up in that room isn’t healthy,” Adora countered.

“I like your new look,” Glimmer said, “There’s just one thing missing…”

She set the tray down in the captain’s chair, then unwound the dark red scarf from her neck and casually draped it around Catra’s neck and shoulders.

“Wait, is this the same one you were working on before?” Catra asked, poking at the fabric.

“I said I was making you a scarf. So here is a scarf.”

Catra found herself smiling as she tossed one end over her opposite shoulder.

“Thanks, Sparkles.”

“Looks good,” Adora smiled.

Catra blushed a bit. Changing the subject, she gestured toward the tray.

“What’s all this?”

“Oh, I thought I’d cook up something for everyone,” Glimmer said, “It’s dumplings, essentially.”

“You cook?”

“Not really, but I wanted to feel useful. I used one of my mom’s idiot-proof recipes.”

“What do you mean ‘idiot-proof’?” Adora asked.

“She wasn’t that good of a cook either,” Glimmer shrugged.

“At least some of the preserved food is getting used up,” Mara added, popping into being, “That junk never goes stale, it’s ridiculous.”

Catra jumped a bit, her tail frizzing, but soon calmed.

"Oh, right, the ship-ghost."

"You and Adora have been talking, I see," Mara said with a smile.

"About many things," Adora replied.

Mara looked from Adora to Catra, noting how closely they were standing together and the way Adora was looking at Catra. Her smile grew.

"Girls…is there something you'd like to tell us?"

Catra snatched a dumpling off the tray and bit into it nervously.

"Oh hey, this is actually good."

"You're stalling," Glimmer said.

"No, really, good food. Nom-nom."

"Yeah, you're stalling."

Adora put a hand on Catra's shoulder. The catgirl calmed at her touch.

"It's okay. They're not going to hurt you," Adora said softly.

Catra sighed.

"You tell them. Nervous as I am, I'll mess it up."

"Oh, like I'm not nervous too," Adora scoffed.

She looked at her gathered friends and took a deep breath.

"So…Catra and I got to talking, and some things came up, and some old tension finally snapped, andthenwekissedandwerekindoftogethernow…"

'Well, so much for calming breathing,' she thought self-deprecatingly, `*Knew I should have paid more attention to Perfuma…'*

The message got across, though. There was a stunned silence before Bow lunged forward and wrapped them both in a hug.

"Oh, congratulations! Gotta admit, that escalated quickly, still happy for you, even if this feels like it came out of nowhere!"

"Actually, it feels like this has been coming to a boil for a long time, when I look at it all in hindsight," Catra wheezed, "Now can I have my lungs back?"

Bow let go, muttering apologies. Catra smoothed out her fur, rolling her eyes at Bow.

"This is going to be a thing with him, isn't it?" she asked Adora.

"He's a romantic at heart," Adora said lightly.

Glimmer, for her part, looked at Adora oddly.

"You're sure about this?" she asked.

"I feel like I should be insulted, but considering my recent past," Catra muttered before trailing off.

“More sure than I’ve ever been in my life,” Adora said.

“Then I guess congratulations are in order,” Glimmer said, smiling, “I hope you two are happy together.”

“Getting there,” Catra said.

“Although if you ever hurt Adora again, I’ll break your kneecaps.”

“Glimmer!” Bow shrieked.

“If I ever hurt Adora again, I’ll help you do that,” Catra replied simply.

“Catra!” Adora shrieked.

“I…don’t have time to unpack that,” Mara said, “Still, good on you both.”

There was an extended silence, as if someone had missed their cue. Bow nudged Entrapta for her comment, the girl having been staring off into space for a moment.

"About damn time," Entrapta finally deadpanned.

"What's that supposed to mean?" Catra asked.

"I take notes on the people around me. Everyone analyzes behavior, but it doesn't come as easily to me, so I compensate. Putting it all down and cross-checking everything helps me figure out how to people. And I noticed that, whenever Adora came up, you'd get just a little…wistful. And even when it was in anger, you'd still sound that way. Also, pupil dilation, my mask picking up on elevated heart rates, a certain rhythm in your tail. I cross-checked it all and came to the conclusion that it was a serious case of love sickness."

There was a beat of silence as everyone stared at her, not fully expecting it from the tech-obsessed princess. Finally, Glimmer broke the silence.

"What could you possibly cross-check that with?"

"I read romance novels," she replied, as if it were obvious.

Everyone continued to stare at her.

"So I have some advice," Mara piped up.

"She said blatantly changing the subject," Glimmer muttered.

"This thing you have, it's going to take work. There will be times you really get on each other's nerves. But it'll be worth it. So, never stop *trying*. Catra, if Adora is anything like I suspect, she throws herself into danger a lot and puts the weight of the world on her shoulders."

"And how," Bow said.

"But you never let that stop you from loving her, or giving her a swift slap upside the head if she's being particularly stubborn. That's the problem with loving a hero type, you have to get used to bonehead maneuvers that give you heart attacks. But that isn't an insult to you, that's just how they are. All you can do is support them when you can and pull them back when they charge too recklessly. And never stop talking to her about what bothers you. She can't help if you don't talk to her. Understand?"

"I think so," Catra said, "But how do you know it?"

"Dad was a special agent for the military, he and Mom had a lot of stories. And Adora?"

"Yes?"

"That last thing goes double for you. Catra wants to help you if something's bothering you, so talk to her. If you keep it inside, it'll just poison everything. And this is very important, there's a lesson that everyone in this business has to learn, and some have hard time learning it. But you are worth more than you can give to other people. She-Ra isn't and shouldn't be all you are. Everyone deserves a chance at love, and I'm glad you found yours. Don't let anything threaten it, not even yourself."

Adora nodded solemnly.

"This is the most important lesson you both can learn," Mara said, smiling, "Love is a powerful force. Love can ignite the stars."

And after that sank in, everyone settled down to eat.

Conversation was light. Stories and laughter flew back and forth. Eventually, Catra started to relax, even threw in a few tidbits of her own. Recognizing that she still wasn't comfortable in the group, they didn't push her…

…although Glimmer did rib her a little when Adora showed off her new She-Ra transformation.

"See anything you like, Catra?"

"Can it."

"I wasn't the one muttering in amazement over how she got 'more beautiful'!"

"I said *can it!"*

"Hey, so, has anyone noticed that her new tiara looks a bit like Catra's mask?" Bow said abruptly.

"Sometimes the form of She-Ra borrows elements from the user's subconscious," Mara said, "I also see an outline on her sigil that resembles your heart sigil, the boots resembling Glimmer…there's even a little me in there. Wanting to better carry on the name, Adora?"

Adora stammered a bit, letting the transformation go.

"Now that you mention it, her old form did have a slight military flare," Entrapta mused aloud, "Mostly in the collar and the shoulders. Having grown up in a militaristic culture, I suppose that's to be expected. Still, it's a fascinating idea. Can't properly test it, of course, but fascinating."

As Adora sat down again, both her and Catra reaching for their drinks to hide their embarrassment, Glimmer spoke up.

"Okay, don't hate me, but I can't sit on this any longer. Catra, I helped Adora look over you for wounds, and I saw your scars."

Catra nearly dropped her cup.

"Scars?" Entrapta asked.

"Yeah," Glimmer said, "A lot of them, too."

"Catra, what happened?" Adora asked softly, "I mean, I get that they mostly get covered up by your fur, but still…"

"More than you expected, I'm guessing," Bow finished.

"We were child soldiers, Adora," Catra said, the look on her face making it clear that she didn't like the subject, "You have scars too."

"You were what," Mara said flatly, but Adora ignored her, focusing on Catra.

"Yeah, but not nearly as many. And they're weird, too. A lot of thin lines that zig-zag and branch off, like…like--"

"Lightning."

Everyone turned to Glimmer, who just regarded Catra sadly.

"They look like lightning," Glimmer said, "And that's because they're from being electrocuted."

She pulled down her shirt collar to reveal similar ones, smaller lines and spikes crawling from the nape of her neck and starting down her back.

"I don't have nearly as many, but then, I was only tortured for a relatively short time."

There was a loud crunching noise. Adora had figured out the common denominator, and crushed her cup in her rage.

"*Shadow Weaver.*"

Glimmer nodded.

"That's it, isn't it?" she asked Catra, "You got those from Shadow Weaver."

It took a moment for Catra to respond, but when she did, she couldn't look at anyone.

"There were a lot of punishments you never knew about, Adora."

Adora inhaled sharply through her nose.

"Note to self," she said through gritted teeth, "When we get back to Etheria, punch Shadow Weaver until her spleen ruptures."

"Adora," Catra began, but then cut herself off with a grimace.

"Catra?"

Catra grunted in pain, scrabbling at the back of her neck. She suddenly shrieked in pain, spasming.

Everyone shot to their feet, Adora lunging to steady the falling Catra.

"What's happening, what's wrong?" she cried.

Catra took several shuddering breaths.

“Prime,” she whispered, “I can feel him…he’s angry…GAH!”

Catra spasmed again.

“Medbay, now!” Mara barked, and the doors flew open.

Bow helped Adora carry Catra to the medbay of the ship, Glimmer and Entrapta scurrying in their wake.

Once she was on the table, Catra stopped spasming so hard, but still shook.

“He’s angry…so angry,” she gasped, “He…Etheria! He wants Etheria! The chips…the chips!”

Catra threw her head back, screaming.

“Revenge, *revenge!*”

Catra gave one last spasm before sagging onto the table limply.

"Catra?" Adora asked, worry heavy in her voice.

"The chip," she whispered, "I'm not fully connected, but I can still feel him…and I think he can feel me…get it off, *get it off! Don't let him take me again!*"

Adora wrapped her in a hug. Catra's shudders lessened considerably.

"Entrapta, can you remove that?" Glimmer asked, pointing at the metal in the back of Catra's neck.

"So long as Mara spots me with her sensors," Entrapta replied.

"Easily done," Mara replied, "Bow, did you pack any numbing agents? That might help."

"I armed for bear stocking this ship," Bow replied, already digging through the cabinets.

"Catra, Catra, look at me," Adora whispered, "I'm right here. You're safe. Okay, now Entrapta's going to remove that thing--"

Catra whined and wiggled closer to Adora, still deep in fear from the images that had been stabbed into her brain.

“I’m don’t…what if she tries to hurt me?”

“Why would I want to hurt you?” Entrapta asked before coming to a swift realization, “Oh, is it because you sent me to Beast Island, stole my work, and used it to rip a hole in space and time? Right, I get it now. Forget it, no hard feelings.”

Various hair tendrils held up various tools and cutting implements. She pulled down her bug-eyed mask, making the image even more unwittingly terrifying.

“Now hold still!”

“Entrapta!” Glimmer snarled, “Dial it back!”

“Catra, I’m right here,” Adora said, “I’ll stay right here until she’s done. Okay?”

Catra took several deep breaths and soon loosened her grip on Adora.

“Okay,” she said softly.

Realizing that her patient didn't want to be here any longer than necessary, Entrapta worked quickly. Her hands were deft as she clipped away wires and slowly eased metal out of flesh. The numbing creams helped, but Catra still winced from various pokes and jolts of pressure. Only Adora's constant presence and reassurances kept her calm.

Glimmer and Bow observed it all. If they had any doubts as to this relationship, seeing the two together brought a swift end to it.

Entrapta consulted an image on the wall, real-time scans from Mara, and nodded.

"Okay, just one more piece…"

"You're doing great, Catra," Adora said softly, "Just a little more."

Entrapta eased the metal out of Catra's neck, her patient wincing the whole way.

"And there…let me just do some quick stitches, and we'll wrap this up."

"You got it all out?" Catra asked.

"As much as I could," Entrapta replied as she sewed, "According to the scans, there's still some pieces in there, connections points from the chip to your nervous system. I'd try for them, but they're gripping your spinal column too tightly for my liking. I've done neurocranial interfaces before, but this is much more physical in terms of interaction with the brain stem. I don't feel comfortable doing more, I could risk some serious brain damage."

"The ring might be able to help," Adora offered, rubbing said ring with her thumb, "Then again, I don't know how well I'd do with such tiny details. I only *just* got it working with regularity, after all."

"Even if you could, it's probably best we get an actual doctor with proper facilities to look at that."

"I'm disconnected from the hive mind, though, right?" Catra asked.

"Oh, definitely," Entrapta said, finishing the stitches, "And I removed the power source, so Prime won't be able to track the energy signature. I'll just dump it out the airlock in a few."

Catra turned and gave her a look.

"*I'll* dump it out the airlock," Bow said, plucking the small object from the tray, "There's an asteroid field nearby, if we're lucky, a few ships will crash into it before they realize they've been had."

“It won’t be enough,” Catra said with a hollow voice, “Prime is different from Hordak. Hordak was evil and power-hungry out of desperation. He wanted to go home, go back to be among his brothers because it was all he knew. Horde Prime is evil and power-hungry because he *wants* to be. How can you fight that?”

Adora gave Catra’s hand a squeeze.

“Together.”

Catra looked at her, and Adora could see hope and fear warring in her eyes.

“And if we lose?”

“Then we’ll do that together too.”

Adora leaned in close, and Catra touched their foreheads together.

“I’m not going anywhere, Catra. I’m staying with you, come what may.”

Catra closed her eyes and began to purr.

Chapter End Notes

Let’s be honest, here. There is nothing that can possibly top the dramatic importance of the canon confession. So I didn’t even try. I think the goal of any Catradora confessions written by fans going forward should be to do something different, and in my case, I went with something quieter and softer, two traumatized people finding comfort and relief in each other’s presence. They survived, and they’ll keep surviving so long as they’re together.

I also seem to have made the scarf a bigger thing than I initially intended. It was just a throwaway line at first, now it’s part of Catra’s look. I have no idea how it happened, it just did.

And lastly, I’d like to give a shoutout to a story called ‘love taught me to lie (and life taught me to die)’ by echoes_of_realities. It’s a great bit of Catra character study, and it greatly informed when I wrote the character’s quieter, introspective moments. It’s also where I got the idea of Catra having a lot of Lichtenberg (electrocution) scars from Shadow Weaver, which just makes sense when you stop and think about it. Of course Shadow Weaver would have used electricity as a disciple tool, she’s horrible!

Therapy Cat

Chapter Notes

Why yes, I do enjoy letting Adora and Catra flirt openly and be soft girlfriends with each other, why do you ask?

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 7

Therapy Cat

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Adora sat in the captain's chair, looking at the stars. Her gaze flickered across the room. Bow and Glimmer were sitting on the floor playing cards. Entrapta was at the main console, speaking in rapid but hushed tones to a small representation of Mara.

Just as Adora was wondering if she could join the card game or something, a familiar form hopped over the arm of the chair and flopped into her lap.

"Seriously, Catra?" she asked with fond exasperation.

"What? I'm not going anything," Catra said smugly.

She then started flicking at Adora's nose with her tail and purring. Adora grabbed the tail and gave it a long stroke, and Catra shivered and squeaked.

"Oh, did we like that?" Adora smiled, taking in the blush on Catra's face, "I wonder how much mileage I can get out of this…"

"We have a problem."

Everyone stiffened at the now full-size Mara's words.

"I'm going to regret this," Catra groaned as she yanked her tail out of Adora's grip, "Okay, what is it?"

"We forced the *Starshine* into deep space really fast, operated at maximum speed, then kept at it for an hour after we picked up Adora and Catra," Entrapta explained.

"Then after we ditched the chip parts, we skirted that asteroid field and did a serpentine path through space, just to keep Prime's forces confused in case they were still tracking us," Mara added.

"All that has put major stress on the ship's systems. We need to undergo repairs before we end up dead in space."

“I’ve already had to fiddle with a few systems to converse power, so we should find a place to set down sooner rather than later.”

“Come to think of it, we should probably find a way to recharge the invisibly spell,” Glimmer said, “It ran out a while ago, but since we were in the darkness of space, it didn’t matter. But if we want to get back to Etheria undetected, we’ll need it. Any bets on whether or not Prime’s blockaded Etheria on the off-chance of catching us?”

There was a pause, and then everyone chorused “NO BET!”

“Okay, let’s get a list together and find a planet to hide out on,” Bow nodded.

“Mara, put up a star chart, show us what’s nearby,” Adora said.

A large hologram appeared in the air. A point of light rapidly blinked.

“So we’re here,” Mara explained, “The closest planets are here…”

Several planets began to glow.

“We should pick one nearby, in case we need to mine some resources.”

“What about that closest one?” Adora asked.

The view centered on the planet in question.

“Krytis,” Mara said, “In my time, it was being scoped out for study, but I’m not sure anything came of it. My records are a thousand years out of date, after all. However, I remember hearing that preliminary results had it as a magical planet.”

“If we could mine some crystals, I can use them to recharge the main crystal for the invisibility spell,” Glimmer said, beaming.

“Wait a minute,” Catra said, standing up, “You said Krytis?”

“Yes, why?” Mara asked.

Catra rubbed at her head.

“I…I’m getting a funny feeling…like phantom pain or something…I think it’s leftover information from the hive mind.”

Adora stiffened, reaching over to touch Catra's shoulder.

"Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Catra said, "But that planet's important. There's something there, something Prime didn't want anyone to know about…I don't know what, everything's fuzzy…"

"Don't strain yourself," Bow said, "How about we go there and find out for ourselves. Anything Prime wanted to keep secret has to be good for us, right?"

"Setting a course," Mara said.

oOo

The planet was a network of scorched rock and weak-looking moss. A bitter gust of wind blew through the air.

The five Etherians donned the space suits Entrapta and Mara had built and went out to explore the wilderness. Adora projected a line of green energy and dragged along a large case of Entrapta's tech.

"That's handy," Glimmer said, stepping around the metal object.

“Getting better every day, I think,” Adora said.

“If smashing through several Horde clones and bots is rookie stuff, I can’t wait to see what mastery looks like,” Catra grinned.

They trekked through the landscape, the only sounds the blowing wind and the crunch of dead moss underfoot.

“Creepy place,” Bow said, stepping around a scorched crater, “Is this what Prime does to planets?”

“I’m not detecting any sign of life so far,” Entrapta replied, “Maybe Prime bombed it all into oblivion?”

“I think the worst part is that he thinks he’s saving the universe. That all this is a good thing, somehow,” Catra grumbled.

She kicked a rock into a burned mass. It collapsed into a pile of soot.

“Oh look, symbolism.”

Left unsaid was the worry for Etheria, should Prime lose patience.

Finally, they came to something important. Overgrown with moss, broken into several pieces, but it was unmistakably one of Prime's towers, identical to the ones that had been popping up on Etheria, but far older and hopelessly wrecked.

"We're definitely in the right place," Catra said, "The fur on my neck is standing up."

"Along with your tail," Entrapta added, pointing at said tail, now bushy, "But speaking of fur, at least your mane of hair is short enough to fit under a helmet. I had to modify mine for that—"

"This haircut wasn't my choice," Catra growled, "Just another violation from Prime."

There was an awkward silence.

"I have touched a nerve," Entrapta said, "I apologize."

And she scurried away, putting Adora between herself and Catra.

Adora reached out to touch Catra's shoulder, but Catra shrugged her off.

"Just…just give me a minute."

"Okay, but I'm here if you need me."

"Maybe there's something we can use in there," Bow said, "Spare parts, salvage…and since we're not under a time crunch, Entrapta should actually be able to get into any computers."

"That's why we're bringing this!" Entrapta grinned, patting the large metal crate, "I built it just for this kind of purpose. It unfolds into a computer relay, one connected to the *Starshine*. I just need to find a place to plug it in, and Mara can help me access the foreign systems. We can trawl through what's left of the servers for any information, including Horde Prime's potential weaknesses!"

"When do you sleep, woman?" Glimmer hissed.

Adora pried open a door with a giant green crowbar, and they all filed inside. The interior was a mess, metal strewn all over the place. It took Entrapta time to find a workable computer terminal, but she quickly plugged in.

"Online!" Mara's voice issued from the relay device, "And good news, everyone! The atmosphere is safe!"

Entrapta immediately removed her helmet with her hair, tossing it to the side before getting to work. Adora, Bow, and Glimmer soon removed theirs.

Catra, however, had been distracted. Being inside this place reminded her of Prime's ship, and a chill ran down her spine.

Bow however, misinterpreted Catra's delay.

"If my helmet were that adorable, I'd leave it on too," he giggled, "Those ears!"

Catra growled and struggled to remove her helmet, even as the others couldn't help but laugh at her flailing. Catra's anger and embarrassment disappeared at the sight of Adora laughing. She found herself smiling a bit, then shifted gears.

"So what's next? Please tell me we're not going to go barging through this structurally unsound building?"

"Only if we have to," Glimmer said, "We might be able to get everything on our shopping list without exiting this area. We should at least start digging through stuff."

"Clean-up detail," Catra hummed, "Some mission."

“Hey, yeah!” Bow said, “This is technically your first mission with the full Best Friend Squad!”

“Why are you smiling at me like that?”

“And now that I think if it, we decided on this planet mostly because of your intel,” Glimmer added, “So this mission is really all on you!”

“No it’s not!”

But Bow and Glimmer had already sandwiched Catra between them, dancing in a circle and chanting “Catra’s first mission!” over the catgirl’s protests.

Catra managed to extricate herself, stumbling into Adora’s arms. She righted herself with a scowl.

“Ugh, I’m going to kill your friends!”

“Please don’t. And they’re your friends now, too.”

Catra glared at her. Adora just smiled back.

"You're such an idiot."

"Well, then I guess I'm your idiot."

Entrapta's cry of interest caught their attention.

"Guys, I'm detecting a heat signature! There's someone else here, someone alive on the planet! And they're somewhere in the tower!"

"Wait, how is anyone surviving on this dead rock?" Bow asked.

"The scorching seemed fairly recent, maybe some time in the past several years, depending on the weather and how long the fires raged," Adora said, "Whatever the case, Prime missed someone. Maybe they can tell us what happened, why Prime left."

"So we *are* going to barge through the structurally unsound building, trying to find a mystery person we know nothing about, in the vain hope they know something about Prime that we don't?" Catra asked.

"Pretty much," Adora said.

"Sounds like a plan," Glimmer said.

“Why not?” Bow asked.

Catra groaned and looked up at the ceiling.

“Honestly, what did I expect?”

“I just pulled up the tower’s schematics,” Mara called out, “Entrapta and I should be able to guide you from here.”

Entrapta tossed them a few communication devices she’d made with Mara’s help, and the four headed deeper into the fallen tower.

As they picked their way through jagged rock and shards of metal, the oppressive air weighed down on them. Catra suddenly stiffened and whipped around.

“What is it?” Adora asked.

Catra’s eyes darted around, but she soon relaxed.

“Nothing. Place must be getting to me, I’m jumping at shadows. Let’s speed this up, the less time we’re here, the better.”

“Couldn’t agree more,” Glimmer said.

The first obstacle came with a large wall, but Entrapta insisted that a door existed on the schematics.

“Data never lies!” she screeched, the comms creating feedback at her shout.

“Ugh, move,” Catra growled, taking off her suit's gloves to free her claws.

A few quick swipes and a kick later, and they had an entrance.

“There’s your door. Let’s go.”

Glimmer cast an eye at Adora, noting her blush.

‘*Strength does seem to do it for her*,’ she mused.

The tunnel let out into an open area. Moss had entered the tower, and unlike outside, seemed to be doing well. Shiny spores drifted in the air. Bow inspected one of the moss-covered metal plates and made an interesting discovery.

“It’s not all moss. It’s partially some kind of mineral growth.”

Glimmer shuddered slightly.

“This place feels strange. I can’t put my finger on why…”

“Yeah, I’m getting a weird feeling too,” Adora said, “The spores are kind of pretty, though.”

One flitted into Catra’s nose, and she sneezed.

“Wait, that’s your sneeze?” Bow asked.

“Yeah, why?”

“It’s just…so…cute!”

“It’s a normal sneeze!” Catra shot back, looking a touch offended.

“I can’t believe the whole time you were trying to kill us, you had the cutest sneeze of all time!”

"I am not cute!" she shouted, her tail bristling.

"The angrier you get, the cuter you are!"

Catra hissed in rage, and one hand started flexing as she actively fought the instinct to just claw Bow's face off and be done with it.

As all that was going on, Adora leaned closer to Glimmer.

"Should we stop that before she tries to kill him?"

"She has to get used to it somehow, and the sooner the better," Glimmer replied.

Adora thought about it for a moment, then nodded.

"Okay, but let me defuse it a little right now."

"Sure, whatever."

Adora stepped closer to Catra, gently shoving Bow away.

"Razza-frazzin…not cute, what's he talking about?" she was muttering.

Adora reached out and started scratching behind Catra's ear. The anger immediately dissipated, and Catra melted into Adora's touch, purring softly.

"It's okay, Catra. I think you're cute, and you don't mind that, right?"

Catra regarded her, then gave a long, slow blink.

"Well, if it's you, it's okay. But can you please talk to Arrow Boy? You know, before I do something you won't like?"

"I'll do my best."

Adora gave her a kiss on the cheek, and Catra gave a small smile in return.

So of course, Bow had to ruin it.

"That is so adorable!" he squealed.

“That’s it!”

Catra lunged at him, but he dodged with a laugh.

The laughter vanished when Catra’s arm sank halfway into the metal plate behind him, like it was made of water. She screamed in shock, and Adora immediately acted, grabbing her by the waist and pulling her out.

The wall grew spikes, and more appeared throughout the tunnel, growing closer to them with every second. The four hightailed it away, Adora still carrying Catra by the waist in a burst of adrenaline.

They managed to climb to a higher level of the broken tower, and the spikes retreated.

“The hell was that?” Catra gasped.

“I think the feeling I had about this place is a bad feeling,” Glimmer panted.

“YOU THINK?! A wall just tried to eat me!”

“Entrapta, Mara, come in! Things just got really weird, really fast!” Adora all but shouted into the comm.

There was static before there was an answer.

“I am not detecting any anomalous readings,” said Entrapta.

“What we just saw was pretty anomalous!”

“I am detecting the energy signature close to your position. Go through the door on your left.”

“What door, there isn’t a--”

Adora trailed off, staring in shock at the gaping darkness before her.

“Guys, was that there a minute ago?” Bow asked weakly.

“And there it is,” Catra deadpanned, “The fur-standing is back again. Why can’t I wake up from this nightmare? I am trying really hard not to freak out right now.”

“Do you want your ears petted again?” Adora asked.

“Yes please.”

Adora did so, and Catra calmed.

“Okay, so, creepy door through the creepy tunnel?”

“Well, Entrapta said through the door, so it’s through the door.”

And so they went for the door.

The atmosphere seemed to get even more oppressive as they walked through the tunnel. Nervous sweat collected on Adora’s brow, and she reached up to wipe it away as it started to drip down.

When she lowered her hand, she froze.

“Adora?” Catra asked, worried at the sudden halt.

“Did this tunnel just get longer?”

Her companions blinked, then looked ahead of them.

"The hell?" Glimmer asked.

Bow looked behind him, and yelped.

"Sudden darkness! I can't see where we were!"

"The double hell?"

"Entrapta, come in, now!" Adora shouted into her comm.

"Sheesh, you don't have to yell! Hey, so, Mara cracked the code! The First Ones did start up a colony here, but then their empire suffered a massive schism! Horde Prime took advantage of the chaos and started attacking them. But while he won this planet, he retreated from it before he could finish the invasion. Then he tried to erase all records of it, covering up his failure. Isn't that exciting?"

"Fine, whatever. That door you wanted us to go through? I think it led to a trap!"

"What door?"

Everyone froze.

"What do you mean, what door?" Catra hissed, her tail bristling in fear, "You told us to go through a door!"

"Guys, I haven't been in contact with you since the previous level."

The four looked at each other, fear writ large on their faces. They looked forward, seeing the tunnel extend before their eyes.

"I knew this was a bad idea!" Catra howled, "We need to get out of this freaky place before—"

"By the way, who's your new friend? I'm reading a fifth heat signature behind you."

The four turned around mechanically. Out of the darkness loomed a large shape with glowing eyes.

Glimmer and Bow screamed and backpedaled. Adora tried to bring her ring to bear, but Bow slamming into her knocked her

over. Catra dodged Glimmer and leapt at the shape. There was a blur of light, and both disappeared.

Adora felt fear grip her heart and she scrambled for her comm.

"Catra! Catra, come in!"

"Adora! I'm back on the lower level and—holy—"

Catra's voice cut off.

oOo

Catra stumbled back from the massive paw that slammed into the ground where she'd just been.

The shape had twisted, resolving into a massive cat. Eyes and teeth glowed a bloody red, and a mane of light and stardust flickered about its neck, just as red as the eyes and taking the form of a forest of spikes. It let off a growl, deep and harsh enough to rattle her bones.

The beast circled the fallen Catra, the tail revealing itself to be just like the mane as it flicked this way and that. She sized it up,

trying to figure out the best way to fight it, or at least survive until Adora could appear and smash it with a giant green hammer.

Just as Catra idly wondered what was taking Adora, the entire cat shimmered an eerie light and disappeared.

All of her instincts blared. She wasn't out of danger yet. She could still hear the rumbling growls, still feel the slight shifts in the spore-heavy air.

The light returned, revealing the cat not two inches from her face. She bit back a scream of fright, not wanting the startle the tremendous doom-beast right in front of her.

Then a tickle hit her nose.

'Great, this is how I die…sneezing,' she thought to herself, *'At least I got to kiss Adora…'*

Catra sneezed, but rather than attack from the sudden noise, the cat reared back, as if confused.

There was another shimmer of light, and when it resolved, the cat was much smaller, about as tall as the seated Catra. The fur was a dusky purple, the mane and tail now a cool blue that billowed in an unseen breeze, and the now-blue eyes looked at her with mild interest.

The creature sneezed, perfectly mimicking Catra's own outburst.

"Oh, wow, that is cute," Catra muttered.

The cat slid a little closer, ducking her head low and nudging Catra's hand. As if by instinct, Catra began to scratch the now-calm beast's ears. As she did, she felt a feeling of calm suffused her.

Hello, new friend.

Catra jumped slightly, and the cat have a soft meow.

New friend okay. Safe, safe, safe.

"Is…is that you?"

The cat purred, nuzzling Catra's hand.

A burst of green appeared from above them.

“Catra, I’m here, I’m—"

Adora stopped, looking at the scene with shock. Behind her, Glimmer looked just as stunned, and Bow lowered his bow.

“What kept you?” Catra asked.

“More spikes, but Glimmer figured out they were magical illusions, and tapped into one for a spell. Are you…petting the thing that’s been trying to kill us?”

“Aren’t you?” Glimmer countered, “Remember earlier? That thing with the ears?”

“That’s different!” Adora said, blushing.

“Actually, I have to agree with Sparkles, it kind of isn’t,” Catra replied, still petting the large cat.

The cat gave her a long, slow blink.

“Huh. It likes me.”

“How can you tell?” Bow asked.

“It’s the slow blink,” Adora explained, “Cats do that.”

“You’d know,” Catra said to her, giving her a slow blink of her own.

“I swear, it’s like you two are making up for lost time or something,” Glimmer said, “You’ve achieved a high level of romantic mush at an astonishing rate.”

“Jealous?” Adora asked cheekily.

“This is so—”

“Don’t start, Bow!” Catra snapped, and the cat growled, mane flickering to red briefly.

“Is it responding to your emotions?” Glimmer asked.

“I think so, yeah,” Catra replied, continuing to pet the cat.

It gave off a few soft mewls, and Catra tiled her head.

“Is anyone else hearing that?”

The others shook their heads.

“Maybe we should ask Mara, this creature might be in her files,” Adora said.

“Do you want to come with us?” Catra asked the creature.

It shrank to the size of a housecat and jumped into Catra’s arms, still purring.

“I’ll take that as a yes.”

oOo

“Well, I do recognize the species from the databanks,” Mara said from the relay, “I don’t think it ever had a real name, not one anyone could agree on. But they’re symbiotic, forming empathic and semi-telepathic links with the planet’s felid population.”

“Felid?” asked Glimmer.

"Cat people, basically. Catra's own physiology and brain chemistry must have been close enough for our new friend."

"So the cat bonded with Catra?" Adora asked.

"In multiple senses, yes. Since we haven't detected anything else on the planet, I can only guess it's the last of their kind."

"She," Catra corrected, "And her name is Melog."

"How do you know that?" Bow asked.

"She told me. I can…kind of hear her."

"Well, congrats, Catra," Mara said, "You now have a therapy animal."

Melog nudged the stunned Catra's hand for more pets.

"I have no idea what that means," Catra finally said flatly.

“Hoo boy, that’s a subject I’m not qualified to touch,” Mara muttered.

“Can you ask her what happened here?” Adora asked.

But Melog heard regardless, looking at Adora for a moment before turning back to Catra and meowing repeatedly.

“So…she’s been by herself for a long time…she’s not sure how long. She’s sorry about earlier, with the spikes and everything, but she thought we were enemies like…the ones who tried to take the magic?”

“The First Ones, maybe?” Glimmer asked.

“They dug into the ground, built machines. And where the machines touched, magic started to…weaken…”

“Yeah, that sounds about right,” Mara sighed.

“They must have been mining the planet’s magic, just like Etheria,” Entrapta said, finally speaking up.

She’d previously gotten too close to Melog, and the cat had taken offense to the prodding, growing huge and snarling at her.

Entrapta had been hiding behind her console ever since.

"They started taking too much. A lot of them knew it, too. There was fighting over the whole thing. Then…the one who destroys came. Who?"

Melog shifted, growing in size and warping in shape. When she stopped, a new figure was before them. It was purple and blue, but is was unmistakably Horde Prime.

"It's okay. He hurt me too," Catra whispered as Melog shifted back, her mane now a sad-looking orange, "I'm still trying to get better from it."

Adora put a hand on Catra's shoulder, and Catra reached up to grab it, letting the touch ground her.

Melog resumed her explanation, saying that Horde Prime had swooped in, destroying the First Ones and trying to conquer the planet. But the magic of Krytis was too powerful, too wild. Prime hadn't known what he was dealing with, couldn't use it or defend against it. He did manage to destroy a significant population of the planet, and unleashed 'fire from the sky' to destroy what was left. As far as Melog knew, she was the last.

"Magic," Glimmer breathed, "Horde Prime is vulnerable to magic!"

Adora reached for Melog. She snarled a bit, but calmed after sniffing the outstretched hand.

Mate of Catra?

"As good as," Catra replied.

Adora threw Catra a questioning look, but Catra waved her off. Melog bumped her head into Adora's hand, and she began scratching at the ears.

"Catra likes this too, you know," she said, smiling before sobering, "I'm sorry all this happened to you. But we're trying to make sure it doesn't happen again. We're going to fight the destroyer, make sure he never destroys another world like he did this one. But for now, you can come with us. Our planet is magical too. I think you'd really like it there."

Melog twisted her head and licked at Adora's hand, making her laugh.

"Great, maybe she can help me find a suitable magic source to recharge that invisibility spell," Glimmer said.

Melog looked over at her, then shimmered. The light enveloped Adora and Catra, and all three vanished.

"Woah!" Bow called out.

After a moment, the three reappeared, Melog looking very pleased with herself.

"Faaaaaaascinating," Entrapta grinned,

"I think we'll be fine on that front, Sparkles," Catra laughed.

oOo

After some repairs, everyone decided to knock off for the night.

Catra exited the bathroom, finding Adora waiting. Without another word, they slid into the bed together. They'd started doing that the same night Catra was rescued. Catra had woken from a nightmare and went to find Adora. Adora had invited her to snuggle, and they'd fallen asleep like that. They'd been innocently sharing a bed ever since. Thankfully, it was just wide enough to accommodate them, and with how close together they ended up being, it worked out.

Having each other close was a comfort. Between their long separation and their respective tramuas, it was nice knowing the other was right there, a rock in the storm.

Tonight, however, something different happened.

Five minutes after settling in, Melog entered the room, passing through the wall like a ghost. She took one look at the two figures cuddled close together and hummed.

She leapt onto the bed, shrinking as she flew, until she was kitten size. She picked her way to the head of the bed and settled on the pillow, leaning against the top of Catra's head.

Adora snickered a bit.

"You have a kitten on your head."

"Go to sleep, Adora," Catra muttered back, "You're tired."

She didn't argue Melog's presence, however. Just as the alien cat was settling down, Catra heard a voice in her head, one that was steadily growing more familiar.

Catra. Adora. New family. Safe, warm, love.

Catra fell asleep easily that night, lulled by Adora’s warmth against her skin and the rumbling purrs from Melog.

Return

Chapter Notes

This is a very eclectic collection of scenes, fair warning

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 8

Return

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Repairs took several days. Between repairing the damage they knew about, finding whole new damage, and some concerns about their fuel supply, time passed in a blur of work. Thankfully, they were able to salvage a lot of usable parts from the Horde tower, and Adora was able to use her ring to recharge the fuel crystals, although it took several tries before it stuck.

Entrapta was already drawing up ideas for how to completely rework the engines to run on Lantern energy.

"That battery you use to recharge the ring would be a practically limitless source of energy. I just need to figure out how to control the energy flow so the engines don't get overcharged and explode."

And then after that, it would take more time than expected to return to Etheria. Even with Melog helping the invisibility spell, it couldn't be maintained the whole way due to it practically being jury-rigged at this point, so they had to be careful where and how they used it. Often, they had to take a longer route to avoid Horde patrols. Thankfully, Mara's expertise and access to extensive star charts were able to compensate for the detours.

All and all, it took two weeks from that first day on Krytis for them to make it back to Etheria.

In that time, Adora carefully observed Catra, worried about her, but her girlfriend (and what a joy such a simple word brought) seemed to be healing well. Most of the time, she was back to her snarky self, before Thaymor and the beginning of her spiral into anger and darkness. It was all a little softer than before, a little kinder, but it was still unmistakably Catra.

Occasionally, though, she'd find Catra brooding. Every time, she slipped close, gave her a soft kiss on the cheek, and asked if she wanted to talk. Often, she didn't, and Adora would simply resign herself to being a quiet but comforting presence. She didn't push, not wanting to smother Catra after everything she'd been through. Other times, Catra did talk, trying to give voice and work through her issues, however difficult it was for her. Like Adora had after coming to live at Bright Moon, Catra had to learn that real affection didn't come with strings attached, and that was a process that was going to take time.

Some of those talks ended up tripping on Adora's issues. It wasn't that she was unaware of how self-sacrificing she could be or how much weight she would put on herself. She might not have the exact words to describe it, but she knew that the emotional manipulation that Shadow Weaver had called affection had caused invisible but potent mental scars. The problem was, she was never sure how to begin to address it. It had just festered, contributing to the break she'd had with Catra, both so wrapped up in their own pain that they couldn't fully see the other's.

But without Shadow Weaver hanging over their heads, without the perils of war getting between them, they'd been able to see and repair the breaks. Their time at the homestead had started it, and now they were continuing it.

Melog had been a godsend. Between using her link with Catra to send waves of calm into the brooding young woman to the shifting colors of her mane providing a window to Catra's emotions, Adora found in Melog a partner in helping Catra heal from her trauma.

One day, Glimmer noticed them talking. She didn't hear all their conversation, but she caught the end of it and realized what was going on.

"You know, when this is all over, my aunt could set you up with a therapist."

"A what?" Adora asked.

"Someone trained to listen to people and help them with their issues and problems, basically. I mean, I hope I'm not overstepping, but you both could use help working through your nightmarish childhoods, Catra's villain spiral, and whatever the hell happened or will happen with Prime."

"Wait, is this related to that crack Mara made about Melog?" Catra asked, the cat in question cocking her head in interest.

"Kind of? I'm not well versed in the subject, but I think it's something you should look into."

They decided to revisit the subject later, but Glimmer took solace in how they hadn't dismissed the idea outright.

But the one talk they'd had that had utterly broken Adora's heart had been when Catra described the humiliation train that was her life, how she inevitably lost any good just as things were really starting to go her way.

"And I wonder, what's going to ruin this? Every time it looks like I can be happy, something ruins it. What's—"

Adora had cut her off with a kiss.

"I won't let that happen. I won't let anything hurt you again. We're going to get the happy ending if we have to pry it from fate's cold, dead, hands."

oOo

The second they entered the atmosphere, Adora perked up.

"Swifty?"

"Something up, Adora?" Bow asked.

"You know that whole 'sacred bond' thing I have with Swift Wind?"

"Not particularly, since I never had an animal companion," Mara muttered, "Unless you count that stray dog I had for a few years. Why no, I'm not bitter at all, why do you ask?"

"The bond kicked back in?" Glimmer asked.

"Mara, bring up a map of Etheria."

Adora traced her finger over the resulting hologram, then stopped at a certain point.

"There."

"That's the Fright Zone," Catra said, "What are they doing there?"

"Let's find out."

oOo

Entrapta steered them toward the Fright Zone, landing in a field outside it. The entire group disembarked, taking a moment to smell the air of their home planet.

Glimmer let sparks dance across her fingers, laughing as she did so.

"Oh, that feels *good*! I missed magic!"

Melog pawed at the grass, making confused squeaks, but was soon bounding around the field in joy.

“Someone’s happy to be out in the open,” Adora laughed.

“Oh, you have no idea,” Catra laughed back, tapping at her temple.

They all took a moment to breathe in the air of home, then set off. They kept a tight formation, Adora and Catra in the lead, Bow bringing up the rear. From the center, next to the tense Melog, Glimmer her eyes peeled and ready to teleport at the first sign of trouble. Entrapta had her eyes glued to a tracker-pad, murmuring to herself.

“Anything interesting?” Glimmer asked.

“Etheria has a lot of signals zooming this way and that, the Horde talking to each other. But the signals here…there’s something off. It would pass cursory inspection, but still…”

“Maybe the signals are fake?” Bow asked, “If you want to hide a tree, pick a forest. If the Rebellion set up camp here, they could have people sending out fake signals to hide themselves.”

“The tech in the Fright Zone would certainly help them do it,” Catra agreed.

They crept into the Fright Zone itself, stepping lightly amongst the old metal. It was far too quiet, but no one gave voice to it.

Suddenly, Catra held up her hand, ears twitching. Melog grumbled slightly, sensing something as well. Catra and Adora shared a look, a silent conversation, then Catra crept forward, claws at the ready.

A glowing net flew out of nowhere, striking Catra and pinning her to a wall.

"Catra!" Adora shouted in worry, but before she could act, large vines burst from the ground and wrapped around the rest of the group.

People stepped out of hiding, appearing like ghosts. They wore haphazard pieces of armor, some clearly old Horde armor and some not, and held stun batons at the ready. Among them were Frosta, Netossa, and Perfuma.

"Show us your necks!" Perfuma shouted, a crazed look on her face.

"Wha--"

"YOUR NECKS!"

Frosta darted around the trapped group, a serious look on her face.

"They're clear!" she said, "What about the jerk-cat?"

"Give me a minute, she's wearing a scarf," said one helmeted soldier, working around the net.

"Lonnie? Is that you?" Catra yelped.

"Hey, Catra. Still mad at you, hold still or I shock you."

Lonnie worked the scarf down and hummed at the sight of Catra's neck.

"Some scarring and weird bumps. Could be something new…"

"And there goes my patience!" Adora snarled.

Green light flared, arcs of energy ripping apart the vines containing the group. She thrust her hand forward, and an identical hand of green light shot forth and yanked Catra off the wall, breaking the net and bringing her to the safety of Adora's side.

Adora put her hand on her sword, a serious look on her face. Beside her, Melog had grown in size and was now standing protectively over Catra, growling deeply.

"You want her, you go through me and the magic cat," she growled, "Who's first?"

Several soldiers stiffened, gripping the stun batons tightly. Frosta formed a pair of ice fists.

"EVERYONE COOL IT!" Glimmer shouted, startling everyone, "Catra's with us. She was chipped, but we got it off. She's fine now. So let's all put down the weapons and talk like civilized people."

Weapons were slowly lowered. Adora helped Catra up, the two exchanging quiet reassurances. Perfuma leapt into Bow's arms, crying about how she didn't want to be in charge anymore. Frosta kept giving Catra the evil eye, but a look from Glimmer made her stop. Frosta then proceeded to coo over Melog, who ate up the attention and mugged for more. At some point, Swift Wind showed up, hugging Adora between his wings and refusing to let her go. It took five minutes to convince him otherwise.

Basically, everyone was happy to see their friends all right for the most part.

Finally the big question was asked: what was going on?

Netossa told the story as they went deeper into the Fright Zone.

“We started hiding out here a while back. Refuge in audacity. The heart of the old Horde is the last place the new one would look. They don’t seem to care about this place.”

“But why leave the Kingdom of Snows?” Bow asked, “What happened?”

Netossa took on a pained look.

“Spinny happened. She got chipped.”

“Oh no,” Glimmer gasped, and Catra’s hand unconsciously went to her neck.

“The Horde kept her as a sleeper, having her chip as many Rebellion members as she could. She got to half the fighters before she was caught.”

“How?”

"Our old friend the shapeshifter."

"Double Trouble?" Catra asked, a stunned look on her face.

"They'd been spying on us out of raw curiosity, and blew the whistle. They pretty much joined after that, using their powers to keep track of everything."

"By themselves?" Catra asked, "They're good, but I didn't think they were *that* good."

"Actually, they've been working with Kyle," Lonnie spoke up, having removed her helmet, "He got a bunch of old spy drones working, really quick too. The two of them have essentially been our entire intelligence operation."

"I always said he would've done better in engineering," Adora chuckled, "So I take it a few old Horde soldiers are on our side now?"

"A fair few of them," Lonnie shrugged, gesturing toward a few of the random soldiers in the party, "We didn't like what Horde Prime was doing. Even if the Horde was cruel, it was still grounded. This is just…twisted."

"You got that right," Catra muttered.

“And you’re sure the Fright Zone is clear?” Bow asked.

“We swept for bugs, twice,” Lonnie said, “We’re as sure as we can be.”

“The only signs we had that Prime was ever here was that it looked like he had Hordak’s lab ransacked,” Netossa said, “Not sure why he didn’t go further.”

“He was pretty upset that Hordak was trying to build his own empire,” Catra explained, “He probably just wants to put it all out of his mind. He was actually ready to blow up the whole planet and erase every trace of the perceived mistake, but decided to investigate the Heart of Etheria further.”

“Small mercies, I guess,” Frosta winced.

“There was another thing missing,” Perfuma spoke up, “The Black Garnet.”

Shock was writ large across the faces of the newcomers.

“Is that even possible?” Entrapta asked, “I assumed that all the runestones were fixed in their position.”

"Really, only the Heart Blossom is like that, and that's because it's attached to a tree," Glimmer replied, a thoughtful look on her face, "The rest…it's not well known, but the person connected to a runestone can move it using rituals. It's just not done because they're so darn big, and usually very well-protected. Mom taught me how in case something ever happened to her."

"And Prime's tech means transporting something that huge is more of a minor logistical challenge, not a super-difficult task," Catra added, nodding.

"But I don't understand how they could have knowledge of that ritual. It's a closely guarded secret."

The other princesses looked uncomfortable.

"We lost a few members of our A-team," Netossa said slowly, "When Double Trouble blew the whistle, Spinnerella activated all the sleepers, tried to cut off our escape. Scorpia, Mermista, and Micah held the line for the rest of us to escape. They…they didn't make it out. Kyle's drones briefly picked them up a day later. They've been chipped."

Glimmer looked like she'd been struck by lightning. She stumbled, Bow reaching out to steady her. She turned and wept into his chest.

"No…Dad…I didn't even get to…"

By this point, they'd entered the main base of the Rebellion, where more people were gathered. Any celebrations for the return of their lost members were put on hold at the sight of Glimmer weeping over her father's loss. One soldier peeled off from the mass and helped Bow lead Glimmer away to mourn in peace.

There was a long silence as the newcomers digested all that had changed.

"It makes sense now," Entrapta ventured, "Micah is a powerful sorcerer, and he was married to Queen Angella. He would have had the knowledge and power to move a runestone."

"So I'm guessing Shadow Weaver wasn't happy to see the Black Garnet gone, huh?" Catra finally said.

She'd been struck by the news that Scorpia had been captured, weighing it against the apology that she knew she owed the woman. Realizing she was starting to spiral, she changed the subject.

"Oh, she was furious," Frosta said lightly, "It would have been funny seeing her rage if she wasn't such a terrible person."

Catra stared at her.

"What?" she snapped.

"I like you, kid."

Frosta sputtered before turning away with a growl. Catra looked around and noticed similar disgruntlement on the faces of many around them. It made sense. She'd been a major enemy of the Rebellion, and her last days as Horde Commander had been riddled with mistreatment of her soldiers. Small wonder neither party was happy to see her.

"Haven't seen this many angry faces since mechanics class," Catra muttered, "Least then, I wasn't alone in screwing up."

"Actually, if I'm being honest, I flubbed a few assignments on purpose so you wouldn't stand out so much," Adora said.

"Aww…that's not true," Catra replied, mix of care and disgruntlement in her voice.

"It's actually completely true."

This time, Catra's "Aww" was more genuine.

“What’s happening?” Perfuma asked quietly.

“They’re flirting with each other,” Entrapta replied.

“Wait, what?”

“Yeah, they’re together now. It’s a whole thing.”

“Dammit, now I owe Kyle extra rations!” Lonnie exclaimed.

The other princesses just stared at Adora and Catra, who both sighed.

“It’s a long story,” Catra said.

“Well, we have time,” Perfuma replied, “What happened to you all?”

Adora took a seat on a crate and collected her thoughts.

“Well, it all started when a magic ring appeared at Bright Moon…”

oOo

At some point, Glimmer and Bow returned. Glimmer's eyes were red, but she was more composed. She and Bow began helping tell the story where it was relevant.

After that, Netossa guided them on a brief tour of the facilities they'd rigged up. Unsurprisingly, Entrapta peeled off around the forges, reuniting with her companion-bot Emily and integrating herself with some of the technical research.

"And this is intelligence," Netossa said, looking in on a room filled with screens. A few people manned them, but Kyle was at the center, his eyes darting this way and that.

"Hey, Net," he said offhandedly, not looking away.

"Is that really any way to greet some old friends?" Adora said with an amused look.

Kyle immediately spun around, falling out of his chair in the process.

"Adora? Catra?"

“Hey, Kyle,” Catra said, “Gotta say, you look in your element.”

“Uh, yeah, yeah, this suits me better, I think,” Kyle stammered, “Uh, nice hair?”

“It’s a new feature,” Catra replied, tugging at a stray lock, “Relax, I’m not going to bite.”

Kyle did so, picking himself up and sitting back in his chair.

“It is actually good to see you,” he said, “Even after everything. Prime’s messed up a lot, so it’s nice to see old faces.”

Catra’s face dipped a bit.

“Yeah, sorry about before. I wasn’t exactly in a good frame of mind.”

“I figured. It’s fine. Lonnie and Rogelio might still be ticked at you, but at least you’re apologizing.”

“I’m trying to do better with my life.”

“You’re succeeding a bit, I think,” Adora said, putting her arm around Catra’s shoulders and squeezing.

“You’re a sap,” Catra said, but shot her a grateful look all the same.

“You love it,” Adora laughed before pecking her cheek.

Kyle looked from Adora to Catra and smiled.

“So…Lonnie owes me those rations, then?”

“And she’s thrilled about it,” Catra laughed dryly.

“Well, someone’s more chipper,” came a dark voice.

Catra turned to see Double Trouble peeling themselves away from the shadows.

“Looks like that little therapy session I gave you worked,” they said.

"Is that what you call it? Because it seemed more like you were kicking me while I was down."

"Eh, po-tay-to, po-ta-to."

"That is *not* how therapy works!" Glimmer shrieked.

"It better not, or I'm definitely not doing it," Catra said, her tail lashing.

In the future, she might look back on that moment as the day where, after hitting rock bottom, she started to make the attempt to turn her life around. But for now, as much as her head realized what a turning point it was, her heart still railed against the barbed arrow that had pierced it.

"Moving on, anything interesting, Kyle?" Netossa interjected.

"Nothing so far," Kyle replied, "Believe me, I'd be shouting to the rafters if I found one of the chipped princesses. And the first sign of Spinnerella, you'll be the first to know."

"Thanks, I appreciate it."

“I’m a romantic at heart,” Kyle said, smiling a little before turning back to the screens.

“I was never the biggest fan of star-crossed lover stories myself,” Double Trouble snarked, “Really formulaic, takes a lot for one to stand out.”

“How would you rate me and Catra’s?” Adora snarked back.

“Don’t know, I haven’t seen enough of it, don’t have a lot of the finer details.”

They morphed into Catra, albeit her pre-Prime look.

“Although I think I’ve gotten this character down,” the Catra copy said.

“Don’t remind me,” Catra grumbled, glaring a bit at her double.

“I’m not apologizing,” Double Trouble deadpanned while turning back to normal.

“Any word on Castaspella?” Netossa asked.

"She checked in about half an hour ago. No joy," Kyle replied, "She's going to take another look around, but she'll probably be back at the end of the day."

"Who are we talking about?" Catra asked.

"Glimmer's aunt," Bow replied, "She's a sorceress."

"Hang on. She's a sorceress, and her name is 'Cast-a-spell-a'?"

"Ummmm…yes?" Glimmer said awkwardly.

Catra groaned.

"You know, sometimes I really do have to wonder about Etherian naming conventions."

"It's funny that you think Double Trouble is my real name," came a smug reply.

oOo

They'd gone through a few other areas before Catra heard a familiar voice cursing aloud.

"Is that—"

"Yeah, that's Shadow Weaver," Netossa grumbled, "No one's happy she's here, but we deal with it for her knowledge. Castaspella is usually here to keep her on an even keel, but as you heard earlier, she's out chasing a rumor about Micah. You ask me, I'm tempted to throw that witch to the wolves and be done with it."

"She'd find a way out," Catra grumbled, "She always does. Woman's a cockroach, I swear."

"What's she up to now?" Glimmer asked.

"She seems to think that it might be possible to release all the stored magic from the Heart of Etheria in a safe manner, bringing to planet to magical levels not seen since before the First Ones," Netossa explained, "Honestly, I don't really get what she's on about, really."

"Well, I hate to give her credit, but it might help protect us from Prime," Adora said, "Melog's from a magical planet, and it was too much for Prime to deal with. We think he's weak to magic."

"He also managed to ravage Krytis when he couldn't use it," Catra argued, "So I don't feel too comfortable with the idea."

"Castaspella seems to think it's worth a shot," Netossa shrugged, "Honestly, most of us have been focusing on guerilla tactics, sabotage, and trying to figure out how to break the chips. We don't exactly have a lot in the way of long-term strategy."

"Luckily for you, that was my specialty," Catra grinned.

"I figured, given how hard it was starting to get fighting the Horde."

The group made their way on, but Adora noticed Catra lingering a bit, and resolved to talk to her about it.

oOo

Shadow Weaver grumbled as she poured over the many scrolls of old text.

"Nothing here…"

A kitchen timer went off, and she slid over to her cauldron, adding a few ingredients and stirring it before taking it off the heat.

“Now that just needs to cool.”

She scoffed.

“Making medicines is a waste of my talents.”

“I don’t know, it certainly seems more useful than scaring the spit out of cadets.”

Shadow Weaver jerked her head around, seeing a familiar figure slouching against her doorframe.

“Catra…”

“Shadow Weaver.”

The sorceress stared for a moment at her old charge before turning away.

“I hate the new hair,” she hissed.

“Didn’t ask your opinion,” Catra shot back.

“Then why are you darkening my door?”

“That’s it? No ‘Where have you been, Catra?’ or ‘Did Prime capture you?’ Just you passive-aggressively telling me to get out?”

Shadow Weaver didn’t answer, merely opening a fresh scroll.

“You know, I don’t know what I expected,” Catra scoffed, “I don’t even know why I’m here. I know how this is going to go. You only have two settings when it comes to me: angry shouting or false kindness.”

“I heard about your job performance as second-in-command from some of the old Horde soldiers. You are hardly any better.”

“Nice deflection. What’s your next trick, pulling a killer rabbit out of your hat?”

“I don’t have time for this, Catra,” Shadow Weaver snapped, turning back, “If you have something to say, then say it.”

“Fine…why?”

"Why what?"

"Why what, she asks," Catra grumbled, "Everything you did to me, all the pain and suffering you put me through, and you have the nerve to wonder why I'm so mad at you."

"Everything I did was to—"

"Make me strong, yeah, I call bull, lady! You didn't do it for me, you did it to make yourself feel strong! How did it feel, then, to know you were so good at making a little girl feel like something you'd scrape off the bottom of your shoe?"

"Insolent child! You have no idea what I sacrificed to get to where I am."

"Oh yeah, hiding like a rat in a crumbling kingdom, the people you're ostensibly working with hating your guts! Real position of honor there."

As the two spoke, they'd drifted toward each other, voices raising with each step. They were now mere inches apart, each giving a glare like they were trying to set the other on fire.

"I don't expect a feral creature like you do understand!" Shadow Weaver spat.

"Oh, calling me an animal, real original! Maybe don't use lines I've heard a million times in the locker room! That's your problem, Shadow Weaver! You *hate* me! You've hated me so much and for so long that you probably don't even know why anymore! You were supposed to be an adult, but instead, you were a spiteful brat!"

"You needed disciple!"

"*I needed a mother!"* Catra shouted back, tears in her eyes, "But you showed me nothing but hate and violence. And now you're surprised that I look at you like a monster."

Shadow Weaver reached her hand up, intending to slap Catra, but Catra caught her by the wrist.

"QED," she hissed.

She threw the hand away before turning around.

"You're *horrible*. And I'm through with you. Come near me and Adora again, I'll slice your throat open and damn the consequences."

She started to stalk out of the room, but froze at Shadow Weaver's quiet snarl. It was barely audible, no doubt something she hadn't intended for Catra to hear, but she'd forgotten how good her old ward's hearing was.

"I should have taken more of your memories after those escape attempts. I should have wiped you both clean and started over."

One of the things that had always bothered Catra was exactly what happened to make Adora leave; that she left because of some strangers, not because of what was done to Catra. The past few weeks had softened that stance, Catra realizing that it wasn't that she was an afterthought or that Adora didn't care about Catra's hurt. Adora hadn't known the full extent, and everything in Thaymor had happened so fast that Adora hadn't been able to prioritize anything. If she had, she would have made certain she left with Catra, fancy new princess powers be damned.

But now, any remaining resentment died a quick death.

"It was you…you did it all…"

Catra's fury became extremely cold.

"You took it from us. You took everything from us!"

She turned back to Shadow Weaver, glacial anger all over her face.

"We could have been happy *years* ago, but you just couldn't lose your little puppets! How many times did we try to get away from you? How much did you take?"

"Clearly not enough," Shadow Weaver replied, not even bothering to deny it, "I did what I had to do to keep you both in line. You would have ruined Adora's future."

"Being around *you* ruined plenty."

"And what of you? Do you honestly think you'll ever be absolved of all you've done? Do you think that Adora will ever truly forgive you?"

Catra couldn't help but laugh.

"Wow, you really have no idea, do you? Adora stormed an alien battleship to bring me home! I know how she feels about me!"

"It won't last," Shadow Weaver scoffed, "You have too much anger in your soul. You crave power and push everyone away eventually. I've seen it. And after all, what did you do once you had my old position? You acted just like me. In the end, we're the same."

"*No!* I refuse!" Catra snarled, tail lashing and claws a heartbeat away from extending, "I've seen where that road leads and I want no part of it! If it takes the rest of my life, I'm going to prove you wrong. And when I die, they're going to say 'she was a good person, she was loved'! I will *never* be like you, not ever again."

"It's too late, Catra," Shadow Weaver replied, looming over her old charge, "Far too late for either of us."

"Wrong again."

They whipped their heads toward the new voice. Adora stood in the doorway, her eyes flickering green-and-gold. She stomped right over, putting herself between Catra and Shadow Weaver and staring the latter down.

"She's going to be better than you ever were. Because she knows what she's like at her worst, and doesn't want that to happen again."

Shadow Weaver started to say something, but Adora cut her off.

"You know what the real difference between you and Catra is? You both did terrible things, but I haven't once heard you say that you're sorry. Not say it and mean it, anyway. Catra did. Catra knows what she did was wrong, and she wants to fix it. You?

You don’t care who you’ve hurt. You’ve only ever cared about yourself.”

She turned, giving Catra a smile and touching her gently at the elbow, leading her away from Shadow Weaver.

“Oh, and one more thing…”

Adora’s right hand, the one wearing the ring, wrapped itself in green energy. She spun and struck, the blow ramming into Shadow Weaver’s masked face with enough force to rattle her brain inside her skull. Shadow Weaver fell back, with a bloody nose and a visible crack in her mask.

“What was that for?” she moaned.

“You figure it out!” Adora spat, then pulled Catra out of the room.

“How long were you listening in?” Catra asked.

“Long enough,” Adora said casually.

“You didn’t have to do that.”

Adora stopped and turned, the flare gone from her eyes as she looked at Catra tenderly.

"Yes I did. You look out for me, and I look out for you. Besides, the way she was going, she was probably going to use me as a weapon to get in your head. Me punching her makes for a good counter-argument, doesn't it?"

"Well, I guess I can't argue with that."

Catra leaned in close, touching their foreheads together.

"Please stay."

Adora quickly realized what Catra was really asking.

"I'm not going anywhere. This thing we have, it's going to last. I'll make sure of it. We both will."

Catra began to purr.

oOo

The *Starshine* flew silently through the sky. The cockpit was tensely silent, five people mentally gearing themselves for what was to come.

It had been a few days since the Best Friend Squad had returned to Etheria, but this was to be their first big mission. Double Trouble had located two of the chipped, and they didn't have much in the way of back up. The opportunity was too good to pass up.

One might have wondered why these two didn't have much Horde support. But when one was Micah, support wasn't necessarily needed.

"I love the stealth capabilities," Mara said suddenly, no doubt tired of the silence, "Can we make this a feature?"

"We'll look into it," Glimmer smiled lightly before sobering, "So, let's go through the plan one more time."

"You and Adora are the heavies on this mission," Catra said, fingers stroking Melog's amorphous mane to deal with any nervousness, "So you two will have to deal with Micah. He's the most dangerous piece on the board right now, and we need to get him out of Horde hands. Between She-Ra's might and your magic and teleporting, you should be able to keep him off balance enough to take him down. Me and Netossa, meanwhile, will stealth-takedown Spinnerella. With her wind powers, any sustained fighting will get harder as she builds momentum. So dealing with her quickly and quietly is our goal. Bow will hang

back and snipe if he sees a proper opening. Once the two have been taken out, Mara swoops in, and we're out of there."

"My question is about the chips themselves," Netossa said.

"When I fought the chipped Catra, she sustained a blow to the back of the neck," Adora explained, "It damaged her chip enough for her to start shaking off the brainwashing. If Prime hadn't intervened himself, she might have thrown it off completely, or at least enough for me to get at the chip myself."

"You blindsided me and zapped it with your ring," Catra deadpanned.

"After trussing you up like a prize hog. I doubt Micah will give me the chance until we've damaged the chip enough."

"Hit the back of the neck and her left ankle, got it," Netossa nodded.

"Left ankle?" Bow asked.

"She twisted her ankle really bad when she was a kid. Keep her off balance enough, and it'll act up on her."

"Important combat tip, thanks," Catra nodded.

"But can your cat-thing keep us cloaked long enough to do it?"

Melog made a sound like she was insulted.

oOo

Micah and Spinnerella walked through the city streets. Civilians hid in their homes, fearful eyes peeking out of windows.

A sudden noise from the rooftops drew their attention. They gazed up with blank eyes. Without any outward sign of communication, Spinnerella launched herself up onto the rooftops. She flew around, looking for any disturbance. As she set down, toxic-green eyes looking this way and that, a potent blow suddenly hit her ankle.

Spinnerella fell to the ground with a cry, and an unseen weight pinned her there. Before she could counter, a claw pierced her chip. She slumped bonelessly to the roof like a puppet with its strings cut.

Netossa and Catra shimmered into view, Catra still crouched atop Spinnerella.

"Nice hit," Catra said.

"Thanks. Let's get her out of here and hope the others had as much luck."

Meanwhile, back on the ground, Micah seemed to realize that something had gone wrong. A bright green light appeared out of the corner of his eyes, and he threw up a magical shield just as a beam of energy hit. When the smoke cleared, his attacker stepped forward.

"She-Ra," he hissed.

She-Ra just smiled.

Micah launched a series of fireballs, but She-Ra easily blocked them all. Seeing that it wasn't doing anything, he began to charge his fire with shadow magic, hoping that would do the trick. He paused, sensing a build-up of magic behind him, and dodged the beam of sparkling light just in time.

"Well, well, well, if it isn't my wayward daughter," he smirked.

"This really isn't how I wanted to meet my dad," Glimmer muttered before ripping up the cobblestones beneath her and sending them flying at her brainwashed father.

He blocked the attack with a storm of purple lightning, turning the rock to dust.

"Is that your best? Your mother would be so disappointed."

That was the wrong thing to say.

Glimmer began teleporting rapidly, striking with blasts of energy from every angle, never staying still for more than a second. Micah did his best to block, even as She-Ra added in her own energy blasts to ramp up the pressure, but inevitably, shots got through.

"Do! Not! Talk! About! My! Mom!" Glimmer shouted, before bringing both hands to one side and charging up a powerful beam spell.

Micah quickly realized what she was doing, and called down dark lightning. But Adora was there, holding up a shining green shield above them and reflecting the lightning. When the attack was done, she threw the shield at Micah like a discus. It flew too fast to dodge, and rammed into his stomach. As he doubled over, winded, Glimmer took the chance to unleash her spell. She thrust her hands forward, and a large beam of power shot forth, enveloping Micah.

Miraculously, he still stood, a dark aura surrounding him to ward off some of the damage. But his body still smoked and burned from the attack.

He glared at them before concentrating the aura into his hands, intending on a counterattack.

There was the twang of a bow, and an arrow sprouted from his back. A surge of electricity shot through him, and he howled in pain. The howl was cut off by a giant green fist slamming down on him.

"And he's out," Adora said, "Good thing we took him by surprise in a confined space. I don't want to think about what would have happened if he had more room and time to work with."

Adora sent up a green flare before kneeling down to fry the chip, and a sudden wind was soon over them. The invisible door opened above them, revealing Catra.

"Need a lift?" she asked with a grin.

Bow quickly joined them, and they got Micah on board. Just as they were taking off, Micah stirred.

"Angie?" he whispered.

"No, Dad. It's Glimmer," Glimmer replied softly.

His eyes went to her and he smiled.

"Oh, look at you…my beautiful baby girl…you've got your mom's eyes…"

Glimmer hugged him tightly, tears of joy forming.

"Dad…"

oOo

Entrapta removed the remainder of the chips and Castaspella gave them a clean bill of health, but urged bedrest.

Catra looked in on Spinnerella and Netossa, the latter having not let go of her wife's hand since she woke up. Taking a deep breath for courage, she made herself known.

"She'll be fine. I mean, she'll have nightmares for a while, but in the long run, there shouldn't be any side effects from being chipped. I'm speaking from experience."

"Thanks, Catra," Netossa said, "You know, you're alright."

"I'll take that as a compliment. Can I ask you two something?"

"Sure," Spinnerella said.

"How did you know you were the ones for each other?"

Netossa got a strange smile on her face.

"Is this about Adora?"

Catra's ears dipped and she got a small blush on her face.

"Look, whatever self-esteem issues you've got, forget them when it comes to Adora. That girl's crazy about you, couldn't hide the smile she gets with you in a dark room. Anyone with eyes can see that."

"We've been trying to kill each other for three years," Catra deadpanned.

"You're saying your fights *weren't* sexually-charged on some level?" Spinnerella asked.

Catra blushed further and looked away with a hiss.

"Look, if you want my advice, there's something important you need to know and *never* forget," Spinnerella said, "Communication is key. Never stop talking to each other. Even if something hurts, it's better out in the open where you can both work on it than it is festering inside your chest. Keeping your heart open is scary, but if you don't, you miss out on what makes life wonderful."

Catra nodded.

"I've been hearing that a bit recently…"

"Perfuma?" Spinnerella asked.

"Perfuma."

"Well, take it from some relationship veterans, it's good advice," Netossa said.

oOo

Swift Wind hovered in the clouds over the white tower.

"Why'd you pick this one?" he asked.

Adora shifted on his back before replying.

"It's far enough away from the Fright Zone that it won't be traced back there, but it's also one of the taller ones, so it'll be seen in a lot of places."

"I do have to wonder why he put a tall one near the Crimson Wastes," Swift Wind said, "It's not like there's a large population there."

"Don't try to wrap your brain around the actions of an egotist," Adora replied, "It's a long and winding road with no satisfactory destination."

"You get that from Mara?"

"She's nice to talk to."

Adora drew her sword and took a deep breath.

"Grayskull calls upon me to fight

To defend innocents from their plight

I stand firm against evil's might

I have the power of GREEN LANTERN'S LIGHT!"

The second the transformation was done, She-Ra leapt from the back of her mount, holding her sword high. Light pooled around the blade, extending outward at a rapid pace. As she fell, she brought her sword down.

A giant blade of light cleaved into the tower, shearing through metal and circuitry with ease.

By the time Swift Wind had caught Adora, the tower had been bisected three-quarters of the way down. One half still stood, but the other was in the process of crumpling to the ground.

"I really missed you, Adora," Swift Wind said.

"You've said that about a dozen times," Adora laughed, patting her horse's neck.

"And what, you didn't miss me?"

"Of course I did, silly. It might not seem like it all the time, but you're part of the family! I don't know what I'd do without you."

Swift Wind have a brief whinny as they turned in the air, flying away from the tower.

About a mile away, waiting in the skiff with a recording device capturing the action, Catra and Sea Hawk watched the message being made.

"Kyle and Double Trouble will have some fun with this," Sea Hawk grinned, "Give it a week, and this song will be sung in every corner of Etheria!"

"Right?" Catra chuckled, "And is it wrong that I find this really damn hot?"

"I'd be worried about you two if you didn't!" Sea Hawk replied with a laugh.

He stopped laughing, a serious look on his face.

"You seem to be doing better."

"A little every day, I think. It still hurts, but…I'm dealing, you know?"

Catra gazed at the distant Adora as she said this, a smile on her face.

"Then bless that broken road," Sea Hawk said sagely, "For it led you to accepting love in a way you couldn't have before."

Catra turned to question him, but he was already walking away to prepare for the return trip.

She would later share those words with Adora, and Adora would agree.

"We both had issues, and they prevented us from seeing what was happening to the other. But now we see. Now we can help each other heal and becoming stronger for it."

Chapter End Notes

Man, between this, my Supergirl story, and my Ducktales story, I seem to take a lot of joy in having damaged people confronting their abusers and telling them to piss off.

Failsafe

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Gold Light, Green Light

-

Chapter 9

Failsafe

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Teeth pierced and ripped into tender flesh. The slavering animal tore into her prey with brutal efficiency. A terrified squeal echoed through the air, only to be answered by the animal's pleased cry.

"Oh sweet Earth Mother, how have I never had this before?"

Catra tore into her fish with her teeth, moaning in delight all the way.

"This is scary to watch," Bow said, his own fish forgotten at the sight of Catra's teeth easily ripping her fish to shreds.

Behind Bow, a reclined Swift Wind grimaced, his eyes never leaving Catra's teeth.

"Try being what's technically a prey animal, domestication and/or magical enhancement be damned."

Melog, from her position behind Catra, gave a chuffing sound that resembled laughter.

"Don't start with me, you!" Swift Wind spat back.

"Slow down, Catra," Adora said with worry, "You'll swallow a bone if you keep this up."

"Don't care! Too good!"

"You know, we really should have expected this reaction," Glimmer muttered, "Although that's a good question, how hasn't she had fish before?"

"Remember the stuff I told you about dining in the Horde?" Adora said.

"Right, good point. I thought you were going to pass out in joy when you ate that strawberry cake that first day."

“Regardless, we’ll have to thank Sea Hawk for leading that expedition. He brought back intel and fish, both good things.”

Catra moaned in agreement, her tail whipping about and curling in joy.

The group was in an old hanger that had been all but claimed by them. They were gathered around a camp stove and eating fish that they had grilled themselves. Not far away, the *Starshine* sat waiting. Earlier, Entrapta had dashed in, Emily on her heels, the technological savant throwing an explanation of working on a project with Mara before disappearing into the ship. Otherwise, the Best Friend Squad were left to their meal and bonding.

“So what’s the current situation with that ring?” Glimmer asked, “I’ve seen you messing around with it lately, even when we’re not doing raids.”

“Honestly, mostly practice,” Adora replied, stroking the ring, “I think I’ve got blasts, shields, and energy constructs pretty down, so long as that last one isn’t too complicated.”

“Multiple swords at once isn’t complicated?” Swift Wind snarked.

“When you get down to it, a sword is a simple shape. Multiplying it is fairly easy. No, I mean the really complex stuff. I could never

make something like a skiff. A boat, maybe, but it wouldn't be much more than a hull and some seats; I'd have to move it along myself."

"What, like getting out and pushing?" Bow laughed.

"Sustained energy beam, but that'd be basically the same thing, right? All the same, I can tell that there's more to the ring than that."

"Like?"

"I flew through space," Adora replied, "I might be able to fly again, but I haven't had the time or inclination to test it yet."

"Maybe when this is all over, I could give you some tips?" Swift Wind offered, spreading his wings slightly.

"There's also a sort of…mind. And no, the ring's not alive, at least I don't think. It's a little more like Light Hope."

"Hopefully without an agenda," Glimmer muttered.

"I don't think so, no. It's probably more simple, only doing what's asked of it," Adora shrugged, "The problem is, I don't know how

to fully access that. I don't know if it's me or the ring is just… damaged somehow."

"Could it be both?" Catra asked, "Remember back on Prime's ship? It said those systems were like, half operational."

"That's a good point. It had enough thinking power to plot a course and get us out, but it stopped talking after that."

Adora sighed.

"I guess that's still a work in progress. Still, what I've already got is pretty potent, so…mystery for another day."

Conversation drifted after that. The Best Friend Squad just hanging out and joking around. Then the peace was shattered. Catra's ears suddenly flicked to the hanger doors. Melog sniffed at the air and started growling.

"Something up?" Adora asked, immediately catching onto the tenseness of her girlfriend and their feline companion.

The question was answered for her when Shadow Weaver casually strode into the hanger.

"Ah, there you all are. Eating like savages I see."

"Well, it *was* a pleasant campfire bonding experience until you showed up," Bow replied with uncharacteristic anger. It was hard to remain Mr. Positive knowing what he knew about how Shadow Weaver had treated his friends, although he was painfully aware that what he'd been told was only a fraction of the whole truth.

"So insolent. Your fathers weren't this flippant," Shadow Weaver replied.

"Probably because they don't know what I know. If they were, you'd have had your ass kicked a long time ago."

"Really?" came an answering scoff, "They don't seem the type."

"You know George was a soldier, right?" Glimmer piped up, "He probably knows several ways to kill someone with his bare hands."

"A dozen, I think," Bow nodded.

"Can we see that fight?" Catra grinned viciously.

"If we're done," Shadow Weaver interjected, "I came here because I thought you ought to know, we found proof of the

failsafe in the Heart of Etheria. George and Lance found an old transmission in a First Ones ruin, one that had been attempting to reach the previous She-Ra…"

Shadow Weaver trailed off, because her audience had suddenly made a mad dash for the ship. Curious, she followed.

"No, I never got a transmission about a failsafe," she heard from the cockpit, "Then again, it was pretty chaotic near the end, so I'm not overly surprised."

"But do you think it's legit?" Catra was saying.

"Depends on who was sending it. If it was Keldor, I'd ignore it. I found some evidence that he was a double agent, but I wasn't able to adequately prove it. And then I was in no position for further investigations. Being a ghost will do that to you."

Shadow Weaver stopped dead. They were talking to a ghost? That could be both enlightening and incredibly dangerous. Or perhaps she could use that to her own ends.

She burst into the cockpit, but she was resoundingly ignored in favor of the blue woman hovering above the main console.

"However, there's always Luz. She was the brains behind the Light Hope AI, and someone I trusted with my life. If she was the

one who found the failsafe, we can definitely trust it."

"How could we tell?" Adora asked.

"When making transmissions, she always hid her identity behind a modified image of Light Hope. Hooded, broad shoulders, holding up a crystal slate…"

"That's the image George and Lance described," Shadow Weaver interjected, hoping to pull attention back to her.

"Well then, we can trust it," the blue woman said.

"What do you think this is supposed to be, Mara?" Adora asked.

"The Heart of Etheria drew magic from the planet into itself, concentrating it. If the failsafe can destroy the Heart, it'll release the shackles on all that power, spreading it all throughout Etheria."

"Such a power surge would probably fry a lot of Horde Prime's tech, since I haven't found evidence that the rank-and-file weaponry are hardened against a mystical discharge of sufficient force," Entrapta chimed in from a corner.

“And it would keep the Heart out of Prime’s hands,” Glimmer mused, “When I was his prisoner, he was really interested in the Heart. Plus, there’s the princesses to consider. Activating the Heart supercharged us…at least until it started cycling up to fire. Releasing all the trapped magic would probably have a similar effect.”

“So where is this place?” Bow asked.

“The transmission referenced an outpost called Arxia,” Shadow Weaver replied, “I believe this is in reference to an artifact called the Crystal of Arxia, hidden by a group of traitorous First Ones—"

“Probably my rebellion,” Mara interjected.

“—beneath what is now Mystacor.”

Mara waved her hand, and a map of Etheria appeared.

“So in my time, Arxia was here…”

She pointed at a spot on the map, and Glimmer nodded.

“That’s where Mystacor is. About three hundred years ago, they raised the land into the sky. No doubt they took this crystal with

them.”

“Then we have a target,” Adora said, “Mara, how’s the ship?”

“Considering I’m pretty well attached to it, I’ve made sure she’s shipshape and purring like a kitten. Stealth drive could use a recharge—"

“Adora, are you really going to pin everything on a ghost?” Shadow Weaver scoffed, “I thought I raised you better than to put trust in the undead.”

Her gaze went to Catra, who bristled.

“But then, you always did have a soft spot for the untamed.”

Mara winked out of existence. Suddenly, a massive form was standing in front of Shadow Weaver. It was shaped like a man, eight feet tall and with muscles on muscles. The head was an angry bull, snorting in barely-restrained fury.

“CAN IT, GASLIGHT!” it roared right in Shadow Weaver’s face.

And then it was gone, and Mara had returned, continuing as if nothing had happened.

"I can definitely get us there, and Melog can easily cloak the party for the rest of the way. I heard that Mystacor is under Prime's control."

"That's right," Bow said, "Micah was commanding it, but it's still full of chipped sorcerers."

"We'll definitely have to do this with stealth," Catra said, "It'll be dangerous, but we don't have a lot of other options."

"Actually, I think I'm close to finding a way to disrupt Horde Prime's link with the mind control chips," Entrapta interjected, "The data Swift Wind and I got on that scouting mission was what I needed."

Entrapta suddenly looked wistful.

"I saw Hordak. He remembered me. He's struggling, but…he knew me."

"Are we compromised?" Shadow Weaver asked, actually sounding worried.

"No, I got her away before he could sound an alarm," Swift Wind said, "But even if we crack the chips, won't we still have Prime to

deal with? And I imagine he'd be pretty pissed off if we took his toys away."

"He's right. Mystacor is our only option," Adora said, "Micah is still out of it, so Castaspella will have to guide us. And like Mara said, Melog can cloak the party until we're past the guards."

"I'd be the better choice," Shadow Weaver said, "I've spent my whole life studying the secrets of Mystacor. I can get us in far better than Castaspella can."

"No dice, Shadow Weaver," Adora replied, "No one trusts you further than they can throw you. Heck, if you could have gotten in there so easily, why are you asking us for help?"

The two stared each other down for a moment before Adora broke it off.

"You can come if you want, your knowledge might be useful. But if you pull anything, we're leaving you to the wolves."

"Understood," Shadow Weaver snarled.

Catra looked uncertain, but a look from Adora had her sighing and nodding.

"Uh, can I duck out?" Swift Wind asked, "I'm not good with stealth."

"No problem, Swifty," Adora replied, patting the horse's neck, "You hold down the fort here."

oOo

Catra really didn't like this. After everything Shadow Weaver had done to her, having to work with her on this mission rubbed her the wrong way. She took solace from the fact that Adora only agreed to the sorceress' part in it reluctantly.

'*She trusts me with everything*,' she kept thinking to herself*, 'But she trusts Shadow Weaver with nothing. That bridge has been burned to cinders.'*

The thought gave her comfort, that's why she kept it in mind, even while glaring daggers at Shadow Weaver's invisible back.

While under Melog's cloak, they could see vague outlines of each other, but to an outsider, there was nothing. They'd had several close calls, ducking around empty green gazes, but they pushed on.

At one point, their path was blocked by a sorcerer that wouldn't move, but Castaspella knocked him out easily. Bow and Glimmer

stuffed the unconscious body in a closet and locked the door.

"That probably won't hold if he wakes up," Shadow Weaver whispered.

"I used the extra-strength version of the spell. He'll be out for hours," Casta replied, "Just because Micah is the more powerful of the two of us doesn't mean I'm useless."

They could make out Castaspella's glare, punctuating what had to be a common argument.

Soon enough, they reached a hallway with several statues. After checking that the coast was clear, Catra had Melog drop the cloak.

"Let's hurry up, I don't like how exposed we are," she said.

"Is your cleaning staff that lax?" Shadow Weaver hissed, pointing at a charred and cobwebbed statue on the end.

"We keep yours like that as a warning to future generations," Castaspella spat, "Now stop moaning and help me with the passage."

The two made a combined sigil and cast it at a wall. A hidden door opened, and they all hurried through it.

The hallway was dark, and the state of the walls indicated just how much time had passed since anyone was last here. Melog sniffed at the floor and sneezed on some dust.

Bow had his eyes on the various murals on the wall, the pictures itching at his mind thanks to being the son of historians.

"What is all this?" he asked.

"We're on the right path," Castaspella said, "The Crystal of Arxia was rumored to be the key to reaching deep magic within Etheria."

"Given what we're here for, I think we can confirm that."

"But the many who tried and failed to find it didn't have the knowledge that we have, nor She-Ra on their side."

They all looked at Adora, who just shrugged.

"But those who hungered for more power," Castaspella continued, taking on a haunting voice, "have long sought other ways to

obtain the deep magic…”

She gestured to one mural, depicting a shadowy mass with far too many eyes and several grasping hands, looming over tiny depictions of people. Just looking at the representation of this dark force sent a chill down their spines.

“And those hungry ones found only disaster waiting for them.”

Shadow Weaver, who was at the front of the party, stopped and turned back to them.

“The Spell of Obtainment was a mistake, one for which I’ve paid the price. I don’t see why you keep bringing it up.”

“Maybe because it feels like you didn’t learn a damn thing?” Glimmer asked with faux-sweetness.

Catra tried really hard not to crack up, and Glimmer caught her eye and winked.

“Also, you roped Micah into your twisted dark magic when he was only a child,” Castaspella added with a glare, “You could have killed him. And don’t give me that bunk about it working until he broke the connection. What you were doing was dangerous, plain and simple, and you used my brother for it without thought to the consequences.”

“Micah was an exceptional sorcerer, even then—”

“And that makes it okay?” Casta shot back, fire flicking from her fingers, “Even someone with decades of experience would have been hard pressed to do such a complex bit of magic properly. No matter how talented he was, Micah was a child! He had no business dealing with that kind of magic, especially not dark magic!”

The sorceress calmed a bit, but still glared at Shadow Weaver.

“But you didn’t care, did you? That’s your problem, really. Even when you were Light Spinner, you were self-centered.”

She brushed past Shadow Weaver, taking the lead, and that seemed to end the conversation.

The hallway got darker as they descended a flight of stairs. The atmosphere got more oppressive as they traveled. There wasn’t the same level of weirdness that had been on Krytis, but it was still a heavy feeling.

Castaspella and Shadow Weaver stopped, as if examining something, but Adora, not noticing, kept walking.

A circle of light erupted around her, and a massive plume of fire enveloped her. Catra leapt forward with a cry, charging right into the flames. She exited back out moments later, her and Adora tumbling to the ground.

"I'm okay! I'm okay!" Adora gasped, and everyone breathed a sigh of relief.

Adora looked at Catra, still hovering over her, and smiled.

"Did you just jump into fire for me?"

"Shut up, I was worried!" Catra groaned in annoyance, even as she nuzzled Adora's chest and briefly listened to her heart, as if to assure herself that everything was fine.

Glimmer stepped forward, a thoughtful look on her face.

"Guys…there's no heat…is this an illusion?"

Melog padded up next to her, sniffing at the fire before letting off a grumble.

"It is," Catra said, finally picking herself up off her girlfriend, "Melog can practically taste it."

“Handy little friend you’ve picked up,” Castaspella muttered.

“We should still be cautious,” Shadow Weaver said, “I doubt all of the fire is illusory.”

The group entered the flame, walking through the tunnel of fire as they continued on. Adora hung back a bit, still a little jumpy about her close call, but pushed past it.

Shadow Weaver matched pace with her at the back of the group.

“You and Catra are certainly close,” she said conversationally.

“Does it sting?” Adora asked, “All your little mind games with the two of us, trying to pit us against each other, and our bond is stronger than ever.”

Shadow Weaver just hummed in reply.

“I’m just wondering if that’s wise…”

Adora stopped dead, glaring at Shadow Weaver.

“I think you lost the right to dictate my life a long time ago.”

“Some friendly advice, then. She-Ra is our only chance at stopping Horde Prime. She is a being of pure magic, and like all magic, she works best when you are focused, clearheaded. Catra is a distraction right now. The world needs She-Ra, not Adora. If your emotions are pulling you in different directions, if your connections are keeping you from your full potential, then we will be doomed.”

Shadow Weaver got close to Adora.

“Besides, haven’t you and Catra hurt each other enough?”

Adora merely hummed.

“That’s funny.”

“How so?”

Then Shadow Weaver stiffened, because Adora had drawn her sword and brought its tip right up to her neck, so quickly that the motion could barely be seen.

"Because focusing on my connections, on the love I have for Catra and my friends, helped me forge this."

Adora tapped the blade with her free hand, making a musical ring.

"Kind of undermines your advice, really. And then there's the ring. While it too is powered by my focus, I find that my greatest will comes from when I protect what I care about. I don't just fight for Etheria, I fight for *them*. Without my friends, without Catra, I'd have nothing. So here's my theory on what should happen next: I tell you that you're full of it, and you remain as quiet as possible for the rest of the mission unless we actually need your knowledge. We clear?"

"Crystal," Shadow Weaver squeaked.

"Excellent," Adora replied, sheathing her sword and smiling, "Glad we understand each other."

Then Adora walked away, going to join the others. As she settled her pace to match Catra's, she noticed her girlfriend smiling.

"How much of that did you hear?"

"Now, you know the answer to that question," Catra replied, her ears flicking, "And FYI, watching you smack down Shadow Weaver…that was really hot."

Adora just blushed.

"So you liked it? I mean, sometimes I worry that I'm being too protective, I know you don't like that, and—"

Catra's hand on her shoulder cut her off.

"I'm getting used to knowing that someone's in my corner. Let me fight some of my own battles, and we shouldn't have issues, okay?"

Adora nodded.

oOo

Eventually, they exited the hall of fire, and came out in a large cave. Before them was a massive crystal pillar. It gleamed with an inner light, casting the cave in a soft glow, and was covered in First Ones writing.

"*That* is the failsafe?" Glimmer gasped.

"It's a lot bigger than I thought," Bow said, "How are we going to get it to the Heart?"

“The failsafe is a code,” Shadow Weaver replied, “It’s stored inside the crystal. We just need the password to open it.”

“I think I know it,” Castaspella muttered before speaking up, “We’re friends of Mara!”

The crystal pillar rumbled. Lines of light shot from the top to the bottom. When the light died, it left cracks behind. The crystal split along those cracks into three separate pieces. Bluish lightning shot between the tops, a tether of energy.

“It was on the message Lance found,” Castaspella shrugged, “I asked about it.”

“Hang on, I can make something out,” Adora said, peering at the crystal, “‘Someone needs to go inside and accept the failsafe’?”

“It needs to be bonded to a willing soul and carried to the Heart of Etheria in their body in order to be deployed,” Shadow Weaver said.

“And we’re sure that’s safe?” Bow asked.

“We can’t turn back now, not with the failsafe in our grasp.”

She stepped toward Adora, but Catra and Melog got in between them, Melog snarling and turning red.

"I know where this is going," Catra said, "You're going to make Adora do it. Why don't you take it?"

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes.

"I've been watching you, the whole way in. You've been in here before, haven't you? You could have taken the failsafe yourself and gotten all the power you ever wanted. So why didn't you? What aren't you telling us?"

"You're being paranoid, Catra. This is the only way to stop Prime, Adora understands that well enough," Shadow Weaver replied.

"I notice that you didn't actually answer her question," Bow said, "And now I'm curious myself."

"You're a power-hungry witch, and you didn't take a chance at this power?" Glimmer scoffed, "Yeah, that fish is three days old and I'm not buying it."

"I suggest you answer the question," Castaspella said, fire licking at her fingertips.

Melog snarled in agreement.

With glares on all sides, Shadow Weaver sighed.

"Whoever uses the failsafe must absorb the full magic of the Heart when it is destroyed. However briefly they hold it, that much raw magical power would be too much for anyone. Anyone except She-Ra. Only she could survive the process."

Catra gave a loud growl.

"I knew it! You were using us again!"

"I wouldn't call getting the one person capable of doing this into the room 'using' you."

"Do you know what the Heart nearly did to Adora the last time? What it did to Mara? It nearly killed them both! Mara was so broken up that couldn't stop her ship from crashing and finishing what the magic started! What if Adora doesn't make it?"

"Then the magic of Etheria would be restored through her sacrifice. She would give us the power to bring us to victory and destroy Prime."

“Absolutely not!” Glimmer and Castaspella shouted simultaneously.

“There is no way we’re risking Adora like this!” Bow added.

“We don’t have any other option!” Shadow Weaver shot back.

“I am not letting the woman I love march to her death!” Catra practically roared. Melog actually did roar in agreement.

“You can’t stop this!” Shadow Weaver shouted, matching Catra’s volume, “I don’t care what you are to Adora, you will not get in the way of her destiny!”

And then suddenly, all the anger and shouting stopped at the sound of something unexpected.

Laughter.

Adora still had her back to them, but her head was thrown back in laughter. After a moment, she stopped, but continued to stare at the crystal pillars.

"You know, I've been hearing that word a lot since I picked up the Sword of Protection. 'It is your destiny,' 'She-Ra is your destiny,' 'You were destined for this,' destiny, destiny, destiny. Was it my destiny to be the key to a superweapon? Was it my destiny to take a path that cost me my best friend, that pit us against each other? Was it my destiny to suffer for the mistakes of people who lived long before I was born?"

She spun around, anger on her face.

"FUCK DESTINY! Fate is a lie, prophecies are bullshit, and I'm not going to follow orders from some doddering old men or wrinkled crones from a thousand years ago! I'm not going to keep getting smacked around for the rest of my life out of some weird penance for the crimes of my ancestors! I *refuse* to be the puppet of a *concept*!"

She spun around, glaring at the light.

"I'm not doing this because of destiny. I'm doing it because it's *right*! Because I *chose* to protect this planet and its people! Because I want to build a proper future for me, my friends, and my love. *Destiny* can go suck a cactus!"

Adora resolutely stepped forward. Catra rushed forward and caught her arm, but Adora just turned with a smile.

"Do you trust me?"

Catra didn't answer, but she did let go.

"Ring, can you help me contain the failsafe code?"

Computation systems sixty-five-percent operational. Slowing in download possible.

"Do your best."

Confirmed.

She stepped into the crystal formation. Blue light rained down on her. It felt like lightning bolts spearing her, but she gritted her teeth against the pain. Green light flared around her, mixing with the blue lightning as the energy shot through her. Soon, she wasn't in pain anymore.

After what felt like forever, the light faded, save for the thin aura of green surrounding Adora.

Code scanned and contained. Processing…constructing safety protocols…done. Failsafe for Heart of Etheria ready to deploy at Lantern's discretion.

"And I can safely shut down the Heart?"

Calculating…odds of survival seventy-nine-percent.

"I'll take those odds. Better than a sacrifice play. Keep working on any other safety stuff you can do, though."

Confirmed.

When Adora turned, a glowing sigil was on her chest. Blue light shone from a heart-like shape, and a ring of emerald green surrounded it.

"No one else dies for this. We're ending this, and then we're going home. All of us."

Chapter End Notes

I don't want to hear any arguments, after what Adora's been through in the service of DESTINY, of course she'd be bitter. Instead, I want to talk for a moment about Shadow Weaver, because I'm not sure I'll get another chance.
F*CK SHADOW WEAVER!!!
I know there are some people out there who think that her sacrificing herself to save Adora and Catra, her final words of admitting how proud she is of them, that scene somehow equals a redemption arc. This is the Internet, 'Draco in

Leather Pants' exists as a trope for a reason. Those people are wrong.

It's the Severus Snape effect, honestly. Here we have a character who is utterly unlikeable, but then they do something that people say justifies everything and makes them a good guy in the end. Here's the thing, though: Snape still did those horrible things. Yes, he was a spy for the Light, yes, he saved Harry's life several times, yes, he did it all out of his Lost Lenore feelings for Lily Potter, and yes, he protected Harry up until the end and gave him valuable information at the cost of his life. He did all this knowing that he'd be considered a bad guy in the story regardless of the good he did, and he was strong enough to bear that weight. This makes him a brave man. It doesn't make him a good one.

He didn't have to go so far in being the villain of the story, but he did! He abused his position of power and authority, picked on children who could do nothing to protect themselves, and abused Dumbledore's trust in him to get away with it. Even while quietly protecting him from overt attempts on his life, he still made Harry's life as difficult as possible, all out of some petty revenge against a man who'd been dead for over a decade! He found information that Sirius Black was probably innocent, but still intended to hand him over to the authorities to be killed as soon as humanly possible. He ruined Remus Lupin's life by outing him as a werewolf to a society that puts as much fear and hate on that as 80s AIDS victims. He traumatized Neville Longbottom to the point where HE was the poor kid's worst nightmare, and dollars to donuts that Neville wasn't alone in that boat.

I think people get blinded by the transcendently good performance given by the late Alan Rickman, but the fact is, despite the good he accomplished, Severus Snape was still a bully. A bitter man who became far worse than he ever accused James Potter of being. James grew up, Snape only got older.

Whoops, that bit got away from me, back to Shadow Weaver.

In the comments, because I'm running out of space here, see you below...

For Etheria!

Chapter Notes

Tragic and furious, the clash of the steel of the gods!
And so magic, the power, the sword in his valorous hands!
Oceans of fire are blasting the throne of the demons!
And from distant red skies, the thunders are calling his name:
The name of the master of pain!

For Ancelot,
The ancient cross of war!
For the holy town of gods!
Gloria, gloria perpetua!
In this dawn of victory!

Gloria, gloria perpetua!
In this dawn of victory!
--'Dawn of Victory', Rhapsody of Fire

Buckle up, people. We may not have gotten a knock-down, drag-out final brawl with Horde Prime in canon (which I know wouldn't have fit in the story they wanted to tell, what we got was still great), but different circumstances require different finales.
After all, Adora isn't just She-Ra, she's also a Green Lantern.

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Chapter 10

For Etheria!

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“Sounds like it was a bad time all around.”

Adora slumped back in the captain’s chair, laughing lightly at Mara’s simple summation.

“I think Catra’s still a little mad at me. She’s more mad at Shadow Weaver, mind, but still…”

“Really wish I still had hands so I could throttle that bitch,” Mara grumbled, clenching her holographic digits.

“I just hope this will all end well,” Adora said, “Last thing I want to do is disappoint everyone.”

“I think if this whole thing is a giant disappointment, we’ll all be dead, so it won’t matter.”

“You know what I meant, Mara.”

“Gallows humor is to be expected when talking to ghosts. Now, are you asking me if you did the right thing?”

"Yes and no…much as I hate to agree with Shadow Weaver, I was the only one capable of carrying this."

Adora tapped on the failsafe glowing on her chest.

"It always has to be you, doesn't it?" Mara sighed.

Somehow, Adora thought that was a rhetorical question, but she responded regardless.

"Well, I'm She-Ra, right? I have to be the one."

"You know what the main problem with this life is?" Mara asked, "Everyone assumes you have to be this or that. That you're *supposed* to be something. I'll let you in on a little secret, though…"

Mara leaned forward, a kind look on her face.

"*Everyone* fails at that. The real measure of a person, especially a hero, is how good that are at being *who they are*."

Adora sat back, lost in thought.

"Now, whether or not you were right to take on the failsafe, that remains to be seen. To tell the truth, I'm probably not the best person to judge. I wanted the She-Ra line to end with me. I dropped that sword in a forest known for its mysteries, hoping that none would ever find it."

"Light Hope forced that to happen. She took me away from my home and family to fulfill her agenda."

"And I'm glad you freed her from that cursed programming, even if it was in death," Mara replied, "She was a good friend, once. The day that virus rewrote her was one of the worst days of my life."

"Just one of?" Adora snorted.

"Actually dying tends to top the charts," Mara said, rolling her eyes, "But I'll be honest, if anyone had to carry the mantle, I'm glad it was you. You did something no other She-Ra has done in a long, long time."

"What?"

"You faced down everyone that wanted to manipulate you, from Shadow Weaver to Light Hope to Horde Prime to Fate itself…and you told every one of them to kiss your ass. You said 'screw destiny, I'm doing what's right!'"

Mara pointed directly at Adora's heart.

"You listened to *this* before ever listening to Light Hope. That's how I know you're worthy of She-Ra. That's how I know you'll win. Because you're fighting for your future and for everything you love. And woe be to anyone or anything in your way."

"Thanks, Mara," Adora smiled, "These chats we have…they're nice."

"It's what I'm here for. Now I want you to do something, no matter what happens next."

"What's that?"

Mara looked at her with a mix of worry and pride.

"You come home safe. No matter what, you survive. *You live*. Because no one wants you to be a martyr."

oOo

It was two days before everything went to hell.

Ever since Entrapta had discovered it on her last scouting mission, Kyle had tasked a drone to keep watch over the strange construction project that Horde Prime had been pouring resources into. It was far different from the other towers, but its purpose wasn't easily discernible.

That is, until it drilled into the earth and began releasing a toxic-looking energy.

"He's infecting the planet?!" Bow shouted.

"Between the scientific data from Entrapta and the mystical interpretation from Micah, that's what it looks like," Kyle replied, "According to the intel from Adora and Catra, we know that he has a hivemind, and that it's tied to a unique energy. He's injecting that energy into the planet, probably to slave the Heart of Etheria to his will. Good news, it's slow going. Etheria's fighting him the whole way. Bad news…"

"It can't hold out forever," Perfuma guessed, fingers sunk into the dirt, "I can almost feel it…like the planet is crying."

"So what do we do? Attack the drill?" Glimmer asked.

"It was pretty well defended when Entrapta and I found it," Swift Wind replied, "And with it fully operational, no doubt there's even

more guys. We'd be walking right into fire."

"We don't have to!" Entrapta suddenly shouted, practically vibrating with excitement, "I cracked the code! We can crash the chip network, free everyone! And that shock to the hivemind that freeing everyone will make will significantly affect Prime. We'd definitely slow the infection."

"Giving me enough time to get to the Heart and destroy it," Adora said, "I know we were trying to make a better plan for a full assault on Prime and the Heart, but we're out of time."

She took a deep breath and let it out slow.

"That large tower between Salineas and the Whispering Woods. The one Sea Hawk's been scouting. We use that, make our final stand there. Draw the Horde's attention and crash the network. While all that's going on, I'll travel to the Heart and activate the failsafe. We can purge Prime out of Etheria with the sheer power being released. He'll be vulnerable, and we can finally end this. Gather the troops. We leave in an hour."

As soldiers and princesses rushed to ready themselves, Glimmer, Bow, and Catra stayed behind.

"Adora," Glimmer began, but Adora shook her head.

"I know what you're going to ask, and the answer is no. You two are more important on the battlefield and helping Entrapta with her gear. Crawling through catacombs would be a waste. Besides, with as much energy as the Heart is going to be putting off, I don't want you anywhere near it."

Glimmer and Bow reluctantly nodded, but Catra growled.

"No dice, Adora. Sparkles and Arrow Boy can be in the combat part of the operation, but I'm staying with you."

"Catra—"

"*I'm not losing you!* Not again."

Catra squeezed her eyes shut, stopping the welling tears.

"I'm not going anywhere. I'm staying with you, whatever happens. We promised a long time ago to look out for each other. This is me making good on that."

Adora and Catra stared at each other. Adora broke first.

"Dammit, Catra…"

Catra slid closer and held Adora's hands in her own.

"My place is right beside you, and damn the consequences. I'm not letting you walk into fire alone."

oOo

The air was calm. Robots patrolled the perimeter of the outpost, a gleaming white tower dominating it.

One robot that was facing the woods noticed it first. The trunks swaying, branches shaking, leaves rattling. If it had had enough mental bandwidth, the robot might have mused that it seemed like the woods were getting ready for something.

Then an arrow sprouted from its eye and it fell to the ground.

The Whispering Woods seemed to part, making way for the army of Etheria. Tanks and skiffs rattled forth, crewed with soldiers from all across the land. At the head were the leaders of the Rebellion, magic and weaponry ready.

A great cry rose up, and the army charged.

"For Etheria!"

Tanks fired, breaking down the wall. Vines and spikes of ice widened the gap, allowing men to pour in like a swarm of bees. Robots and drones fell in droves. A signal seemed to be set off, and more clones and Horde forces teleported in with flashes of green, but Etheria was undeterred.

Perfuma cast out a large vine, knocking aside several robots. Sea Hawk vaulted over the vine, his saber flashing out like lightning and decapitating a few that his friend had missed.

Netossa cast several large nets into the air, and Spinnerella used her wind to send them flying toward more forces, tying them up and allowing Frosta and a few soldiers to dispatch them.

Rogelio bulldozed a line of clones, crushing them with his sheer bulk. Lonnie blasted any he missed.

A line of chipped sorcerers from Mystacor showed up, but were stopped by a large circle of magic.

"Where do you guys think you're going?" Micah said, stepping through his own barrier like it was water. Beside him were Glimmer and Castaspella.

“Why don’t we show them what this family can really do,” Castaspella said, fire flaking from her fingertips.

“Read my mind,” Glimmer replied, fists aglow with energy.

As all this and more was going on, a shimmer in the air zipped toward the tower itself. It entered easily, and resolved into Entrapta, Bow, and Melog.

“Good girl,” Bow said, running a hand through Melog’s smoky mane.

“We need to make this fast, Bow,” Entrapta said, lugging her crated console, “Prime will send reinforcements.”

“Right, the sooner we smack the hivemind upside the head, the sooner this ends.”

Bow took point, a glue arrow ready for anything they might encounter on their way to a suitable spot to hack from.

oOo

Adora and Catra entered the ruins, breathing in stale air.

“All this time, and we’re back here again,” Catra muttered, “No spiders this time, right?”

“With Light Hope gone, a lot of the functions of this place went with her. I checked, only a few hologram systems are still active,” Adora replied.

As if to prove her right, a static image appeared before them.

“Welcome, Administrator. What is your query?”

“We’re friends of Mara,” Adora replied.

The hooded figure actually twitched, setting down the crystal tablet and speaking in a more natural voice.

“Welcome, Friends of Mara. Do you wish to activate the failsafe?”

“Yes.”

The ground opened up before them, a set of stairs appearing out of the crystal.

"The failsafe must be delivered to the Heart. Do not stray from the path."

"And here we go," Catra muttered as they descended.

They walked in silence for a moment, the only sound being their footsteps and the faint hum behind the crystalline walls.

Adora bumped her shoulder with Catra's.

"Hey…thanks for coming with me. I know you don't like this whole thing."

Catra sighed, reaching out to grab Adora's hand.

"Me not liking it is an understatement," she said, stroking with her thumb, "Channeling the Heart before nearly killed you. It *did* kill Mara, at least to hear her tell it. I don't like that you have to be the one to do this. But I get it. If you don't, who will? Who even can? This is just how you are, if you see someone in trouble, you can't ignore it."

"Sometimes I wish I could," Adora replied, but Catra gave her a look.

"No, you don't. But the fact that you're willing to be the hero, to be the sword and shield for those in need…I love that about you, but I also hate it. Does that make sense?"

"You wouldn't want me different, but you just wish I were more careful?"

"Yes, exactly! You give so much of yourself to others, and that's great…but what about you? What do you want, Adora?"

Adora hung her head for a bit.

"You know, ever since I was a kid, I was told that I had to be the leader, the perfect soldier. I had to dedicate everything to a cause. When I became She-Ra, I was so lost, untethered from everything I knew. I latched onto Bow and Glimmer because they were supportive, and I latched into the Rebellion because it gave me a cause. I was the paragon princess, the warrior of light, the hero. And I loved it, don't get me wrong…but there was always something missing…"

Catra felt she knew what that was, but she asked anyway.

"What was missing?"

"After everything I'd been taught to believe, everything I found to dedicate to, everything I worked towards for the betterment of all…there was always one thing I truly wanted, deep down. One desire that I kept close, one selfish thought. The one thing I wanted, but Shadow Weaver always told me I couldn't have."

"What?"

Adora gave Catra a significant look. Catra wilted slightly, her eyes wide and her tail low.

"Oh. That long, huh?"

"I didn't really have the words to describe it until recently, but… yeah, that long."

Catra didn't have words. So she just hugged Adora.

"I don't want you to get hurt," she finally said, "I *just* got you back. I don't think I could take it if something happened to you."

"You're here with me," Adora replied, "I know you'll watch my back. So everything will work out."

Catra pulled back a bit, a watery smile on her face.

“You have so much faith in me it hurts.”

“You look out for me, and I look out for you,” Adora replied with a smile.

A light appeared at the end of the tunnel, putting a hold on their conversation. They walked towards it, coming out in a lush forest.

“Wait, what?” Catra asked.

Adora walked over to a tree and touched it. Her finger sank, the area around it fritzing and crackling.

“Holograms.”

“Right, of course,” Catra muttered, “Like that didn’t get old the first time.”

They walked through the forest before coming to the edge of a cliff. As they looked around, Adora grumbled.

“We really don’t have time for this.”

Catra suddenly made a hissing yelp and jumped to Adora's other side.

"She wasn't standing there before!"

Not two feet from where Catra had been standing, a tall woman in white and gold armor stood.

"Mara."

"What? She looks nothing like her!"

"That's how she looked as She-Ra."

Catra blinked at Adora's explanation, then took a second look. The patterns and cut of the woman's clothing did look familiar.

"The infection is spreading," the woman said, "Etheria systems are trying to compensate, but complete takeover will occur within the half-hour."

The image of Mara shuddered, her form twisting and splintering.

"In-in-infection accelera-a-a-ating. Heart of Etheria be-be-be-be-being targeted-targeted-targeted."

The image solidified for a moment.

"Save us."

And then the hologram shattered. The shards came back together in a new shape.

"Ah, there you are, She-Ra."

Catra felt her heart stop as she gazed at the face of a nightmare.

"Prime," Adora whispered.

The image of Horde Prime smiled darkly as the light around them turned a toxic green.

"I know what you're trying to do. I see all, I know all."

"What you aren't is actually here," Adora shot back, grasping Catra's shoulder to ground her, "You can't stop us."

"We shall see on that latter point," Prime replied casually, "But you know, I'm still not entirely sure if I've heard the name She-Ra before. But I know your sort. Many of your kind have fought me. All have failed, and one by one, their faces are forgotten, lost to oblivion. Yours will be too."

A shrieking pierced the air. Adora immediately turned into She-Ra, sword blazing with emerald light. A whip-like tendril shot out of the forest, scoring a hit on her side.

Pain erupted through her body. It felt like fire surging through her veins. She fell to one knee, She-Ra falling away as she screamed. She heard Catra's cries of horror and Prime's mocking laughter.

"A parting gift from the First Ones, an old security system with a very potent toxin. I actually do hope you survive long enough to reach the Heart, so you may see my triumph. But whether for now or forever, this is farewell, *hero*."

Prime vanished, the spiteful bite of the final word still hanging in the air. The forest fell away, revealing a large crystalline cavern…

And the giant worm creature with multiple tendrils for a face standing before them, said tendrils dripping with poison.

Catra swore and got in front of Adora, her claws at the ready. The worm lunged, but bounced off a green bubble that was suddenly there.

"Adora?"

"Help me up," Adora wheezed, struggling to her feet.

Catra grabbed her and pulled and arm over her shoulders. Adora weakly grabbed her sword with a line of light from her ring, which Catra helped her sheathe.

"We need to be ready to move, I can't keep the barrier up for long," Adora groaned, "A lot of ringpower is going into trying to purge the poison."

"You can do that?" Catra asked.

"Apparently. The ring's doing most of the work."

Affirmative.

“It’s weird when that thing talks,” Catra grumbled, even as her body tensed, ready to run.

The worm smashed against the barrier. Finally, it shattered, and the girls made a run for it. Adora hobbled along as fast as she could, Catra supporting her. Tendrils lashed out, but Catra pulled them to the side, flecks of acidic spit misting at her heels.

They were almost to the door on the other side when a tendril came down hard behind them. The shockwave threw them off their feet. Catra quickly flipped herself over, ready to defend herself and Adora.

Suddenly black flames hit the worm on the side of the head, forcing it back. Catra blinked in shock at the newcomer.

“Shadow Weaver?”

The sorceress was wreathed in black flames, throwing fireball after fireball at the worm to keep it off balance.

“Both of you, get to the Heart!” she shouted, “None of this will matter if you don’t!”

“Did you seriously follow us to get a shot at some of the magic?” Adora snarled.

“Yes, but now’s not the time! GO!”

A rush of tainted air threw the girls through the doorway, and a shield of purple energy sprang up to block them off from the larger room.

“What are you doing, Shadow Weaver?” Catra shouted.

“What I must!”

Tendrils of black and purple light erupted from Shadow Weaver’s hands, wrapping around the worm’s face and binding the tendrils for a moment. Shadow Weaver looked back at the two girls she raised, feeling a spark of hope.

“You two need to set the magic free. I will hold off the monster.”

“That thing’s a toxic behemoth!” Adora shouted back, “It’ll kill you!”

“Worry for me, after everything?” Shadow Weaver replied, even as she conjured a shield to stop the worm when it broke free of the bindings, “You truly are a good soul, Adora.”

Adora wasn't sure how to feel about that comment, since it was delivered by someone who she'd once dedicated her life to but now viewed as a monster.

"Regardless, it's too late for me. But you two, you have a future. Go fight for it."

She looked back at them, removing her mask. The field of deep scars across her face made it hard to smile, but she managed.

"Whatever else, I'm proud of you both. And you're welcome."

She let the mask fall from her fingers as she threw everything she had into her next spell. Her dying curse set off a fireball of epic proportions, incinerating everything in the room in a massive explosion.

After a moment, the shield she put up over the door flicked and died, vanishing with its caster. Adora and Catra looked over the charred room, the ashen skeleton of the creature dominating the view. The only thing left of Shadow Weaver, the woman who raised them and yet caused them so much pain, was the broken remains of her mask.

It would have been a somber moment, at least without any context. With context, however…

“Wait, that’s it? ‘You’re welcome’? Seriously?” Adora asked, “After everything she did to us, that’s how it ends?”

A tide of anger shot through Adora.

“She just waltzes in here, kills a giant worm by blowing herself up, never apologizes for anything that happened, and she expects us to…what, mourn her?”

Catra stomped over and kicked the remains of the mask.

“Right? And pride? What gives you that right?” she spat, “Years spent trying to drive us apart, making us smaller, and that’s all you have to say about it? Screw you, you dried up old prune. I’m living my life, and you can’t stop me.”

Catra went right back over to Adora and hugged her.

“You sound better.”

“Ring’s doing the job,” Adora said, “I mean, it’s bonded to me, it probably knows my body better than I do.”

She grimaced against a sudden spike of pain.

"It's just going to take time."

"Save your strength," Catra said, moving to support Adora, "You'll need all of it for the Heart."

The two of them turned and continued toward where the Heart was. They didn't look back.

oOo

"Almost there," Entrapta muttered.

Bow had finished his part in the link-ups, and was now keeping an eye out for any more clones. They'd already dealt with four before setting up shop, Bow's quickdraw and Melog's impressive speed paving the way forward. But the room they were in now was large and open-ended, which made Bow nervous. An attack could come from anywhere.

Melog's hiss of distress was the first clue, and Bow dove to the side to avoid the oncoming attack, a bolt of red-tingled electricity.

"Oh, brilliant," he muttered, switching his shock arrow for a glue arrow.

Electricity wasn't going to do anything to Scorpia.

The mind-controlled princess was not alone. A clone was with her, weapon cycling up to fire.

Melog pounced on Scorpia, growing in size until she equaled the tall woman. The two rolled way in a flurry of thrashing claws. This left Bow to deal with the clone, but the clone was nimbler than he expected, dodging the arrow and firing back. Bow dove out of the way, briefly losing his grip on his bow.

The clone turned toward Entrapta, weapon ready…

And then hesitated, the arm cannon dipping a bit.

"You again," he said mutely.

Entrapta sucked in a breath.

"Hordak."

The clone shook his head, bringing his weapon back up to bear.

“I have no name, stop acting like I do!”

“But you do have a name,” Entrapta replied, stepping out from behind her kit after one more keystroke, “You chose it. You had nothing, but you built yourself back up. You made a life here on Etheria. Maybe it wasn’t much different than the one you had before, but you know better now. You can be better.”

“NO!” the clone snarled, “Those are flights of fancy, signs of imperfections! I reject them! I remain pure in Prime’s light!”

“Imperfections are what made science possible. It’s how we learn and grow, how we become more. Imperfections are beautiful. Don’t you remember me telling you that? I know you do.”

The clone’s weapon shook and he let off harsh breaths. Entrapta stepped closer.

“Your name is Hordak. Mine is Entrapta. And we’re lab partners. You’re not going to shoot me. I believe in you. I believe you can be better. You can be more than what you were, what he made of you. You’re as Etherian as the rest of us, and Prime can’t control us. He doesn’t get what makes us strong, that’s why he’s losing.”

“No. Horde Prime is all-powerful.”

"Then why is he losing ground here? Why is he pinning everything on an ancient superweapon if he's so powerful and advanced?"

Entrapta reached into her pocket and pulled out a small purple crystal.

"I gave you this because we're friends. Please, remember."

The clone stared at the crystal, memories flooding back.

"Please," Entrapta whispered, tears in her eyes, "Come back to me."

"Enough!"

Out of the shadows stepped a new figure, and Entrapta felt a shudder go down her spine at the impossible coldness on the newcomer's face.

"Is this what I come to find?" Horde Prime said, "I take the field personally for the first time in ages, celebrating a looming victory, and I find doubt in my ranks. Finish this chatty rebel, little brother."

The clone's hand still shook, and he kept staring at Entrapta.

"Did you not hear me? I will not have any blights on my perfect dominion. Do it, little brother. Do it!"

There was a flash of light and a sound like thunder

Horde Prime looked down at his stomach, shocked at the gaping hole where it had been.

"My name is Hordak. I am more than what you made me for. And I defy your will!"

He fired again, incinerating his big brother's skull.

Hordak slowly lowered his weapon, breathing heavily. Entrapta cheered and hugged Hordak from behind.

"I knew you'd pull through!"

Hordak began to chuckle. But Entrapta quickly realized that this wasn't mirth. This was cruelty.

"Oh, little brother. How quickly you forget a very important detail…I OWN YOU!"

Hordak spun around, pulling Entrapta up by her hair painfully and holding her aloft. His eyes glowed an evil green, and his voice held a cadence of superiority.

"Did you really think I could be dealt with so easily? I am not my weak-minded little brother, easily corrupted by your foolish wiles. I am Prime! I am perfection!"

"You're also easily distracted!"

Prime's head whipped toward Entrapta's console, where Bow finished the last command. The green lights of the room became blue as the program ran roughshod over the hive mind. He grimaced as he felt it being disrupted. Even without hearing Scorpia's scream of pain, he could feel multiple minds disappearing. His clones were still connected, their links different than the chips, but it was clear that all the work he'd put into taking control of Etheria's populace was now up in smoke. What's worse, the disruption was creating shockwaves through the entire hivemind. The complex web of mental energies shuddered like it was undergoing a seizure. When the dust finally settled, it would take a lot of work to repair the damage, and until then, any use of the hivemind would be difficult.

Entrapta kicked out, catching him in the stomach and forcing him to drop her. She scurried away, ducking behind Bow, who drew and arrow and stood ready.

"It matters not," Prime snarled, "A momentary setback, that's all. The Heart is still mine, I can feel it! I breached the chamber not a minute before coming down here. Even now, an avatar of magic is mocking mighty She-Ra for her failure. The power is mine! And with it, your pitiful plan—"

A massive bolt of electricity slammed into him and was sent him flying into the wall.

"MAN, his voice was annoying!" Scorpia groaned, "Ego the size of a moon, I swear."

"You feeling better, Scorpia?" Bow asked.

"Bit of a headache," Scorpia shrugged, "Is everyone else fighting outside?"

"Real big fight."

"Then if you'll excuse me…"

oOo

Adora was walking much more steadily now, the toxin almost purged from her system. She'd thrown up at one point, but the ring had assured her that this was normal.

Catra was still muttering about how it was green and how weird that was.

Finally, they stepped out of the tunnel and into the light.

The room was massive, bigger than could be believed. Above them was a shape that defied description, a mass of interconnected and nested angles and lines. It glowed with light of every color, including some that they'd never seen before. Energy pulsed in the air, feeling for all the world like static before a big storm.

But what struck them the most was the presence, the feeling of incredible power. Staring at the Heart was like seeing something they'd always known about, but was still beyond anything they'd ever known. It was truly alien, but at the same time, as familiar the arms they had around each other.

Adora took a deep breath and stepped forward. She could feel the failsafe burning in her chest, a similar feeling crackling in her right hand.

“You ready for this?” Catra asked.

Adora regarded her ring, seeing it pulse with green light.

“You know, I never felt comfortable as She-Ra,” she said offhandedly, “It always felt like I was wearing clothes that didn’t fit right. It wasn’t until I reforged the sword, bound it with the ringpower, that I felt like me when as She-Ra.”

Catra tilted her head in confusion, but Adora kept going.

“It’s will. It’s my will. That’s what powers the ring. It’s my drive, my courage, my resolve. The ring itself came from elsewhere, but what fuels it…that comes from me.”

Adora smiled.

“And it feels great. Sometimes it’s exhausting, but when I’m in the moment, when I’m right at the center of the storm, I feel more powerful than I ever have before. I feel like I can do anything, face any challenge. I can feel the power in every fiber of my being. I can feel all my senses sharpening to point where I can *taste* the light. When I’m a Green Lantern, I feel unstoppable.”

Adora stopped, then drew her sword.

"But none of that would matter without what's really behind my will."

She looked at Catra with such love in her eyes that Catra could feel it like a physical presence.

"My drive comes from my wish to protect what matters most to me. When I forged the Sword of Courage, I had memories flowing through me. Bow and Glimmer were there, so were the rest of my friends…but you were at the front of it all."

Adora held the sword out, beckoning Catra to touch it. Catra wrapped one hand around the hilt, fingers pressing against Adora's.

"I am She-Ra…but *we* are the Green Lantern. I could never do what I do without you."

Adora took a step back, taking the sword with her. She transformed in a flash, still breathing deeply.

"Stay with me."

“Always,” Catra replied, “I’m never running again.”

Adora smiled at her, then her gaze went up to the Heart, still burning above their heads like a tiny star.

She raised her sword and closed her eyes.

“Activate failsafe.”

The sigil on her chest glowed brightly. The Heart pulsed and a thick beam of energy shot down.

She-Ra was covered in a barrage of colors. Energy poured over her like a waterfall. For a moment, everything was fine.

Then she fell to one knee, grunting in obvious discomfort. Even with the sword lowered, the energy kept cascading down. After a moment, she began to sputter and hiss.

Then she began to scream.

Burns appeared on her arms, tears rolled down her face. Her limbs shook, blood began to drip from her nose. And of course, there was the screaming.

Energy exceeding projections. Error. Insufficient will. Error. Lantern in distress. Unable to compensate. Error.

Catra cried out as Adora crumbled, the She-Ra transformation flickering. She reached out, forcing her hand through the curtain of energy and grasped Adora's hand. Her fingers brushed the ring, which burned even hotter than the Heart's energy. Her entire hand burned, she could see her fur singeing, but she held on.

"Stay with me, Adora. We're so close! You can't give up on me now!"

Her instincts screamed at her to get away, but she fought them down. She wouldn't leave Adora, not now, not ever again.

Second source found. Willpower rising.

She-Ra's flickering stopped. Adora could feel the load lightening, as if someone else was helping lift it. It took her a second to realize that Catra was holding her hand. Adora saw sparks of power flicker up Catra's arm.

"Catra, what…are you helping?"

“I think I am, actually?” Catra gasped, feeling lances of heat and pain shooting up her arm.

However it happened, the power flow leveled off. Energy shot into Adora, and she breathed deep, the pain lessening.

It was working.

Which of course was when something went wrong.

The top of the chamber glowed a toxic green. A bolt of energy the same color shot down and impacted the Heart, mixing with the energy surrounding it.

Adora let out a cry as the energy cascade abruptly cut off.

“Prime,” Catra whispered with a hint of fear.

The evil energy swirled amongst the Heart. They could see the impossible rainbow fighting back, but the power of Prime was gaining ground. Catra shivered, and Adora squeezed her hand.

“I’m here,” she said, “He won’t touch you again.”

Catra shot her a grateful look, then grimaced at the storm above them.

"So what now?"

Adora didn't have an answer for her.

"Isn't that beautiful? Two loving souls, here together at the end."

Prime's voice pierced the air like a dagger scraping across stone. A swirl of energy shot off of the Heart and toward them, coalescing into a familiar shape.

"So much power," Horde Prime said, "I've never felt it's like. And a perfect union between a physical form and an energy one? Don't mind if I do."

"What are you?" Adora breathed.

"Ah, you two are more familiar with my physical forms, be it my vessel or my brothers. Since you're going to die anyway, I see no reason to hide it."

Prime smiled a twisted smile even as his form became less translucent.

"At my core, I am a being of energy. I am power given form, thought made real. I take physical forms to better interact with the universe at large, but due to my true nature, I am near impossible to kill. Damage, rarely, but kill?"

Prime chuckled darkly.

"Prime rises again. So it has been, so it always shall be."

He looked at Adora, taking particular note of the ring on her finger.

"You should have refused the ring to begin with. It did not bring you hope. It is but the remnant of a dying organization."

"What?" Adora hissed.

"Come now, you know what you are capable of with only a little practice. And no doubt you've suspected a larger world behind that ring. Did you think an army of better trained wielders would have let me get as far as I have? True, in the past, the Green Lantern Corps have prevented the expansion of my empire, but that was just that, the past."

Prime's tone became almost gleeful as he continued.

"No, in recent years, one crisis after another has whittled away their power. First it was the Darkstars, then the Sinestro Corps, then Atrocitus and his Warriors of Rage. It is a shame none of them made it this far out. I do wonder which would have recruited you, little sister."

"Screw you, creep," Catra snarled, a flicker of anger overtaking her fear. Adora's hand tightened around hers, and she drew strength from it.

"But then there came the Blackest Night. An army of the undead descended upon the Lanterns. They won, but only by the skin of their teeth. Their numbers decimated, their leaders cut by half, and their central planet destroyed. Such a pity you joined their ranks in the twilight of their power. In the end, the Green Light of Will availed you not. Such is the lesson here. There is only *my* light, *my* will, *my*--"

"Will you *shut up*!" Adora screamed, "I don't care about your stupid empire or your 'mighty' victories. All I care about now is that you're threatening *my* planet and its people. And it stops *now*."

Prime stared back at her, as if stunned that anyone would dare interrupt him.

"And one more thing, how are you Hordak's brother? He at least knows when to shut his filthy word hole," Catra added.

And Prime took offense to that.

"Very well then," he snarled, now looking far more solid than when he arrived, "Some beings truly are destined only for destruction!"

Energy pooled in his hands and he thrust them forward, evil green lightning shooting forth.

oOo

Horde Prime's flagship loomed overhead, having slid into Etheria's atmosphere with little effort. It cast a long and menacing shadow, and from it teleported down more clones and robots.

But Etheria stood firm.

Micah drew a glyph in the air, and Glimmer gave it a quick boost. The resulting beam of energy overtook the line of robots and turned them into so much scrap. One managed to survive by dint of being behind all the rest, until Glimmer teleported next to it and sliced its head off with a disc of energy.

"That's my girl," Micah smiled, allowing himself a moment of pride before conjuring fire and jumping back into the fray.

Overhead, Spinnerella flew through multiple flying drones, twisters in her wake. The drones couldn't keep up with the clashing winds, and crashed to the ground. Swift Wind was right with her, kicking more drones out of the sky.

One drone landed on a clone menacing Frosta, but it didn't matter much given how many were menacing her. Her barriers of ice were being chipped away by their fire, and it was all she could do to defend.

Suddenly, crimson lightning shot past her, taking down the clones as it swept across their line.

"Get away from my little buddy!" roared a familiar voice.

Frosta cried out with glee as Scorpia stormed past her, picking up a large hunk of ice and hurling it at the clones as they tried to regroup.

"Who else wants some?" Scorpia shouted, electricity sparking from her claws and eyes, "I'm not an angry person by any means, but I've been under mind control for the past several weeks, forced to hurt people, including the people I love, *so I have some frustrations to work out!"*

A robot managed to jump at her. She caught it by the neck and squeezed.

"Next!"

Sea Hawk hurried through the chaos of the battle, carrying the half-conscious Mermista with him. The princess had appeared midway through the battle, but Sea Hawk was able to keep her distracted. Still, she'd had a bad reaction to the chip network going down, resulting in the current affair.

"Kelp…shake…princess of ice cream…seagull…"

"Just hold on, dearest. I'll get you out of—EEP!"

Sea Hawk quickly dodged what looked like Rogelio in a wrestling match with two clones and a robot, and ran smack into Perfuma, who was defending a few fallen soldiers.

"How is she?" Perfuma asked as she shielded them with a barrier of vines.

"The chip's off, I think, but she's all wonky."

"I saw Scorpia in the distance laying waste to some robots, the network's definitely down. It might be that Mermista's system took greater issue with the mind control than Scorpia's did. Scorpia *is* built like a brick house."

As she spoke, Perfuma formed a flower and brought it toward Mermista's face.

"A little aromatherapy might help," she said before blowing the pollen in her friend's face.

The herbal smelling salts worked almost immediately, and Mermista began to shake off her wooziness.

"Ugh, why does my mouth taste like rotten sea cucumbers?"

"Are you back with us, dear Mermista?" Sea Hawk asked with great care as he helped her sit up.

"Haven't felt like this since I raided Dad's wine cellar after he died," Mermista groaned, "Really bad hangover."

She shook her head, wincing.

"I'll survive, though."

Sea Hawk wrapped his arms around her, pulling her close. Mermista didn't even bother with a token protest, instead returning it.

"You scared me, dearest," he whispered.

"Sorry, I guess," she replied.

Mermista soon broke the hug, standing up.

"Come on, there's still work to be done."

"Stay close to me, then," Sea Hawk replied, pulling out his saber, "You're still not at full capacity."

"Whatever, let's just go."

And the two leapt back into the fray with a combined cry of "ADVENTURE!!"

And so the battle continued. The people of Etheria gave everything they had against the onslaught from the stars.

Many, however, wondered if it would be enough.

oOo

Down in the depths of Etheria, a different battle was beginning.

Adora erected an emerald shield, but the evil lightning began to eat at it immediately. Cracks formed on the surface, and Adora pumped more power into trying to maintain the shield.

Catra darted to the side, hoping to flank Prime. She pounced at him, but his form twisted around her attack before solidifying and swatting her away with a backhand.

"Catra!" Adora called out before glaring at Prime.

She-Ra rose and charged Horde Prime, sword raised and her eyes burning green-and-gold.

Prime again twisted around the blow, but Adora expected him to, feinting on her follow-up attack and scoring a blow. The snake-like form of Prime howled in pain, and a large arm formed out of the mass and latched into Adora's neck.

Adora gasped for breath as Prime reformed fully and held her up with one hand.

"You have no power!" he snarled as he began to squeeze, "This spark of hope you claim to have, it will go out before it ever truly lights!"

"Haven't you heard, asshole?"

And then Catra was on his back, wrapping her arms around his neck and clawing his face, ripping out one of his superfluous eyes. Her own eyes burned green-and-gold and her voice was strong, shouting over Prime's scream of pain.

"Love can ignite the stars!"

Prime turned into a mass of energy, slithering out of Catra's grip and darting away to get some distance. He reformed with a glare, the gouged eye slowly healing.

But it was a wound nonetheless.

"How?" he hissed.

Catra inspected her claws, seeing wisps of odd green flaking off, remnants of her attack.

"Not exactly blood," she said, a grim smile appearing on her face, "But it does say something that the guy who puts himself up like a god can still bleed, doesn't it?"

Beside her, She-Ra rose up, flaring with energy.

"Let's see how much he can bleed, then," she said.

Two young women, their eyes burning green-and-gold, charged at their enemy with matching grins.

Catra reached him first, her speed outstripping her girlfriend's as always, even with the longer strides she had as She-Ra. Catra lunged at Prime, who writhed out of the way. But this left him open to Adora's swing, and her sword bit deep. Prime countered with a blast of toxic lightning, and She-Ra was shoved away. Catra immediately took her place, landing several slashes to Prime's face and torso in quick succession.

Prime turned again into an amorphous mass, using it to gain some distance. He writhed around the blasts of energy Adora shot toward him, some just barely missing. When he reformed, he twisted around and sent a large blast of evil magical energy toward them.

She-Ra, however, just rushed forward, a shield forming on her off-arm that blocked the large blast and the hurried follow-ups. Like a charging bull, she rammed into Prime shield-first. With her enemy caught on the shield, she took advantage and slashed at him several times.

Prime exploded in a mass of energy and impossible matter, breaking the shield and knocking the sword from her hand. When he reformed, two massive arms were holding up She-Ra, squeezing her.

"If at first you don't succeed," he grinned, tightening his grip and relishing her cries of pain.

However, so focused on the larger target, he forgot that he was fighting two people.

The Sword of Courage came down on his arms, severing them and freeing Adora. Catra continued her attack, striking out with the sword. Her blows were clumsy, having not trained with swords very much, but she was fast and determined, and that made up for it.

After catching her breath, Adora joined in, forming a sword in each hand from ringpower and striking out. The two fought in sync, their moves complementing each other. Where Prime dodged one of Adora's blades, Catra was there. Where the Sword

of Courage was blocked with an enlarged hand, Lantern blades sliced at the wrists to free it.

A logical mind could argue that the synchronization was the result of long years living and training together. Adora and Catra knew each other's moves as well as they knew their own. A more romantic mind would submit that the bonds of love united them, two souls so linked that they could react instinctively to the other.

Both were correct, in a way.

Prime finally managed to shove them away. All three combatants took a moment to catch their breaths, the pause happening so naturally one would think it had been agreed upon prior.

"Hey, Adora, here's your sword back."

"Thanks, Catra. You like it?"

"Eh, a little heavy for me."

"How are you doing this?" Prime hissed, "I am perfection!"

"You're ego is what you are," Adora shot back.

“And why are your eyes glowing?”

Adora and Catra looked at each other, just now noticing that their eyes had a matching corona of green-and-gold surrounding them.

“You know something? I don’t think I care,” Catra shrugged.

Prime opened his mouth to continue, but Adora cut him off.

“Flashbang!” she shouted.

A brilliant light of verdant green erupted from her, and Prime flinched. When he got his bearings back, it was too late. Catra was upon him, delivering a fast and furious flurry of claw slashes.

He knocked her away, only to be hit in the head by a glowing shield that had been thrown like a discus. This was followed up by a swarm of similarly glowing knives that impacted his chest. The energy they were made from burned, and he turned amorphous again to divest himself of the knives.

A large green form shaped like a tank fell on him from above, splattering his mass like jelly.

“Okay, that’s just ridiculous,” Catra groused before smiling, “Do it again.”

Prime reformed, only for the previous crushing to happen again. This time, it was Sea Hawk’s boat.

“Stop that!” shouted the reforming Prime.

“No,” Adora replied, hitting him in the head with the anvil from her forge.

Catra burst out laughing, and Adora grinned at her.

“Give me a minute, I’ll do the *Starshine*.”

Prime reformed arm first and used it to blast Adora.

“Do you think that was funny?” he growled.

“It was hilarious,” replied Catra from right behind him before ripping at his back.

Prime snarled in pain and fury as he spun around and shoved Catra away.

"I should have done this from the start," he grinned before pumping evil lightning into her.

After a few bolts, a shining green bubble snapped into place around Catra.

"How is it that you continue to find ways to piss me off?" he heard Adora say from behind him.

Before he could turn to respond and/or attack, he was sent to the other side of the room by a giant green fist. He quickly recovered, but had to twist and slither around the follow-up attack, a series of energy blasts that hit the area like a meteor shower, a more potent barrage than had been unleashed earlier in the fight.

As Prime reformed, still singed from some of the blasts that hit home, Catra was on him. He lashed out, but she caught his arm and swung off it, twisting around him and delivering multiple strikes. And then Adora joined in with a circle of whirling blades, the Sword of Courage in one hand and a large warhammer in the other.

On and on the two attacked, weaving around each other and striking in sync. Prime lashed out with fists and blasts, but Adora

and Catra had his measure now, and they dodged everything he threw at them.

Finally, Prime let out a radial blast of energy and used that opportunity to get some distance. He idly looked up and froze.

At the start of the fight, the toxic green of his infection as progressing smoothly, enveloping almost half the Heart. Now, it barely took up an eighth of the shining mass, the rest burning a golden light.

And with a start, he realized what was wrong. He'd been drawing upon the infected portions of the Heart to heal his form, and the Heart had taken advantage of it to fight back.

His presence had been getting burned away from two fronts: the Heart was fighting off his infection even as the energies of She-Ra and the Green Light of Will had been attacking his physical-energy form.

Adora's blasts and sword slashes *hurt*, he had to admit it. Every blow that was struck burned away a little more of him. And Catra? Somehow, she was wielding a similar energy. Her claws raking across his form peeled off more energy, did more damage than they could have before.

The two truly were united.

And he was *losing*.

So stunned by all these realizations, he didn't see Adora coming.

The Sword of Courage ran him through. He gasped as the blade went through his chest and out his back. In front of his eyes, She-Ra glared at him with righteous fury.

"You're done, Prime."

Prime started to answer, but Catra's voice came from behind him.

"How did that oath to the Lantern go again, Adora? *In brightest day…*"

"*In blackest night*," Adora continued.

"*No evil shall escape* our *sight*," Catra picked up, leaping to crouch on the bit of sword sticking out of Prime's back. Her claws stabbed deep into his face and neck, and he howled.

"*Let those who worship evil's might*," Adora resumed, and energy poured into the sword.

As Horde Prime burned from the sword and the claws, he heard them finish in unison.

"Beware our power, GREEN LANTERN'S LIGHT!"

There was explosion of green-and-gold. The chamber of the Heart burned with power.

All shadows were cast out.

oOo

The armies of Horde Prime shuddered and fell. The robots toppled over and the clones cried out and crumpled to the ground.

The ground nearby cracked and split open, and a great golden light erupted upward. The light enveloped Prime's flagship. Everywhere it touched, life sprang into being. When the light stopped, the entire ship was covered in green, a large tree sprouting out of the top.

The light expanded, flowing like water as it spread over the land. Where it touched, life sprang anew. Where forests had fallen over the course of the war, new trees shot up. Flowery moss covered

the Fright Zone, choking the smokestacks until no more pollution spewed forth. Creatures long dormant stirred. The sea took on a new sheen. Sparkling mist formed in the air, charging it with new potential.

Everywhere on Etheria, magic was waking up.

But the most interesting thing about what came to be known as the Restoration was that, across Etheria, people would swear up and down that the light took on humanoid shapes in places, as if spirits were running with the light…

oOo

They felt nothing and yet everything.

They didn't see, they didn't hear, they didn't feel. But they saw light pouring over the land. They heard the cries of creatures great and small as they rejoiced in the new life. They felt the rush of wind and waves.

Indescribable feelings flowed through them, an energy beyond anything else. They somehow knew exactly what was going on, but would never be able to put it into words.

They felt each other, always. Their steps crossed leagues of distance, but they were always stepping together. Their hands

shaped in unison, purging the poison from the land and allowing Etheria to be born anew.

They danced together in the light, and their happiness urged the power onward, bringing the gifts of life and healing to a world that needed it.

The exact memories of the moment would fade, but they would never forget the feeling.

And then everything faded.

For a moment, there was darkness.

Then a bright light appeared on the horizon. It was warm, like the sun on a spring day. A voice echoed, kinder than ever thought possible.

"*Hello…*"

Suddenly, hands were on their shoulders.

"You don't want to go that way."

Adora and Catra turned to see a new person.

"Wow, that is a hat," Catra said.

"Thank you," the woman with the falcon headdress said with a smile, "And as I said, you don't want to go that way."

"Why not?" Adora asked.

"Because if you do, you can't come back. Now come along."

The woman led them away from the light. Adora spoke up.

"Who are you?"

"Just a concerned party," the woman replied, "When everything settles down, look for Eternia. We will talk more then, dear Adora."

"Eternia? Wait, how do you know my--"

And then there was nothing.

After the War

Chapter Notes

> You guys can play the fan song of the same name if you want. It's why I did what I did with the chapter title.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

-

Chapter 11

After the War

-

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Adora's eyes snapped open. Above her was a bright aurora, colors dancing with the stars in the sky.

She picked herself up, seeing a field of rolling green, then heard a groaning next to her.

"Did you see who was driving that skiff?"

Catra wrenched herself up, catching Adora's gaze.

"Did…did we win?

Adora laughed, pulling Catra into a kiss.

"Yeah, we won. It's over. He's gone."

Catra gave a small laugh and touched her forehead to Adora's.

"Good riddance."

They stayed like that for a while, feeling the warm wind blow around them and drinking in each other's presence. The only sound was Catra's purring.

"Hey, Catra?"

"Yeah?"

"It was Horde Prime's hands we pried it out of, but we got our happy ending."

And Catra started to laugh, tears of happiness welling up. Adora kissed the tears off her cheeks, laughter welling up in her too.

They laughed and cried and kissed and reveled in this, a happy ending after so much pain.

oOo

The key members of the Rebellion picked their way closer to each other. Sea Hawk held Mermista close, the latter having taken a bad hit in the final minutes. Scorpia was carrying Frosta on her shoulders. Netossa and Spinnerella were checking each other for injuries. Glimmer and Micah supported Castaspella between them. Perfuma was muttering about what healing herbs they'd need. Bow, Entrapta, and Melog exited the tower, a familiar figure with them.

"Is that who I think it is?" Glimmer asked.

"Afraid so," Bow replied.

"And we're just, like, okay with this?" Mermista asked, eyeing how Entrapta had practically wrapped herself around Hordak's arm.

Entrapta heard this and gave Mermista a surprisingly jarring death glare.

"I think we're cool, for now at least," Bow replied.

Castaspella yelped suddenly.

"Micah, can you feel that?"

Micah focused for a moment, then his eyes snapped open in shock.

"Woah! That's some kick!"

"Translation, please?" Netossa asked.

"The magical fields of the planet," Micah said, "They've undergone a fundamental shift. I feel more energy in the air than I've ever felt before.

"Then they did it!" Glimmer gasped, "They set the magic free!"

Bow poked at his tracker pad, a look of concentration on his face.

"Kyle, come in. Do you read?"

Kyle's voice issued from the pad.

"*Loud and clear, Bow!*"

"Give me a sit-rep. What do you see out there?"

"Lot of crazy stuff going on. I've got drone eyes all over Etheria, and everywhere I look, Horde tech has been knocked out and clones are stumbling around. No hostile movements. They see more confused than anything else."

"It looks to be the same here," Spinnerella said, pointing at a few nearby clones blinking at the sky in confusion.

"They are disconnected from the hivemind," Hordak spoke up, "I experienced the same symptoms when I was first banished to Etheria. Without it, they are operating solely on their own senses and memories, and the average clone is not used to that. However, if this phenomenon isn't limited to here, but is in fact as widespread as your intelligence states, then that can only mean one thing."

Hordak took a deep breath, a look on his face somewhere between amazement and confusion.

"Horde Prime is dead."

Everyone stared at him. Finally, Glimmer started to laugh.

"He's gone. Adora and Catra did it! They destroyed the Heart, freed the magic, and wiped Prime out of existence. He's gone! We won!"

Laughter started to bubble up from the group. Netossa dipped Spinnerella into a kiss. Frosta let out a whoop of victory from her position atop Scorpia. Perfuma lunged to Scorpia to hug her, which the other woman easily returned. Entrapta clung tighter to Hordak, speaking a mile a minute. Bow told Kyle to start spreading the word before pulling Glimmer into hug. Sea Hawk pulled Mermista into an impromptu dance, Mermista telling him to slow down but not actually meaning it if her laughter was any judge. Swift Wind took to the sky, looping through the air in joy. Micah and Castaspella kept sensing the magical fields, eyes wide in wonder at the new sensations.

Across the battlefield, soldiers threw down their weapons and embraced each other, laughing at their victory. The threat was gone, the world was safe.

Two people crested the hill, looking down at the joyful chaos. They held hands as they picked their way down the hillside, only letting go once they reached friends.

Bow and Glimmer immediately tackle-hugged them, and the Best Friend Squad went down in a tangle of limbs and laughter.

When they finally got up, Adora and Glimmer started talking each other's ears off. Catra spotted someone in the crowd and grimaced. Catching sight of this, Bow nudged her and gave her an encouraging smile.

Catra made her away over, clearing her throat when she was close enough.

"Hey, Scorpia," she said hesitantly.

Scorpia paused in her conversation with Perfuma, then took Frosta down from where the ice princess had been seated on her shoulders.

"Look, I—"

Scorpia lunged, picking Catra up and squeezing her into a tight hug.

"And there it is," Catra wheezed.

"You know I'm a hugger," Scorpia said smugly.

Catra took this as a measure of forgiveness and smiled. Her smile dipped a bit when Perfuma and Frosta piled on.

"Okay, you guys are crushing me!"

Adora heard the shout and whipped her head around, but her worry vanished upon seeing what was going on.

"Guess Scorpia forgives her. Catra was worried about that."

"I still don't know why she was," Bow replied, "Super-hard exterior, sweet and gooey center, that's Scorpia."

"So, what now?" Glimmer asked.

Adora breathed deeply, feeling a weight lift.

"Now…we start living."

oOo

Bright Moon had been settled on as the base of operations for rebuilding Etheria. For a long time afterward, there would be people coming and going. Plans would be made, aid would be directed, and new treaties to protect this new future would be made.

One of the first big questions was what to do about Hordak. On the one hand, he started the war in the first place. All the damage that the Horde had done over the years started with him. Even if he wasn't involved in day-to-day things for most of that time, he still started the fight, still set the policies that had led to so much pain.

On the other hand, seeing what Horde Prime was like and how he had conducted his business, an argument could be made that Hordak had fallen back on what he knew when faced with a new paradigm. Hordak himself had admitted that he had never taken his banishment well, and most of his actions had been trying to find a way home, as well as prove to his big brother that he still had worth. In hindsight, that last bit had been an exercise in futility, but serving Prime had been all he had known, so it was the only thing he could truly dedicate himself to.

Entrapta had argued passionately on Hordak's behalf. Later accounts by the princesses would have it that they'd never seen Entrapta so determined. Her arguments were extensive, her entire being dedicated to the single goal of helping Hordak, because she truly didn't believe he was entirely at fault.

"He still did horrible things," Glimmer said.

"He didn't know they were horrible, and by the time he did, he was in too deep to stop! Can you really punish him for that?" Entrapta argued, "I know that doesn't invalidate all he did, but that has to count for something!"

Hordak had little to say for himself. He was a model prisoner, rarely speaking but not arguing with orders given. He seemed resigned to the entire process.

When he was asked to speak, he was fairly blunt about everything. He agreed on Entrapta's point that he'd fallen back on what he knew, but chalked his continuance of the Horde more as apathy than anything else. Running it was just something he did after a while. It wasn't until Entrapta came into his life that he started climbing out of his rut. As it stood now, his taste for conquest had been thoroughly crushed. The prospect of picking it back up left a bitter taste in his mouth.

"If you ask me if I grieve, if a feel apologetic for all I have done… that is a complicated question. Mostly, no, I do not. I have tried in these quiet hours to generate the correct emotion, but it does not come. I have regrets, but they are…complicated. Nothing is quite so easy as you all likely wish."

He looked at them all with an expression somewhere between somberness and schadenfreude.

"You all wished to slay a mighty dragon that had been terrorizing your land for so long, but when you got to the cave, you found only a withered creature that was a shadow of its former self. I do not envy you your position."

Finally, the big question was asked: if he were allowed to go free, what would he do? Where would he go?

"Somewhere quiet, I think. Little jolts of excitement are fine, but…mostly, I'd rather be left alone to tinker. To live on terms I set myself, without the shadow of Prime looming over me. But as for conquest, restarting the Horde? No, no I think not. I have had my fill of war's fury, and I shall not have any more of it."

The deliberations were long, but in the end, Adora said it best.

"The war is over. Let's let it remain that way."

So Hordak was sentenced to what was effectively community service. Under the guidance of the Princess Alliance and the stewardship of Entrapta, he would serve to help repair the damage done to Etheria.

"We call it restorative justice," Glimmer said, "Basically, you're still being punished, but you're being given the chance to fix what you broke."

It was an offer that was readily accepted by Hordak and Entrapta, especially since the former was half-convinced that he would have been sent to Beast Island. This was an idea that Adora and Micah had quickly squashed. Having experienced its horrors, they would not wish Beast Island on anyone.

The next debate was over the now-leaderless clones. Thankfully, that was much shorter. Interviewing one clone had been an exercise in futility. All it did was cry over being alone, of not hearing the voices of its brothers or Horde Prime.

"Honestly, I'm not surprised," Hordak commented, "I was fairly broken up over being disconnected from the hivemind. The difference is that my genetic degradation had already started affecting my mind, making me more susceptible to bending or breaking my programming."

"You're saying you were more likely to think for yourself, and that helped when you were kicked out?" Adora asked.

"Yes, although only to a degree. It still took time for me to mature enough mentally to function on my own. The rest of the clones will not have that luxury."

"They do seem pretty directionless, from what we've observed," Bow said.

"Directionless? The poor things are practically babies!" Entrapta argued, "They're even worse off than Hordak's own lousy beginning—no offense—"

"None taken."

"—so they shouldn't be held accountable for Prime's actions. And we broke them, so they're our responsibility!"

They all ended up in Dryl with Entrapta, where she and Hordak could monitor them in a safe environment and acclimate them to their new reality. The princesses figured that the common Etherian might be a little leery of them for a while, so it worked out.

And as for the rest of the former Horde, most of them seemed perfectly willing to fade into the woodwork. Amnesty was offered to the common soldier, and it was eagerly taken. Soldiers of all stripes began to slowly integrate themselves into the various kingdoms. Dryl and the newly-reborn Scorpion Kingdom received the lion's share, but old soldiers found their way to all corners of Etheria, starting new lives wherever they could.

The higher-ups in the Horde were harder. Some willingly surrendered, following Hordak's lead in restorative justice. They took reduced sentences in exchange for work on rebuilding the damaged kingdoms. Some refused all offers, and ended up imprisoned. And a very small number ended up trying to fight their way out. Stories would be told of Force Captain Octavia's last stand, of how she dueled Mermista one-on-one before losing her footing and falling into rocky waters to her death. Of the fighters, only Captain Vultak escaped unscathed, disappearing into the Crimson Wastes. Huntara was still tracking him.

Once the biggest problems were out of the way, the work of rebuilding began in earnest…

oOo

Catra looked over several papers at once, eyes flicking from them to the holographic map at random intervals.

Glimmer just blinked on shock. When Catra had tagged along to the meeting room, she expected her to stay by the wayside and make snarky comments while she, Adora, and Bow did actual work. Maybe interspersed with a comment that left Adora blushing, because that was just life now.

Shows what she knew for not believing her friends when they said that Catra had a keen strategic mind. And fool on her for not remembering all the battles Catra had led.

Maybe it was because military planning was different from peacetime relief operations. But either way, Catra had been surprisingly attentive to the job at hand.

Now if only Glimmer could get Adora to stop smirking at her.

"Okay, I think I've got it," Catra said suddenly, "Scorpia is working on getting the forges in the old Fight Zone converted, so metalwork will probably be their biggest export. We can use that for getting proper trade up and running. Perfuma and Mermista have breadbasket operations cornered, between farming and

fishing, so what we need is a way to get that food to where it needs to be quickly and efficiently. Half the problem with food transport is getting it to a place without it spoiling on you, so we need to make good use of fast routes until Entrapta can crack mass production of those cooling units her and Hordak are experimenting with. Maybe conscript old Horde transports, they're a lot faster than the horses most of the kingdoms use. There are plenty of Horde soldiers that are skiff-trained and looking for work, put them up to it."

She drew several lines on the map, then paused on one in particular.

"This one is risky. The terrain means that it's prime for ambush by bandits. We've been seeing a few coming up recently."

"That's true," Bow said, "I was going to ride along with the next shipment out of Bright Moon, keep an eye out."

"Archer's eyes would be good for that. We should send a few soldiers along with any transports taking this route, and we should work on flushing out and taking out any bandit groups. I'll take a look out on the area later."

"Do you want help?" Adora asked.

"Nah, this should just be a scouting mission. Me and Melog can move faster on our own."

Catra continued to lay out a few more ideas, and then sat back with a smug look on her face.

"Do you need job?" Glimmer asked, "You have a job now. You're on my advisory board. See my dad after the meeting for the details."

Adora snickered.

"Sure," Catra shrugged, "I was hoping for something that'll let me stay in Bright Moon."

She gave Adora a significant look, and Adora smiled.

oOo

Adora was working on something in her forge when Bow came to see her. A part of him felt guilty for intruding on her, since blacksmithing was how she relaxed. As much as others might be confused at how such a strenuous activity could be relaxing, he actually got it. He was similar when he was crafting new arrows, after all. But he had a problem and he wasn't sure how much longer he could stand it.

He'd waited until she stopped hammering to call out. Adora held up a finger and dunked her project in the water barrel before addressing him.

"What's up, Bow?"

"We've been real busy lately, so I haven't had a chance to…ask you about something."

Bow shifted from one foot to the other. Adora hummed in confusion.

"Bow, is something wrong?"

"No, no, no…at least, I don't think so…"

"Then why do you look like you killed someone's pet—"

"Glimmer and I kissed!" he blurted out.

Adora's mouth opened and closed like a fish.

"It was right before the big final battle. She hugged me tight, super worried, said she couldn't lose me too. We talked it out, and then suddenly she was kissing me, and I was kissing her, and we haven't really talked about it since, like was it a one-time thing, heat of the moment, or is there something else there? I've known her my whole life, and now I'm looking back at everything and second-guessing myself, like, was I feeling this way the whole time and never known it, is she in the same boat, what's going on? I am freaking out, Adora! You're in a relationship, help me!"

He finally stopped, and Adora shook herself back into focus.

"You think I have any answers for you?" Adora asked incredulously, "I'm working practically blind with Catra! There's a part of me that's constantly worried that I'll do or say the wrong thing and she'll freak out. I keep counting down the days until we can see that therapist so we can start to fix things and neither of us have to keep tiptoeing through a minefield!"

Bow moaned, dragging his hands down his face. Adora took that opportunity to hug him.

"Don't get me wrong, I'm excited for you. I'll support you two no matter what you decide. But if you really want advice, I suggest Spinnerella and Netossa. Catra went to them a while back, and she had nothing but good things to say about the conversation."

Bow slowly calmed down, returned the hug, and thanked Adora for the advice.

Ironically, when he went to their married friends, he found Glimmer trying to have the exact same conversation. The older women ended up mediating, then quietly excused themselves from the resulting romantic moment.

Such was life.

oOo

Perfuma dug her fingers into the soil, frowning.

"It's weak, but it might be doable. It'll take a lot of work, though."

"So what do you suggest?" Scorpia asked.

"There's a type of grass that is extremely hardy. It can grow in fairly infertile soil. That will be the first step, as it can also absorb a lot of the pollutants in the soil. Doing so will kill the grass, but that's what you want. You just need to remove the grass before it can rot and release those pollutants back into the soil."

"Got it. How'd you find that grass, anyway?"

"We use it for reclamation, step one in making soil fertile again," Perfuma shrugged, standing up and brushing the dirt off her hand, "It helped after we drove the Horde out of Plumeria and started trying to fix the damage from them poisoning the land. Now, once you're sure the grasses have sucked all the toxins out, I recommend clover, soy beans, and millet. You can harvest some from the latter two crops, and leave the rest behind to rot. Compost won't go amiss either."

"I get it. The rotting plants will put nutrients into the soil," Scorpia said.

"And those plants specifically can give a lot back, yes. You may have to go through several rounds of beans before you can be sure the soil is suitable for other crops. And it's good to get in the habit of field rotation. Keep a crop of the beans in addition to whatever else you're growing, and when it's time to replant, put the beans in a different plot—"

"So that the other crops can take advantage of the newly-rich soil, great!" Scorpia squealed, "Thanks for your help, Perfuma. This'll be super-helpful. Now I just have to convince some of the old soldiers that they need to work the fields, not just the forges."

"Just because metalwork is shaping up to be your kingdom's thing doesn't mean you should ignore agriculture," Perfuma nodded, "Growing your own food will leave you less reliant on imports."

"We're a fairly weak kingdom, all things considered," Scorpia frowned, "A lot of Etherians are going to be giving us the side-eye

for a long time. I want to be a good leader, and that means having all the bases covered."

"It's funny you bring that up. Being a good leader means also taking care of yourself. If you're out of balance, you can't run things effectively. I wanted to invite you to a class I'm teaching on meditation."

"I don't know…"

"Catra will be there."

Scorpia blinked at her.

"What?"

"Yeah, I convinced her to give it a shot. It'll be good for you both, I think. You both have some stress you need to learn to deal with. Different stress, mind, different traumas, but still…"

"Maybe we should get Adora to join, then," Scorpia joked.

"Oh, we tried that once. But Adora doesn't have the patience for most meditation, and eventually gave up," Perfuma shrugged,

"Although we did discover her spirit animal! A falcon, interestingly."

"No, I can kind of see it."

Scorpia tapped her claws together before nodding.

"Okay, I'll try it. When is it?"

Perfuma rattled off a date and time, and the two continued to walk through the area that Scorpia had set aside for the farming attempt. Somewhere between irrigation and pest control, a familiar feeling struck Scorpia, and it slowly grew the more she talked with Perfuma. It was something she'd idly thought about during their time together in the Rebellion, but with no threat on the horizon, the thought started to make itself more and more known.

Finally, as they were finishing up and Perfuma was about to mount her horse, Scorpia spoke up.

"Hey, listen, Perfuma," she said slowly, shuffling her feet, "You're… you're a really good friend. You're kind, you're smart, you're really pretty…I was just kind of wondering if you wanted to do something…or not, if you really don't feel like—"

Perfuma reached up and put her finger over Scorpia's lips.

"I'm…open to exploring whatever happens next."

She smiled at Scorpia before getting on her horse.

"Maybe some tea after the meditation lesson?"

"Tea! Yes, tea is good! Tea sounds…super."

Perfuma giggled a bit before bidding her good-bye and riding off.

Scorpia stood there waving until she couldn't make out Perfuma anymore, then pumped her claw.

"I've got a shot!"

oOo

The Salineas Sea Gate flickered on and off. Parts of it started to solidify, but other parts didn't. Hordak scowled as he worked the console.

“Power fluctuations seem to be centered around the upper portions…maybe…”

He trailed off, muttering. Entrapta let him. She worked with him enough to know when to let him think.

Mermista crested the top of the stairs.

“How’s it coming?” she asked.

“Nearly there, I think. The invasion by the Horde and subsequent chaos of Prime damaged the superstructure of the Gate,” Entrapta replied, “But I think we’re almost done. Then Adora can come in all glowy and initiate the full recharge.”

“Think her sword will still work?”

“If it doesn’t, the ring’s energy can provide an adequate jumpstart. It’s surprisingly versatile.”

“Entrapta, can you check the connections at the top?” Hordak spoke up, “I think we might have a few loose ones.”

“On it!” Entrapta chirped before climbing the Gate’s outer wall with her hair.

Once she was far enough up, Hordak turned to Mermista.

"Princess, may I ask you a question?"

"Sure, I guess."

"I didn't wish to bring this up in front of Entrapta, no need to squash her enthusiasm, but why are we bothering with this? The Sea Gate is a potent defensive structure, but the war is over. Surely its purpose is moot now?"

"Well, for one thing, it's good for keeping off pirates," Mermista shrugged.

"Between your power, your kingdom's navy, and your lover's connections, I highly doubt pirates are truly that big of a problem," Hordak deadpanned.

"You're right, but pirates aren't the biggest reason."

Mermista turned to observe the Sea Gate, her face softening.

"This thing has been standing for over a thousand years. Salineas got started because of it. It's a symbol of the kingdom. Most of my people consider it a cultural site first and a defensive fortification second. So, even if it's never used for protection again, repairing it means giving my people back a symbol of hope. And after everything that's happened to them recently, they need that hope."

Hordak pondered that for a moment, then nodded.

"Thank you, I had wondered about that."

"No problem," Mermista shrugged, "You're out here fixing the thing, you might as well know why."

Left unsaid was that Hordak had a major hand in breaking it in the first place. But by mutual silent agreement upon arriving in Salineas for the start of repairs, the two had agreed not to bring it up. The citizens of Salineas had likewise kept their distance, although that was mostly thanks to threats of severe punishment to any trying to interfere with the work, threats that Mermista had handed down the previous week in anticipation of any difficulties. A few foolhardy souls tried to test this, as tends to happen, but were taken care of by the guards before getting near the genius princess and the ex-warlord.

Mermista would never like Hordak, but she at least respected that he was here to make reparations. Dealing with idiots trying to attack him and his work was the least she could do.

And she didn't want to deal with Entrapta's sad eyes if something did happen…

oOo

Perhaps unsurprisingly, one of the former Horde soldiers opened up a bar in the former Fright Zone. It was into this establishment that Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio entered. After getting their drinks, they sat at a booth.

"Crazy times we're living in, huh?" Lonnie said.

Rogelio hissed in agreement.

"You know, moments like this, it makes you want to say something profound," Kyle said.

There was a moment of silence.

"Not feeling it either, huh?"

"Nope."

Hisss.

"So, what's next for you, Lonnie?" Kyle asked.

"Honestly, after everything, I'm tired of fighting," Lonnie shrugged, "I was going to sign up for that farm Scorpia's trying to start up. Should be quiet. You?"

"Still into engineering," Kyle replied, "But instead of spy drones, I'm going to be helping reconfigure the old machinery. I was at a meeting about that earlier, the ideas were flying! It'll definitely keep me busy."

Rogelio gave a hissing laugh. Then through a mixture of growls and hand signs, he took his turn.

"Medicine? Really?" Lonnie asked.

"No, I can kind of see it," Kyle said, "He's always been interested in that kind of thing. Remember, he was usually the one patching me up."

Lonnie made a noise like dawning comprehension.

"Oh, yeah. I didn't get hurt very often, and Adora and Catra usually took care of each other."

"Speaking of whom, you still owe me over the bet."

Lonnie grumbled, and Rogelio laughed at her misfortune.

"I told you, Lonnie," Kyle said, "That was building up for ages, they just didn't see it. You didn't really think they'd be oblivious forever, did you?"

"Oh, can it!"

They lapsed into companionable silence for a moment, then Lonnie raised her glass.

"Here's to the future, then."

The boys clicked their glasses to hers, agreeing.

oOo

"I'm sorry you missed out on it all," Adora said.

Mara shrugged.

"This ship isn't armed. It's an exploration vessel, built for speed and stability. It has particle shields, but they're for space debris, not heavy combat. If I had been there, I'd have been shot down in a heartbeat."

Adora grimaced. Mara had hit upon a subject that she wasn't sure how to addressed.

"Screw it, in for a bronze chip," she whispered before raising her voice, "I actually wanted to talk to you about that."

"About what?"

"Technically speaking, you're trapped. You can't leave the ship. You not…free, really."

Mara gave her a funny look.

Then the *Starshine* shuddered. Adora could see the trees disappearing from the windows.

"You underestimate just how much control I have over this ship," Mara said as they rose into the sky, "It is my body. The engines are my legs, the sensors my eyes and ears. Do I miss the feel of the wind through my hair and across my skin? Hell yes, but I have another chance to live now. I'm choosing to look at the brighter side of things, appreciate what I have."

Adora pondered this for a moment while the ship leveled out.

"Well then…since you are a spaceship, you don't have to stay. The war's over, the universe is opened up. You could go off and explore and why are you laughing at me?"

Mara muffled her snickers.

"Making a lot of presumptions here, aren't you? Adora, this world is my home. My friends are here. And there's still this blonde punk flailing around with awesome magical powers and responsibility that could benefit from the guidance of this old solider. Sorry, Adora. You're not getting rid of me that easily."

Adora gave a relieved laugh.

"I actually hoped you'd stick around. I just don't want you feeling trapped."

"It's not trapped if it's my choice," Mara replied.

Adora hummed in reply. Then she asked if Mara could bring them up a little higher.

"I strangely don't feel as comfortable trying this from the ground."

Adora walked to the edge of the gangplank, looking out over the empty air and the ground far below. She could see Swift Wind flying in the distance, free as a bird.

She took a deep breath and stepped forward.

The wind rushed around her as she fell. Then she felt the soothing heat of the ringpower envelop her.

Adora shot through the air on an upward trajectory, whooping in delight. She shot past Swift Wind, and her horse neighed in glee and increased his speed to join her. They dove and looped through the air above Bright Moon without a care.

"Enjoyable, isn't it?" Swift Wind called out.

"Heck yeah!" Adora shouted back, "Catch me if you can, Swifty!"

She shot off, and Swift Wind snorted.

"Oh, it's on!"

oOo

Catra took a deep breath and let it out slowly. Adora reached out and squeezed her hand.

"You ready for this?"

"As I'll ever be. You?"

"I think so, yeah."

Together, they walked through the doorway into a pleasantly decorated room. The walls were a soft blue, and there was a plush sofa against one wall. The woman in the other chair looked up from her notepad and smiled at them.

"Adora, Catra. Welcome. I'm Doctor Ransdottir, but you can call me Grace. Have a seat and we'll get started."

oOo

Later, Catra flopped onto the bed, groaning.

"That was exhausting…"

"Just remember what Glimmer and Micah said: first session is usually the worst," Adora replied, sitting down next to her girlfriend.

Catra just groaned again.

"At least we were able to break for dinner."

Another groan.

Adora finally let it be, and got up to get ready for bed. Catra eventually joined her, slipping on an old shirt of Adora's that she'd tore specifically to claim it for her own.

As they crawled into bed, Catra sighed.

"I know this is going to help eventually…but I just feel so strung out."

"Yeah, me too," Adora said, "I think you got the worst of it, but I feel pretty drained myself. I'm proud of you for doing it, though."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah. It felt good to talk about it, get it off your mind, right?"

And as Catra thought, she found herself agreeing. It felt right, or as right as anything involving their nightmarish childhoods could be. It felt…

"Clean," she said, "Like I'm washing it away."

"Fresh start," Adora nodded, agreeing, "No more war. No more suffering…"

"No more lying awake at night because of how lonely you are…"

"No more being punished for petty reasons…"

“No more looking over your shoulder…”

“No more Shadow Weaver…”

“No more Prime…”

“Just friendship and love,” Adora finished, “Just us.”

“Like how it always should have been,” Catra smiled.

The two gazed at each other for a time. Then the kissing started. Soft and light, the warmth building within them with every passing moment.

And soon it was only them. Adora and Catra, together in all things.

A happy ending at last…

Chapter End Notes

NOT the end!

Sister Planet

Chapter Notes

Now, question of the hour:
Are we really doing this?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

-

Chapter 12

Sister Planet

-

-

Six months later…

Adora loved this.

She woke to warmth and fluff. Catra was nestled close to her, and their arms were around each other. Adora enjoyed these moments greatly. She loved looking at Catra's face, completely relaxed in warmth and safety. She would hear either a series of tiny snores or, if Catra was partially awake, soft purrs. She wasn't sure which she liked better.

Adora could have spent all day like this, she and her love ensconced in blankets and the feeling of each other. Warm and safe and loved.

They had things to do today, however, and they couldn't just spend all day in bed.

The outside world could wait a little longer, though. Yes, as Adora observed Catra's ear flicking, she decided that she could afford to lay there a little longer.

She knew Catra was waking up when she heard the snores transition to purrs. Catra's hand, laying against Adora's chest, flexed a bit, claws gently tickling the subtle scarring that the failsafe had left. She felt Catra's tail brush against her leg.

"Mmmmmorning," she heard Catra say.

Adora just chuckled and kissed Catra on the forehead.

Catra slowly opened her eyes, and Adora marveled at them. There were times they looked like iridescent gemstones. This was one of those times, as Catra looked at Adora with unguarded affection. Catra was a woman who took great care in how she interacted with people. Even with those close to her, she held back a touch. According to their doctor, this was a remnant of her rough childhood. But moments like this, when Catra was completely open, they were for Adora and Adora alone.

They lay like that for a little longer, snuggled up close. Eventually though, nature called, and they had to move.

The morning routine was one that had solidified quickly as time went on. Adora would shower first, as she took less time, then Catra would have her turn, as her fur required more care. Usually, Catra would use a minimal amount of water and take a sponge bath. Today, however, seemed to be a shower day. Before entering, Catra made sure the water was screaming hot, warmer than Adora liked it. This was a normal occurrence when she showered. Part of it was a general feline distaste of water, but the rest was her post-traumatic stress from Horde Prime's pool. When the water was super-hot, her mind didn't make the connection with the blistering cold of the pool.

She still refused to go swimming when they visited Salineas, and it took a lot to tempt her into Mystacor's hot springs.

Once she exited, Adora helped her comb out her fur. It wasn't just to help it dry out faster, it was also a soothing ritual. Catra was sometimes agitated in the mornings, but the feeling of the comb through her fur and Adora's soft touch helped ground her.

"Big day today," Adora said as she attacked the tail.

"Yeah, Sparkles is finally starting to plan off-world diplomacy," Catra replied, combing through her hair.

"I'm excited."

"I know, dummy. You've only been smiling about it for the past week."

"You can't tell me you're not curious."

"Well…maybe a little."

"And just think, once we've established a few lines, there will be a need for people to go out on diplomacy missions. Picture this, you and me, traversing the stars, *alone together"*

Catra didn't need to look back to know Adora was grinning in a certain way. She could *feel* it.

"That does sound nice," Catra replied, fighting down a blush.

The last bit of fur was near Catra's neck. Adora paused.

"How is it this morning?"

"Tingling a bit. Where's the cream?"

Adora opened the cabinet, retrieving the tin of special cream. Of all the multiple scars between them, the patch of furless skin on the back of Catra's neck was the one that acted up most often. That's not to say it itched most of the time, it didn't. But sometimes, it made itself known.

Perfuma thought it was psychosomatic, Hordak thought it was her body reacting to the small pieces still attached to her spine, buried deep under her skin, and Catra was convinced it was a little of both.

She still had nightmares surrounding the chip. She knew it was no threat now. Horde Prime was gone, the chips and hivemind with him, and what was left in Catra was empty metal and broken fibers. There was no threat. Still, Catra wouldn't be lying if she said that them being there still concerned her some days.

After dealing with the scar, they dealt with hair. Both of them had grown it out in recent months, part of their first steps toward healing. Catra tied her longer hair back into a now-customary bushy ponytail, then helped Adora with the neat braid the blond sported.

"You know, I sometimes wish I could do this," Catra said as she finished with the braid, "It seems so practical."

"We could try, one day."

"You know it's still too bushy. It took a lot of work to keep it straight for my Horde Commander look, and even the ponytail is tough to gather up some days."

"Shame, I think you'd look good."

After that, they exited the bathroom and went to the dressers. They dressed in a slow dance of progress and lingering looks, but it got done. Adora let out a thin line of green from her ring, retrieving a pair of jackets from the hook near the door as well as a dark red scarf.

"You have to do that all the time?" Catra asked, shrugging her black jacket.

"Good practice," Adora replied, pulling her own jacket on and briefly fumbling. She'd taken out the shoulder pads a few weeks ago, no longer feeling a need to compensate for her slim frame like she used to, but it was still felt new not having them there.

"Like you don't get enough of that between bandits and the forge," Catra fired back, adjusting the scarf that she was rarely without.

"Just be happy that I figured out how to store the sword in the same pocket as the lantern, or I'd have another thing to keep track of."

"Certainly took you quicker to find an easy way to store it than the last one."

"True."

"Anything else we're forgetting today?" Catra asked, looking at a calendar on the wall.

"Only thing I can think of is Doctor Ransdottir, but that's next month, isn't it?"

Catra quickly checked.

"Yup, the twentieth. I'm surprised she's letting us go to a monthly visit, after everything. When we started, it was weekly."

"Well, we did have a lot to go through," Adora grimaced, "But we've come a long way and neither of us is backsliding, so I agree that we're okay with not seeing her as often."

Before leaving their rooms, they joined hands, touched foreheads, and took deep breaths in sync. With that last ritual out of the way, they left for breakfast.

In the hallway, Melog appeared out of thin air.

"You have a good night in the forest?" Catra asked, petting the big cat.

Melog gave a pleased purr. Sometimes, she'd spend the night in the Whispering Woods, running through the trees and sleeping under the stars. It reminded her of her wilder days, but it was always nice to be back home.

They ran into Bow and Glimmer just outside the dining room. Micah was already inside, sipping coffee and looking over a report.

"Morning, kids," he said absently.

Glimmer gave him a brief hug before settling in like the rest.

"So, big day today," Adora grinned, piling some strawberries on her plate.

“And here she goes again,” Catra muttered, grabbing a few strips of bacon and sneaking one to Melog.

“Maybe dial it back, Adora?” Glimmer said while grabbing some pancakes, “It’s not like we’re going to another planet *today*. We’re just headed to Dryl start gaming this out.”

“Quit wasting your breath, Glim,” Bow snorted around his cup of coffee, “That’s too much enthusiasm to be squashed.”

“Hear, hear,” Catra nodded in agreement, “It took forever to get her to sleep last night.”

“You sure excitement wasn’t the only reason you two were up so late?” Glimmer asked with a particular grin.

Micah coughed a bit, and they suddenly remembered there was an adult in the room.

“So, how about that netball team from Salineas?” Bow asked awkwardly.

“They suck,” Catra replied in perfect deadpan.

Bow gave her a scandalized look.

“She’s not wrong,” Micah muttered.

Breakfast continued in that vein. The four young adults chatted amicably, Micah interjecting at various points. Eventually, the conversation circled back to the inter-planetary diplomacy plans.

“I think we should start with other planets that were enslaved by Horde Prime,” Glimmer said, “Countless people suffered because of him. Maybe we can find solidarity.”

“And if nothing else, the fact that we defeated him will certainly win us brownie points,” Bow added.

“So what was the first step, again?” Micah asked, “I’ve mostly been focusing on more down-to-earth matters. This project is Glimmer’s baby.”

“Our first stop is Dryl,” Glimmer said, “Prime’s ship crash-landed near there following the final battle, and the kingdom has been slowly stripping it for useable material ever since. One of the things they did with all that metal and tech was build an observatory.”

“Right, I heard Hordak pretty much runs it,” Adora nodded, “Which makes sense, really. He has the familiarity with the stars already, and it keeps him busy.”

"More importantly, it keeps him out of sight of the general public," Catra grumbled, "Which keeps him away from anyone still bitter about the war."

Left unsaid was that is also kept him firmly under Dryl's protection, which guarded against assassination attempts. There had been a few, people who refused to heed the call for peace after the war. Dryl's security kept the assassins from getting too close. It helped that, whether as a means to keep them productive or out of respect for Entrapta, Hordak had ensured that the kingdom was treated with a light touch when under Horde control. This meant that the citizenry were less likely to hate Hordak and more inclined to treat him as a weird neighbor who retired from his previous job.

Catra had also experienced one attempt on her life. Emphasis on *one*. Catra's hearing meant the assassin's attempted ambush was foiled, and while she could have fought him off when he decided to be direct, Adora had gotten there first.

The wrath of She-Ra was legendary. No one tried for Catra again. Even to this day, Adora got *twitchy* whenever the subject of assassins was brought up.

"So the six of us will make up a list of planets and their coordinates, pick a close one, and then we'll see about forming a diplomatic envoy," Glimmer said, "Shouldn't be too hard to start."

“Right, it’s when you actually land on another planet that things will start to get tricky,” Micah hummed.

oOo

“Have I mentioned how much I love having our own spaceship?” Bow said, “Used to be this trip took most of the day, now it’s minutes.”

“We know,” Catra groaned good-naturedly.

“Say hi to Entrapta for me!” they heard Mara call out before the gangplank retracted back up.

They made their way to the castle and knocked on the door. A familiar face answered, but not a familiar voice.

“May I help you, brothers?” the clone said in a bright cadence so unlike Hordak.

“We were looking for Entrapta?” Adora said hesitantly.

“Princess Entrapta is at the observatory with Lord Hordak. Shall I escort you?”

“No, that’s okay,” Glimmer replied, “We can make our own way.”

The clone cheerily bid them farewell, then left them to their confusion as they walked away from the castle.

“That was trippy, right?” Catra said, “Seeing Hordak’s face, but it was smiling?”

“Must be something they got used to,” Bow said, jerking a thumb at the milling people in the square.

Several Horde clones walked among them, their gaits still robotic. The few snatches of conversation they heard was stilted and dull, and they only spoke when spoken to. The Dryl citizens seemed more than willing to help them navigate their various errands, treating them fairly and explaining things every step of the way.

One clone they literally bumped into apologized dully before continuing on his way.

“Definitely something they got used to,” Catra nodded.

Melog nuzzled Catra’s hand, reminding her of their appointment.

They traversed a path carved out of the mountainside, soon reaching the top. Perched on the highest peak around Dryl was a circular building with a large telescope poking out of the rounded roof.

"Think we're in the right place?" Catra snarked.

Adora knocked on the door, and after a few minutes, Entrapta answered. She stared at them blankly for a moment before gasping and pulling out a pocket watch.

"Was that today? Shoot!"

"No worries, Entrapta," Bow said, "We would have probably ended up here anyway."

Entrapta invited them in and brought them to the main area. In one corner, Hordak was hunched over some star charts, muttering to himself as he made notes.

"Hordak, we've got company!" Entrapta said cheerily.

"You forgot that today was the day you met with the other princesses, didn't you?" he replied dryly.

Entrapta gave an embarrassed chuckle. Hordak briefly looked up from his work.

"Greetings. I'll be with you all in a minute, I just need to finish these last few annotations. And I apologize for her."

"No worries," Adora said, "We're used to her flightiness. One of the clones gave us directions. Cheerful guy, was playing doorman at the castle?"

"Oh yeah!" Entrapta grinned with a snap of her fingers, "Most of the clones still haven't progressed beyond simple words and functions, but that one's a lot more advanced. Isn't he just the goodest boy!"

"He's certainly more vocal than the other clones we saw in town," Glimmer said.

"Yeah, he's definitely been the most outgoing of all the clones. Like I said, more advanced than the others. He's also the only one comfortable with a real name as opposed to a number. I wanted to call him Wrong Hordak—"

"But I convinced her to let him have a book of names and let him pick one himself," Hordak interjected, not even looking up from his own project, "He seems to have settled on Horace, for some reason."

“Someone’s mellowed out considerably,” Catra muttered to Adora, pointing at Hordak.

“I think Entrapta’s been good for him,” Adora whispered back.

Hordak finished his work, tapping his pencil on the table with finality before rising.

“Wearing that old armor, I see,” Catra hummed.

Hordak shot her a dark look, but composed himself.

“I suffer from a muscular and skeletal degradation. Prime’s treatments halted it, but the disorder has started to make itself known again. Entrapta and I have been working on a way to keep it at bay. Regardless of the success or failure of it, this armor aids me in day-to-day activities. Without it, many of my endeavors would be…problematic.”

“So long as you don’t go crazy on anyone, I don’t see how that’s any of our business,” Adora shrugged, “If that armor helps keep you together, then go ahead.”

Hordak studied Adora carefully, then nodded.

Sometimes, neither was sure where they stood with each other. Other times, Adora took a more sedate approach to their interactions, and Hordak responded in kind.

He asked her about it once, and she replied that she was in no mood to restart the war. Hordak could agree with that, at least.

"So, Entrapta and I found something interesting the other week. Given the subject matter, we decided to bring it up for our scheduled meeting," he said, rummaging through a filing cabinet.

"What discovery?" Glimmer asked.

"Etheria isn't the only planet in our solar system. Another planet orbits the same sun."

While the others stood stunned, Entrapta dashed over to a console and up a picture on the display.

"This is a mock-up I made," she chattered, "The green ball is Etheria, and the blue one is our new neighbor."

Around an image of the sun, two balls spun around. Their orbits brought them close occasionally, but they danced away from each other more often than not.

“Here’s the really crazy part,” Entrapta said.

“The planets might as well be twins,” Hordak picked up, showing them the data they’d collected, “Same size, similar topography, similar weather patterns. As far as we can tell, it even possesses a similar magnetic field, gravitational field, and atmosphere.”

“Obviously, we can’t confirm everything without sending a probe or going there ourselves, but think of the possibilities!” Entrapta exclaimed.

The group poured over the sheets of paper Hordak gave them. A lot of it was technical, but enough was legible to give them the gist of it.

“I think I need to sit down,” Bow said woozily.

“Well, I wanted something close by to start with,” Glimmer muttered.

“I just thought of something,” Adora said, “I know Mara’s databanks are out of date, but maybe there’s something there we can use?”

“A planet this close to Etheria? More than likely,” Catra said, Melog humming in agreement as Catra idly scratched her companion’s head.

Entrapta began pouting.

“Well sure, take all the fun out of discovery why don’t you?”

Hordak lightly touched her shoulder.

“Forewarned is forearmed, Entrapta.”

Entrapta gave her groaning assent, and they gathered the notes and trooped back to the ship.

Mara took one look at all the data and blinked in shock.

“It’s still there? I would have thought it had been ravaged or something.”

“Why would you think that?” Glimmer asked.

"The planet is called Eternia," Mara explained, "It was Etheria's sister planet, and just as settled by the First Ones. Maybe a little more heavily, if I'm being honest. It was the seat of my people in this sector of space, and with the civil war going on when I went under, I thought that it would have been ground zero for a lot of bad stuff. And even if it had hung on, there is Horde Prime to consider."

"I do not think my mad brother had much of a presence around here before Etheria slipped out of Despondos," Hordak replied.

"And if he discovered it at the same time as Etheria?" Bow asked.

"Then he likely wouldn't have made much of a move on it, at least not until he finished with Etheria and harnessed the Heart's power. Any conquering that was already being done was allowed to continue, but anything new, he wanted to wait until he had his new toy."

"Friggin' drama queen," Catra growled.

"You'll get no argument from me on that subject," Hordak smirked.

"Eternia," Adora muttered, thoughtful.

"Adora?" Glimmer asked.

"That name popped up a lot when I was working with old First Ones stuff. And there's something else."

"What else?"

"Just…I feel like I have to go there."

Adora cast a look at Catra. Her girlfriend's eyes widened, suddenly getting the same feeling as Adora. A flash of memory, gone as quickly as it came, flickered between them.

look for Eternia

oOo

Over the next two days, supplies were gathered and a solid plan was made. When the time came, the *Starshine* launched out of Etheria's atmosphere. Arrayed around the cockpit were the chosen delegation. Adora sat in the captain's chair out of instinct, with Catra leaning against it and Melog leaning against her. Bow and Entrapta worked the main console. And Glimmer and Scorpia ran over a few talking points.

"So I'll probably end up doing most of the talking, but you should know some of this stuff too," Glimmer was saying.

“Uh-huh, uh-huh, great,” Scorpia nodded, “But, quick question, why me? I’m not good with delicate stuff. In multiple regards.”

Scorpia clacked one pincer as evidence.

“Mermista and Perfuma are busy, and I don’t want Frosta to be on a first contact mission. This requires tact, and she’s not always best at that,” Glimmer said.

“And if all else fails, you look intimidating,” Catra threw in.

“Okay, fair. What about Entrapta? I love her to bits, but I wouldn’t pick her for something this delicate.”

“If we tried to leave her behind, she’d just sneak aboard. And Mara would let her.”

“I actually like her,” Mara piped up, “Since coming to live inside a computer, my mental processes have gotten a lot stronger, more rapid. She can talk at my level.”

“See?”

The trip took a few hours. As they got close, Mara let out a few sensor sweeps.

"I think we can confirm a lot of Hordak's theories," she said, "Atmosphere has the same composition as Etheria—"

"Good, I was worried about that," Adora said.

"Gravity looks the same…hello!"

"I'll say!" Entrapta squealed, "I'm picking up a First Ones energy signature. There's practically a mountain of tech down there, more powerful than Beast Island and the Crystal Castle combined! Eeeee, I'm so excited!"

A beeping noise interrupted Entrapta's squeals.

"Huh, we're receiving a transmission," Bow said.

Mara's holographic form went very still.

"Oh my," she said, her eyes wide.

“What, what’s it say?” Adora asked.

“I’ll let down the drawbridge. Welcome to Castle Grayskull.”

Chapter End Notes

Heck yeah, we’re doing this! Welcome to the second of the three story arcs for Gold Light, Green Light. We’ve dealt with Horde Prime, now let’s see what the Eternia Arc brings us!

Grayskull

Chapter Notes

I keep imagining Tilda Swinton's voice coming out of the Sorceress' mouth. I mean, I was going for Ancient One vibes, so maybe that's it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 13

Grayskull

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The child wailed as the two soldiers took her away. Shadow Weaver stood shock-still, her only movement the constant billowing of her hair from the cantrip she kept up for intimidation purposes. Her senses were screaming at her, telling her that the infant was important.

"This one is different," she said almost to herself.

She turned to Hordak, who was just getting up from his throne.

"Can't you feel it? She has power!"

Hordak just rubbed his forehead, no doubt trying to will away the headache that had come with the girl's cries.

"Fine, take it! Just get it out of here!"

He brushed past his subordinate and made towards a workbench, muttering about needing some peace. Shadow Weaver took the infant from the soldier. She felt so small and fragile in the sorceress' arms. She gently stroked the girl's cheek, and she calmed at the touch, looking up at Shadow Weaver with innocent eyes.

"Don't worry, little one. We're going to do great things together."

As Shadow Weaver started to walk away, throwing thanks at Hordak as she did so, her lord spoke up again.

"By the by, her name is Adora."

"Sir?" Shadow Weaver asked, looking back at him in confusion.

"It was stitched on the blanket," he replied, then turned back to his tinkering.

Shadow Weaver looked down at the infant, who was looking at her curiously. She noted the strange writing on the blanket's edge, but couldn't decipher it. Deciding to take Hordak's word for it, she did a swift mental realignment of nouns.

"Adora…you know, I can't help but wonder where you came from…"

oOo

The word hit her like a thunderbolt. It bounced around in her head like an echo.

Grayskull. Grayskull. Grayskull.

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

Catra's touch brought her back to the present.

"Grayskull's a place? Grayskull's *this* place?" Adora gasped.

"Ooo, plot twist," Entrapta murmured.

“Mara, why didn’t you say anything?”

“Because it wouldn’t have mattered,” Mara replied, her holographic form flickering in distress, “I didn’t think this place still existed! It’s been a thousand years, and the rest of my people clearly died, present company notwithstanding. Even if I had told you about Grayskull, I didn’t believe there’d be more than ruins, so what would have been the point? I mean, we all know what good a shape Light Hope was in. She wasn’t!”

“You still should have said something!”

“Okay, everyone calm down!” Bow thundered, “It’s here, we’re here, that’s what matters. Mara, what can we expect?”

Mara sighed, then waved her hand to bring up an image. The castle was large and foreboding, the front gate shaped like a massive skull.

“Castle Grayskull. It was the high seat of my people in this system, and later, the main base for a rebellion against their tyranny, a rebellion I was part of. Don’t be fooled by the stone exterior, that was just a quirk of the architect. Inside, it’s all First Ones’ tech. A massive repository of science and sorcery, greater than anything else in the quadrant. Even if a fraction of it is still viable, it’d be a fantastic amount.”

Entrapta made a noise like ecstasy.

"Whelp, she's having a joy overload," Scorpia said.

"Do you think the transmission was an automatic response to our presence?" Bow asked.

"If it was just the second sentence, sure, but that bit about the drawbridge makes me think that we'll find someone down there," Mara said.

"And hopefully, someone friendly," Adora said, "Take us in."

oOo

Castle Grayskull loomed before them. It sat at the edge of a massive chasm, the only access point being a small land bridge leading to a lowered drawbridge.

"Easily defensible," Catra muttered.

"A lot grungier than the picture, though," Scorpia said.

“Passage of time, probably,” Glimmer replied.

The crept over the drawbridge and into the castle. The stone walls glowed dimly, the air hummed with potential power, and a cool wind whipped around them briefly.

“Anyone else getting a spooked-out feeling?” Catra asked, grabbing her tail and patting the bristled fur down.

Melog growled in agreement, her mane flickering to red.

“Be ready for anything,” Adora said, summoning her sword.

They strode down the dim hall until the area opened up into a large room. At the other end was an ornate crystalline throne, and seated on the throne was a woman. She was neither old nor young, but somehow seemed both. White of hair, but with no wrinkles to speak of. Her hands looked delicate, but her posture spoke of strength. The most noteworthy detail was her ornate headdress. Feathers trailed down her back, and the headpiece resembled a bird of prey.

Adora’s breath caught in her throat.

“You…you were there…when we beat Prime, you were there!”

The woman smiled.

"Merely an astral projection. Hello, Adora. I've been expecting you."

"Who are you?" Adora breathed.

"My name…that is complicated. Truth be told, I'm unsure you'd be able to pronounce it. You may merely call me by my title, the Sorceress of Castle Grayskull."

There was a peal of thunder through the air, and the visitors jumped. The woman, however, frowned and looked up at the ceiling.

"I thought I turned that off."

She flicked her hand and a spark shot up.

"Sorry about that," she said, rising, "I don't get many visitors, so these things slip, you understand. Come, we have much to discuss."

She casually got up and walked toward the wall to the left. A flick of her hand made the stone shift, a doorway soon appearing. She

walked through without missing a beat.

After a moment, she poked her head back out.

"That means follow me."

The visitors snapped out of their stunned stupor and hurried after her.

"Who even are you?" Catra asked, "How are you doing this with an ancient First Ones ruin?"

"I am the castle's steward, as I have been since I was chosen to be so."

"By who?" Glimmer asked.

"You just brought them up. The…First Ones, you call them? My people had a different name for themselves, but I suppose it doesn't matter now, considering I am likely all that is left of them."

Adora stopped dead, then briefly stumbled forward when Scorpia bumped into her from behind.

"*You're a First One?*" she gasped.

The Sorceress looked back with a smile.

"I look good for my age, don't I?"

She then made a sound like she'd found something, and tapped at the wall. Another doorway appeared, this one letting out into a room much more like the First Ones architecture they were familiar with. The walls were still stone-like, but with veins of crystalline material all throughout. Taking up one wall was a massive collection of crystals, the facets forming a collection of screens. The Sorceress tapped at one facet, and an image appeared. A young woman accepted a familiar feathered headdress from a collection of uniformed men.

"I was much younger then," she said, "I had no idea what was in my future. All I saw was the enormous honor that had been placed on me."

"How are you still alive?" Bow asked.

"My position, of course. I am Castle Grayskull's steward, and so I shall remain until the day I decide to relinquish that position and the power it entails. In the meantime, I enjoy…fringe benefits, let's say. The castle provides, as it always has."

"You say that like it's alive," Glimmer said.

"Not in the traditional sense," the Sorceress demurred, "But…well, all that power and magic coursing through these old stones…it leaves a mark. Deep magic works in mysterious ways. Even those that have studied the mystic arts for a lifetime can still be surprised."

Entrapta quietly squealed and started muttering about various possibilities. The Sorceress smiled at her.

"Yes, perhaps you may discover something new, tinkerer."

She shook herself briefly.

"But we are getting off-track."

She snapped her fingers and the facets projected new images, one with which she told her story.

"The beginning of our relevant story is actually an ending. The ending of a long and bloody civil war that ripped apart a galactic empire. We won't get into the causes now, just know that it had been building for decades, so it was not likely to be resolved quickly. One side of the war began looking for powerful weapons

to tip the balance. Things that could achieve incredible destruction in a short time.”

She pointed at an image of a planet.

“You’re familiar with one, I believe.”

“The Heart of Etheria,” Adora grimaced, “They turned an entire planet into a weapon.”

“And Mara gave everything to stop it,” the Sorceress nodded, “That ended up being a flashpoint in the war. Word spread of the superweapon. Fear and anger gripped the galaxy. The side that had built the weapon, the side that Mara and I fought against, suddenly looked like monsters. Opinions turned, hearts and minds changed, and the tide of war drastically shifted.”

She sighed.

“And then, in the midst of it all, Horde Prime came.”

The Sorceress stared at an image of Prime’s armada, a mixture of anger and sadness on her face.

"I still don't know where he came from. I don't think anyone did. But his presence was apocalyptic. The civil war had already ravaged our empire, left it vulnerable. He rolled over us like a storm, slaughtering all in his path. I will be the first to admit, my people had descended into a horrible place…but even as dark as they'd become, they didn't deserve what Prime had done to them."

There was a moment of silence, a dark mood descending.

"Wait, then how did you escape?" Scorpia asked.

The Sorceress' look turned sly.

"The same way Mara did."

Jaws dropped around the room.

"You were in Despondos?" Entrapta gasped.

"Not technically. But from what I gathered, it was just adjacent to Despondos, somewhere between it and what the Kryptonians called the Phantom Zone. It was to this place that I brought Eternia. However, something went wrong…"

"Let me guess," Adora said, "Mara was tapping into the massive magic of the Heart of Etheria when she did her disappearing act. But you didn't have as much power to work with when you did it."

"Got it in one," the Sorceress replied, snapping her fingers in Adora's direction, "Have a cookie."

A cookie appeared in Adora's hand. She stared at it for a moment before shrugging and biting into it.

"As it was, the transition was very rough, to put it mildly. Eternia had already been battered by war, but sending it to another realm was nearly the end. Life clung to its surface by fingertips, the entire biosphere barely holding on."

One screen showed Eternia, a riot of browns and blacks. Then, a wave of greenish-blue washed over it.

"Thankfully, Grayskull had a solution. Using its knowledge, I altered the flow of time outside the castle, seeding the planet with new life and letting it grow at a rapid pace."

Several screens lit up, showing all kinds of life growing and spreading at a rapid pace. Trees grew tall in seconds, animals grew and changed, and buildings rose up. The image of Eternia shifted back to a vibrant blue and green.

"I saw new creatures crawl out of the boiling oceans and stand tall alongside the remaining people. I saw nations rise and fall. I saw the new people of this planet rediscover the magic of Eternia, combining it with machinery in new and fantastic ways. I watched, I guided from afar, and I did my best to atone for the mistakes of my people."

The Sorceress gazed upon the image of Eternia, a sad look on her face.

"They are my children…sometimes, not even in metaphor."

"You have kids?" Bow and Glimmer chorused.

"Several over the millennia. I'm old, not dead."

"I'm sorry, millennia?" Adora asked.

"For Etheria, it's been one thousand years. But for Eternia, it's been more like six."

Catra swore softly.

"Which brings us to the modern day," the Sorceress said, tapping at one screen and changing the image. A line of purpleish-white

ripped through the sky, a small ship falling out of it.

"Approximately twenty-five years ago, there was a rip in space and time. An explorer from a far-off planet arrived in Eternia, a victim of an accident with attempted wormhole technology."

She paused, frowning.

"I think she called it Zeta beams? That doesn't matter."

"I respectfully disagree," Entrapta interjected.

"Regardless, her arrival sent a shockwave through local time-space, breaking the mechanisms that had been used to alter time and bringing Eternia's aging back into sync with Etheria and the larger universe. The explorer, with no way home, settled on Eternia, specifically the kingdom that spans most of the globe and had taken on the name of the planet itself."

"The kingdom and the planet are named the same? Weird," Glimmer said.

"It suits them. The explorer eventually met the rising king of Eternia, and fell in love."

The Sorceress then showed images of the happy couple, and Adora stumbled back, eyes wide.

She knew these people, she'd seen them in her deepest dreams. And even if she hadn't, the woman looked painfully familiar.

After all, it was the same face she saw in the mirror every morning.

"These are King Randor and Queen Marlena. They are your parents, Adora."

Adora heard a gasp, probably from Glimmer, but it sounded much further away than it should. Everything else tunneled out. She dropped to her knees, tears in her eyes. She reached for the image, her voice catching.

"M—my…my parents?"

The image changed. The queen was sitting up in bed, holding two bundles close. The king stood next to her, looking proud enough to burst. A tiny hand waved from one bundle.

"From the union was born two. Prince Adam…and Princess Adora."

“Princess? Me? And…I have…a brother? A twin brother?”

The Sorceress entered her field of vision, kneeling down before Adora and looking at her sadly.

“I was there. In recent years, I made myself an ally to the rulers of Eternia. I blessed you and your brother on the day of your birth. One month later, you had vanished in the night. I spent years searching for you with my magic, but when I found you, it was too late. You were beyond my power to bring home.”

The Sorceress’ breath briefly caught, but she pushed on, speaking with palpable pride.

“I watched you grow from afar. I watched you stumble and I watched you rise. I watched you encounter suffering and I watched you find love. I watched you become a true hero. I watched you become greater than I ever thought possible. I watched you slay Horde Prime, and in my joy, I ended the spell of separation and brought Eternia back, in the hopes that you would find your way back here.”

She pulled the weeping Adora into a hug.

“Welcome home, sweet child.”

Chapter End Notes

I'm not crying, you're crying!

They Have the Power!

Chapter Notes

Hark! Is that the sound of a twin team-up I hear? Why I do believe it is!
The character designs borrow mostly from the 80s version, with some aspects from the 2000s iteration, with Stratos and Buzz-Off in particular more resembling the latter.
Oh, and He-Man has pants. No particular reason, I was always just put off by the fact he always wears a loincloth. Tarzan makes it work because of where he lives, it's questionable on anyone else.

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 14

They Have the Power!

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It took Adora some time to pull herself together. Even after the tears stopped, she sat against the wall, staring at another projection, a more recent picture of her family. Catra snuggled into her on one side, holding her hand and tracing patterns on the back. Melog had claimed Adora's other side, and Adora absently scratched her ears.

"It doesn't feel real. But there they are. I have parents. I have a brother. I'd always hoped I had family out there, but to see it…"

Catra hummed in reply. It wasn't something she could really relate to. She knew for a fact that her parents had abandoned her, the Horde finding her shortly after. She had no real memories of them, and no desire to try and find out more. It wouldn't have been possible, anyway. The only one who might have known was Shadow Weaver, and she would never have told the truth, even if she hadn't taken her secrets to the grave. Catra only had confirmation of the old explanations thanks to Hordak, but even he didn't have any answers for her, as he'd only read it in reports and never thought to investigate further.

Bottom line, she only knew objectively how hard her love's world had been rocked. But she was there to comfort her all the same.

"So what are you going to do?"

"I'm not sure," Adora said, "I…I think I want to see them? But I just…don't know what I'd say."

Catra thought for a moment before answering.

"Speak from the heart. It'll fall into place."

Melog purred in agreement.

Over to the side, the others were in conversation with the Sorceress.

"Of course, I'll certainly be able to put in a good word with Randor," she said.

"Thank you," Glimmer said, "That'll be a big help, especially since I'm not sure how Adora is going to react to meeting him."

Bow and Scorpia shot a concerned look over at Adora.

"She'll be fine, right?" Bow asked.

"I sure hope so," Scorpia said, "That was a big thing she was just hit with."

Entrapta opened her mouth to add something, probably a request to study Castle Grayskull's workings, but was cut off by something unexpected.

A deep, sonorous ringing echoed through the castle. The Sorceress stiffened at the repeating booming.

"No…not now…"

She raced over to the crystal display, waving her hands before them. A horrific image appeared on the largest one, a skull letting loose an evil laugh.

The Sorceress hissed in distaste and worry.

“Today of all days!”

“What’s going on?” Adora asked, having shot to her feet at the skull’s laughter.

“Skeletor,” the Sorceress replied grimly, “A warlord and powerful sorcerer. He’s obsessed with Grayskull and its secrets, and has many times sought to capture them and conquer all of Eternia.”

“The kingdom or the planet?” Catra asked.

“Yes.”

The Sorceress started to activate more facets, showing Skeletor and a colorful collection of warriors at the head of a most horrific army, a shambling horde of rotted flesh and bone. A cacophony of ghastly moans echoed out, and Skeletor laughed.

"Come, my army of the undead! Today is the day! Grayskull will be mine!"

"An army of reanimated corpses?" Glimmer gasped, "That's some twisted magic."

"Skeletor's not capable of such a feat," the Sorceress said, "Unless…but no, I hid that cauldron away."

"Clearly, he found it," Catra deadpanned.

"While the implications of the magic involved are fascinating, this is very disturbing," Entrapta grimaced.

"Is anyone else going to comment on the fact that he's a skeleton?" Bow muttered, "Or at least has a skull for a head? Anyone else find that odd? No, just me?"

The Sorceress changed the view, and they saw a line of heroic figures standing in the way of the undead army.

A man in heavy and hi-tech-looking armor, the plating on his arms shifting and whirring. A redhaired woman, spinning a staff in readiness. A bird-like man with wings, flexing his taloned hands. A massive man with a unique flat-topped helmet, one foot scraping the ground like a bull. An insectoid warrior, wings buzzing and antennae twitching. A goblin-like creature with red

robes and hat, floating in the air and letting off sparks of power from his hands. A man seemingly formed from plant matter, a carpet of green spreading out beneath his feet.

And at their head, a powerfully-built fighter. He had blond hair, muscles on his muscles, an armored harness across his chest, tight pants that evoked a loincloth in one area, and a silver sword that shone in the sun. Adora's eyes were drawn to the sword, feeling a spark of familiarity. He sat astride a massive cat, green fur and orange stripes, with heavy armor and a mighty roar.

"Who are they?" Bow asked.

"They are the Masters, the guardians of Eternia," the Sorceress said before pointing to each in turn, "Man-At-Arms, Teela, Stratos, Ram Man, Buzz-Off, Orko, MossMan…and astride his Battle Cat, the mighty He-Man."

Adora reached out to the screen depicting the heroes, touching at He-Man's image.

"This one…"

"Should I be jealous, Adora?" Catra snarked, earning a brief smile from Adora before she refocused.

"No, but he's important. I don't know why, though."

The Sorceress looked conflicted for a moment before sighing lightly.

"Well, you'd have found out eventually," she said, "You are not the only bearer of a mystical blade. He is as well, one I crafted for the purpose of creating a guardian for Eternia. There have been a few throughout history to bear the Sword of Power and the mantle of He-Man, but in this modern era…"

A new image formed.

"Adam?" Adora gasped, recognizing her brother.

"By the power of Grayskull!" the image shouted.

And then lightning struck. A bright light flashed, and a mighty warrior stood where Adam had before.

"I HAVE THE POWER!"

"Yeah, that's definitely your brother, Adora," Catra deadpanned.

"We have to help him!" Adora cried out.

“I agree, but where are they and can we get there in time?” Glimmer asked.

“Let me worry about transportation,” the Sorceress smiled.

oOo

“You’ve got the teach me this!” Glimmer cried.

The Etherians were now standing on a circle etched into the floor. Geometric lines formed a glyph within the circle, and it all glowed an eerie light that matched the glow now emanating from the Sorceress’ hands.

“The spell will transport you to a ridge next to the battlefield. That’s as close as I can safely put you,” the Sorceress said, “Now, the cauldron is the source of the undead. In order for Skeletor to keep control of the spellwork, it would have to be nearby. I suggest conscripting Stratos to help find it, then deal with it by any means necessary.”

“While the rest of us help the Masters and keep Skeletor’s attention on the battle rather than his fancy artifact,” Adora nodded.

"One more thing, Adora. Your brother keeps his abilities as He-Man a secret to the general public. He doesn't like to advertise his role as the guardian protector of Eternia. Only family and very close friends know. So keep quiet about it until you know who does and doesn't know already."

"Got it."

There was a flash of light and a great pressure, like strong winds were buffeting them. When the feeling faded, they were standing atop a ridge, looking over the battlefield.

"That's a lot of undead," Bow said.

Adora created a spyglass from her ring and took a brief survey of the field before nodding.

"Okay…Entrapta, get that armored guy back up, it looks like his stuff is damaged. Scorpia, you take down the big hairy guy playing battering ram, he looks like he's Skeletor's main muscle. Bow, covering fire. Glimmer, teleport-spam and put all the bad guys off balance. Catra and Melog, with me, we're going after Skeletor. Let's get to work!"

oOo

Orko fell to the ground, tackled out of the air by one of the undead warriors. The rotting form raised its clawed hand to strike.

Suddenly, a bright green light shone over the battlefield, shining like a lantern from the ridge above him. He was close enough and his hearing was good enough to hear a chant called out.

"Grayskull calls upon me to fight

To defend innocents from their plight

I stand firm against evil's might

I have the power of GREEN LANTERN'S LIGHT!"

And several new fighters charged down the ridge. At their head was a figure in white and green. The figure, a woman with a muscular physique that reminded him of He-Man, suddenly leapt up into the air. Her silver sword was covered in green light, and a hammer shaped itself out of the light. She came down hard with the hammer, making shockwaves across the ground and crushing several undead in a blaze of green-and-gold. Across the battlefield, all action briefly paused from the sheer force of the new players' entrance. Even the undead holding Orko down paused to gawk.

"Well that was unexpected," Orko said.

Then sparks flew from his hand and the undead's head exploded.

Orko lifted himself off the ground, then immediately dodged a blob of toxic green liquid. The snake-like minion of Skeletor, Kobra Khan, had noticed Orko's moment of weakness, and was trying to take advantage of it.

Suddenly, what looked like a boxing glove attached to the head of an arrow rammed into Khan's face, sending him sprawling. Orko whipped his head around, spying a smiling archer nearby.

"And Glimmer said that arrow was a dumb idea," he said smugly, before firing an arrow that expanded into a net to keep Khan down.

oOo

Beast Man was Skeletor's savage right-hand man, his brute strength and ferocity more than a match for most opponents.

The scorpion woman who came charging in from nowhere was clearly not one of those opponents. In fact, loath as he was to admit it, he was struggling to overpower her. The one area he had over her was speed, which let him dodge her tail and deliver rapid strikes. But the woman was built like a stone wall, and shrugged off everything he threw at her.

The scorpion woman lashed out with a claw, which Beast Man dodged and caught, holding it down and away from any harm. With his opponent momentarily off-balance, he lashed out. However, she caught his strike in one claw, only the strength of his hand keeping the claw from snapping shut and causing great damage.

They struggled against each other in a sort of fist lock, each holding a hand of the other and trying to overpower. Then, the woman smiled.

"Hey. You wanna see a magic trick?"

There was a crackling, hissing noise. Then Beast Man toppled over like a fallen tree, his fur standing on end and sparks of static flaking off him like dandruff.

Scorpia smiled.

"I really do love the shocky magic."

oOo

Man-At-Arms was a great warrior, but his real pride was as an engineer. Every part of his amazing armor had been crafted by him, giving great strength and a nigh-inexhaustible array of

weapons. However, thanks to some dirty tricks, it was starting to fail.

Suddenly, what looked like purple hair wrapped around his attacker and flung him away. The other attacker was flipped over the newcomer's head like a toy.

"All about leverage," the new person said, "Hi, I'm Entrapta! I'm here to help you get back on your feet!"

Her hair wrapped around him and dragged him to a rock formation, where they could hide and make hurried repairs. Deciding not to look a gift horse in the mouth, Man-At-Arms went along with the helping hand…even if that hand was exceptionally chatty.

"This armor is just *soooo* fascinating," she said excitedly, "You know, I've made exoskeletons before, but this doesn't seem as strong as the one I made for Hordak—oh wait, I see! Inbuilt weapons systems, you're routing power to multiple functions, not just strength! I could probably help you upgrade the power systems later. Oooo, we have so much to talk about!"

"I did not create this monster," he muttered to himself, "But I may have brought it to life…"

oOo

Glimmer darted around the battlefield, teleporting wildly and lashing out at anything in range. She could see several of the undead pulling themselves together, and knew that none of this would matter until the spell was broken. To that end, in addition to keeping all the evil warriors off balance, she was looking for—there!

She teleported next to the downed bird-man, creating a spell circle with one hand and letting out a stream of sparkling energy with the other, forcing the undead back. Her spell turned into a shield, wrapping around her and the other fighter like a bubble.

She sighed and turned to help the fighter up.

“That’ll hold them off for a bit. Stratos, right?”

“Yes,” Stratos said, ruffling the feathers on his arms, “And you are?”

“My name’s Glimmer. The Sorceress sent us.”

Stratos visibly relaxed, any wariness vanishing.

“So what’s the intel?”

“Skeletor’s using this fancy magic cauldron to raise all these undead. It would have to be nearby, to help him maintain the spell, but if we find it, we can stop it.”

Stratos nodded, then turned and crouched down.

“Climb aboard.”

Glimmer latched into his back and dropped the shield. Stratos took off like a bat out of hell, climbing high into the sky.

“So where do you think?” he asked.

“While I was fighting, I was scanning the undead magically. I think I have enough of a feel to track the magical energy back to its source. Shouldn’t be too hard, it was pretty disgusting. Give me a minute.”

Stratos held their position in the air for a moment before Glimmer gasped.

“Got it! Two miles that way!” she shouted, pointing in one direction.

"Hold on!"

Stratos dove, gaining speed that he quickly turned into forward momentum, zooming off in the direction Glimmer pointed. They were soon above the point, which several undead and a large man with two heads standing guard over the cauldron.

"I'll take out the big guy, you buzz the rest the second I do. With them scattered, they'll be easy pickings," Glimmer said.

"Right."

Glimmer teleported off Stratos' back and right behind the two-headed man, quickly drawing a spell circle.

"By the Fractal Flake, *FREEZE!*"

The spell went off like a bomb, encasing the warrior in a mass of ice. Glimmer huffed from the exertion. While her magic could let her imitate the powers of the other runestones for brief moments, it was exhausting to do, and still a pale imitation of what Frosta was capable of.

Stratos unleashed several dive-bomb attacks, taking out a few of the undead. Glimmer blew apart the rest once she got her wind back. Soon, the two were staring at the cauldron.

"Doesn't look like much," Stratos said.

"That's because you don't have magical senses. Trust me, this thing is horrible," Glimmer shuddered, "So…now what do we do with it?"

"Oh, I have an idea," Stratos grinned.

oOo

It was a little scary how in sync Adora and Catra could be sometimes. They were often like two sides of the same coin. They knew when something was wrong with the other. They knew each other's weaknesses and how to compensate for them. Most others were certain they never even fought.

(Which wasn't entirely true, it was just after so long on opposite sides of a war, they had no desire to have drawn-out confrontations. They worked out their grievances in private)

But however 'scarily in sync' they were in everyday life, it didn't hold a candle to how they were in battle.

She-Ra crushed a group of undead beneath a large hammer. Her hunched form served as a springboard for Catra to leap over the

heads of more, getting behind them and attacking. The attacked undead were hit from both sides and quickly torn apart.

Catra rushed toward her girlfriend, grabbing the outstretched arm and allowing herself to be swung in a circle, clawed feet kicking all the way. From her sword hand, She-Ra unleashed a beam of energy, destroying the undead that were stunned from Catra's kicks.

Catra leapt off Adora's arm and tackled a larger example of undead that had been barreling toward them, cutting its throat. Swords of green light covered her as she worked, preventing any other undead from interrupting her. Then she grabbed one out of the air and used it to decapitate three more.

She-Ra grabbed a crab-like warrior of Skeletor's with a shining green lasso, using him like a flail to destroy more undead before flinging him away. The crab screamed in the air before landing with a thud.

"I'm okay!" he shouted.

He was trampled by more undead charging toward She-Ra.

"Less okay…"

Beams of green light shot off She-Ra's form with every other movement. Catra danced among them as she fought, knowing no fear. They were formed of her love's will, and would never hurt her.

The two grinned at each other for a moment as the undead rallied.

"Pretty poor odds," Adora said.

"Yeah," replied Catra, "Poor things don't stand a chance."

They charged into the fray with synchronized yells.

Truth be told, it wasn't all their good relationship that made them so formidable. During the battle against Horde Prime, Catra had absorbed the strange green-and-gold that was the combined energies of She-Ra and Green Lantern. It was a temporary power-up, and she never showed any sign of retaining the power. But there was a lasting upshot to it all. Adora and Catra retained a sense for each other. They couldn't adequately describe it beyond 'a sense', it seemed to defy description. But they had learned to focus it, resulting in an unbeatable combination in combat.

Poor Melog was practically an afterthought, despite her own link with Catra. But the alien cat was still there, running at their heels

in a massive form and crushing undead under enlarged claws and teeth.

"Fall before the mighty Stinkor!"

A large skunk-man with ugly orange armor leapt out of nowhere, spraying a putrid cloud of foul air at them. Adora gagged on the horrible smell, but Catra had it worse. Her own senses were more powerful, and so the smell was actively painful to her. She fell to the ground, gagging and clawing at her face.

Adora acted quickly, projecting a bubble around them. With a silent command, the foul air was vented out, and clean air replaced it.

"Are you okay?" she asked, worry dripping from her voice.

Catra coughed a few times, gasping for fresh air, but quickly calmed.

"Yeah, yeah I'm fine."

"Good."

Then She-Ra glared absolute ***death*** at the skunk-man.

“Quit picking on my girlfriend!”

A section of the bubble detached and shot forward, ramming into him like the fist of an angry god and sending him flying.

Catra gave another cough and shook her head.

“See, this is why I shot down Vultak’s chemical warfare idea. It’s just not worth it.”

Adora smiled at her, and then the two got back to work.

Soon, they were near their target. They knew they were when a large green cat flew over their heads, flung away by powerful magic.

He-Man stood alone against Skeletor and a darkly-garbed sorceress, holding his sword up to block their powerful magics.

“You help Muscles. The witch is mine.”

Catra stalked forward, her claws at the ready and Melog at her heels, the alien cat the size of a horse and snarling.

Melog hit first, tackling the sorceress away and allowing Catra to follow up, slashing at her chest. The sorceress blocked with her staff, and the two struggled briefly.

"You remind me of the woman who raised me…she was horrible at it, and I hated her. Guess who just volunteered to be a punching bag to help deal with my lingering issues."

The woman snarled.

"Fool! The black magic of Evil-Lyn will destroy you!"

"Did you seriously just refer to yourself in the third person? Also, your name is 'Evil-Lyn'? *Really?* Overcompensating, much?"

Evil-Lyn threw Catra off and fired several bolts of purple energy.

"It's a man's world! You do what you have to in order to succeed!"

"I wouldn't know. My boss is a woman," Catra shot back, easily dodging.

Then Melog took another stab at it, ripping into Evil-Lyn's back. She whipped around and fired a spell, but Melog shrank to avoid it, becoming the size of a house cat.

Then he went for the face.

It was actually funny to watch, seeing the dark sorceress sputter and shriek as she tried to dislodge the ball of fur and hate that had latched onto her head.

She finally did so, her face a mess of small wounds, but Melog suddenly vanished from sight.

She heard laughter behind her, and turned to attack.

"What's wrong?" Catra asked the stunned witch.

"Seeing double?" Catra asked the stunned witch.

"How about triple?"

"Quadruple sounds nice!"

The four Catras laughed like loons as they circled Evil-Lyn jumping about in a mad dance.

"This isn't real," Evil-Lyn gasped.

One Catra slashed her arm, eliciting a yelp of pain.

"Real enough," the Catra said.

The Catras whirled about her, making a string of teasing strikes. Evil-Lyn managed to retaliate, letting loose a bolt of power at one Catra. The Catra turned to smoke when the bolt landed.

"Illusions," she snarled.

"Or are they?" the three Catras said in unison.

The smoke from the burst Catra reformed, turning into flying knives headed straight for Evil-Lyn. She flinched instinctively, throwing up a shield of energy in front of her.

The knives turned to dust upon impact, but the damage was done. The real attack came as an invisible Catra struck at Evil-Lyn's wrist, the pain forcing her to drop her staff. Catra snatched

it out of the air, returning to visibility as she did, and whipped it around and down.

It impacted Evil-Lyn's head with a mighty crack. The wood of the staff splintered against the metallic inserts and spikes of her cap, and the dark sorceress went down like a sack of potatoes.

The other Catras vanished, and Melog trotted up, receiving ear scrtitches for a job well done. Catra tossed the remains of the staff onto the unconscious witch.

"And your hat looks stupid."

Meanwhile, She-Ra leapt between He-Man and Skeletor, her sword pointed right at the dark sorcerer.

"One chance," she said, "Surrender now."

Skeletor made a dismissive noise and waved his staff. The earth before him was ripped up and hurled at the interloper. But she beat the rocks aside with sword and fist, standing there without a scratch when the attack finished.

"What," Skeletor said flatly.

“Oh yeah, I didn’t get to introduce myself.”

Her sword flared green-and-gold. An energy blast that knocked Skeletor back several feet.

“I’m She-Ra. I’m here to kick your ass.”

“A female He-Man?” Skeletor hissed, “What even is my life?”

He fired a bolt of black energy from his staff, but She-Ra jumped into the air and didn’t come back down.

“Wait, what?” Skeletor gasped.

He-Man recovered from his shock first, and rammed into Skeletor, sending the sorcerer flying. A burst of power arrested the momentum and let Skeletor briefly float, but then She-Ra dove down from the sky and slammed him into the ground.

Skeletor conjured a sword into his off-hand and stabbed at She-Ra, who nimbly dodged. Then he used the sword to block a blow from He-Man and his staff to block a similar one from She-Ra.

“Well, this is getting sticky,” he muttered.

“You want to see a magic trick?” She-Ra asked, and then several shining green swords appeared around her.

Skeletor swore and twisted out of the blade-lock, doing his best to dodge the barrage of glowing swords that She-Ra was throwing at him.

“That’s a fun trick,” He-Man said.

“Magic ring,” She-Ra replied, “Makes energy constructs and shields. Also flying, but I’m not as confident with that.”

Skeletor let off a barrage of dark magical blasts, which spurred the heroes into action. She-Ra dodged and shielded, while He-Man charged forward, his sword flashing out and deflecting the blasts as he barreled through. Skeletor blocked his rival’s blow with his sword, backed by a magical shield. Then he gestured with this staff and darkness burst from his form.

“You cannot fight what you cannot see, fools!” he cackled as the shadows engulfed the immediate area.

Then a beacon of green light flared, casting the darkness away.

“No evil shall escape my sight,” She-Ra grinned.

Green light became a hail of daggers, flying toward Skeletor like a swarm of bees. He erected a magical shield, and the daggers thunked against it, barely blocking the blades of will made manifest.

Then He-Man let loose a herculean punch and shattered the shield. His fist continued to sail through, slamming into Skeletor's bony face.

Skeletor staggered back in horrible pain, then She-Ra was behind him. Having made a great leap to land behind the wheezing warlord, she spun and lashed out with a powerful kick, sending him tumbling forward.

Skeletor groaned and slammed his staff on the ground, causing the earth to erupt around him and giving him some space as the heroes backpedaled.

"You brutes won't have me!" he shouted, conjuring a snake made of fire to attack his enemies.

"Brutes?" She-Ra asked, creating a giant axe to decapitate the snake, "Is that the best you have?"

"Must be an off day for him," He-Man replied, picking up a particularly large rock from the recent earth-shattering and

throwing it at Skeletor.

Skeletor let loose a blast of magic, pulverizing the rock, then fired another at He-Man. He-Man swung his sword, smacking the blast away.

Skeletor erected a wall of earth between then, but knew that wouldn't slow his enemy down for long. He quickly sidestepped She-Ra's attack, conjuring a string of evil energy that wrapped around her like a constricting snake.

"Let's see you get out of that!"

"Okay."

She-Ra's form flared with emerald energy, and the evil bonds were blasted apart.

"But if we're moving on to rope tricks…"

A lasso of green light ensnared the stunned Skeletor, and She-Ra swung him like a flail at the earthen wall. Skeletor slammed into it hard, partially embedded in the rocky barrier. Then He-Man's fist erupted out of the wall next to him and dragged him through.

Skeletor was flung to the ground, but quickly got to his feet.

"I'll give him this. Guy's got a high pain tolerance," She-Ra said, jumping to the top of the crumbling wall.

"I smack him around often enough, he should," He-Man laughed.

Skeletor unleashed a burst of energy, the black light flying like a swarm of glass shards. He was intending to bury his foes under the sheer amount of energy projectiles, but again, She-Ra shielded, the energy of the Green Lantern more than enough to guard against the black magic.

Skeletor grit his teeth. It was becoming clear to him that he was likely to lose this fight if it kept up like this.

"Cheating it is," he growled before raising his voice, "Undead, attend me!"

Several undead swiveled their heads toward where their master had called. With a moan, several took a step toward him…

and then collapsed in a heap on the ground.

The same was true all over the battlefield. Like a wave rolling over a beach, the undead stiffened and then fell in droves. Soon, the only ones still standing were the protectors of Eternia, the newcomers from Etheria, and Skeletor's minions.

It was the crab-man Clawful, still woozy from his earlier trampling, who spoke up first.

"Wait…what just happened?"

A sparkle of light and sound answered that question.

"Hi, I'm Glimmer, this is my new friend Stratos. We decided to take a quick trip behind enemy lines. We found this really neat dark magic cauldron, and…what did we do with it, again?"

"We dropped it in a volcano," Stratos said, grinning.

"Oh, right!" Glimmer chirped with a smile like a crocodile, "That was fun."

Skeletor's face couldn't turn red, but it made an admirable attempt as he started to storm toward Glimmer.

"You…you…when I get my hands on you, I am going to turn your heartstrings into floss and your skull into a goblet!"

Then a giant green fist wrapped around him

"I'm sorry, I think you forgot I was here. What were you saying you were going to do to my best friend whom I love like a sister?"

Skeletor made a sound like a stepped-on mouse.

"That's what I thought. Have a nice trip, see you next fall!"

She-Ra turned and threw an imaginary ball in a smooth motion. Her conjured fist copied the motion, pitching Skeletor over the horizon. The sorcerer screeched the whole way.

The rising Beast Man, his fur still frizzy, sounded a retreat, grabbing the insensate Evil-Lyn as he ran. The rest of the villains beat a hasty retreat.

"I guess we're letting them go, then?" Scorpia asked.

"I don't think they're going to be a threat for awhile," Man-at-Arms replied.

He-Man, meanwhile, was hunched over, laughing his butt off.

"That was a beautiful throw! And that squeak he made? I'm so glad I saw that, I don't even care that that probably didn't kill him!"

"Seriously, what is he made out of?" She-Ra asked.

"Stupid," Ram Man and Teela replied in unison.

Catra casually strode over and jumped onto She-Ra's back, wrapping her arms and legs around the strong body and giving a pleased purr.

"I take it you had fun," She-Ra said.

"Oh, loads," she said, hooking her chin over her girlfriend's shoulder, "I got to break a magic staff over a witch's head, so I'm having a good day."

"Pretty sure the only ones not having a good day are Bonehead and his Merry Band of Morons."

“Ooo, snarky! I have taught you well.”

“So, who are you guys again?” Orko asked, “And why do you have what looks like He-Man as a girl?”

“It’s a long story,” Bow replied.

Where I Come From

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 15

Where I Come From

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"A diplomatic envoy?" Man-at-Arms asked, one eyebrow raised.

"Kicked a lot of ass for diplomats," Stratos muttered.

"The Sorceress of Grayskull met us as we landed," She-Ra said, "She's the one who told us about Skeletor's threat. She'll vouch for us."

A falcon's cry pierced the air. Everyone looked up, seeing a majestic bird of prey circling overhead. It swooped down and landed on Teela's shoulder.

“Hello?” she said hesitantly.

“Isn’t that one of the Sorceress’ pets?” Moss Man asked, “Or would you call it a familiar?”

“Perhapz a mezzenger?” Buzz-Off hummed.

The falcon preened Teela’s hair briefly, then jumped off her shoulder and glided over to Glimmer. Glimmer stretched out her arm, letting the bird land on it. The falcon chirped happily.

“Well, I think that settles that!” Orko said, rubbing his hands together, “Everyone get close, I’ll whip up a teleport circle.”

“Need a hand?” Glimmer asked as the falcon leapt off her arm and flew away, “I’m a spellcaster myself.”

“Sure, I might need it. There’s more people here than I usually have to work with.”

“Then maybe I’ll lighten the load,” He-Man said, “I can make my own way.”

He whistled, and the massive Battle Cat loped up. He-Man mounted the tiger like a horse.

“See you all later.”

And with that, he rode off.

“Kind of abrupt,” Scorpia said.

“He does that,” Ram Man explained.

“I think I’ll fly off myself,” Stratos said, “You know teleporting makes me nauseous.”

Buzz-Off nodded in agreement.

“See you back at the castle, then,” Man-at-Arms said.

Stratos and Buzz-Off walked away for take-off space and spread their respective wings.

“After you, Bugeyes.”

“Age before beauty, Featherz.”

The two took off, chattering all the way.

"They always do that," Ram Man explained.

"A little more…and there!" Orko said.

"This is an interesting sigil," Glimmer said, observing the glyph drawn in the dirt.

"Okay, everyone pile on. Next stop, Eternia Central!"

Everyone walked onto the drawn glyph, and with a gesture from Orko, they vanished in a plume of smoke.

oOo

They landed in the castle courtyard, right in front of the two members of Eternia's hero team that had elected to remain behind to protect the castle, the extendable hero Mekaneck and the split-personality warrior Man-E-Faces. Man-At-Arms and Teela led the newcomers to the throne room, where King Randor and Queen Marlena were waiting.

The king was a tall, well-muscled man. It was very clear from his physique and the way he carried himself that he was once a warrior himself. His hair and thick beard were blonde of a shade that had one member of the visiting party inhaling sharpy at. The queen, on the other hand, was willowy and red of hair. Her face was strikingly familiar to all the visitors.

"Well, it looks like we won't need to explain that much," Glimmer said.

Settled on the arm of the queen's throne was another falcon, eagerly accepting pets from the queen. She and her husband were reading over a letter. The king gave the newcomers a wry grin.

"Indeed not. The Sorceress can work quite fast when she needs to."

"How many of those birds does she have?" Entrapta murmured a touch too loudly, and Scorpia bumped her shoulder to remind her to focus.

Glimmer strode forward, beginning her introductions.

"I am Queen Glimmer of the kingdom of Bright Moon on the planet of Etheria. We come to you under a flag of peace in the hopes of forging diplomatic ties between our long-lost sister planets."

“Yes, an entirely different planet that had, until recently, been stuck in pocket of space-time outside the normal universe,” Queen Marlena chuckled, “You know, if it weren’t for my own background, I’d call this a fantasy brought on by too many drinks.”

“Truth is stranger than fiction,” Glimmer laughed back, “My companions are Master Archer Bow…”

Bow gave a little wave.

“She-Ra, Princess of Power…”

“I believe myself and your He-Man have much to talk about,” She-Ra said.

“And how,” Catra muttered.

“My advisor, Catra, and her companion Melog…”

Melog gave an echoing meow as a greeting.

“Princess Scorpia of the Scorpion Kingdom…”

“It is an honor to be here,” Scorpia said, giving a slight bow.

“And Princess Entrapta of Dryl.”

Scorpia had to nudge Entrapta to get her to bow as well.

“Your party is well met, Queen Glimmer,” King Randor said, “We welcome you under the ancient laws of hospitality. And I look forward to forging ties with the realms of Etheria.”

Catra exchanged a grin with her girlfriend.

“I think this is going well,” she said quietly, then stepped forward at Glimmer’s beckoning.

The queen and her advisor laid some groundwork with the king and queen for further diplomatic talks, then King Randor called a halt to the proceedings.

“There will be plenty of time to discuss things in more detail in the coming days. For now, you are all likely weary from the journey and the battle, and we have much to celebrate. Skeletor has been soundly defeated and Eternia has herself new allies. This calls for celebration.”

He turned to his queen with a smile.

"My dear, how fast do you think we can get a feast set up?"

"Let's find out," Queen Marlena replied with a grin.

oOo

As it turned out, a feast could be set up pretty quickly, given the right motivation. Soon, the royals, nobles, knights, and Masters of Eternia were celebrating, and the visitors from Etheria were getting swept up in the mood. Everyone mingled around the multiple tables of the grand dining hall, seated with no regard to status.

"Wait, what's this called?" Bow asked, eying the cheesy object on the plate.

"It's called pizza," Ram Man said, setting the plate down in front of him, "It's a creation the queen introduced. A little something from her homeland. Try it."

Bow gingerly picked up the slightly greasy food and took a bite. He stopped chewing after a second.

"Well?"

"*It's wonderful*," Bow squeaked, his mouth full of food and his eyes filled with sparkles.

A ways down the table, Entrapta chirped at the sight of some honeyed buns, despite the size being larger than she liked. But as she reached for one, a blur of green snatched it away. Entrapta blinked in shock.

"Why did it buzz?"

"Yeah, you need to be careful with those when Buzz-Off is around."

Entrapta turned to see a man sitting down next to her. It took her a minute to place him, but that mustache was hard to mistake. For his part, he eyed her plate, which was piled with little hors d'oeuvres, bits of vegetables, tiny wieners, and slices of cheese.

"You sure you don't want anything more substantial?"

"I like tiny food," Entrapta replied simply, "You're shorter without the armor."

“That tends to happen,” he replied with a wry grin before sticking out his hand, “Duncan, the Man-At-Arms.”

One of Entrapta’s pigtails returned the shake.

“Princess Entrapta.”

If he was taken aback by the hair, he didn’t show it, instead asking what the story was behind it.

Glimmer, meanwhile, was seated next to her fellow queen, with her new friend Stratos right across from them.

“I’m sorry, seagull?” Queen Marlena asked.

“Yeah, I’m with the queen,” Stratos said, “How does he speak seagull?”

“I’m not sure,” Glimmer shrugged, “He claims that Mermista taught him, but that’s it. She can naturally communicate with all manner of sea life, but I don’t know where seagulls enter the picture for her.”

"I mean, I can talk with birds, but that's an instinctive knowledge due to my heritage," Stratos continued, "I didn't think it was learnable."

"I stopped trying to figure out Sea Hawk a *long* time ago."

"I've known people like that," Queen Marlena muttered.

Between bites of a vegetable soup, Scorpia was describing Perfuma to Moss Man. The plant-man seemed interested in a fellow floral fighter.

"I must meet this woman."

"We would have invited her, but she was really busy this week," Scorpia said, "Something about a potato blight? Whatever the case, it was going to take up a lot of time to deal with the fallout."

"If the problem is that widespread, I can imagine," Moss Man shrugged.

And at another table, King Randor was deep in conversation with Catra.

"If Dryl is as small as you say, why is it counted among the major powers?" he asked.

"Two reasons," Catra replied, passing a bit of meat to a begging Melog, "One, it's seated on a very ore-rich mountain range. Dryl metal has very good quality, and kingdoms all over consider it a commodity. The second reason is honestly Entrapta herself. She might not be super-magical like other princesses, but she is scary-smart. The technology she's developed has been revolutionary, and with some of the stuff coming out of her workshop now thanks to reverse-engineering old Horde tech, that's going to get even better."

"This is the third time you've mentioned this Horde. What are they?"

"Not really important anymore," Catra replied, "But for a long time, they were a powerful force on Etheria, a war-state that was sweeping over the land. They've fallen, but the scars remain."

"How did they fall? Did their leader die?"

"That's a long story. And no, Hordak's still around. But after the mental thrashing he took in the final days, he was pretty well defanged. He's had no desire to start things back up, spends most of his time helping Entrapta with projects. The two are weirdly close."

King Randor looked over, seeing Duncan talking animatedly with Entrapta.

"Should I be concerned about what she and the Man-At-Arms might get up to?"

"Depends. How much self-control does your knight have and how often does his stuff blow up?"

The king calmed a little.

"I trust Duncan. He's a good man."

Milling about in the room, She-Ra drifted between one conversation and another, looking for an opening to talk to the royals privately. She finally managed to coral Prince Adam, who had showed up a little late. She tried not to immediately let on that she knew exactly why he was tardy, remembering the Sorceress' warning. He offered to pull his mother away, leaving the king for She-Ra.

"Mind if I cut in?" she asked, interjecting into the conversation between Catra and King Randor, "Your Majesty, may I talk to you in private?"

Catra got an understanding look on her face.

“Do you—”

“No, I don’t think so.”

Catra shrugged.

“Okay, but I’m here if you need me.”

Her transformed girlfriend gave her a nod of thanks.

oOo

“So what’s this about?” Prince Adam asked.

Adam had directed them to a room used for meetings, which She-Ra felt suited their purposes well, considering the subject matter. For himself, the blonde prince kept himself ready. There was something about the warrior princess that had his instincts blaring. Something had been poking at his brain ever since encountering her as He-Man, but he wasn’t sure what it was beyond a feeling like he should know this person.

She-Ra took a deep breath, trying to quell the nervousness. It must not have worked, because Queen Marlena picked up on it.

"Are you alright?"

"This is…uh, hard to explain," She-Ra said.

She remembered the conversation she'd shared with Catra earlier.

"Speak from the heart," she muttered, then dove right in.

"Okay, confession time," she said, "This isn't the first time our worlds have had contact."

"What do you mean?" Adam asked, but She-Ra was staring right at the king and queen.

"Adam isn't your only child. You had a little girl once. But she disappeared."

The queen froze, and the king stood straighter.

“How do you know this?” he growled, his posture and voice defensive.

“Because that child, through mystical means that we still can barely understand, ended up on Etheria, where she was raised by a warlord. But nearly seventeen years later, she found a magic sword. She found out the dark truth about the people who raised her. And she chose the path of a hero.”

There was a bright light, and She-Ra was gone.

“I know, because I was that child,” said Adora, tears starting to brim in her eyes, “And for the longest time, I wondered where I came from…until I came here.”

Randor stepped back like he’d been struck. Adam’s jaw dropped. Marlena gasped.

“Adora…my baby…?”

Adora looked at the queen, *her mother,* now opening crying.

“Hi.”

Marlena practically leapt across the room and hugged her long-lost daughter.

"You look like me," she gasped out, "You…Adora!"

The menfolk just stared, still in shock as to all this. Adam was the first to speak.

"I…have a sister?"

Adora gave a tearful smile over her mother's shoulder.

"It's nice to meet you," she said, "I hear we have a few things in common. Like super-strength."

Adam started laughing. He wasn't sure why, it wasn't overly funny. Maybe it was just the emotion of the moment.

The queen finally broke the hug, cradling her daughter's face in her hands.

"I thought I'd never see you again," she whispered, "You've… gotten so big!"

Randor finally made his way over, looking at Adora unblinkingly. Just as it was starting to get awkward, he spoke up.

"You have your mother's eyes."

"And your hair, apparently," Adora replied, running a hand through her own.

Randor briefly stroked his beard, chuckling.

"This shouldn't be so awkward."

"Now I'm actually glad Catra didn't come with me," Adora started giggling, "She'd have held this over me for ages. I love her with all my heart, but she can be kind of mean sometimes."

Adam snorted, then paused.

"Now, when you say 'love her with all your heart', what does that mean?"

"It means I like girls. Is that a problem?"

"Shouldn't be," Marlena spoke up, "I'm bisexual myself. Boys, girls, I'm good with either."

She briefly waved at her husband.

"This lump is just lucky I lean towards men about seven out of ten times."

"Considering Adora and I wouldn't be here if you didn't, I think we're just as lucky," Adam snorted.

"So should I give Catra the shovel talk when I talk to her next?" Randor asked, "That's what fathers do, right? Threaten our daughter's significant other to treat them right or else?"

"Sorry, Dad. Glimmer beat you to it," Adora laughed, privately marveling at how easily the word slipped from her tongue.

"Damn."

Marlena took Adora's hand in her own.

"I want to know everything. Leave nothing out. Your life, your friends, Catra, She-Ra, *everything*."

"It's a long story."

"Think we'll be able to make time," Adam said, pulling out a chair.

"Okay," Adora said, taking a seat at the table, "It starts, unfortunately, with a woman called Shadow Weaver…"

Over the following hours, Adora told her story, her family interjecting at certain points with questions or comments. Adam in particular was curious about the similarities between He-Man and She-Ra.

"I'm guessing since you didn't out me that the Sorceress told you I keep things quiet?" he asked.

"Yeah, she did," Adora replied, "Something about only family and close friends?"

"That's about right. I sort of fell into the secret identity thing, honestly. I just…wanted to keep both sides separate unless it was people I trusted, you know?"

"I get it. That was never a choice with me, and I've met a lot of people in Etheria who think of me as She-Ra first. My friends do their best not to put me on too high a pedestal, but…you know…"

“People treat you different,” Marlena nodded, “I went through the same thing when it was clear that what Randor and I had was serious. It took some getting used to.”

At her mother’s urging, Adora left few stones unturned. She’d skimmed over certain details, like what exactly Shadow Weaver did to her and Catra, the portal affair, and other sensitive material, but most everything else was open season.

Randor seemed to pick up on just how much was being held back about Shadow Weaver, and at one point muttered something about finding out how to raise her from the dead so he could kill her again. Adora felt her heart warm at that utterance, happy that he was so readily putting himself in her corner. It was nice.

When the story was finished, it was fairly late. In the royal’s absence, Duncan and a few advisors had helped close out the party as it wound down. So Marlena took it upon herself to show Adora to a room, Catra joining them as they were exiting the meeting room.

“Hey, Adora. How’d it go?” she asked.

“I think you can guess,” Adora snorted.

Marlena looked Catra up and down with a critical eye.

“You’re the one making my daughter happy?”

“We’re there for each other,” Catra replied, “Always will be.”

“Good answer. Will you be sharing a room?”

“Please and thank you,” Adora said.

She gave them both a look that had them standing up a little straighter.

“I’m trusting you to be responsible adults. Don’t make me regret it.”

“Yes, ma’am,” they said in unison.

As Marlena led them to a room, Adora turned and whispered to Catra.

“She’s definitely a mom. Queen Angella used to give off the same vibe.”

"*Way* better than Shadow Weaver," Catra nodded.

oOo

Adam rose early, as was his way. He got dressed in some simple clothing and went for a jog around the castle parapets. It was a usual sight, enough that the early-shift guard merely nodded at him in greeting.

What wasn't usual was the cat-girl on the western keep.

Adam stared at the disruption to his morning routine. What was strange was that she wasn't doing anything overtly negative. Rather, she was going through a series of slow, graceful movements. Her eyes were closed and her breathing was even. One ear flicked in Adam's direction.

"Morning."

"Morning," Adam said hesitantly, not sure what to make of this sight, "Catra, right? Adora told me about you."

"All good things, I hope?" Catra asked, her tail flicking playfully even as she continued her movements.

"Mostly good. There was a point where you were on opposite sides of the war, but things are better now?"

"I had a rough life, and when Adora left the Horde, I spiraled. Not my best work in the long term."

Catra finally stopped her exercise and opened her eyes, looking towards Adam.

"You're up early."

It was a change in subject, but Adam let it slide.

"Morning jog around the castle. I could say the same to you."

"Same, but I wanted to mediate first. This mountain air is really calming for that."

"*That* was meditation?"

"I can't sit still long enough for traditional meditation, and if I do, I tend to either daydream or brood, but our friend Perfuma helped me create a sort of movement-based technique. Lots of stretching and flowing from one posture to another, controlled breathing, that sort of thing. Helps with my anxious streak."

Catra gave a self-deprecating laugh.

"Didn't make it easy for her. Took a month before I could consistently clear my mind, but the new technique helped immensely."

"I imagine so. Join me?"

"Sure, Muscles. I can share embarrassing stories about Adora's youth."

Adam got a gleam in his eye.

oOo

Adora entered the dining hall. It seemed that this was a room with many purposes, such as where the castle's many residents took their breakfast.

Hearing a familiar laugh, she zeroed in on the source.

"She did that?"

“She did! And then we bolted so Octavia wouldn’t catch us!”

Catra and Adam seemed to be dining together, and from the sound of it, trading stories and bonding. The subject of the conversation was apparently Adora. Adora herself was torn between joy at her girlfriend and her brother getting along and fear at exactly what Catra had been telling him.

Thankfully, she had a good way to change the subject.

“Mouse!”

“Where?!”

Catra bolted upright, her tail raised and her claws out.

Adora cracked up as she made her way over.

“That’s always funny!”

Catra groaned and muttered “Every time…lucky I love you, idiot…”

“Any breakfast recommendations?” Adora asked.

“Platter of pancakes at the end of the table, if you’re inclined,” Adam answered.

Adora made a cheerful noise and darted off to grab a few.

“You just made her morning,” Catra said.

Adora came back shortly after, her pancakes covered in a number of cut strawberries.

“That’s a lot of berries,” Adam commented.

“After a childhood filled with things that could barely be called food, I developed a powerful love of sweet things,” Adora replied, cutting into her pancakes.

“What do you mean by that?”

“Horde food was…well, it supposedly provided all the essential nutrients, but the taste left something to be desired.”

“Weird stews, freezer-burned veggies, mystery meat…hey, remember that yellow slop?” Catra asked, giggling.

Adora groaned and laughed in equal measure.

“Oh gosh, that was so horrible, even by the usual standards! Only Rogelio really liked it!”

“Lizard man had no taste buds, I swear.”

“I remember when it finally ended. You stuck your fork in a pile of it, turned your plate upside down, and slapped it.”

“The stuff didn’t even move!”

“That’s horrifying,” Adam interjected.

“Try imagining having to eat it,” Adora replied.

“I am, that’s what’s so horrifying.”

“Naturally, because I’m doing a thing, Shadow Weaver shows up,” Catra continued, “Bossy bitch tells me not to play with my food.

Then Adora stands up, glares at her, and says—"

"It's not food if it's cemented to the plate!"

"Her voice carried through the entire cafeteria, and suddenly, everyone was glaring at Shadow Weaver. It was beautiful!"

"Two days later, the slop was off the menu and we never saw it again," Adora finished.

"I weep for your childhood nutrition," Adam said.

"I told Glimmer the story early on. She and her mom dragged me to Bright Moon's doctors to make sure I didn't have some kind of lingering issues from all that terrible food. I was fine, some vitamin deficiencies aside, and they gave me a special drink to have with my breakfast for a few weeks."

"Glimmer did the same for me," Catra said, "I was a bit better off because my system processes things a little differently. Like, a cat can go a few days without food with little repercussions, that sort of thing? Basically, I only had to drink that junk for a few days, and that was just to be safe."

"Glimmer worries," Adora said nonchalantly.

“Oh hello Pot, have you met my friend Kettle?”

“Bite me.”

“Maybe later, and only if you’re good.”

Adora blushed like a tomato. Catra laughed and got up, pecking Adora on the cheek.

“I’m going to go wash up. See you in a bit.”

As Catra left, Adora noticed Adam smiling at her.

“What?”

“Nothing, just…you two seem happy.”

Adora softly smiled.

“Yeah…we are. What about you? Anyone special?”

"Not really," Adam said, "Although everyone jokes that Teela and I might end up together because of how long we've been friends."

"And what do you think?"

"I think if I ever did pursue her like that, I'd better have a better reason than a hunch. She'd probably cut me if she thought I was doing it on a lark."

"Well, at least you're informed," Adora shrugged, "Maybe it'll be like me and Catra and you'll fall into each other after a traumatic event that forces you to look back on your past in a new light and realize what's been there all along. Who's to say?"

"You said that so casually," Adam said, giving her a look, "It concerns me. Should I be concerned?"

"I don't think so. We go to therapy, so whatever issues we have, we're working on. Honestly, I'm glad our friends insisted on it. I don't think either of us would be in as good a shape without it, especially after the nightmare that was Horde Prime."

Adam kept looking at her oddly, but changed the subject. They spent the rest of the breakfast talking over their food.

Adora would later comment how easily they seemed to slip into a camaraderie. Adam chalked it up to it being a twin thing,

regardless of their long separation.

oOo

"…Let those who worship evil's might,

Beware my power, Green Lantern's light."

Adora let out a breath as her ring finished charging.

"I got chills watching that," a squeaky voice suddenly said.

Adora whipped around, her ring flaring with light, but she calmed upon seeing her father and Orko peering in from the door.

"What was all that about?" King Randor asked.

"The ring isn't like mine or Adam's sword," Adora said, picking the lantern up, "It needs to be recharged regularly. Thankfully, it comes with both a battery and a sort of pocket space I can put it in."

Adora promptly did so, causing Orko to whistle.

"That's impressive. I still can't manage a magical pocket, and I've been practicing for longer than you've been alive. And you said the ring just came with it?"

Adora regarded the ring briefly.

"The ring comes with a lot of things. Some of which I'm still not sure I'm getting the full details of. Thankfully, the basics, like the oath, seem to be pretty easy."

"I presume this oath is like an incantation to recharge the ring?" Randor asked, to which Adora nodded.

"Funny, that's not the incantation I heard when you were coming down the ridge," Orko said.

"You heard that?"

"These aren't just for show," Orko replied, flicking at one of this long, pointed ears.

"Well, that was more of a personal oath, one I made. The lantern responds better to the one it came with. I still haven't figured out how to change the settings."

"And how did you find that ring?" the king asked, "You weren't really clear on that."

"Actually, it found me. And if I wasn't clear, it's just that there's still a lot I don't know."

Adora created an image of the Lantern sigil, letting it float above her hand.

"I know that there exists a larger force in the universe, a collection of peacekeepers called the Green Lantern Corps. Each member has one of these rings, and they must be chosen from all walks of life on all kinds of planets, if how this ring came to me was any indication. I know they are all chosen for powerful will and courage. And I also know that this ring's journey was a rough one, so it's unable to properly connect to the rest of the Corps. That and…"

Adora dismissed the image with a sad look.

"I can't help but feel a part of something larger, but that larger thing is half-dead. I know so little about the Corps, really. Just bits and pieces I've picked up here and there. But Horde Prime knew of them, and he made it sound like they were a dying organization, like they'd been through a bunch of crises and they were barely holding on. That kind of makes me feel like it would take a miracle to get any real answers."

“Think he was lying?” Orko asked.

“Psychopath seemed pleased about it, so no.”

“The more I hear of this Horde Prime, the more I feel he was worse than Skeletor,” King Randor said.

“Well, does Skeletor go in for mass mind control?”

“No.”

“Then Horde Prime was worse.”

“If it makes you feel better, I know how you feel,” Orko said, “My people are diaspora on Eternia. I’m lucky to have met four others like me, and two of them were my parents so they barely count.”

Light covered Orko’s hand briefly.

“Once, we were powerful in magic. Now, most of us are shadows of what we were.”

"Yes, I remember you joining us in hopes of finding others of your kind," Randor said, "You know we will never stop looking, my friend."

"And I appreciate it, but sometimes, it all feels like a false hope, you know?"

Randor gave a bark of laughter.

"Orko, it's *hope*. How can it be false?"

Adora laughed lightly.

"That's good. Can I borrow that?"

"By all means. You shouldn't give up hope either. You'll find the Corps one day."

Adora smiled.

oOo

"Pass me that wrench?"

"Sure. I think I'm almost done with these new power relays."

"Great. Hopefully that weapon Clawful had that caused so much damage won't be useful again."

"I did wonder about that," Entrapta said, "This is some pretty advanced stuff. I'm surprised that it got so damaged."

"Nine times out of ten, my gear is able to take anything that's thrown at it," Duncan replied with a frown, "But then there's the tenth time."

The two continued to work, repairing the armor of the Man-At-Arms and trading other ideas as they worked. Scorpia had looked in on them at one point, then quickly ducked back out at all the technical talk she was hearing.

"And I'm sure we can rig up a way for our planets to talk to each other. Maybe a comm buoy somewhere in the middle of our orbits? I don't know, I'll have to ask Hordak for ideas, he came from an interstellar empire, he'd know."

"You care about this Hordak," Duncan said sagely, "You mention him a lot. I think you've brought him and his armor up at least a dozen times while we've been working. There are parallels, I admit, but still…"

Entrapta was silent for a moment before softly saying, "I'm going to marry that man someday…when he's ready…"

Then she suddenly grew self-conscious.

"I mean, he used to be in a cult, and they didn't have a concept of marriage or similar binding ceremonies. And when he was running his own army, he doesn't do it anymore, such things weren't the norm. I'm told that relationships existed in the Horde, but everyone kept it to themselves, bindings and the like weren't done. I do think it'll be good for us both, but like everything, I have to ease him into the idea. He can be very stubborn and prideful, poor thing stumbled over himself the first time he gave me an honest compliment, it was so cute I eventually threw him a bone, and it took ages before I could get him to dance with me without it feeling awkward, good thing sex doesn't interest either of us, because that'd be—"

"Good for you, kid," Duncan replied, cutting the ramble off, "I'm sure whatever your plan is, it'll be fine."

Entrapta took a breath and smiled.

"Thanks. Wait, what do you mean kid? I'm in my thirties."

Duncan gawked at her.

“How?”

“Good genes, I guess,” Entrapta shrugged, “Although sometimes I do wish I was taller.”

oOo

“And I think that covers almost everything,” Marlena said, “It’ll have to be slow going until we get proper communication lines and transport up, but everything starts somewhere.”

“Great,” Glimmer said, leaning back in her chair, “No offense, but sometimes, this diplomacy stuff is exhausting.”

“I know the feeling,” Marlena said, “It took me ages to get used to it. Management on this scope wasn’t something my old job really prepared me for.”

Glimmer hummed a bit, then got an odd look on her face.

“Do you miss it? Your old world, your old life?”

Marlena sobered.

“Sometimes. I suffered from a lot of depression when I first came here, and it came back with a vengeance after Adora disappeared. But honestly, if I could go back and do it all over again, I wouldn’t change a thing.”

Marlena got up and walked over to the window, looking out over the castle’s courtyard.

“I saw the stars. I fell in love. I had a wonderful son. And while losing my daughter was hard, she grew up into an amazing woman. I couldn’t be prouder of my children.”

Glimmer got up and walked over to the window. Below, Scopria and Ram Man were sparring. The two, the muscle of their respective teams, seemed to be enjoying a chance to cut loose. Nearby Bow was speaking with Teela and MossMan, the three having an animated conversation between cheering on the spar. Adam, Adora, and Catra strode into the courtyard, and Bow waved them over, a smile on his face.

“I like to think my mom is proud of me,” Glimmer said quietly, “We didn’t always see eye-to-eye, but whenever I doubt myself, I imagine her encouraging me, telling me to hold on a little longer.”

“That’s what mothers do, I suppose,” Marlena asked.

Adora's laugh echoed up to them.

"Is Adora happy? Her life hasn't been easy on her. I can tell she was holding a lot back when she told us her story."

"Yeah, she's had a rough ride," Glimmer sighed, "Growing up in wartime would do that to anyone, and that's before taking on a burden like She-Ra."

Glimmer smiled.

"But she's said it was all worth it in the end, and I agree. She's got friends, practically family, who would do anything for her. She has someone she loves with bone-deep feelings, and who feels the same way back. And after so much pain from people she once trusted, she has a home where she's safe. Whatever the Horde put her through, she's got a good life now. You can be sure of that."

Marlena smiled a bit, then frowned.

"She's not staying, is she?"

Glimmer was silent. Marlena closed her eyes and gave a brief and bitter laugh.

"I just got her back. I know I can't stop her. She has a home on Etheria. She's a grown woman who can make her own decisions…but…"

"Yeah," Glimmer said, "But."

There was a long moment of silence, only broken by the formless chatter of below.

"It's not the end, though," Glimmer said, "Even discounting the communication lines, Adora's not going to let a little thing like distance stop her. Besides, our spaceship's alive and likes her. You can't stop her from leaving, and neither can I. Your daughter is a force of nature when she gets her mind set on something."

She laughed lightly.

"I mean, that ring chose her for a reason. Something about powerful will?"

Marlena finally smiled.

"'*I am the master of my fate, I am the captain of my soul*.'"

"Pardon?"

"It's part of my favorite poem back on Earth."

Glimmer nodded.

"Nice sentiment. You should teach it to Adora, she'd like it."

"I think I just might."

oOo

A few days of diplomacy and rekindling of familial relationships later, it was time for the Etherians to head home.

Adora stood at the castle gates. Before her was the *Starshine,* gangplank open. Entrapta and Mara were likely already making pre-flight checks. Behind her was the home of her biological family, the same one she'd been forming a relationship with for the past few days.

A part of her wanted to stay. The question of where she came from had been buzzing in the back of her mind since she was a little girl. Sometimes the buzzing was louder, sometimes it was barely noticeable. But the question was always there, lurking in her subconscious.

Now she had the answers. Better, she had names and faces. She had a mother and a father and a brother. Part of her wanted more time.

But Eternia wasn't her home, she knew.

She felt a touch on her shoulder, and turned to see her mother. The woman's eyes were red, but she looked at Adora with so much pride.

"I wish you could stay, but I know why you can't."

Adora hugged her mother.

"This isn't good-bye. This is…see you later," Adora said.

She pulled back, smiling.

"I've got a big family. And family doesn't care about distance."

Marlena laughed.

“Glimmer said much the same.”

“I’ll stay in touch as often as I can.”

“You better, young lady.”

There was one more brief hug, and then they pulled away from each other.

“Be happy, Adora.”

Adora smiled at her, then turned for the *Starshine*. She had to will herself not to look back. Catra was waiting for her at the end of the gangplank.

“You okay, Adora?”

Adora wiped away a few tears and gave her love a smile.

“Yeah, I think I will be.”

Chapter End Notes

The poem quote is from Invictus by William Ernest Henley. Look it up, it basically has ‘indomitable will’ stamped onto every line.

Connection Established

Chapter Notes

Buckle up, because things are about to get cosmic

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

-

Chapter 16

Connection Established

-

-

Two years later…

The machine floated silently in space, a large dent in its side. Suddenly, a giant green hand reached out and grabbed it, dragging it off and plunking it down onto a lone asteroid. A glowing figure opened a panel on the side and fiddled with the innards.

"No internal damage, good," she muttered, "Okay, that should do it."

She closed the panel. The machine hummed pleasantly, although the sound was lost to the vacuum as the woman and her energy shield moved away. She pulled out a small piece of technology and spoke into it.

"Hordak, how's it looking?"

"*Brilliantly*," came the reply, "*Everything's back to safer parameters on my end.*"

"Duncan, what about you?"

"*Fine over here, Adora*," came another voice, "*Did you figure out what happened?*"

"Looked like some debris impacted the buoy, knocked it out of position," Adora replied, "Nothing too spectacular."

"*Yes, that was a common problem with Prime's communication lines as well,"* Hordak interjected*, "Nothing for it but to fix the problem when it happens."*

"*Well, that's why we have redundancies*," Duncan said, *"Oh, Adora, before you go. Your mother wanted me to remind you of the special dinner tomorrow*."

"Barring an emergency, I'll be there," Adora replied, "Signing off."

Adora finished her work and floated away from the asteroid. She took a moment to just drift out in space. Flight wasn't a power of the ring she used often. She preferred having something solid under her, be it Swift Wind or the *Starshine*, but sometimes it was nice to soar with nothing but her will holding her up.

After a minute, she shook herself back into focus.

"Right, better get home. Don't want everyone to worry."

Suddenly, her ring flared with brilliant green light.

Connection to Mogo established.

"Wait, what? Explain please!"

Connection to Mogo established. Contact made with Green Lantern Corps. Lantern will report to central precinct.

The ring started to pull her in a new direction, but Adora grabbed at her forearm and pulled back.

"Stop, stop! Belay that order!"

Lantern will report to central precinct.

"Override command! I can't just jet off on a whim! Give me time to prepare for the trip. I'll pack for an extended trip, take the *Starshine* to the coordinates, whatever, but not just yet!"

The ring seemed to accept that, and stopped pulling.

Lantern will report to central precinct.

"I heard you the first time, but I have commitments here too. I'll report to this central precinct, but we do it *my way*, not dragging me off without warning. Clear?"

There was a moment of silence.

Acknowledged.

"Great."

Adora steered herself for home, momentarily musing how the ring almost sounded huffy for a moment, before her mind fully processed what had just happened.

"Oh good gravy, *other Lanterns*."

oOo

"Other Lanterns?!"

Adora wiggled her finger in her ear.

"Thanks, guys, now I'm deaf," she said, barely scratching the storm of noise that was assailing her from three sides.

"How are you not freaking out over this?" Bow squawked.

"I spent about ten minutes emptying my stress into the void of space," Adora replied flatly.

She wasn't kidding. Ever since she got the ring, she'd felt like she was missing something, like there was a larger world just out of sight. Horde Prime practically confirmed it, and she'd be lying if she said she'd never wished for more answers as to the Green Lantern Corps. Now it had been unceremoniously dropped in her

lap. It was exhilarating and frightening in equal measure, and the paradox had left her dizzy.

Catra was the first of the three to stop, taking a few calming breaths. Idly, Adora felt proud of her girlfriend, remembering when the techniques their therapist had taught them had been hard to regularly use but now seemed second nature.

“Okay, so what next?” she asked.

“It could just be the way the ring talks, but the summons seemed fairly urgent?” Adora hummed, “Or maybe because this is the first time it managed to link with the larger Corps and things needed to happen that couldn’t be done before. Maybe there was an initiation I never attended, I don’t know.”

“You did kind of stumble through most of this Lantern stuff in a bass-ackwards kind of way.”

“Gee, thanks,” Adora said with a roll of her eyes.

“So I guess we’re going on a trip then?” asked the calmer Glimmer.

“Dial it back, Glim. There’s no ‘we’ in this situation.”

"What?"

"You're the *queen*, Glimmer, you have responsibilities here. And this isn't like one of our quests," Adora said, "I have no idea where exactly I'm going or how long I'll be gone. Bright Moon's throne can't be empty for that long."

Glimmer opened her mouth to argue, but Bow put his hand on her shoulder and gave her a look. She stopped, clearly not happy but willing to let the conversation continue smoothly.

"So you're going then," Bow said, "A chance to find out more about what you're a part of?"

Adora looked at her ring briefly.

"Yeah. This is probably the only chance I have."

Bow then walked forward and drew Adora into a hug.

"Then be safe."

A spark of light and a shimmering chime heralded Glimmer's joining of the hug.

“Show them what you can do,” Glimmer said, “And come back soon.”

“I love you guys,” Adora smiled, hugging them back.

The hug soon broke, Adora begging off to go pack. She went to her room and pulled a suitcase from the back of the closet. Turning, she saw Catra leaning against the doorframe, a particular smile on her face.

“You didn’t think I’d let you go by yourself, right?” Catra asked.

“No, I just knew you’d come without me having to ask, and nuts to anything holding you back.”

Adora set the suitcase down and brought Catra into a hug.

“You and me, together against all odds.”

“Until the end of the line,” Catra agreed.

oOo

Once the ring disgorged proper coordinates, Mara did some calculations. Even with the ringpower enhancing the ship, it will still take a long time to travel. Mara estimated over two months at maximum speed, and that wasn't taking into account any stops or alterations to their path

But despite what would undoubtedly be an extended trip, there wasn't much worry. Etheria was a peace, and had allies to call upon if the need arose.

"The Star Siblings, the Man-chines, the Rock Lords, Aquatos, Adam…things will be fine here if trouble does come knocking," Bow had said.

It took time to gather all the supplies they'd need and get everything squared away, but within days, the *Starshine* was packed and ready for takeoff. Adora and Catra took time to bid their goodbyes to the small crowd of people gathered by the ship. All of their friends had come to see them off. Even Hordak had come down from his observatory to wish them well.

Actually, Entrapta dragged him, but he didn't protest very hard.

After enduring one last bone-crushing hug from Scorpia and an attempted good-bye shanty from Sea Hawk (Mermista had doused her newlywed husband to make him stop), Adora, Catra, and Melog boarded the *Starshine*.

The ship had undergone some renovations in past years. The kitchen had been updated, the improved engines hummed like they were brand-new, and the cabin spaces had been merged into something more livable. There were even a few rugs in the rooms and cockpit.

Melog parked herself on one of said rugs, and Adora settled herself in the captain's chair. In a similar chair next to it, Catra sat with an eager smile on her face.

"You ready for this?" Catra asked.

"As I'll ever be," Adora replied, reaching out to take her love's hand, "Mara, take us out."

"Destination locked," Mara said, "And we're off to…pause for dramatic effect…*the exact center of the universe!*

Mara's holographic form shrugged.

"Give or take fifty feet."

oOo

One of the upgrades given to the *Starshine* was in the power systems. They had been improved thanks to Hordak and Mara's know-how, and the fuel crystals had been augmented with Lantern energy. With more power than ever under the hood, the ship was far faster than before, and had energy to spare for other systems both old and new.

One of the new systems was a pair of blasters based on Hordak's old particle cannon. It was something Mara had insisted on once the power had been upgraded. While she would never admit it, there was a part of her still upset over not being able to really help against Horde Prime.

Which led Mara to the present, and the collection of ships currently in front of them.

"Pirates," she spat.

"Yeah, it's easy to forget that most of them are scum, considering Sea Hawk's mostly harmless," Adora grumbled.

A collection of smaller ships swarmed a larger one, having already damaged the engines. Two were locked onto the large ship, clearly boarding parties.

"Mara, how are the weapons?"

"I'm itching to test them."

"Good, back me up, I'm going out there."

"I keep forgetting you can fly through space," Catra hummed.

"Yeah, I just prefer to use the *Starshine*," Adora shrugged as she headed for the cockpit doors.

"It's our girl-time," Mara chuckled.

A minute later, a streak of green light arced toward the ships and blasted the engines off one.

"You know, I wonder what the reaction of the pirates is," Catra said.

"I'm picking up a lot of screams of panic, a bunch of what I presume are swears, and a repeating word that I'm *pretty* sure is 'Lantern', but that's to be expected," Mara said, "Now strap in, I might have to do some fancy flying."

Outside, She-Ra flew through space, her sword in her hand. With a few swings, arcs of green energy shot forth, slamming into the pirate ships and disabling them easily. One ship managed to bring

its guns to bear, but suddenly, the *Starshine* swooped down and blasted it with powerful bolts of red.

After a minute of blasting, the remaining pirate ships beat a hasty retreat. Adora entered the ship through one of the holes made by the entering party. She turned to seal it behind her, only for a shield of energy to snap into place around the hole.

"Ah, safety feature. Cool."

She strode through the ship, finding that a few pirates had been left behind in the chaos. They shot at her with energy pistols, but the shots were easily repelled by the green aura around her.

"Really?" she scoffed, "Prime's robots shot harder than that."

She easily took them down with a few arcs of power. She turned the corner, sent a hammer into the face of the last pirate as he tried to take a hostage, then turned to the scared-looking aliens.

"You're safe now," she said.

They garbled in a strange tongue, but then Adora's ring flashed and the words became understandable.

"—Lantern! A real Lantern! I didn't know they were this far out anymore!"

"Yes, and no," Adora said, "I'm actually from about fifty lightyears…I want to say that way. I got the ring awhile back and was on my way to the rest of the Lanterns when I saw the trouble."

"Ah, makes sense," said one alien wearing a nice suit, "Similar thing happened with my cousin. Captain Rroth, at your service."

"Adora. Do you need help getting somewhere safe?"

"We wouldn't mind a tow. There's a stop a few parsecs away, we can get our engines repaired there."

"Happy to help, Captain."

"And hey, if you meet a Lantern called Kraak, tell him I said hi."

oOo

Catra rubbed at her chin as she looked through the fridge. Finally, she smiled and grabbed a few vegetables and a bag of shredded chicken.

“Soup,” she said.

She went back for some stock, then started to cook. Adora entered the kitchen just as she was cutting some carrots to add to the simmering pot.

“Smells good,” she said, stealing a piece of carrot.

“Stop that,” Catra said, lightly flicking Adora’s hand, “It’s all going in the soup.”

Adora laughed.

“Hey, you know Melog’s hiding under the table, right?”

“Yeah, she’s waiting for me to drop a piece of chicken, the little pig.”

There was a grumble from beneath the table at that.

“Yes you are, you do this every time I work with any kind of meat,” Catra shot back.

"Need any help?" Adora asked.

"Yeah, could you find the basil? I didn't see it when I was looking before."

Adora walked over to a cabinet and rummaged through it.

"I think…no, that's not it…AHA! Got tucked behind the paprika, somehow."

"Great, I'll be using that in a minute."

Adora set the small jar on the counter and watched Catra work. Unlike the drawing that Adora had always known her girlfriend was good at, it was unexpected when Catra had fallen into cooking. One day, she'd started occasionally hanging around the kitchens, and the next thing anyone knew, Catra had brought cookies to a princess meeting. Mermista had teased her mercilessly for a minute, but then Frosta tried one and threatened anyone with frostbite should they do anything to dissuade Catra from doing this again.

"These are not cookies. They are slices of paradise."

Adora was glad Catra had found some hobbies. And more presently, that Catra knew how to cook period. It was a long trip, and it would have been even longer if neither of them were good in the kitchen. A few idiot-proof recipes aside, Adora was terrible at cooking. The last time she'd tried, she'd been told it tasted like *regret.*

oOo

It was an interesting fact that outer space was full of radio waves. Sometimes, certain signals could bounce around for hundreds of years, reaching vast distances.

Mara was attempting to tap into them. Why?

"I thought it would be fun."

"What are you looking for, anyway?" Adora asked.

"Music, audio dramas, documentaries, anything really. Oh, I think I found something."

HIZRT—untamed wilds of Omicron Persei 8, where the wild cragodile waits for its next meal. These creatures have an amazing camouflage ability, so powerful that you would never know it was there until OH GOD NO!

“Please find something else,” Adora said flatly over the sounds of ripping flesh.

“Way ahead of you,” Mara said.

“So Mind, what are we gonna to tomorrow night?”

“The same thing we do every night, Tippy…TRY TO TAKE OVER THE WORLD!”

“This sounds weird. Next,” Catra said.

The speaker soon began to play a harsh, guttural sound.

“naDevvo' yIqIm!”

“The hell is that?” Catra screeched, grabbing her ears in pain, “Turn it off!”

Melog agreed, yowling in pain with her mane spiked up. Mara hurriedly altered the receiver, trying to find something that wouldn’t hurt their ears.

So long and thanks for all the fish!

So sad that it should come to this!

We tried to warn you all, but oh dear…

"Well, it's catchy, at least," Adora said, bobbing her head a bit.

"I don't know, I'm going to keep looking," Mara replied.

"*And so, the threat of Doctor Dread was defeated. But what remains of the mad doctor's plan, still lurking in the bowls of his laboratory? We will see you next week for the further adventures of CAPTAIN MARVELOUS!!*"

"Darn, missed it," Adora frowned, "That sounded fun."

"Wait, I think I have something you'll both like," Mara said.

Pleasant-sounding music began to fill the air.

Imagine me and you, I do

I think about you day and night

It's only right to think about the girl you love

And hold her tight, so happy together

Adora looked at Catra. Catra looked at Adora. They both smiled. Catra held out her hand, and Adora took it.

If I should call you up, invest a dime

And you say you belong to me and ease my mind

They pressed up against each other, moving in sync and losing themselves to the music.

Imagine how the world could be

So very fine, so happy together

Catra’s tail swished in joy as they briefly spun.

“When was the last time we did this?” she asked.

I can't see me lovin' nobody but you for all my life!

When you're with me, baby, the skies will be blue for all my life!

"Oh, how very true," Adora giggled.

Me and you and you and me

No matter how they tossed the dice, it had to be

The only one for me is you

And you for me, so happy together

Adora gave Catra a brief kiss as they danced to the music.

"This is adorable," Mara whispered to herself, "Saving this song."

I can't see me lovin' nobody but you for all my life!

When you're with me, baby, the skies will be blue for all my life!

oOo

Cooking themselves was all well and good, but sometimes, it was nice to eat out.

They'd happened upon a space station that looked to be a traveler's rest. After finding a dock, Adora, Catra, and Melog set off to explore the place. There were alien species of all kinds milling about, from tall humanoids to small insectoids, from a

four-legged mass of gray skin and slow speech to an average-looking woman with feathery wings sticking out of her back.

It was the latter that pointed them toward a 'diner', which Catra quickly likened to a roadside tavern, but more metallic. Thankfully, there was a sign on the front that Adora's ring helpfully translated.

Police, emergency responders, and Lanterns eat free!

Adora smiled at Catra, who made a show of rolling her eyes.

"Fine, we can check it out."

Inside, the place was thumping with jazzy music, and aliens of every kind were gathered and enjoying themselves. The three ducked past a lupine talking with a very tall and hairy fellow who communicated in roars and grunts, finding an open booth.

"Is it weird that I kind of understand some of this?" Catra asked.

Adora waved her ring hand, showing that the ring was glowing.

"Ah."

“This translation field is apparently near-automatic, and super-useful.”

A robotic waitress rolled up just then.

“Welcome to Dex’s,” she said in a no-nonsense fashion, “Here’s some menus, can I get you some drinks now?”

“We’re not exactly regulars,” Adora said, “Maybe just some waters?”

“One in a bowl for this one?” Catra added, petting Melog, who had casually hopped up onto the seat next to Catra and was sitting patiently.

“Two glasses of water, one bowl,” the waitress recited back, “I’ll swing by later when you’re ready to order.”

She left them at that. A moment later, a hovering drone delivered their drinks, setting them on the table before darting off with a squeak.

“Cute,” Adora said.

Adora and Catra looked over the menus.

"Adora?"

"Yeah?"

"I don't recognize any of this stuff."

"Yeah, I don't either," Adora replied, "Although this thing called 'fish and chips' sounds safe."

Catra looked where Adora was pointing.

"Popular fried dish originating from…e-ar-th? Well, it looks like just fish and potato slices. Provided there's no weird seasonings, we can go with that."

Suddenly, the door to the diner was slammed open. The music stopped abruptly as a hulking form entered.

"Whazzup, bastiches! The Main Man is in the house!"

There were several groans from around the diner, but the new alien didn't care. He wore leathers, had white skin and wild black hair, a massive gun attached to his back, a chain and a hook hanging from his belt, and a lit cigar in his mouth.

"Weren't you banned from here, Lobo?" asked a four-eyed alien.

Lobo just punched him to the floor.

"Like I care!"

Lobo started to stride up to the bar.

"Gargle Blaster, double-shot! And keep it com—"

He was passing by Adora and Catra's table, but then stopped. He was looking at them, and neither liked that look.

"Well, hello ladies. Name's Lobo. How you doing?"

Catra looked him up and down before scoffing.

"Not interested," she spat.

“Aw, don’t be like that! The Main Man’s a friend to all lovely ladies! How ‘bout you scooch over and I can show you.”

“How about you get lost, bozo?” Catra shot back, Melog punctuating it with a growl.

“Look, let’s not start anything,” Adora said, trying to defuse the situation, “We all just want to eat and relax—"

“And this is how I relax,” Lobo interjected, leaning on their table and flexing his muscles.

“Well, I’d rather relax alone with my girlfriend, so can you please leave?”

Lobo looked stunned for a moment before giving a downright perverted smile.

“Hot. Five quatloos for you two to kiss!”

“No!” Catra yowled.

"Oh, I see. Well, maybe you'd be interested in a little both-sides action. I know a place we can all three go, nice and private."

Lobo closed his eyes and puckered his lips, making kissing noises.

A giant green fist slammed into his face, sending him tumbling to the ground.

He lay there for a moment, stunned.

"The frag?"

There was a brilliant light, and then looking down at him was a tall, muscular, and beautiful blonde, wearing white and green clothes and a murderous expression.

"I wanted to play this nice," She-Ra said before grabbing him by his jacket.

"Hey, what's the big--"

He got punched in the face again.

She continued to punch him in the face as she dragged him toward the door. Then she literally kicked him out, a green aura encasing her foot and enhancing her strike.

"*Beat it, asshole!*" she screamed.

Lobo scrambled to his feet, grabbing his gun and holding it steady.

"Oh, you did not just do that to the Main—"

A giant green sword came down and sliced his gun in half. Lobo looked from his shorter weapon to the warrior woman, his eyes trailing to the green aura around her hand and the sword floating above it.

"Oh, frag me."

"I will if you don't turn around and walk away, *right now*," Adora growled.

Lobo had tangled with Green Lanterns before. The fights were always hard, and not in the fun way. And he didn't have the weaponry or the mood to try today.

"Fine," he grumbled, then walked away, muttering obscenities under his breath.

A beam of green energy shot out and struck the seat of his pants, making him yelp.

"I heard that!" Adora shouted, "And my mother's a saint! Now take your attitude and scram!"

Lobo started to walk a bit faster.

Adora waited until she was sure he was gone before going back to her table. There were cheers from around the diner as she let She-Ra go and slid into the booth.

"That was hot," Catra said, and Melog purred in approval.

Adora blushed.

The waitress from before rolled up.

"So, what'll our hero and her girl have?"

"The fish and chips looked good," Adora said.

"Coming up. And for the record, even if you weren't clearly a Lantern, we'd be giving you it on the house after that display."

After their meal, the manager actually came out to shake their hands before they left, wishing them well.

"Well, that was a lovely afternoon," Catra said, brushing up against her girlfriend and purring, "Admit it, you enjoyed smacking that jerk."

"Maybe a little," Adora smirked.

oOo

Melog, currently the size of a housecat, crouched low, keeping her prey in her sights. Her smoky tail whipped about as every muscle tensed.

She pounced!

But the strange green dot slipped away from her paws.

She pounced again!

But it was too fast!

Melog continued to chase the dot around the room, her quarry always a step ahead.

From her position away from the action, Adora tried desperately to hold her laughter in. She jerked her hand to the side, and the green light Melog was chasing followed her command and again slipped away from the alien cat.

"Isn't this adorable, Catra? Uh…Catra?"

Catra wasn't listening, she was following the light with her eyes, the normally-slitted pupils wide. Adora could see the signs of her body tensing, ready. Her hands were held in a way to allow her claws quick unleashing, and her tail stuck straight up, the tip flicking with nervous energy.

A wicked thought came to Adora, and she couldn't resist. She guided the green dot to Catra's feet, wiggled it around in a taunting maneuver, and sent it racing away.

Catra leapt after it. The dot quickly disappeared beneath a chair, and in her haste, Catra tripped over it, sending her sprawling.

Adora couldn't hold it in anymore, and burst out laughing.

Catra, now back to herself, glared at her girlfriend.

"Shaddup."

oOo

All beings must suffer to become pure, ALL BEINGS MUST SUFFER TO BECOME PURE, ***ALL BEINGS MUST SUFFER TO BECOME PURE!***

Catra shot up in her bed, shaking with fear. Her eyes were blown wide and sweat slithered beneath her fur. Her ears twitched, trying to take in any sound possible. She felt like her heart was going to explode out of her chest, and her breath was fast and harsh.

She heard Adora's voice, but it felt muted, like it was coming from underwater. But hearing it was enough to not lash out when a warm hand touched her shoulder, although she did jump a bit.

Adora entered her field of vision, worry on every part of her face. She slowly brought Catra into a hug, speaking words of comfort in one flicking ear.

"It's okay, it was just a dream. He's gone, he can't hurt you. I'm right here, you're safe with me, I love you."

Adora continued to speak slowly and carefully, and eventually felt Catra relax in her grip.

"'msorry…"

"Don't, don't do that to yourself. You're okay, you're safe."

Catra shuddered in Adora's grip, but didn't break away. Adora considered that a victory, considering the first few times this happened, Catra didn't want anyone to touch her, even Adora. The nightmares of Horde Prime had dropped off as time went on, and she hadn't had one in some time. Being back in space must have resurrected the old memories, and with them the nightmares.

Adora knew that, for many reasons, they were both a bit damaged. But as time and therapy had taught them, they had each other, and could lean on each other when they needed to.

oOo

Catra traced the lines on Adora's bare back with a gentle touch.

“What are you doing?” she heard Adora say.

“Have I ever mentioned how jealous I am of this?” Catra said, continuing to trace the tattoo of a falcon in flight.

“A couple times. Something about your fur getting in the way?”

“Good for hiding most scars, not so much for showing off body art.”

Adora rolled over and trailed a finger down Catra’s chest, following the forking lines etched in the soft fuzz.

“They’re not ugly to me, you know. They were shocking a first, but they’re a part of you. You survived her worst, and you’re still a good person despite her.”

“Stumbled along the way—"

“None of that. You made up for your mistakes long ago. And I love you. That’s the most important part.”

Catra smiled back and they exchanged a tender kiss.

The lights above them flickered. Mara had limited access to their room. There were no cameras and few sensors. But she did have a speaker she could talk through, and often flickered the lights as a warning before speaking.

"Hey, so I think we're getting close to the ring's coordinates. I'd say maybe…an hour, hour and a half?"

"So I have time to put some pants on, then?" Catra drawled.

"Get ready for the day, I'll guide us in."

Catra got up and walked toward the bathroom, then noticed Adora staring.

"Hey, Adora. What's up? Cat got your tongue?"

"No, but she's got my heart."

Catra tried not to blush and failed, but she pulled herself together, a saucy smile on her face.

"You could join me, you know."

“If I do that, it’ll take way longer than we have,” Adora laughed, “Shoo, I’ll whip up some porridge for breakfast.”

Catra laughed, putting an extra swing in her hips and swish in her tail as she walked away. Just to be a tease.

oOo

The green world loomed before them. Cut into the forests of the planet, a familiar shape looked up at them.

Adora let out a heavy breath.

“Today’s the day.”

“Nervous?” Catra asked.

“A bit.”

“Don’t be. You’ll wow them.”

Adora smiled back, pecking Catra on the cheek.

"Thanks."

"Anytime."

"Getting a transmission," Mara said.

"Probably a greeting," Catra hummed.

"Let's hear it," Adora said.

A speaker crackled.

"Unknown spacecraft, state your business."

Catra looked at Adora expectantly.

"Um, I got this ring a while back. I think I'm one of you. A Green Lantern."

There was silence from the other end for a moment. Then there was a flash from Adora's ring.

"*Ring confirmed, craft. We are sending out a welcoming party. Follow them to a safe landing pad. And welcome to Mogo.*"

"Acknowledged, Mogo. *Starshine* out," Mara replied.

"Well," Adora said, taking a deep breath, "Here we go…"

Chapter End Notes

With thanks to The Turtles. Also, Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy.
I hate Lobo. I enjoyed smacking him around.
Okay, but let's address the elephant in the room. The final arc of the story shall be focusing on the Green Lantern Corps. I think we all knew this was coming eventually, but we'll discuss this more next time.

Mogo

Chapter Notes

Before I go and prove myself to be a colossal nerd, story time!
When I was very young, still learning how to read, my grandparents had a shelf full of books that had belonged to my dad and his brothers. One of them was a collection of comic book superheroes, detailing first appearances, behind-the-scenes details, and a bonus of a later issue in the run to see how far the characters, art, and storytelling had come. One section in particular stood out to me, and they became the first superheroes I was ever consciously a fan of.
The Fantastic Four.
Bait-and-switch, I know, but let me continue.
Many years later, around high school, I was still a fan of superheroes, but I didn't really do much regular reading. Oh, I'd look up details here and there, and I'd watch movies and cartoons about them, but that was it. But one day, while volunteering at my public library, I saw a book on display in the young adult section, a trade collection of a particular storyline.
Green Lantern: Rebirth, by Geoff Johns.
I was familiar with John Stewart, Kilowog, and a few other GL basics from the Justice League cartoon, but on the cover was a guy I'd only heard of in passing, Hal Jordan. Curious, I checked it out after finishing my shift.
And reading that trade that afternoon, it was like I was back at my grandparents, reading about the Human Torch dodging fighter planes and the Thing punching out monsters.
Green Lantern is the reason I remained a comic fan into my adult years. If it weren't for that chance happening that day at the library, I might never have gotten back into comics. I might never had explored all these weird and wonderful worlds and characters. I might not even be a writer, certainly not in the same way I do things now.

I tell you all this because it's, I feel, important context to why I'm writing this. This story, and this arc in particular, is my love letter to those wild stories that shaped my imagination. Hal Jordan stands beside Harry Potter, Luke Skywalker, and the Genie as foundational giants of my creative mind. Because stories matter. Never let anyone tell you different.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

-

Chapter 17

Mogo

-

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As they got closer to the planet, two streaks of green light shot up to meet them. There were shapes in the light, and Adora figured they were Lanterns there to guide them in. The *Starshine* followed the lights down to the planet's surface, eventually finding a collection of landing pads in the middle of a large field. One of the Lanterns projected the image of a target on one of the empty pads, and Mara maneuvered the ship to it.

As the ship touched down, Adora headed toward the gangplank, Catra's hand in her own. The gangplank lowered, revealing the two Lanterns touching down nearby.

One was a massive alien, tall and muscular. This head was slightly porcine, and he had a huge jaw. Every part of him

screamed ‘grizzled’. The other was a small, squirrel-like creature that got Catra’s instincts blaring.

The larger Lantern strode over, the smaller resting on his shoulder. Their eyes flicked between Adora and Catra briefly.

“So,” the larger alien said in a deep voice, “Which of you has the ring?”

Adora raised her hand, showing the ring off.

“I was going to ask why you came in on a ship, but your friend there answers that question. Name’s Kilowog, this is Ch’p.”

The smaller alien gave a greeting in a chittering voice, but left Kilowog to ask most of the questions.

“So, who am I talking to and where you from?”

“My name is Adora. This is Catra, and her companion Melog. As for where we’re from…”

Adora projected a copy of their flight path from her ring.

"This is a rough map. We started over here."

Kilowog narrowed his eyes and projected a similar map from his own ring. It was a lot clearer than Adora's, much more detailed. As he looked over the maps, his eyes widened.

"You're from Horde space."

"Gonna have to find a new name for it," Catra said, "Horde Prime is dead. We killed him ourselves."

"You're sure?" Ch'p asked, "We have intelligence that says he's at least partially an energy being. Very difficult to kill."

"We're sure," Adora said, "He was hit point blank by the collective magic of an entire planet. I saw his essence practically evaporate."

"Let me see your ring," Kilowog said.

Adora extended her hand. Kilowog projected a line of energy from his that connected the two rings. A screen with alien text appeared after a minute, and he frowned.

"Over two years from when you got this? Why the delay?"

"We think the ring got damaged somehow before reaching me," Adora replied.

"Yeah, I can see signs of that now…and what's this? Some kind of patch? What energy is this?"

"Magic."

Kilowog looked at her for a moment, then turned and raised his ring. From the light, he created a sleek vehicle that hovered a few feet off the ground.

"Get in. We need to talk with some experts."

oOo

The alien with the long head and the multiple arms worked several screens at once, muttering all the way. Patiently waiting were about nine small blue beings, seated around them in a gallery.

Kilowog had brought them to a large complex and straight to what Adora guessed was an administrative building. The new alien, Salaak, was apparently the chief operations officer for the Corps, as well as one of their leading scientific minds. The blue

beings were the Guardians, the leaders of the Corps and inventors of the rings. They all gathered in the council chamber of the Guardians, to try to figure out the unique circumstances of their newest member.

Finally, Salaak paused, nodded, and tapped one screen.

"Lantern Kraken, please report to the Council Chamber. Your expertise is requested."

Then Salaak turned to Adora.

"Was your ring in close proximity to a magical artifact at any point?"

Adora summoned her sword.

"Years ago, I found this sword, and was chosen by it to wield the power of She-Ra, the protector of Etheria. But before I got the ring, I had to break the sword, because it turned out to also be the key to a superweapon. Long story. Bottom line, I used the ring to reforge the sword, and the two different energies kind of… merged. Does that answer your question?"

"As a matter of fact, it does," Salaak said, "I'm finding evidence that the ring's programming was damaged somehow, but the power from that sword patched the damage. Believe it or not, it

is not the first time such a thing has happened, the ring merging with hyper-advanced technology and/or magical energies."

"What do you mean?"

"That's as good a cue as any," said a new voice.

Entering the room was a new Lantern. She had green skin and hair, offsetting the blacks and deeper greens of a midriff-baring version of what seemed to be the standard Lantern uniform. On her arm, extending up to her elbow, was a gauntlet of deep green crystal and metal, odd designs etched across it.

"So you're a new Lantern, eh?" she said, "Good to have some fresh meat around here. Name's Kraken."

She extended her hand, which Adora shook.

"Adora."

Before, the Guardians were content to observe and listen. Now, one of them spoke up.

"Lantern Kraken is of a similar situation to you. She hails from an extra-dimensional realm called Apokolips."

“Pray you never have to face something from there,” Kraken added with a dark look.

“When she sought refuge in our universe, she brought with her a device called a Mother Box, a sort of living computer of extraordinary power. When a ring chose her, the Mother Box initiated a merge with the ring, becoming something new.”

Kraken waved her gauntlet-clad arm. Sparks of green light flaked off it, taking on a multitude of different shapes before fading.

“All the ring’s green light, merged with the Source-manipulation of Mother Box,” Kraken said, “She can make a construct as easily as a Boom Tube.”

“A what tube?” Adora asked.

“Controlled wormhole, basically. A portal to just about anywhere I wish.”

Adora hummed, giving the gauntlet a speculative look before getting herself back on track.

“So, your two special things merged into one special thing. Neat. But can you do this?”

Adora raised her sword and transformed. She-Ra stood there, her form briefly flaring green-and-gold before the light restricted itself to her eyes as per usual.

"Amazing," Salaak cried, fingers flying over his screens, "I'm detecting an incredible energy. The wavelengths are similar to the Light of Will, but there is enough difference that I can reasonably tell it apart. I'm curious as to what she might be capable of in this form."

"Super-strength, incredible toughness, absurdly sharp sword, healing powers, there's a whole list," Catra said casually from her position against the wall, having been content to let things play out.

The Guardians seemed to talk amongst themselves for a moment before one spoke up.

"Lantern Kraken, why don't you show Adora and her companions our facilities."

"Yes, Ganthet."

"Adora? You have clearly done well with self-taught skills. Reforging a mystical sword and slaying an energy being proves that. But the time has come for you to expand your knowledge.

The Corps exist to defend peace and justice throughout the stars, and despite an oft rocky history, we still stand strong, a shield against the forces of evil. Before, you were chosen to defend your planet. Now, you are chosen to defend more. We formally welcome you to the Green Lantern Corps."

His eyes flicked to Catra and Melog.

"And we also welcome your friends as honored guests."

"Thank you, sir," Adora said as she powered down, "I hope I can live up to your confidence."

Kraken led them out of the room after that, talking about showing them the mess hall first.

Ganthet, for his part, chuckled a bit to himself as he observed Adora and Catra. Their strides were in sync, their bodies close together. Catra's tail even moved to lightly wrap around Adora's waist.

Ganthet was old, but he wasn't stupid.

"Something funny, dear husband?" asked a female Guardian.

"Nothing, Sayd. Just young love," Ganthet replied, smiling.

oOo

Adora and Catra ended up bunking on their ship, mostly out of familiarity. But over the next week, they familiarized themselves with the Lanterns' Central Precinct.

Adora was enthralled. Just being here felt like the answer to the question that had dogged her for the past few years. Now she could truly learn what it meant to be a Green Lantern.

Catra was a touch more sedate. She was really only here to support Adora, and didn't have many plans for herself on Mogo. That said, the archives did catch her attention, and she resolved to check it out.

The people of this world, fellow Lanterns all, were intrigued by Adora and her mixed power. Most were friendly enough, and the Etherians were exposed to aliens of all shapes and sizes.

They quickly found a friend in one of the senior Lanterns, Soranik Natu. She was the chief medical officer of the corps, and the two had been taken to her quickly to compile a medical file 'for emergencies'. Aside from her deep red skin, she could have passed for a normal person on Etheria. She also possessed a business-like attitude while on duty, but once she'd finished her file, she'd begun to relax.

"Okay, I've covered general physiology, dietary restrictions that I will pass onto the mess staff, allergies, immune response, and I'd like to schedule you for a few vaccinations. Do you have any questions for me?"

"Medically, no, but I did have a personal question," Adora said.

"Shoot."

"I was wondering about that other ring you've got."

Soranik frowned. On her other hand was a ring much like her Lantern ring, but yellow in color. She looked at it briefly before sighing and putting down her datapad.

"How much of the Corps recent history are you familiar with?" she asked.

"A galactic conqueror claimed you'd come up against a series of crises," Catra replied, "He mentioned the Darkstars, the Sinestro Corps, Atrocitus, and something called the Blackest Night."

"The Darkstars were before my time," Soranik replied, "But I can tell you about the Sinestro Corps. I was neck deep in that affair

because of personal history, and spent a good chunk of it as a prisoner of war."

She sat down in a chair and visibly composed herself.

"So, first things first, I was adopted. I knew that since I was a kid. All I knew about my biological parents was that my mother had died during the Liberation of Korugar. That itself requires some context, but to sum it up, my planet had been ruled by a dictator before he was overthrown, partially thanks to the Corps. But the dictator escaped, and spent the next several years as a major thorn in the Corps side."

"How?" Catra asked, "From what I've seen, a Green Lantern is a powerful force in battle."

"True, there aren't a lot of things that can go toe to toe with one. Unfortunately, Sinestro found a way."

Soranik light her ring up, letting the green glow play across their faces.

"See, the green light that powers our rings is fueled and shaped by our will. But it's part of a larger spectrum of light and emotion. Every color of the rainbow has a place. Red is rage, orange is avarice, blue is hope, indigo is compassion, and violet is love. Each has their own strengths and weaknesses, and green is considered the most stable."

“You didn’t mention yellow,” Adora said.

“That’s because yellow is difficult for a lot of Lanterns to talk about, especially the senior ones. Yellow is fear. And fear is the enemy of will. Harnessed yellow light can prove a powerful match for green, even cut through constructs of the unprepared Lantern. Sinestro found a way to harness that light of fear, and used it to clash with the Corps for many years, all while accumulating enough power to take his plans to the next stage.”

Soranik projected an image, a legion of aliens with terrifying visages.

“An army of wielders of the yellow light, a counter to the Green Lanterns. And so the Sinestro Corps War began. Green and yellow blazed across the stars, and death soon followed.”

She let the image fade and sighed again.

“I didn’t really take part, I was captured fairly early on. Trapped with a drained ring and no way out. I thought for sure I’d be killed. But then Sinestro himself intervened.”

“Why would he do that?” Adora asked.

"I asked him about it. He told me the full story over dinner. How he used to be a Green Lantern himself, and how he got so tired of 'cleaning up the dregs of the universe', of not being able to effect change like he wanted to. Most of the Lanterns who would tell this story would say that he got drunk on his power, leading him to taking over his home planet and instituting his own rule. Having spent time with him, I know it's more complicated than that, but I'd be hard pressed to really describe it."

She gave a vague gesture.

"I guess…I pity him, more than anything else. He had his convictions, a set of strong beliefs, and in the end, he was too inflexible to alter them, even in the face of knowledge that what he was doing was harmful."

"Why are you defending someone like that?" Catra asked, "He sounds like a terrible person."

"He was," Soranik said, "He was also my father."

Adora and Catra hissed and winced. Soranik gave a pained smile.

"Yeah, I get that reaction a lot."

She raised her other hand, letting some yellow light shine out of the ring.

"I spent months around him. It left me with a lot of mixed feelings. When the war ended, he was captured and imprisoned on the Sciencells on Oa, our old central precinct. There he would stay until the Blackest Night, when Oa came under attack by such a powerful force that we were forced to turn to old enemies for help in preventing the end of everything. Sinestro was one of them, and one of many who gave his life to stop the Black Lanterns. With his death, his ring sought a new wielder, and it chose me."

She looked at the yellow ring sadly.

"He was a horrible person, but he also cared about me in some strange way. He never once hurt me, gave his life to protect me, and now…I guess I'm still coming to grips with all of it."

"I know the feeling," Adora muttered.

Catra knew who Adora was thinking of, and forced down the nasty thought that came with it. She wanted to ask about these 'Black Lanterns', but it was clear to her that Soranik wouldn't like talking about it, so she kept silent.

oOo

"Welcome to the advanced training regimen," Kilowog said, "You've all mastered the basic stuff, whether through teaching or by stumbling though it on your own."

He looked at Adora briefly as he said, this, making her snicker a bit. Since she'd been teaching herself 'ring-slinging' for some time, she'd been able to test out of the basic training and move straight to the advanced classes.

"But now we come to the meat of things. Interstellar flight and navigation, detecting and tracing energy wavelengths, advanced constructs, and much more. You've been able to make swords, now you learn how to make scalpels. But first, let's warm-up."

Kilowog ended up splitting all the trainees into groups of three, with him and his assistant, the robotic Stel, going around the various groups as they went through some assigned exercises.

Because of the odd numbers, Adora ended up with only one other Lantern. She was humanoid, with dusky skin and hair. Over one eye was an iridescent tattoo, but a closer look gave Adora the feeling that it was created by the ring, a unique take on the alterations most Lanterns gave their uniforms.

She also wore a very nervous expression. The way her eyes shifted, and the way her fingers twitched, it was familiar to Adora.

“Hey,” she said, making the other woman jump, “I didn’t introduce myself. I’m Adora.”

“Jessica,” the woman said softly after a brief pause, “Sorry, I’ve… got a lot on my mind.”

Stel walked over, pointing them toward a shooting range and telling them to hit some targets as a warm-up.

“But do not use generic beams. Create projectiles or weapons yourself.”

Adora nodded and casually strode over, Jessica following behind.

“So what are you thinking?” Adora asked, “I’ve got a friend who’s an archer, so…”

Adora crafted an arrow and sent it at the target. It landed just an inch left of center.

“Gotta work on that,” Adora hummed.

Jessica breathed deeply and held up her hands. A long object appeared, and she handled it with the ease of familiarity.

BANG!

The shot hit dead-center.

"Nice shot," Adora said.

"Thanks. I used to hunt, way back when. Haven't been out since…since…"

Jessica looked at the hunting rifle in her hands and shivered. Adora reached out, lightly touching her shoulder and making her jump.

"You okay?"

Jessica shook her head.

"Yeah, it's just…not one of my better days."

"What do you mean?" Adora asked, although she was starting to figure it out.

Jessica huffed and fired twice more at the target before answering.

"I'm Jessica Cruz, the Anxiety Lantern," she said with a bitter laugh, "I'm a superhero, a space cop in training, and there are days where it takes everything I have to get out of bed in the morning. How pathetic is that?"

Adora fired another arrow. It hit the center this time.

"Not really. We all have our hang-ups," she replied, "I used to pull everything on myself until I collapsed under the pressure. I'm better at recognizing it now, and my friends help too."

She laughed a bit.

"Between you and me, I think my girlfriend enjoys calling me out for being stupid."

"But does it affect your entire life like it does me?" Jessica asked, the rifle in her hands flickering as her will wavered.

"Well, it did nearly get me killed a few times," Adora said bluntly.

Jessica whipped her head around and gawked at Adora.

“Did I mention that I got my ring during a war to save my planet?”

“Okay, yeah, that’ll do it.”

The conversation was halted by the next lesson, but after training, Adora practically dragged Jessica to lunch with her and Catra.

One look at Jessica, and Catra immediately understood why Adora had invited her.

“So, what’s your burden?” Catra asked, casually swallowing some fish, “Depression, anxiety, abusive childhood, night terrors, what am I looking at?”

Jessica gawked at her.

“You’re…very forward.”

“But admit it, you like that I didn’t tiptoe around it.”

“Jessica, at this table you have me with the barely-moderated hero complex, the bundle of issues that is Catra, and whatever

you've got going on," Adora said, "We're all adults who have been to therapy, we're all friends here. I didn't drag you here to be mean, I did it because I saw in your face something I see in our bathroom mirror some days. So…spill."

Jessica was silent for a moment, picking at her vegetables, before she sighed.

"My best friends died right in front of me. We were on a camping/hunting trip, and we stumbled across these people burying a body in the woods. They didn't even flinch, they just started shooting. 'No witnesses', they said. My friends were cut down right before my eyes. I ran, I hid, I barely escaped with my life. And I ended up so scared from it all that I locked myself away, barely left my home for four years."

"Oh gods, I'm so sorry," Adora breathed.

Jessica brushed it off, staring at the ring.

"I barely know why the ring chose me. I've had it for months now, and I still don't really know what it saw in me."

"Well, you're out here," Catra said, "You're scared and anxious, but you're still doing this. That has to count for something."

"I guess."

"Hey, no, look at me," Catra said, more forcefully, "You are here. You are living. You aren't over your trauma, because trauma doesn't work like that, but you're *dealing*. There's a little voice in your head saying that you're not good enough, but *you are*. Every day, you're proving that. That nasty little voice is wrong. I know, I've been there. You are not your fears, or your anxieties."

Jessica slowly nodded, breathing steadily. Adora gave Catra a side-hug and a brief kiss.

And the three continued to talk. General stuff, briefly touching on their issues, things like that. But it was nice.

oOo

The lunch talks became a regular thing as training days went by. Catra would meet them in the mess, and the three would talk about whatever they wanted.

"So, I'm going to go kick his ass" Adora said, starting to rise.

"Siddown," Jessica groused, "I'm fine. Graf's a jerk to everyone. There's a reason Laira gave him that scar before she left to join Gardner, or so I'm told that's what happened."

“What was his problem with you anyway?” Catra asked.

“Just a bunch of stupid stuff.”

“Try again, because you wouldn’t have brought it up unless a part of you bought what he was selling.”

Jessica sighed under Catra’s gaze.

“You are persistent.”

“That’s what they tell me.”

“So, my home planet is an odd duck in the galaxy,” Jessica said, “We’re not that advanced, haven’t explored beyond our solar system, but we’ve successfully fended off several alien invasions, have moderately-large populations of alien refugees and superpowered beings, and have produced several Green Lanterns. And all of those Lanterns went on to do great things. Hal Jordan and John Stewart both held high-ranking positions in the Corps, Kyle Rayner explored and pushed the boundaries of Lantern space, and Simon Baz single-handedly defeated the leadership of the Darkstars when they were trying to make a comeback in the wake of the Sinestro Corps War. Hell, even Guy Gardner, the least-thought-of of the Earth Lanterns, was a respected tactician in his day, and he took control of the Warriors of Rage after Atrocitous was killed, turning them into a force for good. They’re called the Red Lanterns now.”

"How come I haven't met any of these guys if they're such a big deal?" Adora asked.

"Because Guy is the only one still around, and most of his group likes to keep their distance from us, or so I'm told. The rest…well, the Blackest Night happened. They led the final charge, and made the ultimate sacrifice to save everything."

Jessica drummed the fingers of her ring-hand on the table, the ring flashing intermittently.

"I guess…on some level I agree with Graf. They did all these amazing things. Hal was even the guy who brought in Sinestro, ending a massive war that killed so many. How am I supposed to live up to that?"

"You don't," Adora said bluntly.

Jessica gave her an odd look. Adora summoned her sword and laid it down on the table.

"Before I was chosen by a ring, I was chosen by a sword. I was chosen to continue a legacy of heroism. I was She-Ra, the protector of my planet, latest in a long line of heroes. I'd be lying if I said that the weight of that didn't bother me sometimes. But in the end, I couldn't be like the other She-Ras. I could only be

me. So my advice to you, don't *try* to live up to something like that. You'll end up failing, and you'll lose pieces of yourself in the process. Just be *you*. Be the best Lantern that *you* can be. I'm not the She-Ra that Mara was, and you're not the Lantern that Hal Jordan was. We have to be *us*."

Jessica looked between Catra and Adora.

"You two are *really* good at this pep-talk thing."

"After the nightmare of our childhoods and living through a big war, we've both got issues," Catra said, "But we've gotten help with them, learned to deal. If anything, we're just further down the path of trauma-to-healing that you're on."

"So if we can help you along the way, we will," Adora finished, "Because it's the right thing to do."

"Well, you certainly do a decent job of it," Jessica smiled

oOo

Adora and Jessica stood back-to-back, eyes flicking over the swarm of glowing opponents.

“You want out of this, you better make some back-up!” they heard Kilowog shout.

Then the army of constructs, all in the visages of alien warriors, charged.

The two Lanterns fought valiantly, blades and energy beams flying every which way. But the exercise was meant to be won by them creating constructed fighters of their own. Adora had been barred from using She-Ra for it, and had to make weapons as herself.

Jessica fell to the ground, and Adora erected a shield around them. The construct army banged against the dome.

“You okay?” Adora asked, helping her friend up.

“Yeah, I’m fine. How long can you hold this up?”

“Not long, but I bought us some time to focus at least.”

Jessica nodded and closed her eyes, starting a breathing exercise. After a moment, she visibly calmed.

And then the ring on her finger began to glow.

Adora smiled, but said nothing so as to let her concentrate. Instead, she began to focus herself.

There was a brilliant green light, and the dome broke, blowing back a few of the construct warriors.

Jessica and Adora were now flanked by four glowing constructs, shaped like people. At Adora's side were Catra and Mara. At Jessica's were two heroic-looking figures. One was a woman with long hair, an armored top and skirt, a tiara, bulky bracelets, and a sword and shield. The other was a man wearing a tight outfit, letting his impressive musculature be shown, decorated with a cape and a sigil on the chest in the shape of an 'S'.

The two Lanterns looked back at each other.

"I recognize Catra, but who's the other one?" Jessica asked.

"Mara, she's kind of a mentor. You?"

"Just some friends I made before coming here."

"Neat."

And the six sprang into action.

oOo

Catra strolled through the Corps archives. When Adora was at her training, she found ways to occupy herself. Sometimes it was minor tasks around the *Starshine*. Sometimes it was helping with the beginner's class, teaching basic combat skills (she still didn't know how she'd fallen into it, but Kilowog was happy with the assistance).

But her favorite thing was looking through the archives. There were multiple stories found in the vast shelves, and Catra liked learning about the history of such the long-running and far-reaching organization.

Midway through an account of Avra, the first ring-bearer to utilize constructs, she noticed a flash of blue out of the corner of her eye.

"Good afternoon, Catra."

"Hey, Saint."

Saint Walker was a man of peace. He'd dedicated his life to preaching hope and telling stories of inspiration. It made a lot of

sense to Catra that he was the first wielder of a blue ring, the first Blue Lantern.

Unfortunately, he was also the last. The Blue Lanterns had been a more recent organization, and the crises that whittled away the Green Lantern Corps had also devastated the fledgling numbers of Blue.

She'd heard rumors that Saint Walker was working with the Guardians to forge new blue rings, but the process of shaping the blue light of hope was more difficult than green, partly explaining the low numbers of Blue Lanterns before. In the meantime, Saint Walker busied himself day-to-day with helping maintain the archives.

"Actually, can I ask you something?" Catra asked.

"Of course."

"I keep hearing the name, and I've been meaning to look it up. What was the Blackest Night?"

Walker's calm face fell into a deep frown.

"That…is no small question."

But he motioned for her to follow. She did so, noting how bleak the mood had become.

Saint Walker led her to a back office, where on a desk was a book in the process of being written.

"Guardian Ganthet and I have been collating and annotating a record of the Blackest Night," he explained, "It's nearly finished, by my measuring."

He gave her a sobering look.

"You must understand, the events of the Blackest Night were horrific, and they still hang heavy over the universe. I do not tell you this to frighten you, but so that you may understand why it is a subject few bring up lightly."

He flipped to beginning of the book, and an illustration depicting a legion of robotic soldiers.

"We begin eons ago, with the Manhunters. They were the Guardians' first attempt at an intergalactic peacekeeping force. The idea was that robots would be able to operate on pure logic, be incorruptible and un-swayed by lies. However, a flaw in the program soon evolved into something horrible. Deeming emotion as the cause of all evil, the Manhunters descended on Space Sector 666 and exterminated all organic life."

Catra looked at him in horror.

"How…how many…"

"Trillions," Saint Walker replied, "Of the countless lives lost in the massacre, only five survived. They escaped, blamed the Guardians for the atrocity, and swore revenge. Even as the Guardians shut down and destroyed all the Manhunters, replacing them with living souls in the Green Lanterns, the group calling themselves the Five Inversions did not halt in their crusade."

The next illustration that Saint Walker showed was of five aliens, their bodies twisted and strange, in command of an armada of ships.

"And so the Empire of Tears was born. Using dark sorcery, they cut a swath through Lantern space, but the Green Lantern Corps eventually defeated them, imprisoning them on their throneworld of Ysmault."

The next illustration depicted a red-skinned Green Lantern, speaking to one of the Inversions that had been bound to a cross.

"Eons later, the Green Lantern Abin Sur came to Ysmault to investigate a distress signal from a crashed ship. While avoiding the cries of the imprisoned demons, remnants of the Empire

having survived via their dark magics, he came upon Qull of the Five Inversions. Qull did not cry out for release. In fact, he offered Abin Sur a gift: three questions, three truthful answers. Because of how calm Qull was, Abin Sur took up the offer. With the first question, he had the information of where to find the crashed ship, rescuing the survivors. With the second question, Qull gave him a prophecy of Abin Sur's death, which later came true."

"And let me guess, the third question gave Abin Sur a prophecy of the Blackest Night," Catra guessed.

"Precisely. Qull spoke of how the enemies of the Corps would band together. He spoke of the Children of the White Lobe, Ranx the Sentient City, the Weaponers of Qward, and many more. He spoke of the shattering of Mogo, of the fall of Oa, and of a darkness that would stretch across the universe."

Saint Walker turned to another page, showing an army of Green Lanterns fighting an army of yellow-clad warriors.

"When Sinestro worked with the Weaponers to harness the Yellow Light of Fear, some of the Guardians thought that this was the prophecy coming true. Sinestro had brought a few of the figures from it into his army, so maybe? However, the penultimate battle of the war was fought and won, preventing the Children of the White Lobe from setting off their blink bomb near Mogo's core. Then in the final battle, Ranx was destroyed and Sinestro captured. Perhaps the prophecy had been averted?"

Saint Walker frowned.

"We were wrong."

He turned the page, revealing a collection of warriors, all glowing different colors.

"Sinestro inadvertently opened the floodgates. The Star Sapphires, wielders of the Violet Light of Love, made themselves known. Larfleeze, sole wielder of the Orange Light of Avarice, left the Vega system for the first time and tried to attack the Reach. Atrocitus of the Five Inversions escaped his confinement, killed his fellow Inversions, and used their blood in dark rituals to create the first red rings, channelers of the Red Light of Rage. He formed a small army of berserkers and attacked Oa, slaughtering many Lanterns before he could be put down."

Saint Walker smiled a bit.

"And thankfully for the last one, Ganthet had been creating rings that channeled the Blue Light of Hope, foreseeing a need for them. The first Blue Lanterns were able to help defeat Atrocitus. Several of his remaining warriors, who'd been lured to his side by the promise of bloody justice, were taken under the care of Guy Gardner. Gardner had been chosen by Atrocitus' ring, and with many dangers on the horizon, decided that a group of Red Lanterns might be needed. He was right."

Saint Walker turned the page, revealing blackness. But the more Catra looked, she more she saw shapes in the black.

"Our new enemy was someone very old. Before the universe, there was darkness. And then there was light. Creation began, life bloomed, the universe spun into existence, and the Emotional Spectrum blazed across the new stars. But one shadow from the before wasn't happy about it."

He tapped at one part of the image, and then Catra fully saw it. Something in the black, a great skull grinning up at her.

"Nekron."

The air seemed to shudder from the mere presence of the name.

"What was he?" Catra whispered.

"Death," Saint Walker replied.

The next page depicted a vast horde of undead, an army that made Skeletor's look puny by comparison. The one in the lead was raising its hand, and on that hand was a black ring.

"Nekron had been planning this for ages, and had been quietly forging black rings out of the corpse of a fallen cosmic horror. The rings latched onto the dead, creating his own corps of Black Lanterns. They were tireless, they were difficult to kill, and they had intelligence enough to mock their target, emotionally torturing those who had a connection to them in life."

The final illustration that Saint Walker showed was of the vast army of black bearing down on ring-bearers of all colors. Green Lanterns were the point of the spear, with multiple colors right behind. But compared to the tide of darkness, the spear of light seemed very small.

"Nekron's goal was the destruction of all life, the return of the universe to its former dark state. He chose the various Lanterns as his first targets, wanting to first snuff out the light of the Emotional Spectrum, the scattered pieces of that first light. The Blackest Night saw enemies turn to allies to stop the end of everything."

Saint Walker sighed.

"So many dead. The Blue Lanterns were all but destroyed, Oa was reduced to dust, and countless other Lanterns lost their lives. Larfleeze, for all the might that being the sole wielder of a power amplified by greed gave him, was killed, and we're still not sure where his ring ended up. Sinestro too fell, helping defend Oa long enough for reinforcements to arrive, and leaving his Corps forever scattered and leaderless. The Star Sapphires, the Red Lanterns, they both took heavy losses. And then there was the Indigo Tribe, wielders of the Indigo Light of Compassion. They appeared

in our desperate hour, but when the war was won, vanished as mysteriously as they came. No one knows where they might be."

Saint Walker turned the page, revealing that the next several pages were entirely a list of names, the names of the fallen.

"The battle was won and Nekron was banished to the void between universes, but the cost…"

Catra's eyes raked over the names, a sense of mounting horror in her. She finally settled on a few she recognized.

Hal Jordan. Thal Sinestro. John Stewart. Kyle Rayner. Simon Baz.

oOo

Catra shivered in Adora's arms as they laid in bed that night.

"Looking at all the records, it was like looking at Horde Prime, but somehow worse."

Adora didn't answer, just held her love tight and stroked her mane.

It was a lesson they both knew all too well: the wider universe was full of wonder, but it was full of danger as well.

But isn't that why there were heroes?

Chapter End Notes

So, this is the status quo for the Green Lantern Corps. I hinted at it using Horde Prime, but here it is in full.
(strap in for a bit, because I'm yet again about to reveal what a colossal nerd I am, shocking I know)
A lot of stuff comes from events and concepts introduced by Geoff Johns, such as the Emotional Spectrum, Sinestro creating his own army of fear, the Black Lanterns, etc. But I did put my own spin on things. For example, Kraken, a Lantern from Apokolips. In the comics, she didn't do much, then became a cyborg, got possessed by the spirit of Granny Goodness, and hasn't been seen since Final Crisis. And I realize a lot of that probably sounded like gibberish to most of you, but that part's not important. Here though, I wed New God tech with Lantern tech, and make her a pseudo-mentor to Adora (at least that's the plan)
Other concepts include:
• Guy Gardner led a faction of Red Lanterns in the comics following Geoff John's departure from the books. Here, he's leading the whole thing, and Atrocitus is dead
• Saint Walker and his perpetually put-upon Blue Lanterns. Seriously, they've been getting whittled down since the Blackest Night event, and any chances to try and rebuild have been smacked down, it's weird.
• The Blackest Night, aka DC Universe vs. ZOMBIES. It ends a lot worse off here than in the comics, with several of the big Earth Lanterns dead

• Soranik Natu has a yellow ring. This is a more recent concept introduced in the lead-up to DC Rebirth, and is explored more in the Green Lantern Corps book of the initiative. Sadly, it doesn't end particularly well for Sora, which I EMPHATICALLY disagree with.
• Because I know some people are going to ask about it: Simon Baz, a character created near the end of Geoff Johns' run on the Lantern books. I like Simon, he's got an interesting backstory, but he does feel a little like an also-ran among the rest of the Earth Lanterns, at least to me. I did enjoy the Green Lanterns book in the DC Rebirth initiative, and he co-headlines it, so he has some good stories under his belt, but I wasn't really keen on dealing with him. So, he gets a heroic death alongside the other Earth Lanterns.

And finally, Jessica Cruz.

Jessica Cruz is my favorite Green Lantern.

Her origins here are ripped right from the comics, sans the stuff with the evil ring from another dimension (COMIC BOOKS, EVERYBODY!), but the bottom line is that she's a courageous woman given great power and trying to do right by it. She also suffers from really bad anxiety, and as someone with anxiety myself, I connect with her story of dealing with it while living her life and doing her job. There's an issue of the Green Lanterns book (#15 of the Rebirth one if you're interested) that's pretty much a slice of life for her, where she fights off an anxiety attack all day while working with the Justice League and fellow Lantern Simon, and then we see her dealing with it at home. There's this one bit where we visually see her bad thoughts spiraling out of control before she reasserts herself, reminding herself that she is not her thoughts and fears. It's a really good scene, and it cemented her as my favorite Lantern.

I highly recommend the Green Lanterns book from the Rebirth initiative. I also recommend the final sets of Justice League issues before Rebirth, which introduce Jessica, and the Justice League VS Fatal Five animated film in which she features prominently.

And of course, I recommend Geoff Johns' run on Green

Lantern. There is a reason that the man is considered one of DC's big-gun writers, and that run is one of the reasons.

Agent Orange

Chapter Notes

So, I don't really know if anyone really noticed, but in the last chapter, I mentioned that by this point in the timeline, Larfleeze was dead. BUT, his ring escaped.
His ring, powered by greed. Powered by the Orange Light of Avarice, which is at its strongest when used by a single user.
A ring that, like any other power ring, would seek out a new wielder.
Let's meet him, shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gold Light, Green Light

-

Chapter 18

Agent Orange

-

-

She didn't get to show off much, but Catra was actually a pretty good storyteller. As evidenced by the several Lanterns listening in rapt attention at the fairly sarcastic summary of some of the events of the Horde War.

"So despite my warnings not to, Entrapta sneaks into Hordak's lair to borrow a tool or two and sees what he's working on. While he's taking a break, she finishes his little doohickey, much to his

shock. Turns out, it was experiments into portals, and he reveals that he's from outer space, and he's trying to build a space portal to reconnect with his people. Horny for science Entrapta *immediately* volunteers to help."

Catra spread her arms wide.

"Ladies and Gentlemen, the weirdest couple you will ever see!"

"You know Kraken's dating Ch'p, right?" came a call from the peanut gallery.

"One of the weirdest couples you will ever see!" she rectified without missing a beat.

And then a loud siren blared throughout the area.

"The hell?"

"That's the general alarm!" one Lantern shouted.

oOo

“Feel the power within you. Let if fill you. Then let it fill your construct. It is your power, it follows your command, your will. Everything is will.”

Adora breathed in. Adora breathed out.

Blazing golden light surged across her constructed sword as she let out her breath.

“Very good,” Kraken said, “It came quick that time. I’m impressed. You sure you’ve never done anything like this before?”

“Nope,” Adora replied, dismissing the construct, “I’ve never really channeled She-Ra’s energy into my old sword, and with the new one, I was using either pure Lantern juice or the weird amalgam energy.”

“Well, you certainly picked it up faster than I did,” Kraken said as odd-colored electricity surged into her gauntleted hand, “I can instinctively call upon the old electrical tricks of my Mother Box and charge them into my constructs, but it took time to get to that point.”

And then a loud siren blared throughout the area.

“And it looks like we’ll have to rain-check the rest of our lesson,” she grimaced.

oOo

Jessica was happy that she'd had the foresight to bring her games. The much-loved device in her hands had gotten her through some rough days in the past.

She was deep into one of her favorites, and the target she'd been pursuing was in reach. She dealt the final blow, then crossed her fingers, her eyes glued to the screen.

And then a loud siren blared throughout the area.

"Ugh, timing!" she groaned.

When she looked back at the screen, the little ball made a satisfying click.

"Huh, timing," she said.

She quickly navigated to the pause menu to save her game.

"I'll give the Dratini a proper nickname later…"

oOo

Soranik stretched out her fingers, working the stress out of them.

"Okay, about halfway there. And it only took…two hours. Ugh, paperwork. I swear, if anything disrupts my momentum, I will—"

But before she could continue writing her reports, a loud siren blared throughout the area.

She growled as she stood up, both rings flashing.

"Okay, who do I need to smack?"

oOo

Daxam.

It was a fairly out-of-the-way planet. Despite its advances of science and technology that could easily allow it to reach to the stars, it had no major treaties with other systems. No trade routes went by it, and no communications were ever sent or received.

And frankly, that was how Daxam liked it.

The Daxamites were an intensely rigid and xenophobic people. While they were familiar with other planets and societies, they resoundingly rejected them. The last attempt to bring them into the wider galactic community had come within inches of turning violent thanks to the Daxamites' deeply-ingrained hate of anything different. Very few ever left the planet, free-willed outliers in their regimented and close-minded society.

Aside from their isolationist rhetoric, Daxam had one other claim to fame, although this one was far lesser known. Thousands of years prior, long before the xenophobia had taken root, a large group of exiles from the planet Krypton had settled on Daxam, interbreeding with the native populace. This resulted in the modern Daxamites possessing the same solar-charged physiology as their Kryptonian cousins. There were a few differences, of course, but the end result was the same. Under a yellow sun, a Daxamite could become a superman.

Their sun was a red star, however, so only those few that had left the planet had ever discovered those abilities.

Lex Luthor was about to change that.

He'd been slithering around Daxam for months, setting his devices in their communication relays and injecting his chemicals in their

water supplies. Each piece of the puzzle was his own design, and it was nearly ready.

He looked down on the planet with smirk.

"Don't take this the wrong way," he said, as if speaking to the populace, "I actually like your attitudes. If only my own planet had possessed the same foresight, it wouldn't be infected with alien outsiders now. But no, why would they listen to Lex Luthor? It's not like I'm one of, if not *the*, most intelligent men on Earth. I'm not bitter. Really."

He flicked his hand, and the trap snapped shut. On every screen on the planet below, lights and noise began. It interacted with the chemicals and simple-but-powerful nanobots that the Daxamites had consumed, and slowly every mind on the planet would know the same thing:

Obey Lex Luthor.

It would take time, but time was something he had. The second phase of his plan would need time to come to fruition.

The devices he'd sent toward the sun were even now creating what amounted to a focusing lens, altering the light wavelengths emitted by the star towards a certain direction. Soon, the light that fell on Daxam would be yellow. And after enough time, the

Daxamites below would have absorbed enough yellow sunlight to gain incredible powers.

"An army of Supermen, at my command," he grinned, "And from there, anything I wish will be in reach."

He took a look at the ring on his finger, the metal gleaming a wicked orange.

"It will be mine. It will *all* be mine, *mine, MINE!*"

oOo

"And that's our situation," Ganthet finished.

"Can we trust this report?" Kraken asked, voicing the question many of the assembled Lanterns had.

"His nickname might be on the strange side, but Space Cabbie's never steered us wrong," Kilowog replied, "His intel is always good."

"We're sure this is Lex Luthor?" Jessica piped up, "I mean, I've always wondered what happened to him, but…"

"The description matches the profile John Stewart wrote up," Salaak replied, projecting an image of a bald man, "It's him."

There was a small storm of noise amongst the older Lanterns.

"This guy's got a reputation I take it," Adora whispered to Jessica.

"Pretty major one, yeah," Jessica whispered back, "Business magnate, criminal mastermind, one of the few people with the stones to *regularly* try to kill an indestructible man…"

"Yikes."

"I'm pretty sure it's going to get worse."

"—and we have reason to believe he is in possession of an orange power ring," Ganthet was saying.

"And there it is," Jessica groaned, even as a storm of noise erupted around them.

It took some time before the Guardians and Salaak could calm everyone down, and then Ganthet continued, this time with visual

aids.

"For those of you unaware or need a refresher, an orange ring harnesses the Light of Avarice, and it is at its most powerful under a single wielder. With Larfleeze dead, it appears that Lex Luthor is now Agent Orange. In addition to the standard flight, energy shields, and energy blasts, his ring is capable of summoning an army of constructs, each with the visage and skills of someone the ring has killed. It also holds a much stronger charge than any other ring, so don't expect to win a war of attrition."

"Does it have a counter?" one Lantern asked.

"The Blue Light of Hope," Ganthet replied, "Therefore, Saint Walker will take point on this mission and engage Luthor with a select few Lanterns as back-up. The remainder of our forces will be charged with containing the Daxamites he has under his sway."

Saint Walker stepped forward and began picking out his squad. Kraken pulled Adora aside.

"I want you on my squad dealing with the Daxamites," she said, "Kryptonians have a vulnerability to magical forces, and if their distant cousins share that weakness…"

"Then She-Ra will be able to take then down much easier than the rest of you," Adora nodded, "Understood. I'll follow your lead."

“Then let’s get to work.”

oOo

In hindsight, Lex should have figured that someone would try to interfere. He was just so caught up in his moment of victory that he overlooked that fact.

But getting smacked out of the sky by a giant green hammer was a hell of a wake-up call.

As he shook his head and refocused, then grimaced.

“Ah, right. Lanterns. No matter, I planned for this.”

Orange armor encased his form, and he rose up to face off against the two dozen Lanterns surrounding him.

“The smart thing to do would be to flee,” he said, “Enough Daxamites have absorbed yellow sunlight to easily back me up.”

“Then where are they?” asked the blue-clad alien leading the squad.

Before Lex could answer, the Lanterns fired. While he easily blocked the green beams with an energy shield, the blue beam popped it like a soap bubble.

Saint Walker was upon him like lightning, his body encased in a blue aura. He unleashed a series of rapid and graceful strikes, then physically threw Lex to the ground, firing a ball of blue energy after him.

Lex dodged the follow-up attack, frowning at the state of his constructed armor. Where his foe had touched, the orange 'metal' was damaged, like it had been eaten away by acid.

"This could be a problem."

Changing tactics, he summoned a small army of construct warriors and sent them on the attack. One Lantern was caught unprepared, and a sword pierced her gut. As she fell to the ground, an orange light was left in her place, which quickly grew sharper.

Identity consumed. Aliza T'Soni, you belong to Agent Orange.

This would turn out to be a mistake, as the rest of the Lanterns began fighting all the harder, intent on avenging their fallen

comrade. The new orange warrior burst under a hail of green lights, the mockery deemed an insult.

Then they turned to Lex. Multiple green beams shot his way, but he flew and dodged them. Beams and missiles of orange light shot from his armor, scattering his foes.

He took the opportunity to order a few of his construct warriors to scatter, concerned about Saint Walker's previous taunt. Then he leapt back into the fray.

oOo

A hammer, green in color but shining with golden light, slammed down. Three Daxamites were knocked out on impact.

"I'm actually surprised at how easy this is," She-Ra said.

"I'm not," Jessica replied, "I'm familiar with the last Kryptonians. They've kind of set themselves up as protectors of my home planet. They're vulnerable to magic, but have years of training and experience to help them power through it or work around it."

"Whereas Luthor's army are all raw recruits," Kraken surmised, letting loose a storm of green lightning.

"Other squads r*rrrr*eporting in," rumbled the hulking Lantern Volk, "Controlled Daxamites down to appr*rrr*oximately fifty percent. Although *pluk-pluk*, our group has had the m*mmm*ost luck. Must be *rumble* the magic sword."

Adora thought that Volk was a nice guy. But it was odd that he had a volcano for a face. As in, a literal volcano where his head should be.

Outer space was weird.

She put it out of her mind as she cast a wide arc of power, knocking down a few more Daxamites. So long as nothing untoward happened, things should wrap up soon…

A flare of orange light appeared on the horizon, and a new form rocketed toward them.

"Heads up, he figured it out!" Jessica shouted.

"Shields!" Kraken ordered.

It didn't matter. Lex Luthor plowed right through them.

Jessica went down with a spear to her side and a punch to her face. Volk sprayed fire from his head to make Luthor back off before grabbing her and spiriting her away.

In revenge, Kraken shot Lex with several hundred volts from her gauntlet, but he powered through and shot a missile at point-blank range, sending her hurtling into a building. Her New God physiology and tech let her survive the attack, but it still knocked her for a loop.

Luthor started firing missiles and spears all around them. The remaining Lanterns bobbed and weaved, but any retaliations were blocked by an energy field.

"You just had to interfere!" he was shouting, "This is my world now, MINE! I won't let you take it from me! I'm Lex Luthor! Power is my right!"

He blasted the Lanterns away, his armor glowing a harsh orange light.

"I will use that power, take what I wish…and anyone who gets in my way will perish! You, the rest of the Lanterns, the Justice League, *anyone!*"

He gave a mad smile.

“I think after this, I’ll start with Superman. To thine own self be true, after all.”

Then a sword shining green-and-gold went right through his shoulder.

“Not while I’m still standing.”

The power of Etheria coursed through the Sword of Courage, lighting up him like a Christmas tree. He let off a pulse of energy to dislodge his attacker, but it was clear that he’d taken some damage. He snarled as he willed his ring to knit his wound together.

“Another knuckle-dragging buffoon, full of self-righteousness, trying to challenge the greatest mind in the universe,” he scoffed, facing his new opponent.

“If you’re so smart, why are you having so much trouble?” She-Ra smirked, “And all this new power, and you still zero in on the one guy you’re personally obsessed with. You’re pathetic, you know that?”

Lex scowled and went on the attack, beams of energy racing towards Adora. But her sword glowed with mystical might, and she parried the beams as she charged. Luthor managed to parry her sword strike, but it still bit deeply into his gauntlet.

And the follow-up punch certainly rang his bell.

Lex erected a shield around himself to give himself some breathing room.

"That…that was nearly Kryptonian-level. Who *are* you?"

"Stronger than you!" Adora replied, even as she started hacking away at the shield, her sword blazing between gold and green-and-gold.

He blasted her, but she bounced right back. She punched him again, but he righted himself in the air and shot back toward her. He summoned a few warriors, she decapitated them with her sword. She shot blazing golden energy, he reacted in kind.

Again and again the two slammed into each other, magic and might clashing with anger and avarice.

"You can't win!" Lex shouted, "My ring contains far more power than yours!"

"I'm not just using my ring!" She-Ra shouted back, shooting him out of the sky with a wave of gold.

As it impacted, he willed his ring to scan the energy. When it came back with a garbled mess, he understood.

"Magic," he spat, "I hate magic. It doesn't follow any logical rules! The tool of lesser minds!"

"You'd know, tool!" Adora spat back, summoning a barrage of green-and-gold meteors.

Away from the battle, Kraken looked with a practiced eye. Adora was holding her own, but the orange ring was too powerful. They needed something to tip the scales.

"Kraken to Saint Walker, where are you? Lex has engaged Daxamite Squad Alpha over the capitol. Adora's holding her own with her magic powers, but we need assistance."

"Arisia Rrab here. Walker's down. When he escaped us, Luthor used a holdout laser gun instead of his ring. Walker didn't see it coming. He should be fine, but he's not going to be combat ready for a while. I'm evac-ing him as we speak. Sorry, Kraken."

Kraken scowled.

"Okay then…I've had enough of this guy. He wants power so bad, I'll give it to him."

Adora panted heavily, a pausing in the fight happening.

"You don't know when to quit, do you?" Luthor scowled as he caught his own breath.

"That's what they tell me."

BOOOOM!!!

A tunnel of bright light appeared next to them. Kraken came charging in, tackling Lex toward it. He tried to struggle, but then She-Ra entered the fray.

"Keep pushing!" Kraken shouted over the noise, "Get him into the Boom Tube!"

The two Lanterns entered the wormhole, shoving Lex through.

Lights of every color surrounded them, swirling in a fantastic display of crackling energy. Lex struggled the whole way, but they kept pushing. Finally, after what seemed like ages, they emerged in a different place.

“Bail out!” Kraken shouted, and the two kicked away from Lex.

He slammed into a new surface. Scowling, he tried to launch himself away…

But he couldn’t.

Looking down, he saw his limbs taking on dull hue. He looked around, seeing giant screaming faces around him.

And he realized with mounting horror where he was. He’d only heard of it in passing, but he *knew*.

The orange ring slipped from his finger, like a rat escaping a sinking ship. Lex Luthor was left only able to scream, a scream that was cut off as the transformation reached his head.

Adora and Kraken floated a ways away, watching as their foe’s fate was sealed.

“Kraken,” Adora said hesitantly, “What just happened?”

"Beyond all conventional space and time, there is a Wall," Kraken intoned, reciting a legend from memory, "This Wall guards unimaginable power and mystery. It is encrusted with the husks of old gods and cosmic titans, as well as those who have tried to breach the Wall and learn the secrets beyond."

Kraken waved her hand at the infinite expanse of ancient metal and petrified giants.

"All have failed. And the Source Wall, the barrier at the edge of infinity, keeps its secrets. So it has before, so it always will."

Adora gulped, feeling the solemn weight of the situation.

"Note to self," she muttered, "*Never* tell Entrapta about this."

"You did good out there, though," Kraken said, her tone lighter, "You held him off for longer than anyone else could have. And now he won't threaten anyone else."

"So this is what we do? I've heard stories, but…experiencing it is different."

"It's a big universe," Kraken replied, "A dangerous one, too. A lot of things out there want nothing more than to hurt anything they can. To be a Green Lantern is to stand between all that hurt and people who cannot stand against it themselves."

Adora pondered that for a moment.

"So what now?" she finally asked.

"I make another Boom Tube back to Daxam, we finish cleaning up there, then we head back to Mogo. Drinks on me."

"So you can go anywhere with these things?" Adora asked, an idea coming to her.

"Pretty much."

"And you came here from some other dimension…place using one."

"Yeah, what are you getting at?"

"Could one reach a point between? Between one dimension and another?"

Kraken thought for a moment. She tapped at her gauntlet. It made a *ping* noise, which only Kraken seemed to understand.

"Possibly, but I'd need more information. Why do you ask?"

"An old friend needs help, and I think you can help her."

"Okay, you're being mysterious and kind of weird."

"I'm weird?" Adora laughed, "Aren't you dating the squirrel?"

"It's an asexual romantic relationship, and I'm tired of people giving me funny looks," Kraken grumbled.

oOo

Catra hated being left out. But she couldn't fly, Daxamites were apparently too strong and tough for her, and all the veteran Lanterns were worried about this orange ring business, which meant it must be seriously bad news.

So, if only to stop herself from going stir-crazy, she'd asked Soranik if she could help with any wounded.

This turned out to be fortunate. Several Lanterns had taken bad hits from the controlled Daxamites, and a few more had engaged

Lex Luthor himself and gotten messed up for their trouble. So Sora was happy for the extra set of hands.

"Sorry, Iolande, but you're going to need surgery," Sora was saying, "Don't worry, it's more annoying than major. You'll be out before tomorrow. Just try to get some sleep in the meantime."

"Could I have more painkillers first?"

"I'll give you a minor increase. If you're still in pain in the next half-hour, we'll see about more."

Soranik fiddled with her patient's IV before turning away.

"Catra, how we doing?"

"Everyone else is comfortable for now. No major issues, although Jessica is still up in the air," Catra replied, "That might have to wait until she wakes up, though."

"Fair enough. At least we can take a breath. Then I need to set up for Iolande's surgery."

The two walked toward Sora's office, still talking.

“What kind of hit was it, anyway?” Catra asked.

“Shattered bones in her leg. All goes well, there won’t even be a limp.”

“Wow. Miracles of modern medicine.”

“Too true, too true.”

“Actually, I’ve been meaning to ask your opinion as a surgeon.”

“Is this about that foreign matter I detected near your spine during my initial scans?” Soranik asked with a raised eyebrow, “The one you brushed off at the time.”

Catra sighed.

“Sensitive topic.”

Catra waited until they were in the office, then closed the door.

"You've heard about the Horde Prime stuff, right?"

"The cosmic cultist you and Adora took down? Yes, what of it?"

"Well, he liked to use these mind control chips on the more stubborn races he conquered…and he used them on a chunk of Etheria, myself included."

Soranik flinched, then got a look of understanding on her face.

"And your planet's surgical tech isn't up to the job of getting everything."

"When Entrapta crashed the network, everyone fell into three camps," Catra explained, "One, those who hadn't been chipped long, so everything just fell off. Two, people like me who'd either been chipped longer or had Prime personally messing with them, so the entire chip couldn't be removed without danger."

"Even surgically," Sora frowned.

Catra snapped her fingers, then continued.

"And three, those who'd been chipped the longest, with large portions of the chip still in them. Entrapta and the clones we

rescued had removed everything that would connect them to the hive mind, just in case something got tripped, but the majority of the chip would still be attached in a way that made surgical removal…Entrapa said problematic, so we'll go with that. There's also my friend Scorpia. She would have been in the second group, but her exoskeleton and subdermal armor forced Prime's forces to use surgical methods to chip her, and she's just too tough for us to try anything without a lot of help. Even Hordak, the most developed clone, he claimed that removal would be really risky, and he knows this kind of implant stuff."

"If it took that much effort to chip her, I'm surprised Horde Prime even bothered, cult leader shtick aside."

"She's really strong, really tough, and has potent electrical powers. He probably saw potential for a powerful enforcer."

"Point," Soranik shrugged, "If you don't mind subjecting yourself to some more scans and tests, I can puzzle something out. Might take time to get something concrete, though."

"Great. The pieces aren't doing anything, but the fact they're there was been bothering me for…"

Catra looked away with a grimace.

"…a while."

"Well, whatever we think up, we'll bring to the Guardians. They'll probably want to package chip removal in any diplomatic overtures to the now-freed Horde space. Like you said, it's doubtful that your planet was the only one he used these chips on."

Suddenly, Soranik's ring started beeping. She projected a readout from it and grimaced.

"It's Jessica, her heartrate is spiking."

Catra was out the door before Soranik had even finished speaking. In moments, she was in front of Jessica's bed. Her friend was breathing heavily, her pupils were like pinpricks, and her body was shaking.

Catra knew instantly what was wrong.

She grabbed Jessica's hand and shoulder and started talking slowly and clearly. She heard Soranik slide up behind her, but ignored the doctor, concentrating on Jessica.

"Jess, Jess, hey, it's okay. Whatever you think, it's not real. You're safe. I'm right here."

Jessica still shuddered, but her breathing started to level out.

"Good, that's good. Keep breathing just like that. Nice and slow, in and out. Now, tell me three things you can see…"

Jessica panted a bit before answering.

"Uh…you, some lights…Sora?"

"Good, good. Now, two things you can hear."

"Some coughing over there…and a whipping noise?"

"That's my tail. Now, one thing you can touch or feel."

"The blanket?"

"Good, good."

Jessica let out a breath, feeling her heart calming.

"What was that?"

"Centering exercise. My friend Perfuma taught me. It's good for anxiety, helps ground yourself in reality and give you something to focus on. Personally, I add smell to the list, but my nose is pretty strong. Really works, huh?"

By this point, Jessica had fully calmed, and was looking at Catra oddly.

"You were taught…wait, do you have anxiety?"

Catra paused, then looked over at Soranik.

"Could you give us a bit?"

When the doctor had given them space, Catra turned back.

"Adora and I both do, to some extent," she replied candidly, "I'm surprised you didn't notice. We had really terrible childhoods. Our mother figure, and I use the term *very* loosely, was abusive. And she was very good at pulling our strings without us realizing it, so even after she was mostly out of the picture, she'd find ways to screw with us."

Catra sighed.

"Things are a lot better now. We're both getting therapy, we have better coping mechanisms, we have each other to lean on when things get difficult, and Shadow Weaver is in no position to mess with our minds anymore."

"She in prison?"

"Better. Dead."

Jessica balked.

"And don't even try to offer any sort of apologies," Catra continued, ears pinned back, "I practically spat on her grave. Adora's the one who put it best; all Shadow Weaver ever did was ruin people, ruin any chance that they can find happiness. When she died, Adora and I promised that we'd live our lives on our own terms, that we'd do whatever it took to find happiness with each other after so long with that magical bitch trying to tear us apart. She died as she lived: trying to give us severe trauma. This time, though, we didn't take that lying down."

Catra's vehemence calmed, and she chuckled.

"Our therapist told us that living well was the best revenge. I take some comfort in the fact that, while she's rotting in Hell, she has to watch us be happy and can't do a damn thing about it."

“That’s…a little dark…”

“If it works,” Catra shrugged, “You okay?”

“I…think so?”

“Well, take it easy for a few days, you got stabbed in the side. Luckily, it missed anything vital. Now, let’s make sure you don’t have a concussion. Follow my finger…”

Catra went through a brief checklist, confirming that Jessica was shaken but fine. Once she was done, the Lantern spoke up.

“Think you can teach me a few of those techniques?”

“Tell you what, come to dinner with me and Adora and we’ll talk. I’ll cook.”

“So long as you don’t give me food poisoning.”

“Don’t insult me,” Catra said wryly.

Chapter End Notes

Jessica likes Pokémon, it’s canon.
The volcano-faced Lantern is also canon.
Kraken and Ch’p…is not canon. Ch’p was canonically dead long before Kraken was created. I just thought it’d be funny.

For the Kids

Chapter Notes

Certain dialogue beats lovingly ripped off from Alan Moore. You'll know.

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 19

For the Kids

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Guy Gardner was a jerk.

He was loud, crude, and had a very long streak of anger.

But, despite his overall boorish appearance and attitude, he was *not* a simple man. He was well aware of his shortcomings, and confident enough in himself to live and thrive with them. Who cared what others thought, he knew who he was.

He was also not a stupid man. One didn't get to have the leadership positions he'd had by being dumb. Champion quarterback in high school. Head coach of a multi-year champion

team for that same high school. Justice League member. Green Lantern Honor Guardsman.

And now this. Taking a bunch of bloody berserkers and transforming them into a force for good.

It certainly wasn't easy. Red rings did…interesting things to the bearer's psyche. And they were often attracted to those who had enormous rage in their hearts, the kind that only came with having the universe repeatedly stomp on you until you were half-broken. For example, Guy's second-in-command had seen her planet ravaged and had her wings viciously ripped apart before being sold into slavery, and not the hard labor kind. And in this volatile stew of emotions, the rings came, ramping up what they were feeling to maddening levels. Most new bearers of red rings were practically animals, lashing out at anything that moved and several things that didn't. Things usually leveled off after the first week, but it still took work to get them to the level of a functioning sapient.

Atrocitus, the creator of the red rings and the first leader of the organization, hadn't cared. He wanted an untiring army, juggernauts of destruction, his Warriors of Rage. He didn't care about who got hurt in his quest for vengeance, be it innocents or his own people.

So it was a good thing he was extra-dead.

As for Guy, it had been a genuine shock that Atrocitus' ring had chosen him. An even greater shock when the ring hadn't

immediately driven him to madness. He'd chalked it up to his well-channeled inner anger, as well as retaining possession of his green ring to help even things out, and moved on.

So now he was a teacher of a different sort. He'd seen the red ring wielders directionless after Atrocitus' death, and taken it upon himself to mold them into something better. Again, it wasn't always easy, but seeing his Red Lanterns improve a little every day was worth it. And seeing a growing number of them jumping into doing good, that was even better.

Still, it wasn't all sunshine and roses. They weren't Green Lanterns. Their mentality was different for one thing. The kinds of crimes that attracted a Red Lantern to intervene were usually violent crimes, the kinds where they could exercise some justified vengeance. They weren't built for certain things.

He was looking over one of those things right now.

A streak of red light landed next to him, and he turned to his second-in-command.

"How's it looking, Bleez?"

"Rough," the blue-skinned woman said, the skeletal remains of her wings shivering on her back, "We're just not built for this, Guy. Dex-Starr is having the least trouble, but…"

"But even a cat's patience is limited, yeah, I hear you. And it's not fair to dump it all on two Lanterns."

"Even if one of them is our illustrious leader?" Bleez replied with a smile.

"Stroke my ego, why don't you?" Guy smiled back, then soured, "We can't do this ourselves, you know that, right?"

Bleez sighed.

"Yeah…go ahead and call them."

Guy nodded and raised his right hand, where his green ring sat gleaming. A sudden screech broke his concentration. Bleez sighed.

"See, this? This is why I never wanted kids."

oOo

"Repeat that for me, Guy? Children?" Salaak asked.

The figure in the viewscreen looked contrite.

"Yeah, my Reds busted up a sentient trafficking ring yesterday, but found out too late that it specialized in children. Lot of different species and ages. We're kind of in over our heads."

"And you need help taking care of them and returning them to their families."

"You guys have a more extensive network then we do, so we could use some help," Guy nodded, "*Also, a few ships, and people who are better with kids. I mean, I was a teacher, but I'm only one guy and there are a lot of kids."*

"I'll start drumming up volunteers, and go through my contacts for some ships to help. You didn't take the children back to Ysmault, did you?"

"*I'm not* that *dumb*," Guy scoffed, "*A lot of these kids are already traumatized, and Ysmault isn't exactly a hospitable place. Transmitting our coordinates. Don't dawdle."*

oOo

When the call went out, Adora had immediately volunteered.

"I have my own spaceship, just seems right to use it."

Catra had rolled her eyes as she got the *Starshine* ready.

"Forgot for a second I was dating a girl with a hero complex."

They landed on a fairly barren world, the kind of backwater place that had made it a good rest-point for smugglers of all kinds.

Adora headed down to the cargo hold where Catra and Jessica were double-checking the area. Blankets and food rations had been stacked up and ready.

"We good?" she asked.

"As ready as we'll ever be," Jessica replied, rubbing her hands anxiously.

"So, let's go meet the brats," Catra said.

They headed outside, noting a few Green Lanterns guiding in three more ships. Spotting Kilowog, Adora and Catra headed over.

Kilowog was talking to a human in a red and black jacket, two more aliens at his side.

"Ah, Adora," Kilowog said, "This is Guy Gardner, and his second Bleez. Guy, this is Adora, a rookie. She came with her own starship, so that's why she's here."

"And I came with her," Catra added with a hum.

Suddenly, she locked eyes with the third red-garbed alien. Her ears shot up, and her tail started to lash.

"Catra? What's wrong?" Adora asked.

Guy made an amused noise, gesturing to the small blue feline floating next to him.

"Your friend's in a staring contest. This is Dex-Starr, our resident angry kitty."

Adora relaxed, giggling a bit over how serious the two felines looked.

"That's Catra," Adora said, "*My* angry kitty."

Catra and Dex-Starr continued to stare at each other before the Red Lantern hissed. Catra hissed right back, matching the tone and adding "yourself" at the end.

The two stared at each other for a moment more, neither breaking their gaze. Finally, Dex-Starr's tail flicked happily.

"Not bad, orrrange girrrrl. You have my rrrrrespect."

"Congrats, kid," Guy said, "You got him to talk, and you got his respect. Double points."

"Back to business, you were talking about the kids?" Kilowog asked.

"Yeah, I've managed to sort them into groups based upon star clusters and sectors, that sort of thing. Tasked a few older ones with watching the younger ones, which was a real god-send. Dex and I are the only ones with experience working with kids, but we were getting a bit overwhelmed."

Guy grinned ruefully.

"And I didn't want to leave Dex alone with them for too long. Especially after what happened to one of the slavers."

"I'm going to regret asking, but what happened?" Adora asked.

"Gutted like a fish," Bleez deadpanned, while Dex-Starr calmly licked his paw.

"We're not nice people, kid," Guy added in response to Adora's queasy look.

"We managed to get Rog to game returns out," Bleez continued, holding out a datapad, "He's surprisingly good with numbers, but maybe you should look over it first. And there is one other problem."

"The miscellaneous grrrrroup," Dex-Starr hummed.

"Several kids either couldn't tell us where they were from for one reason or another, or simply had no desire to return. Didn't have a home, ran away from abuse before being picked up, lotta reasons," Guy said, "Not sure what to do with them, honestly."

"Well, we'll bring them to Mogo and sort it out there," Kilowog said, "Any luck, some of the Lanterns know families looking to adopt."

"Wouldn't it be funny if one of them ended up getting picked by a green ring?" Catra chuckled.

"Ha! If by some miracle that happens, I'll owe you a drink," Kilowog laughed.

"Make it a nice fish and you've got a deal."

Dex-Starr gave a hissing laugh.

"Cleverrrr girrrrl."

oOo

There were almost two dozen kids in Adora's group, all different ages and species. Letting Mara fly them back to Mogo, Adora, Catra, and Jessica kept the kids occupied.

Mostly Adora and Jessica. While several kids were fascinated by Catra, she kept her distance after a younger one pulled on her tail.

Finally, Adora got an idea.

“You all want to hear a story?”

That caught the attention of several, and the rest were quickly added to the herd. With Melog curled around the three youngest and Jessica and Catra hanging in the back, Adora began to speak in a clear tone.

“I am Adora of Etheria. I was raised in the army of a mighty warlord named Hordak. But one day, I found out that the Horde were not the heroes I had been taught. That same day, I discovered a magic sword.”

From behind her back, she summoned her blade, then brought it out for them to see.

“Fabulous secrets and powers were revealed to me when I held it aloft and said FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!”

There was a flash of golden light, and the children gasped at the transformation.

“And I become She-Ra, the Princess of Power and the Defender of Etheria!”

“And a Green Lantern, right?” one little girl asked.

“No, that came later,” She-Ra replied casually, “But let me take you on my journey…”

Catra looked on as Adora told her story, obviously cleaned up for smaller ears, and she smiled.

“She’s good at that,” Jessica whispered to her.

“Yeah, she’s better with kids than me.”

“They liked you well enough. Must be the fuzz. It’s cute.”

Catra reached over and flicked her.

“Hey!”

“That word is Adora-only,” Catra grumbled.

oOo

They got back to Mogo quickly enough, and were greeted at their landing pad by Salaak and Saint Walker, who directed them to housing that had been set up. Adora hummed at the series of shelters erected next to a forest.

"Why do those seem like they've been grown out of the woods?"

"Probably because they are," Salaak said.

Adora looked at him strangely, not picking up on the muffled giggles coming from Catra and Jessica.

"What do you mean?"

As an answer, Saint Walker spoke loudly.

"Who wants to hear a tale of the Green Lantern Corps?"

Eager for another story, the children gathered around, and Saint Walker began to tell his tale.

"We begin with a man known as Bolphunga the Unrelenting. He was a warrior, with great feats of strength and skill to his name. He'd beaten a long list of mighty contenders, and got it in his head to challenge a legendary Green Lantern. These were the

days when that Lantern had more mystery about him, his name spoken of in hushed tones.

"He tracked the Lantern down to a verdant planet, landing on it easily and calling out his challenge. But the Lantern did not answer. Bolphunga wandered through the thick forest, cutting away at the brush and roaring out his challenges. But he found no takers.

"Indeed, try as he might, he found no trace of intelligent life on the planet at all…save for one thing. The foliage had obviously been cut and tended by some higher life form. There were large clearings, the edges too neat to be natural. There were places where the greenery had been clipped into vast and indecipherable shapes…"

The children were rapt, and Adora found herself paying a lot of attention to the story. She idly wondered why Saint Walker hadn't given the name of this Lantern…

"Weeks turned to months, and months to years. Bolphunga grew methodical in his search, drawing painstakingly-detailed maps. But there was no trace of his quarry. Then one night, he grew more frustrated than usual. He poured over his maps, and finally saw something. The shapes cut into the greenery made a pattern, one he hadn't noticed before. He put his maps together like the pieces of a puzzle, and what he saw filled him with complete, soul-shaking *horror*."

Saint Walker took a breath, letting the sentence hang, and then continued.

"And so Bolphunga the Unrelenting…well, relented. He raced back to his ship like all the demons of Tartaros were after him. He careened into the void of space, not as a mighty warrior, but as a wailing blob of terror.

"As his craft burst free of the atmosphere, he looked back once, just once. Looked back at the carpet of forest that covered a continent, looked back at the design carved into that forest…"

At Walker's gesture, Salaak projected a construct of a ship launching from a planet, the shape of it changing as the perspective shifted. And then the planet turned…

"Looked back…and saw the Green Lantern known as *MOGO*."

Adora nearly swallowed her tongue.

"Wait, *what?*"

And the ground beneath then rumbled, a noise not unlike deep laughter echoing through the air.

CHILDREN…YOU ARE WELCOME TO THIS WORLD…TO ME…

And then Catra and Jessica couldn't hold it in any longer, and collapsed to the ground, laughing.

"You freaking traitors! You knew, and you let me get blindsided!" Adora screamed, even as several children began to laugh at her shock.

"Don't take it personally," Saint Walker said, "It's sort of a rite-of-passage for older Lanterns to freak the rookies out with the story. Besides, Mogo doesn't socialize…usually."

The ground rumbled again, the laughter of a living planet.

oOo

Elyzia of Thanagar. You have the ability to overcome great fear. Welcome to the Green Lantern Corps.

She kept turning the words over and over in her head. Despite the ring on her finger, she could still barely believe it. A month ago, she'd been a runaway from the foster system, fleeing from a series of circumstances that she didn't want to dwell on. Two weeks ago, she'd been a prisoner, set to be sold into slavery. A

few days ago, she was arriving on Mogo, being told that they'd help her find somewhere to call home.

Now, it appeared home would be Mogo itself. She still wasn't sure what to think. A part of her was disappointed, she'd been oddly looking forward to meeting with that uncle that Lantern Rrab had spoken of, the one willing to be a foster parent. Graxos IV would have been different from Thanagar, but considering everything that had happened to her there, she was in no hurry to go back.

"Guess I got my wish there," she muttered.

And now? Now she was part of a larger world. Or at least, about to take her first steps into it.

The young teen, barely thirteen summers, touched down near the training course. She immediately spotted two familiar faces, and they spotted her as well.

"Elyzia, right?" Adora asked, "Nice to have you with us."

"You nervous?" Jessica asked.

"You can tell?" Elyzia said self-deprecatingly.

Jessica just hummed.

"I didn't see a green aura when you came in. Not used to your ring?" Adora asked.

"Not really," Elyzia replied, her hawk-like wings rustling nervously.

"Well, look at the bright side. You'll probably be the best flier in your class. You've already got experience."

"Better than Adora," Jessica chuckled, "She still flies like a thrown rock."

"Hey!"

This elicited a small laugh out of Elyzia, which the older women considered a victory.

Then the Thanagarian spotted something out of the corner of her eye.

"What's Miss Catra doing here?"

“Stalking Kilowog so he can’t welch on that bet,” Adora deadpanned, “Just ignore her, she’s just being competitive.”

As the training class was called to order, Jessica had Elyzia stick close to her and Adora, the two taking the teen under their wing.

They laughed about the pun later.

oOo

Esme fought down her tears. The older kids had told her not to go too deep into the woods, but she’d gone anyway. The planet was alive, after all, surely it could help her.

But Mogo was a busy one. And Esme was so very small.

A rustling in the leaves made her pick her head up, her heart in her throat. But out of the branches slinked an orange and red form.

“Miss Catra!”

“There you are! Melog and I have been looking all over for you,” Catra said, jumping to the ground.

Esme ran to hug her, her breath hitching. Melog stepped out of the foliage, sniffing at the girl. She looked at Catra with a sad expression.

Fear. The kitten is afraid.

"Were you scared, little one?" Catra asked.

She felt Esme nodding against her stomach. Catra held her close, running her fingers through the little girl's purple hair.

"You're okay, now. No one's going to hurt you. You're safe."

They sat there for awhile until Esme could pull herself together. Then Catra plunked the little girl on Melog's back. Esme grinned as she held on, Melog purring at her.

"So how'd you find me?" Esme asked.

"I'm a good tracker," Catra said, "I can see, hear, and smell extremely well. I was able to pick up on your trail."

"Was it hard?"

“Not really.”

“How come you don’t have a ring like the other big people?”

“I’m not actually a Lantern. I just came to support my girlfriend, who is.”

“Miss Adora?”

“Yeah, that’s her,” Catra chuckled, “The dummy would be lost without me. You ask a lot of questions.”

Esme just shrugged, and kept talking. Catra let her. Anything to get the girl’s mind off the dark and scary woods.

However, it was the last question, asked as they broke the tree line, that tripped her up.

“Are you and Miss Adora gonna get married?”

Catra didn’t have an answer for her.

oOo

Hours later, she still didn't.

It wasn't something Catra had thought about. Given her upbringing, both Shadow Weaver's influence and the general militaristic culture of the Horde, romance hadn't been something she considered for the longest time. It really wasn't until Adora had left that Catra started to confront just *why* she was missing her friend so much. And even then, it took a lot of time and more than one stumbling block to fully admit it.

And then suddenly, there she was, kissing her back. There they were, together in every way.

What she and Adora had…it was comfortable where it was. But Catra would be kidding herself if she didn't sometimes have dark thoughts about how it might end. Thanks to therapy, she recognized that those thoughts were just her fears, not truly hers. Support from her friends and girlfriend helped her keep them away.

And now a new thought was in her head, and it wouldn't leave.

So, drawing upon all the lessons she learned in therapy, she went to talk to a friend about her thoughts…

“Honestly, I don’t know what to tell you,” Soranik said.

“Come on, Sora! You’re the only friend I have in reach that’s mastered adulting,” Catra moaned, “You’re seriously telling me you have no frame of reference for this?”

“Unfortunately, no,” the doctor sighed, “The longest relationship I had was with Kyle Rayner.”

Catra’s exasperation evaporated upon recognition of the name.

“It didn’t end the way you’re thinking it did,” Soranik said, “We were happy, but we eventually grew apart. He was a free spirit, loved to travel, I was more down to earth and liked stability. I was still reeling from my POW days, and he didn’t know how to help me. It was an amicable parting, at least. He was a good man, but he wasn’t what I needed long-term. We stayed friends, though, and I spoke of him at the post-Blackest Night memorial.”

Soranik gave her a kind look.

“My best advice for you? Do what feels right.”

“And if I’m wrong?” Catra asked hesitantly.

"Honestly, I think you'll be fine. That girl looks at you like you hung the moon. Whatever you two decide, it'll work out."

Code Yellow

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Gold Light, Green Light

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Chapter 20

Code Yellow

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The Sinestro Corps was dead.

For a time, they were a serious threat, unleashing fear and devastation across the stars, feeding an engine of war against the Green Lantern Corps. But the Green Light won against the Yellow. The central battery of the Sinestro Corp was destroyed, and Sinestro himself captured.

His corps limped along, helped by a second, smaller battery hidden away for safekeeping. But the Blackest Night shredded much of their remaining numbers, the black god Nekron attacking them to ensure they wouldn't be a threat.

And with the death of Sinestro in the final battle of the Night, his dream of universal order through fear was doomed. Few bearers of the yellow light remained. Most served under Arkillo and Lyssa Drak, laying low and biding their time in the criminal underworld.

But some were not content to lick their wounds. Four of them had stolen a ship equipped with a powerful stealth drive and used it to infiltrate Mogo…

oOo

Romat Ru *really* wanted to kill something. Preferably one of his targets, but he'd settle for one of his teammates if he had to.

It was unfortunate, considering he liked Karu-Sil in a professional capacity. But the fanged woman was extra surly today, and it was starting to get excruciatingly annoying. He supposed he couldn't blame her, even as she heard her snarl deeply at another member of their squad. She had been raised by lupine creatures, and felt most at home amongst the wildest places. So having a teammate be a ruthless hunter was…trying.

Hasp the Hunter was a cruel soul, a poacher and big game hunter that had led a galactic-scale endangered species trade before the Green Lanterns had finally taken him down. Romat had read of his exploits, and of the conditions of his animals. It was downright cruel and often sadistic, something he privately applauded. Not that he'd ever voice that in Karu's vicinity, lest she tear his throat out with her teeth. It was a wonder she hadn't done it to Hasp. *Yet*.

The final member of their squad wasn't helping. Tekik was a robotic lifeform, responsible for a virus that had driven the entire population of his world mad with fear. He had an extremely clinical view on the universe, and if an interpersonal thing didn't interest him, he ignored it. As such, he made no moves to intervene when Karu and Hasp started something.

It was starting to piss Romat off.

Another growl from Karu, followed up by a harsh word from Hasp, made him groan.

"Girls, girls, you're both pretty," Romat huffed, "But if you don't mind, I'm trying to accomplish a mission. We've made it into the city, so can we just get the residential sector quietly, slit a few throats, and be on our way?"

"Why did we even need *him*?" Karu growled, "I'm far stealthier than he is."

"Ah yes, hunting with the bright yellow images of your old wild family, that's unnoticeable," Hasp scoffed.

Karu tried to lunge at him, but Romat dragged her back. He looked at Tekik, but the robot was annoyingly silent.

“I will gut you, hunter!”

“Not if I get you first, wild-woman!”

“Alright, enough!” Romat shouted, resisting the urge to bang his head against the nearest wall, “I get it, you hate each other, but is it too much to ask for you both to suck it up? Or do you want to attract attention before we can kill a few Lanterns?”

“Too late.”

The hiss from above made them all look. Crouched on the edge of a roof was a feline form, staring at them with a heterochromic gaze.

“You guys aren’t that quiet for assassins,” Catra sniffed.

She leapt down before them, landing quietly.

“You must be these Sinestro people I’ve heard about. Yellow rings, powered by fear. Mostly a lot of cut-throats. The kind of people I’ve dealt with before.”

Romat Ru looked at the new person, his gaze flicking about as he studied her. Then he gave a small smile.

“Yes, you *would* know. I can sense it on you…”

“Sense what, exactly?” Catra replied, body tense and ready.

“There is much anger in you, much fear. You’ve led a hard life, full of people who doubted you at every turn. Was it fair-weather friends? Bad bosses? A poor mother figure?”

Catra flinched a bit. Romat smiled. This was what he was good at, finding insecurities and needling them.

“Yes, you’ve pulled yourself up from nothing, grabbed at whatever power you could. There are a number of my fellows that are the same way.”

Behind him, Hasp tried to speak up, but Karu elbowed him and hissed “Quiet, he’s doing a thing.”

“Yes, I can see it in your eyes,” Romat said, “A seeker of power, a way to break the chains that others have put on you.”

He reached into his pocket.

“I keep one with me, in case I find someone promising.”

The yellow ring gleamed balefully in his hand, casting twisted shadows across Catra’s face.

“And I have a sense that you are promising.”

Catra stared at the ring, then flicked her gaze up at Romat.

“Why me?”

“The better question is, what are you going to do? I can practically smell your hurt, your anger, your fear. Beaten down by the world, made to feel small. Don’t you want something more? Here you are, dragged halfway across the universe, and you’re not even one of them. You’re just a tagalong on someone else’s adventure, am I right?”

Catra was silent, but the way she twitched made Romat knew he’d struck a nerve.

“That’s it, isn’t it? You’re the weaker piece of someone greater. Don’t you want something better? Don’t you want to prove all your naysayers wrong? Don’t you want to grasp at power? Put the fear of the gods into those who wronged you?”

Romat jiggled his hand, making the ring dance in his palm and throw off sparks of yellow light.

"It's your choice, my friend."

Catra stared at the ring, and then stretched out her hand…

oOo

There was a sharp intake of breath.

"Hey, are you okay?"

"Just…a feeling…"

oOo

Catra's fingers were inches from the ring when she paused.

"You're not wrong," she said quietly, "I have had a really rough life. For the longest time, I was a bitter soul with an axe to grind on anything and everything around me. I reached for whatever power I could, however I could. I hurt people, even enjoyed it a

bit. I embraced the cackling, power-mad villain routine that everyone judged me as. And do you know what I learned from it all?"

Her hand redirected, and she raked her claws across Romat Ru's surprised face.

"Villainy is overrated!" she shouted over the killer's screams.

The other yellow-ringers went on the attack, but speed and surprise were on Catra's side. She shoved Romat to the ground and dodged the retaliating blast from Tekik. She weaved around the beams, jumping for her first target. She landed on Tekik's chest and pushed off with all four limbs, sending the android sprawling.

"I know exactly what you people are selling, and I'm not buying!" Catra shouted as she twisted around a shining throwing axe.

A massive clawed hand lunged toward her, but she slid under it, before popping up on her hands and delivering a roundhouse kick to the caster. Karu-Sil's head snapped back, one of her sharp teeth flying out of her mouth. Catra pressed the attack, landing out of her handstand and slashing at the alien's leg, severing the tendon of the ankle. Karu went down with a scream.

"Anger and hate brought me nothing but loneliness and grief," Catra continued, lunging into a series of rapid strikes at Hasp,

“Spreading fear didn’t bring me peace. Any enjoyment I got was brief and fleeting.”

Catra’s pinpoint strikes savaged Hasp’s arm, crippling it, and then she decked him with a haymaker.

“I won’t go down that road again. Never again!”

Seeing Tekik rise, she went for him, but was blindsided by a beam of yellow light. The light morphed into bonds that pinned her to the wall.

Romat Ru snarled at her, blood leaking from his scratches and one eye squinted closed.

“You will pay for this, little cat. You shall be the first one I skin, and your screams will be my lullaby tonight.”

Then his face fell.

“Wait…why are you smiling?”

Catra raised her head, revealing eyes burning green-and-gold.

“Hey, Adora,” she purred.

An armored fist crashed through the wall, grabbing Romat and yanking him through. There was a thunderous sound of a punch, and then a tall figure in green-and-gold armor appeared.

“Hey, Catra,” Adora said as she stepped through the hole made by her entrance, “Mind if I tag in?”

“Knock yourself out, sweetheart.”

She did so by swinging her sword and chopping off Tekik’s arm. Hasp shot a beam of baleful yellow light, but a shining green shield appeared in Adora’s offhand. Then a green lasso shot forth and wrapped around him.

“Get over here!” She-Ra shouted, pulling Hasp off his feet and straight into her shield. There was a resounding *GONG*, and Hasp slumped to the floor, out cold.

Seeing her three fellows beaten down so easily, Karu-Sil decided that discretion was the better part of valor, and bolted into the sky.

She ran head-long into an unamused Soranik Natu. In one hand was a large hammer, shining a rich green. Arrayed around the other was a fan of very large scalpels, glinting a baleful yellow.

"You know," she said, "If dear old dad were here to see you, he'd be very disappointed."

oOo

Soranik yanked the last yellow ring off the new prisoners. Normally, removing a power ring of any color was difficult, but Sora had a way. Her yellow ring had an override function, allowing her to deactivate other yellow rings.

Because it had once been Sinestro's ring, and he hadn't been an idiot. He knew that the people he sought for his corps of fear weren't the kind that played well with others, so he had covered his bases.

Meanwhile, Adora fussed over her girlfriend.

"Are you sure you're okay?" she asked, cupping Catra's face in her hands and stroking a glowing thumb over her cheek, wiping away a small wound as easy as a bit of stray flour left over from a baking session.

"I'm fine," Catra said, "Bird-face was talking some junk, but I tuned it out."

Adora gave her a look, and Catra sighed.

"I'll tell you later."

"Yes, you will. Don't backslide on communication now, Catra."

"Yes, dear," Catra replied, rolling her eyes.

oOo

Catra did end up talking about it. It came after an idle question from Adora as they were getting ready for bed.

"So…you nearly got a ring, but you turned it down."

"I knew there were too many strings attached to that offer."

"And if there weren't, hypothetically."

Catra gave Adora a flat look.

"You're wondering what kind of ring I'd get if I could."

"I mean, haven't *you* wondered?"

Catra murmured for a moment, collecting her thoughts.

"So going down the list, I'd probably fit in with the Gardner's group. But I'd like to think whatever rage or fear or similar in me has been tempered by now. If this were years ago, at the height of my villain days, that'd be a different story, but that's not me anymore."

"Check," Adora nodded, "Orange isn't an option, even if it weren't only one user at a time."

"I've seen records of Larfleeze, that ring drove him *nuts*. No thank you. Speaking of records, I spend a lot of time in that hall while you're off on training exercises, so I've talked a lot with Saint Walker. Some of it's philosophical stuff. Ask him about this cave allegory if you ever want a mindscrew."

Catra trailed off into a short laugh.

"But anyway, it takes a special kind of hope to run a blue ring, and according to him, I don't really have it. And he'd know. The Indigo weirdos are the same way, really selective of who they pick, so my odds aren't good."

"And the Star Sapphires? The love people?"

"Again, they look for a special variant of that emotion. It requires a great love of *everything*, not just a small handful of people."

Adora looked like she wanted to argue, but then thought about it.

"Okay, yeah…I mean, I don't really agree—"

"Yeah, well, you're biased."

"What about green?"

Catra hummed.

"That's the question, isn't it? And I have thought about it. But honestly, even if they offered, I'm not sure I'd say yes. I'm… comfortable with who I am and what I do. This Corps stuff, space police and whatnot, it's too big for me. I'm good with guarding the home front, helping Glimmer run Bright Moon and maintaining peacetime. Being the big savior, that's your world."

"You can't tell me you're not tempted," Adora replied, creating small shapes and flares of green light.

"Of course I am, I'm not an idiot. But I don't think I want everything the ring comes with. I'm not the big superhero type. But that's okay. I like being *this* me. Catra the advisor, the reader, the friend, the lover."

"That's a mature outlook."

"That's the idea."

They slipped into bed, curling close together.

"That said, I was tempted," Catra said after a moment of silence, her voice anxious, "Bird-face hit a nerve or two. For a hot minute, I thought about taking that ring."

"Does that scare you?" Adora asked.

Catra didn't answer. She just buried herself tighter into Adora's embrace.

"Oh, Catra…a small moment of weakness doesn't make you a bad person. I see you out there, every day, and you're *trying*. You're trying so hard, despite your fears and regrets. Even if sometimes, you don't think you're really good. But you're *good enough*."

Catra picked her head up and stared at Adora, trying to will away the tears forming in her eyes and failing miserably.

Instead, she settled on saying "I love you."

Adora smiled and kissed her gently.

"I love you too. *So much*."

And as Catra drifted off to sleep that night, wrapped in a warm embrace, a realization came to her.

I want this to be forever.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter hated me. That's partly why it's so short.
And maybe now some people will stop asking about a ring for Catra.
(mostly on the other site, but whatever, it got annoying)

Many Happy Returns

Chapter Notes

And now, the finale…
I want to thank you all so much for sticking with this nerd's crazy idea. And a shout-out to the people one FF.net who've been here since the beginning for your patience while I wrangled uncooperative plot bunnies.
There's really only one loose end left to tie up, and it's not actually one of mine. Cliché as it might be in this fandom, but I couldn't help myself from giving everyone a happy ending, and I do mean *everyone.*
Enjoy our final trip into this world, and I hope you've all had a good time.

One later minor note. *Lightning Flame Dragon Roaring* is perfectly acceptable to play during the fight scene.

Gold Light, Green Light

-

Chapter 21

Many Happy Returns

-

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It has been months since Adora started her training on Mogo. She'd been a diligent student, attacking everything with incredible zeal, whether it be formal exercises or ride-alongs with Kraken. She'd mastered advanced constructs, environmental scanning, phase-shifting, adaptive camouflage, space flight, and even the

minor wormholes that most Lanterns used to cross vast swathes of the universe quickly.

Now, as she stood before the Guardians, she knew that it had paid off.

She could feel Catra's gaze on her, her girlfriend observing from the door and no doubt fit to burst with pride. Next to Adora stood Kraken, who was shooting her a smile.

"…and so we formally welcome you, Adora of Etheria, into the Green Lantern Corps. May you serve with dignity and pride."

"Thank you, sirs," Adora said formally.

"And now for your first assignment," Ganthet continued, "You are to aid Lanterns Kraken and Natu in extending diplomatic overtures to the inhabited worlds of the former Horde Space. That is a sector of the universe in desperate need of order and justice. Your senior Lanterns can fill you in on the rest of the details, but for now, I suggest you pick out the rest of your squad."

"Permission to add Jessica Cruz to the short-list? I've worked well with her through my training, and I trust her."

"Granted. You are dismissed for now. Serve well, Lantern."

Adora nodded, trying to keep herself composed and forestall the massive grin threatening to cross her face.

She managed to keep it up until leaving the room, whereupon Catra tackle-hugged her and ruined the moment.

"You made it!"

"Does that imply doubt, sweetheart?" Adora teased.

"Get over yourself, honey," Catra replied with a wicked grin.

The two laughed together, Adora pulling Catra in tighter and soaking up the warmth. A pleased rumble built in Catra's chest.

Then Kraken cleared her throat, making the two jump.

"Hate to break up the moment, but the sooner we tackle preparations, the sooner you lovebirds can see home," she said with a knowing look, "And I might be persuaded to use a Boom Tube to expediate our trip, incidentally…"

Adora and Catra smiled. Home sounded pretty good right now.

oOo

'Home's looking a little rough right now,' Glimmer thought as she fell to the ground with a grunt.

Things had been fine for the last few months. No massive emergencies to deal with or mystical fires to put out. The only major issue had been sudden tension with Aquatos, thanks to a new political figure that had managed to weasel his way into a potent position of power despite being *extremely* unqualified, but any diplomatic snafus caused by his raging ego had been dealt with by more level-headed people. And then he'd been found guilty of massive amounts of fraud, and had been summarily impeached, so that took care of that.

Basically, nothing that had required She-Ra-type intervention, thankfully.

Then Adam had shown up a week ago, claiming that the Sorceress of Grayskull had foreseen something happening soon. What exactly was unknown, but if it was dangerous enough to send He-Man to help fend it off, it was something to be worried about.

It turned out to be an alien invasion.

"*Again*," Glimmer growled as she teleported behind a solider about to get the drop on Perfuma and zapped him.

The strange lizard-aliens had come out of nowhere. They seemed to be concentrating on Bright Moon, no doubt intending to use it as a beachhead for the rest of the planet. If there was any consolation, it was that they didn't have Horde Prime's numbers. The downside was that their technology was just as good, and they also fielded a number of warbeasts, monstrosities of varied strengths.

Case in point, the one that Glimmer just dodged. It was the only humanoid one, an orange-skinned female that could fire beams of energy. Given the complex headgear and the blank look on her face, Glimmer was pretty sure she was brainwashed.

Glimmer dodged another beam and grimaced.

"Okay, that's it."

She teleported above, coming down with a burning fist into the crown of her foe's head. The helmet cracked, and the alien went down.

"Sorry about that, we'll give you medical attention later."

She took a moment to look around, finding the rest of the Princess Alliance in various states of trouble. Even He-Man was pinned down, dealing with two massive warbeasts and six floating tanks that fired whenever there was an opening.

A bolt of energy slammed into her side, and she crumpled to the ground as electricity surged through her. She heard Bow's cry of worry, but was more focused on her attacker.

"You are a fool, primitive," the lizard-man said, "Your resistance is futile. Your planet's resources will fuel the Psions. As for its people, they will be most interesting test subjects."

Glimmer fought to rise and continue the attack.

She didn't have to.

A beam of emerald light shot down from the sky and speared one of the floating tanks, destroying it instantly. The explosion caused a brief lull in the fighting.

"Well, look at this!"

Heads jerked up at the voice, and everyone saw She-Ra in her full glory. She was standing on a green platform hovering in the air. Beside her, an equally battle-ready Catra stood, Melog snarling at her side.

“Seems we got here just in the nick of time. What do you think that makes us, Catra?”

“Big Damn Heroes, Adora.”

“Aren’t we, though?”

“LANTERN!” one Psion screamed in fear.

“We can see that, Myke!” shouted another, “It’s only one, we can take her!”

Adora just grinned.

“Yeah, about that…”

She raised her head and shouted to the heavens.

“Let those who worship evil’s might!”

A dozen shining green forms dropped out of the sky, answering Adora's call.

"Beware our power, GREEN LANTERN'S LIGHT!"

And back on the ground, Glimmer slowly smiled, looking at the now-stunned Psion who had mocked her.

"It was at this moment, they knew…*they fucked up*."

Jessica Cruz was the first of the Lanterns to move, charging right toward He-Man and the warbeasts, targeting the bigger, gorilla-looking one and going with the first thing that popped in her head.

"Charizard, use Flare Blitz!"

A green dragon wrapped in emerald flame hit the warbeast like a freight train, sending it away. Jessica charged right after it, already thinking about her next construct.

He-Man took advantage of the shift in battle and threw the other warbeast, a large cat-creature, off him. One tank tried to fire on him, but the shell was blocked by a glowing energy shield.

“I got the monster, big guy,” Soranik Natu said, hovering closer, “You can have the tanks.”

“You sure?”

Soranik smiled, constructing an array of scalpels with both green and yellow rings.

“Yeah. This isn’t a fight, it’s an operation.”

Three scalpels flew forward, embedding themselves in the cat-creature’s joints and eliciting a howl of pain.

“And I’m a surgeon.”

He-Man decided to take her word for it, and jumped up to come down on one tank fist-first.

Meanwhile, Kraken used a pair of shining scissors to take care of some electrified nets that had pinned Netossa, Spinnerella, and Mermista.

“Well, that was ironic,” Netossa said, “You okay, Spinny?”

"No sweat, sweetie," her wife replied, quickly blowing away several Psions.

Mermista didn't bother with banter and went right back on the attack, summoning a stream of water from the nearby river and dousing more Psions. Kraken shot a bolt of green electricity from her power gauntlet, and the combo-move took them out.

"I thought rings were you guys' thing?" Mermista said with an impressed look.

"It's complicated," Kraken shrugged.

Across the battlefield, Catra tore through several Psions, her body wrapped in green light. A more philosophical part of her mind felt a unique comfort in being wrapped in and strengthened by her love's will.

The fact that she was shredding right through several layers of armor was a nice bonus too.

Glimmer teleported in, dropping a Psion she'd been grappling onto a large rock, then stopping to briefly hug Catra before launching herself back into the fray.

"It is *so* good to have you two back."

“And I’m enjoying the welcome back party, Sparkles,” Catra grinned.

A small warbeast tried to pounce on them in their moment of distraction, but Melog appeared and bowled it over, roaring hard enough to rattle her target’s bones.

Spinnerella shot past them, riding atop a tornado and sending Psions flying. Each one either landed hard on the ground, or were knocked down to earth by a fellow fighter. She watched one Lantern send a Psion plummeting with a mace, and fought down a savage grin. Her wife was the competitive one, but she’d by lying if she said she didn’t enjoy having the high ground once and awhile.

She flew past Sea Hawk dueling back-to-back with a Lantern, gold and emerald swords flashing and laughter piercing the air.

Another Lantern with green skin flew past them, going to help Perfuma.

“You tap into the Green,” he said to her, blocking a blow that would have knocked her down, “I can sense it on you.”

Perfuma summoned several large vines to swat away her opponents. When she got a moment, she looked at her rescuer

with a practiced eye.

"I don't think I've ever called it that. But I know something is telling me that you're part-plant somehow?"

"It's my species, but we can talk later," he replied.

"Agreed," Perfuma said, "If you can help me get to that one orange-skinned girl Glimmer was fighting, I'd appreciate it. I'm pretty sure she was mind-controlled."

"Done deal."

Then he launched one Psion through the air with a well-timed burst of energy.

It flew past where Jessica was finishing with her warbeast. The Lantern took a few deep breaths to calm her nerves. Her construct Charizard spread a wing over her head and grunted soothingly.

"You know, sometimes, I wonder exactly how much subconscious stuff I'm putting into my construct creatures," she muttered, even as she allowed a constructed Pikachu to hop on her shoulder, "You guys are remarkably life-like."

A constructed Lucario grunted, readying a combat stance in the face of another squad of Psions.

"Right, introspection later," she said, "Let's go, boys!"

The Charizard roared in approval as the four charged.

Nearby, Frosta summoned a pillar of ice beneath her, launching herself out of danger, and allowing Scorpia to bum-rush the Psion that had been previously attacking her. Just as Frosta wondered if she's been too hasty in acting without a way to get back down, a Lantern flew by and caught her.

"Aren't you a little young to be in a battlefield?"

"Probably, but I'm used to it," Frosta sighed, "Hey, want to make a bombing run?"

"Eh, why not?"

"Then let's bring the hail!"

She-Ra shot past them, coming down from the sky on emerald wings and making a shockwave where she landed. Multiple construct swords flew around her, striking in sequence with her

physical blade as she waded through the fight. Her blades moved almost without prior prompting to parry attacks and block energy blasts.

Catra, her brief power-up now spent, leapt in and grabbed a sword in one smooth motion.

"So, how do you think we're doing? Or do I even need to ask?" she commented as she stabbed a Psion.

A floating tank crashed to the ground near them, and He-Man dismounted from the wreckage.

"Hey, sis, sis-in-law. Welcome to the party."

"Nice to be home," Adora smiled, even while casually directing a sword to trip up a charging Psion.

An arrow landed near them, exploding and taking out the Psion's friends. Adora followed the trajectory back and waved to Bow, who excitedly waved back.

One Psion, his garb and large gun indicating his higher rank, fired on the three. When the dust cleared, he saw a shining shield and three unamused faces. Before he could fully react, She-Ra was upon him, holding him up by the throat.

“How?” he squeaked, “This is outside Lantern space. This was supposed to be a new branch in our genetic empire. How did you know about us?”

“We didn’t, we just got lucky.”

The Psion captain stared at her in shock.

“Then how…why…I demand an explanation!”

“That’s funny, because I have a demand for you.”

She-Ra brought him closer, staring right into his eyes.

“Get off my planet,” she growled.

The Psion captain’s eye went wide as he realized the implications of that phrase. Then She-Ra threw him away.

The rest of the fight continued to go poorly for the Psions. Hail and green energy flew through the air, winds and water swept them aside, and raw muscle charged through their lines.

As Adora took a moment to catch her breath, Soranik flew by, calling out that most of the Psions seemed to be retreating.

"Then let's make sure they keep running," She-Ra replied, launching into the air.

Other Lanterns joined them, firing lasers at the retreating Psion dropships. They were merely warning shots, designed to keep them running, but the message was clear.

"And tell your bosses that Vega's next!" Soranik shouted through a green megaphone, "Larfleeze and Luthor can't protect you now!"

oOo

Catra and Melog looked down at the celebrations from their perch on some Bright Moon architecture. The visiting aliens had been visibly confused at the sudden eruption of a big party, but Adora had waved off their questions.

"Just roll with it, that's how it works here," she had said.

A shimmer of green from the side alerted her to a new presence.

“Do you mind if I hide out here with you for a bit?” Jessica asked.

“Pull up a roof,” Catra replied, “Partied out?”

“Big rowdy crowds, not really my thing.”

Jessica sat down. Melog shifted from Catra’s side to place her head in the young woman’s lap. Jessica began to scratch the big cat’s ears, and the immediate relaxation showed on her face.

“Yeah, I’m not a fan of stuff like this either,” Catra shrugged, “Most of it is sound and smell, after a while I start to get overwhelmed.”

“That sounds like it sucks.”

“My friends know I have a limit, and they don’t push. Sometimes Adora stays with me to people-watch.”

Catra pointed into the crowd below.

“I can hear Entrapta squealing about Kraken and her Mother Box. Which fits, honestly.”

"From the stories you've told, I'm surprised it took Entrapta that long to hunt Kraken down," Jessica giggled, "What about over with Soranik and the pale guy?"

"Oh, that's Hordak. I think they're making plans for dealing with the last of the Prime chips."

Catra felt a twinge in the back of her neck, and ignored it with great effort. Instead, she tuned her ears toward the conversation just as Scorpia joined in.

"…and I'm tough, so I'll be able to take whatever you can dish out. Also, if it works, maybe I can get Perfuma to stop worrying so much about me."

Catra smiled a bit at that. Scorpia and Perfuma had gotten very close the past few years, and she'd be shocked if one of them didn't pop the question soon. The only thing holding either of them back were nerves.

"I see the Green Man's found a kindred spirit," Jessica said, pointing to another part of the crowd.

"Figures a half-plant man would find himself in deep conversation with the flower princess," Catra snorted as she noticed the Lantern talking to Perfuma, "What *is* his real name, anyway?"

“No one knows,” Jessica shrugged, “It doesn’t translate well outside of the plant kingdom.”

“That orange girl looks like she’s fitting in,” Catra said, indicating the new person dancing to the music with a pleased look on her face.

“Right, the Tamaranean,” Jessica said, “Don’t be surprised if she settles down here.”

“People around here are super-welcoming, so she probably wouldn’t have a hard time, but why do you say it like that?”

“Tamaraneans are diaspora in the galaxy. Their planet was destroyed in a meteor strike about a decade or so ago.”

Catra winced.

“Sorry I asked…”

“Yeah, so you find them all over. There’s one living on my home planet, actually. Nice girl, but don’t bring up the Psions around her. They experimented on her and others of her kind. It’s probably what happened with our new friend.”

"I should probably point her toward my therapist, then," Catra muttered.

A sudden noise form directly below drew their attention, and they looked down to see Sea Hawk attempting to start a shanty, to Mermista's visible, if fond, annoyance.

"*Why?*" she could be heard groaning.

"*Honey, you married him*," Netossa could be heard telling her.

"Love's a funny thing, I guess," Jessica said with a sad expression.

"Eh, you'll find someone," Catra said.

"I don't know, between my high-travel job and my anxiety—"

"Hey, I made it out okay," Catra countered, gesturing toward where Adora was talking animatedly with Bow and Glimmer, "And not that it's a competition, but I was *a lot* more messed up than being a shut-in. You'll get there."

"If you say so," Jessica hummed.

Melog tilted her head to bump Jessica's stomach, making the Lantern look down at her. The alien cat was giving her a reproachful look.

"So *we* say so," Catra laughed.

"Okay, I give!"

Melog gave a pleased rumble.

"So what do you think is next?" Jessica asked.

"Oh, I have an idea or two," Catra replied as she watched Kraken and Entrapta make their way towards Hordak.

oOo

One month later…

It was a gangly and unartful piece of machinery, but it didn't need to look good. It just needed to function.

Adora looked it over with a small smile. The past month had been hectic, as she worked with the other Lanterns to get the Etherian Alliance (as their collection of planets had started to be called) under the protection of the Green Lantern Corps, as well as remove the last of the Prime chips and erase the last wounds of Horde Prime's empire. All the while, Kraken had been periodically dipping into the lab with Entrapta and Hordak, working on a project that Adora had posed to her long ago:

A portal to the space between, a way to rescue Queen Angella.

To the side, Glimmer clutched at the hand of her father like a lifeline. Bow was standing on Glimmer's other side, one arm wrapped tightly around her shoulders. On Micah's other side, Castaspella was doing the same.

"All this time, and you didn't tell me you were doing this?" Glimmer all but whimpered, tears beading in her eyes.

"We didn't want to say anything until we had something concrete," Entrapta said as she looked over the apparatus one last time, "If it turned out we couldn't do it, and we had told you we could…well, that just seems cruel."

"And you're sure this will work?" Micah asked, a tone of desperation laced in his voice.

"As sure as we can be with unstable multi-dimensional physics," Hordak replied, looking over his console, "Lantern Kraken has been an enormous help in that regard. I'm reasonably confident myself, but I'd rather not give you much in the way of raw probabilities, in case I jinx something."

Hordak gave the king a flat look.

"I cannot tell you how many times I thought I had an experiment down cold, only for something unforeseen to happen, so you'll forgive my brief superstition."

Glimmer looked over at Adora and Catra, who were off to the side.

"This was your idea."

"Don't look at me, Sparkles, this is Adora's baby," Catra hummed.

"Don't act like you didn't figure out what I was plotting months ago," Adora replied, giving her girlfriend a light elbow.

"That's because I'm smart and I know you," Catra smiled back.

"I think we're just about ready for our attempt," Kraken said, shifting the conversation back, "Now the only question is, who's going to take the plunge to pull our target out?"

Adora pushed off the wall. Catra frowned.

"Oh, right. This is the part of the plan I hate."

"Between the ring and how tough She-Ra is, I have the best chance of making the trip," Adora argued.

"And I know that, but…"

Catra trailed off. Her flat affect was hiding the depth of her worry, and she was reasonably sure that all her friends knew it. The fact was, there was an ache in her chest at the thought of possibly losing Adora. Her mind flashed to a small object back home, buried in a drawer. The drawer contained Catra's pants, specially tailored to accommodate her tail and clawed feet, and was one of the few places to hide something from her beloved. Underneath the clothes was a box. The thought of the contents of the box never seeing the light of day sent a chill down her spine, all the way to the tip of her tail.

She must have shuddered a bit, because Adora wrapped her in a tight hug, rubbing her back and making shushing sounds.

"Breathe for me, Catra. You're going to be fine, I'm going to be fine, everything is going to be fine."

Catra relaxed into the embrace, a small purr welling up. Adora leaned back, looking her love right in the eyes.

"I'm coming back. You're my lifeline, Catra. And you always will be."

She then raised her ring-hand and generated a rope.

"And I don't just mean that metaphorically right now."

Catra took the shimmering rope in hand. It was warm, and if she closed her eyes, she could *just feel* Adora.

Adora gave her a brief but tender kiss.

"I'm coming back," she said, and her eyes flashed a green-and-gold light.

"You promise?" Catra asked, a plaintive tone in her voice. A similar light briefly flared across her eyes.

"I promise."

Adora walked over to the portal, the rope wrapping itself around her wrist and continually generating new length.

"So how's this going to go?"

"The machine will link with Kraken's Mother Box, feeding it the data that Entrapta and I collected during the previous portal project," Hordak explained, "It will then use that data to create and maintain a portal to the in-between. If Queen Angella's body has held out—"

"And given her nigh-immortal nature, the odds are good," Entrapta interjected.

"Then you should be able to retrieve her, and exit in the same manner. However, the nature of the portal and its target are unstable, so I have little idea how long we will be able to keep this portal open."

"So work fast, then."

"Correct. And I'd transform sooner rather than later. She-Ra's greater durability may be an asset, and the magic may serve as an additional tether to Etheria."

Adora nodded solemnly, shifting into She-Ra with little fanfare.

"Ready."

Kraken thrust her gauntleted hand into the hole in the side of the device.

"Okay, Mother Box. Hit it."

PING PING!

Crackles of multi-colored cosmic energy began to fill the portal apparatus. Hordak and Entrapta worked over their controls in a mad dance, chattering scientific terms to each other that went right over everyone else's heads.

Finally, the flowing colors of the portal solidified into a solid blue.

"That's your door!" Entrapta shouted over the dull roar of the portal.

"Everybody comes home," Adora said with intense resolution.

Then she took the plunge.

Every color on the rainbow and several that weren't shot past her. Heat and cold grappled together across her skin. She felt a great wind rip across her body. She felt her ears pop as she shot through a heavy wall of sound. It was unlike her previous experience with a Boom Tube, and more like being in the center of a great storm.

The Universe jumped, spun, froze, and then splayed itself out in several different directions.

And then everything was purple.

She looked around, finding herself in Bright Moon. But it was crumbling, not as if from age or battle, but with great cracks of nothingness splitting everything.

She recalled an old nightmare, a twisted version of her love, and shivered.

"Definitely in the right place," Adora muttered.

She picked her way through the jagged rubble. A bitter wind blew, carrying a scent like decay. A sharp crack from above

caught her attention, and she leapt back to avoid some rubble that had fallen. The shards of stone, holding a sort of reverse-glimmer from what she was used to in Bright Moon, hit the ground and crumbled into blackened dust.

But it was the feeling that got to her. A feeling like despair weighed down on her, slowly sapping at her like a bitter winter wind.

Adora shuddered. Her ring flared, and warmth shot through her body.

"Thanks," she whispered to it, "Best not to linger."

This was a broken place, after all. Everything from the crumbling keep to the sour air reflected it. She couldn't imagine what Angella had been through, surviving in this for so long.

And she *was* alive. Adora *had* to believe it. She *refused* to believe that she was dead, that this was for nothing. She still remembered the wails of grief that had echoed through the castle when the queen was gone. And she never wanted to hear their like again.

"Everybody comes home," Adora repeated to herself, "*Everybody comes home.* Everybody gets their happy ending."

And so she continued to walk through the crumbling castle on a lonely patch of earth in the bottomless void, searching for the last lost soul in her life.

After a few minutes of searching, a thought came to her, and she made her way toward a specific place. Sure enough, she was right.

Queen Angella had often been found before the mural of King Micah, seeking solace in the image of her lost husband. And here she was again, knelt before it in a meditative calm. She didn't look good. Her clothes were tattered, her hair was matted, and her skin was sallow. The thing that struck Adora most, though, was the wings. Angella's wings were the most prominent part of her, shimmering in the light like stained glass. Adora had once asked about the wings, and Angella had explained that they were mostly energy, a physical representation of her inner magic. The look of them now spoke volumes about her current health. They were chipped and ragged, multiple feathers missing, and their luster was completely gone.

"Your Majesty!"

Angella didn't move from her position, nor did she open her eyes.

"Ah, it will be talking hallucinations today, then," she said flatly, "No thank you, spirit. I am trying to meditate. These are harsh environs, and these techniques help me survive longer."

"I'm not a hallucination, it's me! Adora!"

"They all say that," Angella replied with palpable depression, "I have been here for long enough to know that between this shattered reality and my own lonely mind, there is little I can trust anymore."

"No, I'm really here! I'm here to take you home!"

Angella merely scoffed, getting up. She kept her eyes closed as she started to walk away, heedless of Adora's outstretched hand and pleading expression.

"There is nothing you can offer me, spirit."

"No, don't go! Glimmer and Micah are waiting for you, so just take my hand and we can—"

Adora was cut off by a sharp laugh. The sound was full of regret, and pierced her heart like a knife.

"Oh, now I know you're a trick of a cruel mind. Don't you recall? Micah is dead. Long gone these many years."

"He told me about when Glimmer was born," Adora replied desperately.

"I suppose about how proud he was to be a father? That's all he ever told me, about how much he loved his family."

"No, he was terrified!"

Angella stopped walking.

"Glimmer was born prematurely. She was extremely small and weak. There was a moment when she stopped breathing. You were both scared to lose her, but he kept up a strong face. He only talked about his fears with his sister, but he was half-certain you'd overheard."

Angella finally looked back, her eyes wet with tears.

"Wait, you…how do you…Adora, is that you?"

"And when the doctors cleared her, and you could fully hold your daughter, you started crying with joy. And that was when Micah knew that everything would be okay. He told us that story a year ago, and Glimmer said she was thankful he hadn't taken out the photo album. When she asked how he got through it, he said that he *had* to believe that things would work out. If he thought

for even an instant that Glimmer would die, then he might as well have given up then and there. Being brave was the only choice."

"That's…what?"

"Micah's alive! He's been on Beast Island. I'm bringing you back for him and Glimmer. Take my hand!"

For a moment, Angella still thought that it was a trick of her fevered mind. After all, never in her wildest dreams could she have imagined Micah surviving on the infamous Beast Island, only to come back to his family after so many years…

Oh.

Later, Angella wasn't too proud to admit to the ungainly lunge she made toward Adora, all flailing limbs and flapping wings. It must have looked absolutely ridiculous from outside.

oOo

Catra kept a death-grip on the emerald rope. She was holding it so tightly that she felt a tingle of energy shoot up it a millisecond before the tugging started. She swore and immediately started pulling. Bow and Glimmer jumped in and pulled as well.

"Woah!" Bow shouted, "It's fighting!"

"That's what we were worried about," Entrapta shouted, "Getting in might be easier than getting out!"

Glimmer caught the look on Catra's face and immediately spoke up.

"Adora's strong, she'll be fine. We need to do our part. Now pull!"

The trio pulled, Micah and Casta soon joining them. Entrapta and Hordak desperately worked the controls, trying to find a way to lessen the portal's pull and make it easier.

The tug-of-war continued until finally, with a sound like a cork popping, She-Ra and Queen Angella burst out of the portal.

For Angella, everything hurt. The sensation like being pulling through a hose lingered, and everything was too loud and too bright. She squeezed her eyes shut, hissing, and tried to focus things back one sense at a time.

"Closeitcloseitcloseit!" shouted Entrapta's voice.

“What do you think I’m doing?” snapped a voice that sounded like Hordak from that one time Angella had encountered him, but how could that be?

“Mother Box, power down!” shouted a completely unfamiliar voice.

“Adora!” shouted a voice that was familiar, but she wasn’t sure how.

“Give them some space!” shouted another voice that was definitely Castaspella.

Was she really home?

A pair of touches on her shoulders helped reorient her. She looked up and saw her daughter, tears in her eyes. And then she saw the man beside her. He was a little more scarred than she remembered, but she’d know that face anywhere.

“Welcome home, Angie.”

With a cry, Glimmer launched herself into her mother’s arms. Micah joined in.

“Is this a dream?” Angella asked, still not quite believing it.

“No, Mom. You’re home,” Glimmer’s voice sounded out, thick with tears, “You’re home.”

Angella’s breath caught. Slowly, the wrapped her arms around her family, her wings shifting to cover the group. With desperation born of long isolation, Angella hugged her husband and daughter for the first time in years.

Glimmer looked over at Adora, who had powered down. Catra was attached to her like a limpet, muttering her worries.

“It’s okay, Catra. Everyone made it home safe,” Adora whispered.

“Don’t scare me like that,” Catra whispered back.

“I’ll try not to.”

Glimmer and Adora locked eyes.

“Thank you,” Glimmer whispered.

Adora smiled back.

After a few minutes of hugging her family, Angella looked around. She took in the machinery, deeming it the reason she was back. She looked at the familiar faces, at her family, at her practically-adopted daughter, at her only-a-matter-of-time son-in-law, and she wondered what had changed with them. She looked at the new faces, at a much calmer version of the cat-woman who had led a Horde invasion of Bright Moon, at a green-skinned woman with a green uniform, and she wondered what their stories were.

She saw Hordak standing next to Entrapta. The two locked eyes. Hordak edged backward, clearly intending to leave, but Entrapta stopped him

"Don't be scared," she said quietly, "I'll be right here."

She *really* wanted to know what had changed.

She must have said that last part out loud, because Adora gave a small laugh.

"The war ended, ages ago. We got our peace, and no one had to die save for the unrepentant."

She smiled at the queen, and Angella was struck at how at-peace Adora looked, a far cry from the stressed and scared young woman she had seen last.

"I took care of them, just like a promised I would."

Angella closed her eyes and melted back into her husband's embrace.

"Good," she all but whispered, "That's good…"

oOo

It took a week for Angella to be up to visitors. She spent that time recovering some from her ordeal. Her immortal nature helped, speeding her physical recovery. What didn't help was that she was terrified of falling asleep, for fear that it would all be a dream. She made it thirty-six hours before folding like a cheap tent and sleeping for two days straight. She still required someone to remain in close contact with her, a physical assurance that this was real.

When the week passed and she was feeling better, she allowed a small celebration. Nothing that big, just the old Alliance coming over for a nice dinner and a light party. It was a quiet affair, perfect for the still-shaky queen.

Catra waited until things had started to wind down. As Scorpia and Perfuma were saying their goodbyes and asking Jessica for a ride for them and a conked-out Frosta, Catra pulled Adora aside.

‘*Now or never*,’ she thought to herself.

As they walked through the garden, the glow of the night sky beaming down and lunar blossoms blooming around them, Catra sucked in a breath and drew on her courage.

“So I’ve been thinking—”

“Uh-oh,” Adora snorted, and Catra elbowed her.

“Hey, I’m being serious,” she said with a short laugh.

“Sorry, sorry, go ahead.”

Catra’s nerves were screaming at her. A tiny voice was saying that this would end poorly, that she didn’t deserve this. Thankfully, she’d gotten good at ignoring that pessimistic voice after staring therapy.

“So, I’ve been thinking about this for a long time. And I don’t know how you feel about it, but I’ve decided to take a leap of faith.”

She pulled a box out of her jacket pocket, opening it to reveal a bracelet. It was a fine gold, with several small stones; emerald, turquoise, and citrine. Adora gawked at it.

"Catra, it's beautiful…"

"I had it made after we got back from Mogo. I know it's not quite Etherian tradition, but I figured we could get away with it, all things considered."

"Tradition?"

"Yeah, don't couples usually exchange accessories for this? I didn't have anything that felt right, so I decided to make something."

In a flash, Adora realized what was going on.

"Catra…are you…"

Catra went down on one knee. Adora felt her breath hitch and her heart stop.

"Adora, I love you. You're my everything. Even when we were fighting, even when I was at my worst, you never gave up on

me. We've been through fire and come out the other side, stronger together than we ever were apart. And I want that to be forever. Will you marry me?"

Adora stood shock still. For a moment, an anxious part of Catra wondered if she'd made a terrible mistake, but then Adora pounced on her, peppering her face with kisses and all but screaming "Yes!" between pecks.

Soon Catra was laughing in joy. They were already making plans, chatting excitedly and drowning in each other's love. After Adora promised to forge a matching bracelet for Catra herself, Catra laughed and showed her one detail that she absolutely had to include.

Engraved on the inside of the bracelet was a phrase that had inspired them years ago, and would continue to inspire them in the years to come.

Love can ignite the stars

THE END

End Notes

I do not own She-Ra and the Princesses of Power. It is owned by DreamWorks Animation, show creator Noelle Stevenson, and based upon characters made by Larry DiTillio, J. Michael Straczynski, Filmation, and Mattel
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